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House of Representatives

The House met at 2 p.m. and was called to order by the Speaker pro tempore (Mr. BUTTERFIELD).

DESIGNATION OF THE SPEAKER PRO TEMPORE

The SPEAKER pro tempore laid before the House the following communication from the Speaker:

WASHINGTON, DC,
November 12, 2019.

I hereby appoint the Honorable G.K. BUTTERFIELD to act as Speaker pro tempore on this day.

NANCY PELOSI,
Speaker of the House of Representatives.

PRAYER

The Chaplain, the Reverend Patrick J. Conroy, offered the following prayer:

Dear God, we give You thanks for giving us another day.

We ask Your special blessing upon the Members of the people's House. They face difficult decisions in difficult times, with many forces and interests demanding their attention.

Give them generosity to enter into their work. May they serve You in the work they do as You deserve, give of themselves and not count the costs, fight for what is best for our Nation and not count the political wounds, toil until their work is done and not seek to rest, and labor without seeking any reward other than knowing that they are doing Your will and serving the people of this great Nation.

Bless them, O God, and be with them and with us all this day and every day to come. May all that is done be for Your greater honor and glory.

Amen.

THE JOURNAL

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The Chair has examined the Journal of the last day's proceedings and announces to the House his approval thereof.

Pursuant to clause 1, rule I, the Journal stands approved.

Mr. LARSEN of Washington. Mr. Speaker, pursuant to clause 1, rule I, I demand a vote on agreeing to the Speaker's approval of the Journal.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The question is on the Speaker's approval of the Journal.

The question was taken; and the Speaker pro tempore announced that the ayes appeared to have it.

Mr. LARSEN of Washington. Mr. Speaker, I object to the vote on the ground that a quorum is not present and make the point of order that a quorum is not present.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to clause 8, rule XX, further proceedings on this question will be postponed.

The point of no quorum is considered withdrawn.

PLEDGE OF ALLEGIANCE

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Will the gentleman from Washington (Mr. LARSEN) come forward and lead the House in the Pledge of Allegiance.

Mr. LARSEN of Washington led the Pledge of Allegiance as follows:

I pledge allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America, and to the Republic for which it stands, one nation under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

EX-IM REAUTHORIZATION

(Mr. LARSEN of Washington asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute.)

Mr. LARSEN of Washington. Mr. Speaker, today I rise to express my support for H.R. 4863, the United States Export Finance Agency Act, which reauthorizes the Ex-Im Bank's charter for 10 years. The Ex-Im Bank is a proven job-creating success story.

For years, I have met with small- and medium-sized manufacturers in northwest Washington State who rely on the Ex-Im Bank to compete in the global marketplace. Since 2014, companies, suppliers, and other manufacturers in my district who rely on the Ex-Im Bank have generated nearly $24 billion in total export value.

Vista Clara Inc. in Mukilteo is a small, veteran-owned business which used Ex-Im funds to develop and manufacture advanced nuclear magnetic resonance, NMR, geophysical instruments for groundwater, environmental, and energy resources investigations.

The Ex-Im Bank levels the international playing field for U.S. exporters and workers, enabling them to respond to foreign competition when it is backed by export credit agency support. It also supports large manufacturers like Boeing, America's largest exporter.

I represent nearly 18,000 current employees at Boeing's Everett plant, which depends upon the Ex-Im Bank to support millions of dollars in total insured shipments, guaranteed credit, or disbursed loans.

The U.S. can be an attractive alternative to China by employing a strategic approach combining development assistance, ensuring protections for the environment and worker rights, and supporting good governance and the rule of law.

Mr. Speaker, I look forward to voting for H.R. 4863 this week to provide much-needed certainty for the Nation's manufacturers, and I urge my colleagues' support.

RECESS

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to clause 12(a) of rule I, the Chair declares the House in recess until approximately 4 p.m. today.

Accordingly (at 2 o'clock and 5 minutes p.m.), the House stood in recess.

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AFTER RECESS

The recess having expired, the House was called to order by the Speaker pro tempore (Ms. FRANKEL) at 4 o'clock and 5 minutes p.m.

MESSAGES FROM THE PRESIDENT

Messages in writing from the President of the United States were communicated to the House by Miss Kaitlyn Roberts, one of his secretaries.

ANNOUNCEMENT BY THE SPEAKER PRO TEMPORE

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to clause 8 of rule XX, the Chair will postpone further proceedings today on motions to suspend the rules on which a recorded vote or the yeas and nays are ordered, or votes objected to under clause 6 of rule XX.

The House will resume proceedings on postponed questions at a later time.

PROTECT THE GI BILL ACT

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I move to suspend the rules and pass the bill (H.R. 4625) to amend title 38, United States Code, to require that educational institutions abide by certain principles as a condition of approval for purposes of the educational assistance programs of the Department of Veterans Affairs, and for other purposes, as amended.

The Clerk read the title of the bill.

The text of the bill is as follows:

H.R. 4625

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America in Congress assembled,

SECTION 1. SHORT TITLE; TABLE OF CONTENTS.

(a) SHORT TITLE.—This Act may be cited as the ''Protect the GI Bill Act''.

(b) TABLE OF CONTENTS.—The table of contents for this Act is as follows:

Sec. 1. Short title; table of contents.
Sec. 2. Clarification of educational assistance for individuals who pursue an approved program of education leading to a degree while on active duty.
Sec. 3. Verification of enrollment for purposes of receipt of Post-9/11 Educational Assistance benefits.
Sec. 4. Clarification regarding the dependents to whom entitlement to educational assistance may be transferred under the Post 9/11 Educational Assistance Program.
Sec. 5. Expansion of reasons for which a course of education may be disapproved.
Sec. 6. Oversight of educational institutions subject to Government action for purposes of the educational assistance programs of the Department of Veterans Affairs.
Sec. 7. Additional requirement for approval of educational institutions for purposes of the educational assistance programs of the Department of Veterans Affairs.
Sec. 8. Clarification of accreditation for law schools for purposes of the educational assistance programs of the Department of Veterans Affairs.
Sec. 9. Clarification of grounds for disapproval of a course for purposes of the educational assistance programs of the Department of Veterans Affairs.
Sec. 10. Requirements for educational institutions participating in the educational assistance programs of the Department of Veterans Affairs.
Sec. 11. Overpayments to eligible persons or veterans.
Sec. 12. Improvements to limitation on certain advertising, sales, and enrollment practices.
Sec. 13. Additional limitation on certain advertising, sales, and enrollment practices of educational institutions.
Sec. 14. Charge to entitlement to educational assistance for individuals who do not transfer credits from certain closed or disapproved programs of education.

SEC. 2. CLARIFICATION OF EDUCATIONAL ASSISTANCE FOR INDIVIDUALS WHO PURSUE AN APPROVED PROGRAM OF EDUCATION LEADING TO A DEGREE WHILE ON ACTIVE DUTY.

Section 3313(e) of title 38, United States Code, is amended—

(1) in the heading, by inserting ''FOR A PERIOD OF MORE THAN 30 DAYS'' after ''ACTIVE DUTY'';

(2) in paragraph (1), by inserting ''for a period of more than 30 days'' after ''active duty''; and

(3) in paragraph (2), in the matter preceding subparagraph (A), by inserting ''for a period of more than 30 days'' after ''active duty''.

SEC. 3. VERIFICATION OF ENROLLMENT FOR PURPOSES OF RECEIPT OF POST-9/11 EDUCATIONAL ASSISTANCE BENEFITS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Section 3313 of title 38, United States Code, as amended by section 2, is further amended by adding at the end the following new subsection:

''(l) VERIFICATION OF ENROLLMENT.—(1) The Secretary shall require—

''(A) each educational institution to submit to the Secretary verification of each individual who is enrolled in a course or program of education at the educational institution and is receiving educational assistance under this chapter for each month during which the individual is so enrolled and receiving such educational assistance; and

''(B) each individual who is enrolled in a course or program of education and is receiving educational assistance under this chapter to submit to the Secretary verification of such enrollment for each month during which the individual is so enrolled and receiving such educational assistance.

''(2) Verification under this subsection shall be in an electronic form prescribed by the Secretary.

''(3) If an individual fails to submit the verification required under paragraph (1)(B) for two consecutive months, the Secretary may not make a monthly stipend payment to the individual under this section until the individual submits such verification.''.

(b) EFFECTIVE DATE.—The amendment made by subsection (a) shall take effect on August 1, 2020.

SEC. 4. CLARIFICATION REGARDING THE DEPENDENTS TO WHOM ENTITLEMENT TO EDUCATIONAL ASSISTANCE MAY BE TRANSFERRED UNDER THE POST 9/11 EDUCATIONAL ASSISTANCE PROGRAM.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Section 3319(c) of title 38, United States Code, is amended to read as follows:

''(c) ELIGIBLE DEPENDENTS.—

''(1) TRANSFER.—An individual approved to transfer an entitlement to educational assistance under this section may transfer the individual's entitlement to an eligible dependent or a combination of eligible dependents.

''(2) DEFINITION OF ELIGIBLE DEPENDENT.—For purposes of this subsection, the term 'eligible dependent' has the meaning given the term 'dependent' under paragraph (2) of section 1072 of title 10.''.

(b) APPLICABILITY.—The amendment made by subsection (a) shall apply with respect to educational assistance payable under chapter 33 of title 38, United States Code, before, on, or after the date of the enactment of this Act.

SEC. 5. EXPANSION OF REASONS FOR WHICH A COURSE OF EDUCATION MAY BE DISAPPROVED.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Section 3672(b)(2) of title 38, United States Code, is amended—

(1) in subparagraph (A)(i), by inserting or ''or (D)'' after ''subparagraph (C)''; and

(2) by adding at the end the following new subparagraph:

''(D) A program that is described in subparagraph (A)(i) of this paragraph and offered by an educational institution that is at risk of losing accreditation shall not be deemed to be approved for purposes of this chapter. For purposes of this subparagraph, an educational institution is at risk of losing accreditation if that educational institution has received from the relevant accrediting agency or association a notice described in section 3673(e)(2)(D) of this title.''.

(b) EFFECTIVE DATE.—The amendment made by subsection (a) shall take effect on the date that is 180 days after the date of the enactment of this Act.

SEC. 6. OVERSIGHT OF EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTIONS SUBJECT TO GOVERNMENT ACTION FOR PURPOSES OF THE EDUCATIONAL ASSISTANCE PROGRAMS OF THE DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Section 3673 of title 38, United States Code, is amended by adding at the end the following new subsection:

''(e) NOTICE OF GOVERNMENT ACTION.—(1)(A) If the Secretary receives notice under paragraph (2), or otherwise becomes aware of an action or event described in paragraph (3), with respect to an educational institution, the Secretary shall transmit such notice or provide notice of such action or event to the State approving agency for the State where the educational institution is located by not later than 30 days after the date on which the Secretary receives such notice or becomes aware of such action or event. A State approving agency shall perform a risk-based oversight survey to the educational institution by not later than 60 days after receiving notice under this subparagraph.

''(B) If a State approving agency receives notice as described in paragraph (2), or otherwise becomes aware of an action or event described in paragraph (3), with respect to an educational institution, the State approving agency shall perform a risk-based oversight survey to the educational institution by not later than 60 days after receiving such notice or otherwise becoming aware of such action or event.

''(2) Notice under this paragraph is any of the following:

''(A) Notice from the Secretary of Education of an event under paragraph (3)(A).

''(B) Notice of an event under paragraph (3)(B).

''(C) Notice from a State of an action take by that State under paragraph (3)(C).

''(D) Notice provided by an accrediting agency or association of an action described in paragraph (3)(D) taken by that agency or association.

''(E) Notice that the Secretary of Education has placed the educational institution on provisional status.

''(3) An action or event under this paragraph is any of the following:

''(A) The receipt by an educational institution of payments under the heightened cash monitoring payment method pursuant to section 487(c)(1)(B) of the Higher Education Act of 1965 (20 U.S.C. 1094).

''(B) Final punitive action taken by the Attorney General, the Federal Trade Commission, or any other Federal department or agency against an educational institution relating to misconduct or misleading marketing practices, as defined by the Secretary of Veterans Affairs.

''(C) Final punitive action taken by a State against an educational institution.

''(D) The loss, or risk of loss, by an educational institution of an accreditation from an accrediting agency or association, including notice of probation, suspension, an order to show cause, or revocation of accreditation.

''(E) The placement of an educational institution on provisional status by the Secretary of Education.

''(4) If a State approving agency disapproves or suspends an educational institution, the State approving agency shall provide notice of such disapproval or suspension to the Secretary and to the other State approving agencies.

''(5) This subsection shall be carried out using amounts made available pursuant to section 3674(a)(4) of this title as long as such amounts remain available.''.

(b) EFFECTIVE DATE.—The amendment made by subsection (a) shall take effect on August 1, 2020.

SEC. 7. ADDITIONAL REQUIREMENT FOR APPROVAL OF EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTIONS FOR PURPOSES OF THE EDUCATIONAL ASSISTANCE PROGRAMS OF THE DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Section 3675 of title 38, United States Code, is amended—

(1) in subsection (b), by adding at the end the following new paragraph:

''(4) The educational institution is approved and participates in a program under title IV of the Higher Education Act of 1965 (20 U.S.C. 1070 et seq.) or the Secretary has waived the requirement under this paragraph with respect to an educational institution and submits to the Committees on Veterans' Affairs of the Senate and House of Representatives notice of such waiver.''.

(2) by adding at the end the following new subsection:

''(d) The Secretary shall submit to Congress an annual report on any waivers issued pursuant to subsection (b)(4) or section 3672(b)(2)(A)(i) of this title. Each such report shall include, for the year covered by the report—

''(1) the name of each educational institution for which a waiver was issued;

''(2) the justification for each such waiver; and

''(3) the total number of waivers issued.''.

(b) REQUIREMENT FOR APPROVAL OF STANDARD COLLEGE DEGREE PROGRAMS.—Clause (i) of subparagraph (A) of paragraph (2) of subsection (b) of section 3672 of such title is amended to read as follows:

''(i) Except as provided in subparagraph (C) or (D), an accredited standard college degree program offered at a public or not-for-profit proprietary educational institution that—

''(I) is accredited by an agency or association recognized for that purpose by the Secretary of Education; and

''(II) is approved and participates in a program under title IV of the Higher Education Act of 1965 (20 U.S.C. 1070 et seq.), unless the Secretary has waived the requirement to participate in a program under title IV of the Higher Education Act of 1965 (20 U.S.C. 1070 et seq.).''.

(c) EFFECTIVE DATE.—The amendments made by subsections (a) and (b) shall take effect on August 1, 2020.

SEC. 8. CLARIFICATION OF ACCREDITATION FOR LAW SCHOOLS FOR PURPOSES OF THE EDUCATIONAL ASSISTANCE PROGRAMS OF THE DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Paragraphs (14)(B) and (15)(B) of section 3676(c) of title 38, United States Code, are each amended by striking ''an accrediting agency'' both places it appears and inserting ''a specialized accrediting agency''.

(b) EFFECTIVE DATE.—The amendments made by subsection (a) shall take effect on August 1, 2020.

SEC. 9. CLARIFICATION OF GROUNDS FOR DISAPPROVAL OF A COURSE FOR PURPOSES OF THE EDUCATIONAL ASSISTANCE PROGRAMS OF THE DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Section 3679(a)(1) of title 38, United States Code, is amended by inserting ''(including failure to comply with a risk-based survey under section 3673(d) of this title and secure an affirmation of approval by the appropriate State approving agency following the survey)'' after ''requirements of this chapter''.

(b) EFFECTIVE DATE.—The amendment made by subsection (a) shall take effect on August 1, 2020.

SEC. 10. REQUIREMENTS FOR EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTIONS PARTICIPATING IN THE EDUCATIONAL ASSISTANCE PROGRAMS OF THE DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Section 3679 of title 38, United States Code, as amended by section 6, is further amended by adding at the end the following new subsection:

''(f)(1) Except as provided by paragraph (5), a State approving agency, or the Secretary when acting in the role of the State approving agency, may take an action described in paragraph (4)(A) if the State approving agency or the Secretary determines that an educational institution does not perform any of the following:

''(A) Prior to the enrollment of a covered individual in a course of education at the educational institution, provide the individual with a form that contains information personalized to the individual that describes—

''(i) the estimated total cost of the course, including tuition, fees, books, supplies, and any other additional costs;

''(ii) an estimate of the cost for living expenses for students enrolled in the course;

''(iii) the amount of the costs under clauses (i) and (ii) that are covered by the educational assistance provided to the individual under chapter 30, 32, 33, or 35 of this title, or chapter 1606 or 1607 of title 10, as the case may be;

''(iv) the type and amount of Federal financial aid not administered by the Secretary and financial aid offered by the institution that the individual may qualify to receive;

''(v) an estimate of the amount of student loan debt the individual would have upon graduation;

''(vi) information regarding graduation rates;

''(vii) job-placement rates for graduates of the course, if available;

''(viii) information regarding the acceptance by the institution of transfer of credits, including military credits;

''(ix) any conditions or additional requirements, including training, experience, or examinations, required to obtain the license, certification, or approval for which the course of education is designed to provide preparation; and

''(x) other information to facilitate comparison by the individual of aid packages offered by different educational institutions.

''(B) Not later than 15 days after the date on which the institution (or the governing body of the institution) determines tuition rates and fees for an academic year that is different than the amount being charged by the institution, provide a covered individual enrolled in a course of education at the educational institution with the form under subparagraph (A) that contains updated information.

''(C) Maintain policies to—

''(i) inform each covered individual enrolled in a course of education at the educational institution of the availability of Federal financial aid not administered by the Secretary and financial aid offered by the institution; and

''(ii) alert such individual of the potential eligibility of the individual for such financial aid before packaging or arranging student loans or alternative financing programs for the individual.

''(D) Maintain policies to—

''(i) prohibit the automatic renewal of a covered individual in courses and programs of education; and

''(ii) ensure that each covered individual approves of the enrollment of the individual in a course.

''(E) Provide to a covered individual enrolled in a course of education at the educational institution with information regarding the requirements to graduate from such course, including information regarding when required classes will be offered and a timeline to graduate.

''(F) With respect to an accredited educational institution, obtain the approval of the accrediting agency for each new course or program of the institution before enrolling covered individuals in such courses or programs if the accrediting agency determines that such approval is appropriate under the substantive change requirements of the accrediting agency regarding the quality, objectives, scope, or control of the institution.

''(G) Maintain a policy that—

''(i) ensures that members of the Armed Forces, including the reserve components and the National Guard, who enroll in a course of education at the educational institution may be readmitted at such institution if such members are temporarily unavailable or have to suspend such enrollment by reason of serving in the Armed Forces; and

''(ii) otherwise accommodates such members during short absences by reason of such service.

''(H) Designate an employee of the educational institution to serve as a point of contact for covered individuals and the family of such individuals needing assistance with respect to academic counseling, financial counseling, disability counseling, and other information regarding completing a course of education at such institution, including by referring such individuals and family to the appropriate persons for such counseling and information.

''(2) Except as provided by paragraph (5), a State approving agency, or the Secretary when acting in the role of the State approving agency, may take an action described in

paragraph (4)(A) if the State approving agency, the Secretary, or the Federal Trade Commission, determines that an educational institution does any of the following:

''(A) Carries out deceptive or persistent recruiting techniques, including on military installations, that may include—

''(i) misrepresentation (as defined in section 3696(e)(2)(B) of this title) or payment of incentive compensation;

''(ii) during any one-month period making three or more unsolicited contacts to a covered individual, including contacts by phone, email, or in-person; or

''(iii) engaging in same-day recruitment and registration.

''(B) Pays inducements, including any gratuity, favor, discount, entertainment, hospitality, loan, transportation, lodging, meals, or other item having a monetary value of more than a de minimis amount, to any individual or entity, or its agents including third party lead generators or marketing firms other than salaries paid to employees or fees paid to contractors in conformity with all applicable laws for the purpose of securing enrollments of covered individuals or obtaining access to educational assistance under this title, with the exception of scholarships, grants, and tuition reductions provided by the educational institution.

''(3) A State approving agency, or the Secretary when acting in the role of the State approving agency, may take an action described in paragraph (4)(A) if the State approving agency or the Secretary determines that an educational institution is the subject of a negative action made by the accrediting agency that accredits the institution, including any of the following:

''(A) A show cause order.

''(B) Accreditor sanctions.

''(C) Accreditation probation.

''(D) The loss of accreditation or candidacy for accreditation.

''(4)(A) An action described in this subparagraph is any of the following:

''(i) Publishing a warning on the internet website of the Department described in section 3698(c)(2) of this title, or such other similar internet website of the Department, that describes how an educational institution is failing to meet a requirement under paragraph (1) or (2).

''(ii) Prohibiting the pursuit by an individual of a course of education at an educational institution under chapter 30, 32, 33, or 35 of this title during the period beginning on the date of such prohibition and ending on a date specified by the State approving agency, in consultation with the Secretary, or the Secretary when acting in the role of the State approving agency, unless the individual was enrolled at the institution before such period.

''(B) The Secretary shall establish guidelines to ensure that the actions described in subparagraph (A) are applied in a proportional and uniform manner by State approving agencies, or the Secretary when acting in the role of the State approving agency.

''(5)(A) The Secretary may waive the requirements of paragraph (1) or waive the requirements of paragraph (2) with respect to an educational institution for a one-academic-year period beginning in August of the year in which the waiver is made. A single educational institution may not receive waivers under this paragraph for more than two consecutive academic years.

''(B) To be considered for a waiver under this paragraph, an educational institution shall submit to the Secretary an application prior to the first day of the academic year for which the waiver is sought.

''(6) On an annual basis, the Secretary shall submit to the Committees on Veterans' Affairs of the House of Representatives and the Senate the following reports:

''(A) A report, which shall be made publicly available, that includes the following:

''(i) A summary of each action described in paragraph (4)(A) made during the year covered by the report, including—

''(I) the name of the educational institution;

''(II) the type of action taken;

''(III) the rationale for the action, including how the educational institution was not in compliance with this subsection;

''(IV) the length of time that the educational institution was not in such compliance; and

''(V) whether the educational institution was also not in compliance with this subsection during any of the two years prior to the year covered by the report.

''(ii) A summary and justifications for the waivers made under paragraph (5) during the year covered by the report, including the total number of waivers each educational institution has received.

''(B) A report containing the recommendations of the Secretary with respect to any legislative actions the Secretary determines appropriate to ensure that this subsection is carried out in a manner that is consistent with the requirements that educational institutions must meet for purposes of other departments or agencies of the Federal Government.

''(7) In this subsection, the term 'covered individual' means an individual who is pursuing a course of education at an educational institution under chapter 30, 32, 33, or 35 of this title.''.

(b) APPLICATION DATE.—The amendment made by this section shall take effect on June 15, 2020, and shall apply to an educational institution beginning on August 1, 2020, except that an educational institution may submit an application for a waiver under subsection (f)(5) of section 3679 of title 38, United States Code, as added by subsection (a), beginning on June 15, 2020.

SEC. 11. OVERPAYMENTS TO ELIGIBLE PERSONS OR VETERANS.

Subsection (b) of section 3685 of title 38, United States Code, is amended to read as follows:

''(b) Any overpayment by an educational institution to a veteran or eligible person shall constitute a liability of the educational institution to the United States if—

''(1) the Secretary finds that the overpayment has been made as the result of—

''(A) the willful or negligent failure of an educational institution to report, as required under this chapter or chapter 34 or 35 of this title, to the Department of Veterans Affairs excessive absences from a course, or discontinuance or interruption of a course by the veteran or eligible person; or

''(B) the willful or negligent false certification by an educational institution; or

''(2) the payment is made pursuant to—

''(A) section 3313(h) of this title;

''(B) section 3317 of this title; or

''(C) section 3680(d) of this title.''.

SEC. 12. IMPROVEMENTS TO LIMITATION ON CERTAIN ADVERTISING, SALES, AND ENROLLMENT PRACTICES.

(a) SUBSTANTIAL MISREPRESENTATION.—

(1) IN GENERAL.—Subsection (a) of section 3696 of title 38, United States Code, is amended to read as follows:

''(a) The Secretary, or a State approving agency acting in the role of the Secretary, shall not approve the enrollment of an eligible veteran or eligible person in any course offered by an institution, or by an entity that owns the institution, engaged in substantial misrepresentation described in subsection (e)(1).''.

(2) DEFINITIONS.—Such section is further amended by adding at the end the following new subsection:

''(e)(1) Substantial misrepresentation described in this paragraph is substantial misrepresentation by an educational institution, a representative of the institution, or any person with whom the institution has an agreement to provide educational programs, marketing, advertising, recruiting or admissions services, concerning any of the following:

''(A) The nature of the educational program of the institution, including misrepresentation regarding—

''(i) the particular type, specific source, or nature and extent, of the accreditation of the institution or a course of education at the institution;

''(ii) whether a student may transfer course credits to another institution;

''(iii) conditions under which the institution will accept transfer credits earned at another institution;

''(iv) whether successful completion of a course of instruction qualifies a student—

''(I) for acceptance to a labor union or similar organization; or

''(II) to receive, to apply to take, or to take an examination required to receive a local, State, or Federal license, or a nongovernmental certification required as a precondition for employment, or to perform certain functions in the States in which the educational program is offered, or to meet additional conditions that the institution knows or reasonably should know are generally needed to secure employment in a recognized occupation for which the program is represented to prepare students;

''(v) the requirements for successfully completing the course of study or program and the circumstances that would constitute grounds for terminating the student's enrollment;

''(vi) whether the courses of education at the institution are recommended or have been the subject of unsolicited testimonials or endorsements by—

''(I) vocational counselors, high schools, colleges, educational organizations, employment agencies, members of a particular industry, students, former students, or others; or

''(II) officials of a local or State government or the Federal Government;

''(vii) the size, location, facilities, or equipment of the institution;

''(viii) the availability, frequency, and appropriateness of the courses of education and programs to the employment objectives that the institution states the courses and programs are designed to meet;

''(ix) the nature, age, and availability of the training devices or equipment of the institution and the appropriateness to the employment objectives that the institution states the courses and programs are designed to meet;

''(x) the number, availability, and qualifications, including the training and experience, of the faculty and other personnel of the institution;

''(xi) the availability of part-time employment or other forms of financial assistance;

''(xii) the nature and availability of any tutorial or specialized instruction, guidance and counseling, or other supplementary assistance the institution ill provide students before, during, or after the completion of a course of education;

''(xiii) the nature or extent of any prerequisites established for enrollment in any course of education;

''(xiv) the subject matter, content of the course of education, or any other fact related to the degree, diploma, certificate of completion, or any similar document that the student is to be, or is, awarded upon completion of the course of education; and

''(xv) whether the degree that the institution will confer upon completion of the course of education has been authorized by the appropriate State educational agency, including with respect to cases where the institution fails to disclose facts regarding the lack of such authorization in any advertising or promotional materials that reference such degree.

''(B) The financial charges of the institution, including misrepresentation regarding—

''(i) offers of scholarships to pay all or part of a course charge;

''(ii) whether a particular charge is the customary charge at the institution for a course;

''(iii) the cost of the program and the refund policy of the institution if the student does not complete the program;

''(iv) the availability or nature of any financial assistance offered to students, including a student's responsibility to repay any loans, regardless of whether the student is successful in completing the program and obtaining employment; and

''(v) the student's right to reject any particular type of financial aid or other assistance, or whether the student must apply for a particular type of financial aid, such as financing offered by the institution.

''(C) The employability of the graduates of the institution, including misrepresentation regarding—

''(i) the relationship of the institution with any organization, employment agency, or other agency providing authorized training leading directly to employment;

''(ii) the plans of the institution to maintain a placement service for graduates or otherwise assist graduates to obtain employment;

''(iii) the knowledge of the institution about the current or likely future conditions, compensation, or employment opportunities in the industry or occupation for which the students are being prepared;

''(iv) job market statistics maintained by the Federal Government in relation to the potential placement of the graduates of the institution; and

''(v) other requirements that are generally needed to be employed in the fields for which the training is provided, such as requirements related to commercial driving licenses or permits to carry firearms, and failing to disclose factors that would prevent an applicant from qualifying for such requirements, such as prior criminal records or preexisting medical conditions.

''(2) In this subsection:

''(A) The term 'misleading statement' includes any communication, action, omission, or intimation made in writing, visually, orally, or through other means, that has the likelihood or tendency to mislead the intended recipient of the communication under the circumstances in which the communication is made. Such term includes the use of student endorsements or testimonials for an educational institution that a student gives to the institution either under duress or because the institution required the student to make such an endorsement or testimonial to participate in a program of education.

''(B) The term 'misrepresentation' means any false, erroneous, or misleading statement, action, omission, or intimation made directly or indirectly to a student, a prospective student, the public, an accrediting agency, a State agency, or to the Secretary by an eligible institution, one of its representatives, or any person with whom the institution has an agreement to provide educational programs, marketing, advertising, recruiting or admissions services.

''(C) The term 'substantial misrepresentation' means misrepresentation in which the person to whom it was made could reasonably be expected to rely, or has reasonably relied, to that person's detriment.''.

(b) REFERRAL.—Subsection (c) of such section is amended by striking the last sentence and inserting the following: ''The findings and results of any such investigations shall be referred to the State approving agency, or the Secretary when acting in the role of the State approving agency, who shall take appropriate action in such cases not later than 60 days after the date of such referral.''.

(c) REQUIREMENTS FOR NONACCREDITED COURSES.—Paragraph (10) of section 3676(c) of such title is amended to read as follows:

''(10) The institution, and any entity that owns the institution, does not engage in substantial misrepresentation described in section 3696(e) of this title. The institution shall not be deemed to have met this requirement until the State approving agency—

''(A) has ascertained that no Federal department or agency has taken a punitive action, not including a settlement agreement, against the school for misleading or deceptive practices;

''(B) has, if such an order has been issued, given due weight to that fact; and

''(C) has reviewed the complete record of advertising, sales, or enrollment materials (and copies thereof) used by or on behalf of the institution during the preceding 12-month period.''.

(d) APPLICATION DATE.—The amendments made by this section shall apply to an educational institution beginning on August 1 2020.

SEC. 13. ADDITIONAL LIMITATION ON CERTAIN ADVERTISING, SALES, AND ENROLLMENT PRACTICES OF EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTIONS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Section 3696(a) of title 38, United States Code, as amended by section 11, is further amended—

(1) by inserting ''(1)'' before ''The Secretary''; and

(2) by adding at the end the following new paragraph:

''(2) Not later than 120 days after a State or Federal department or agency takes final punitive action against an educational institution relating to practices described in paragraph (1), the Secretary or the relevant State approving agency may—

''(A) take an action described in subsection (f)(4)(A) of section 3679 of this title; or

''(B) disapprove under such section each course offered by that educational institution.''.

(b) EFFECTIVE DATE.—The amendment made by subsection (a) shall take effect on August 1, 2020.

SEC. 14. CHARGE TO ENTITLEMENT TO EDUCATIONAL ASSISTANCE FOR INDIVIDUALS WHO DO NOT TRANSFER CREDITS FROM CERTAIN CLOSED OR DISAPPROVED PROGRAMS OF EDUCATION.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Subsection (c) of section 3699 of title 38, United States Code, is amended to read as follows:

''(c) PERIOD NOT CHARGED.—(1) The period for which, by reason of this subsection, educational assistance is not charged against entitlement or counted toward the applicable aggregate period under section 3695 of this title shall not exceed the aggregate of—

''(A) the portion of the period of enrollment in the course from which the individual did not receive credit or with respect to which the individual lost training time, as determined under subsection (b)(2); and

''(B) the period by which a monthly stipend is extended under section 3680(a)(2)(B) of this title.

''(2)(A) An individual described in subparagraph (B) who transfers fewer than 12 credits from a program of education that is closed or disapproved as described in subsection (b)(1) shall be deemed to be an individual who did not receive such credits, as described in subsection (b)(2), except that the period for which such individual's entitlement is not charged shall be the entire period of the individual's enrollment in the program of education. In carrying out this subparagraph, the Secretary, in consultation with the Secretary of Education, shall establish procedures to determine whether the individual transferred credits to a comparable course or program of education.

''(B) An individual described in this subparagraph is an individual who is enrolled in a course or program of education closed or discontinued as described in subsection (b)(1) during the period beginning on the date that is 120 days before the date of such closure or discontinuance and ending on the date of such closure or discontinuance, as the case may be.

''(C) This paragraph shall apply with respect to a course or program of education closed or discontinued before September 30, 2023.''.

(b) EFFECTIVE DATE.—The amendment made by subsection (a) shall take effect on August 1, 2020.

SEC. 15. DETERMINATION OF BUDGETARY EFFECTS.

The budgetary effects of this Act, for the purpose of complying with the Statutory Pay-As-You-Go Act of 2010, shall be determined by reference to the latest statement titled ''Budgetary Effects of PAYGO Legislation'' for this Act, submitted for printing in the Congressional Record by the Chairman of the House Budget Committee, provided that such statement has been submitted prior to the vote on passage.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to the rule, the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) and the gentleman from Tennessee (Mr. DAVID P. ROE) each will control 20 minutes.

The Chair recognizes the gentleman from California.

GENERAL LEAVE

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I ask unanimous consent that all Members may have 5 legislative days in which to revise and extend their remarks and to insert extraneous material on H.R. 4625, as amended.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Is there objection to the request of the gentleman from California?

There was no objection.

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Madam Speaker, I rise in support of H.R. 4625, as amended, the Protect the GI Bill Act.

In 2009, before passage of the Post-9/11 Veterans Educational Assistance Improvements Act of 2010—the Post-9/11 GI Bill—the Department of Veterans Affairs supplied educational benefits to over 14,000 veterans and paid schools over $36 million in educational benefits.

Now, VA provides educational benefits to over 600,000 veterans and pays institutions of higher learning over $11 billion to cover the tuition, fees, and books for veterans on an annual basis.

The increased educational benefits enacted through the Post-9/11 GI Bill and the Harry W. Colmery Forever GI Bill of 2017 have made pursuing an education a viable path for many veterans

across the country. Schools across this country have embraced the influx of students to their campuses with open arms; and, in return, veterans have brought their knowledge, expertise, and ideas into the classroom and, eventually, the workforce.

Since 2010, most institutions of higher learning have provided student veterans with a means to upward economic mobility through traditional education and vocational training.

However, a small number of predatory schools have sought to expand their coffers by targeting veterans for their educational benefits, providing subpar educations in return. Not only do veterans lose precious time and benefits from being misled by these malicious actors, but it also costs taxpayers millions of dollars each year, which is why we must pass the Protect the GI Bill Act today.

The Protect the GI Bill Act would hold all schools to standards set forth by the principles of excellence outlined in Executive Order No. 13607. By codifying the principles of excellence, we are ensuring that schools can no longer misrepresent their student outcomes, job placement rates, and graduation requirements when marketing to veterans and members of the military.

The Protect the GI Bill Act also ensures that schools are upfront and honest regarding the cost of attendance, scholarships available for veterans before they take loans, and whether additional training is needed after graduation to pass State-based licensure or certification tests. This will allow veterans to make informed choices about the schools they want to attend to start their new careers and ensure that institutions are more accountable to veterans.

This legislation also includes Congressman BILIRAKIS' Student Veteran Empowerment Act, Congresswoman SUSIE LEE's Forever GI Bill Class Evaluation Act, Congresswoman SUSAN DAVIS' Reserve and Guard GI Bill Housing Fairness Act, and Congressman FOSTER's GI Bill Education Fairness Act.

This bipartisan legislation empowers State approving agencies to conduct targeted, risk-based surveys; eliminates waste in the Post-9/11 GI Bill program; ensures that spouses of servicemembers in the Reserves and Guard are not penalized when servicemembers are called to duty; and clarifies that servicemembers can transfer their education benefits to stepchildren, foster and adopted children, and other minor dependents.

As amended, the Protect the GI Bill Act also protects veterans by stopping them from incurring debt from Post-9/11 GI Bill overpayments. According to a GAO report, in fiscal year 2014, the VA paid approximately $10.8 billion in education assistance through the Post-9/11 GI Bill and made approximately $416 million in overpayments to veterans in about 6,000 schools. Approximately one in four veterans received an overpayment in fiscal year 2014.

Now, saddling veterans with unexpected debt is an injustice that we cannot perpetuate. This bill delays payments to schools, mandates that veterans confirm their enrollment each month, and prohibits late payment charges to students who are receiving GI Bill benefits.

The Protect the GI Bill Act would also allow more veterans to restore their educational benefits in cases where schools they attend close, are disapproved by a State approving agency, or are discontinued for other reasons outside of their control.

Current law only allows veterans to restore their education benefits if they attend schools that close or are disapproved by State approving agencies and if these veterans do not transfer any credits to another school or institution.

This requires these veterans to restart their education to restore the benefits, which could erode their motivation and cost taxpayers more money. There is no reason that veterans should be forced to repeat basic classes or core credits in order to regain their educational benefits.

This bill allows veterans to restore their education benefits while transferring up to 12 credits to another school.

The expansion of eligibility in this bill is retroactive and will allow thousands of veterans to recover their educational benefits upon the enactment of this much needed bill.

Madam Speaker, if our goal as a legislative body is to improve veterans' economic opportunities and end veteran homelessness, we must empower veterans to develop new and marketable skill sets in community colleges, universities, and trade schools.

We must also be good fiduciaries of taxpayer funds by enacting rigorous standards and providing adequate oversight of institutions who seek to collect funds from veterans' educational benefits, which is why I support this bill.

This bill also has the support of the Student Veterans of America and Veterans Education Success.

I want to thank Representative LEVIN for his hard work on this excellent bill. I would also like to thank Representative BILIRAKIS, Representative LEE, Representative DAVIS, and Representative FOSTER for their contributions to this bill, and I urge my colleagues to support it.

Madam Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

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Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Madam Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Madam Speaker, I rise today in support of H.R. 4625, as amended, the Protect the GI Bill Act.

Earlier this year, we celebrated the 75th anniversary of the original World War II GI Bill that helped launch the modern middle class. In the past 75 years, the GI Bill has helped millions of transitioning servicemembers get the training and education they need to be successful and help grow our economy. I used the GI Bill myself when I got out of the military.

Part of our role on the Veterans' Affairs Committee is to protect the GI Bill's important legacy and ensure that the incredible benefit the GI Bill provides remains available for veterans for generations to come.

The Protect the GI Bill Act would advance that goal by putting important protections in place to help student veterans make the right choice when using their GI Bill benefits by helping regulators flag and, if necessary, remove bad schools and programs from being eligible for the GI Bill.

This bill would also double down on our support for student veterans whose school has closed before they finish their program by restoring their GI Bill entitlement if the student is unable to transfer their credits to another institution.

I thank my friend and fellow longterm committee member, Congressman GUS BILIRAKIS from Florida, for his hard work on this bill. GUS is the ranking member of the Subcommittee on Economic Opportunity, and this bill includes the text of his bill, H.R. 4085, the Student Veteran Empowerment Act, and builds off his work in the 113th Congress to create the GI Bill Comparison Tool.

I would also like to thank Student Veterans of America, Veterans of Foreign Wars, and, especially, Veterans Education Success for their help in crafting this legislation. Their expert advice and counsel are critical to ensuring that we preserve the legacy of the GI Bill for another 75 years and beyond.

Madam Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I yield 3 minutes to the gentleman from Illinois (Mr. FOSTER), my good friend.

Mr. FOSTER. Madam Speaker, I thank the gentleman for yielding.

I thank Chairman TAKANO, Ranking Member ROE, and members of the House Committee on Veterans' Affairs for their steadfast commitment to the men and women of our armed services and for their work on H.R. 4625, the Protect the GI Bill Act.

Included in this bill is legislation of mine that I have been working on with Representative MCMORRIS RODGERS for some years now to remedy the bureaucratic oversight affecting military families across the country.

Under current law, the Department of Defense includes wards and foster children in their definition of an ''eligible child'' who is authorized to receive their parents' unused GI education benefits. However, the Department of Veterans Affairs does not. Unfortunately, this misalignment has led to a nightmare for some members of the armed services and their families.

This issue first came to my attention when a constituent, Sergeant First

Class Angela Dees, and her son, Christopher, reached out to my office to share their story.

Regrettably, their story is not unique, and they are not alone. To date, nearly 100 wards and foster children were initially approved by the Department of Defense for the transfer of GI education benefits, and money was paid out to their schools. Then, midsemester, the Department of Veterans Affairs revoked their benefits. The students and their families were notified that they would have to repay tuition expenses.

These families now face unexpected and crippling debts. They aren't just stuck with bigger loan payments but with outstanding bills. In many cases, the students even had to drop out of school.

Children of the men and women who serve honorably should not be denied the benefits that they were promised because of bureaucratic oversight. These servicemen and -women have honored the promise that they made to serve our country, and we need to honor the promises we make to them.

This legislation would correct this discrepancy and prevent this situation from happening in the future. Doing so would allow foster children and wards like Christopher, who were approved for GI education benefits only to have them revoked, to receive the education funding that they were promised.

I urge my colleagues to join me and vote ''yes'' on this critical piece of legislation.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Madam Speaker, I yield 4 minutes to the gentleman from Florida (Mr. BILIRAKIS), my good friend, a tireless working member of the Veterans' Affairs Committee. I know of no one on our committee who works harder for veterans, whether it is on PTSD or the benefits they have earned, than GUS BILIRAKIS.

Mr. BILIRAKIS. Madam Speaker, I thank the ranking member and the chairman. I appreciate them working with us on this very good bill. Also, Chairman LEVIN, who is not here at the time, does an outstanding job, and I look forward to working with him on many more bills.

Madam Speaker, as Ranking Member ROE just mentioned, one of the most important jobs of the House Committee on Veterans' Affairs is defending and protecting programs like the GI Bill that continue to provide life-changing education and training benefits to our Nation's veterans and servicemembers. I am proud that provisions in H.R. 4625 will continue this goal and are a by-product of several bipartisan hearings that I have led with Chairman LEVIN to improve oversight of the GI Bill.

I am also pleased that this package includes all the provisions from my bill, H.R. 4085, the Student Veteran Empowerment Act. My bill is designed to limit overpayment of GI Bill funds to students and schools, improve oversight of the GI Bill program by VA and State approving agencies, and, most importantly, extend the restoration of entitlement for student veterans impacted by school closures.

This last section extends benefits we originally provided to a limited number of students in the Forever GI Bill to all students. It extends to all students; that is important. It is critical to ensure that a student's entitlement is not lost when a school closes or is disapproved before the student completes their education.

My provisions in this bill would make important structural improvements regarding GI Bill oversight and accountability. These changes are important so that we can do all we can to prevent unnecessary school closures and ensure that a student's hard-earned benefits are used on training and education programs that will set up the veteran for long-term economic success.

Again, like Dr. ROE, I thank the veterans service organizations for their advice and suggestions, especially Veterans Education Success.

I also thank the bill's sponsor, as I said before, the chairman of the Economic Opportunity Subcommittee, my friend from California, MIKE LEVIN. It has been my distinct pleasure, as the ranking member, to work with him on this bill and on other issues that come before our subcommittee. He is a thoughtful legislator, and I thank him for including the provisions of my bill in this legislation before us.

I urge passage of this great bill, H.R. 4625.

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Let me just say that this bill, the Protect the GI Bill Act, contains so many elements offered by both sides of the aisle. I have to point out, for the RECORD, the coincidence of having the interests of foster children being protected by a man named BILL FOSTER. There are not enough people in here to get that joke, but I thought that was worth pointing out.

The language in this bill also contains enhancements to the authorities of State approving agencies. One of the broken parts of how our schools, our for-profit schools or all schools, get approved, get their programs approved, is because our State approving agencies lack sufficient authority to intervene when they know that a certain for-profit operation that has had a shady history is about to open in their State. This legislation would allow a State approving agency to act before a bad-acting for-profit school is actually charged, formally charged.

Madam Speaker, I have no further speakers, and I am prepared to close. I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Madam Speaker, I have no further speakers, and I, too, am ready to close. I yield myself the balance of my time.

I do want to say that this bill is indicative of how, when we work together, we can solve problems. You heard various issues from both sides of the aisle that were brought to bear and worked in the subcommittee and committee to solve these problems for constituents all across the country.

Madam Speaker, I encourage all Members to support this bill, and I yield back the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I yield myself the balance of my time.

I urge all of my colleagues to join me in passing H.R. 4625, as amended. Indeed, both sides of the aisle worked carefully together, and I am pleased to recommend that we pass this bill on suspension. I yield back the balance of my time.

Mr. SABLAN. Madam Speaker, I rise in support of H.R. 4625, the Protect the GI Bill Act, which restores education benefits for veterans impacted by recent for-profit school closures and provides the VA additional tools to keep schools who violate the terms of their GI Bill funding accountable.

For the past 75 years, the VA estimates the GI Bill has helped more than 25 million veterans and their families nationwide including the Marianas achieve their educational and career goals.

In recent years however, closures of several for-profit schools have left many veterans with degrees and credits that are not recognized or transferable and facing serious hardships from diminished GI Bill funds that also help pay for housing and other living expenses.

The Protect the GI Bill Act would help the victims of school closures by reinstating lost benefits and barring schools who do not meet quality standards for receiving GI Bill funds. Under H.R. 4625, schools would also be required to inform veterans of the actual cost of attendance including how much their benefits cover, as well as graduation and job placement rates. The bill requires VA and State Approving Agencies to take swift action on schools in violation of GI Bill requirements including suspension of new enrollments as well as bans on deceptive practices like automatic re-enrollment without the veteran's permission.

Passage of H.R. 4625 is critical to preventing future victims of school closures and ensuring veterans and their eligible family members receive a quality education for their hard-earned GI Bill benefits.

I thank the gentleman from California, Mr. LEVIN, for his leadership on this legislation and urge my colleagues to support H.R. 4625.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The question is on the motion offered by the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) that the House suspend the rules and pass the bill, H.R. 4625, as amended.

The question was taken; and (two-thirds being in the affirmative) the rules were suspended and the bill, as amended, was passed.

A motion to reconsider was laid on the table.

REDUCING HIGH RISK TO VETERANS AND VETERANS SERVICES ACT

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I move to suspend the rules and pass the bill (H.R. 4477) to direct the Secretary

of Veterans Affairs to submit to Congress a plan to address certain high risk areas identified by the Comptroller General of the United States regarding the Department of Veterans Affairs in the 2019 High-Risk List of the Government Accountability Office, and for other purposes, as amended.

The Clerk read the title of the bill.

The text of the bill is as follows:

H.R. 4477

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America in Congress assembled,

SECTION 1. SHORT TITLE.

This Act may be cited as the ''Reducing High Risk to Veterans and Veterans Services Act''.

SEC. 2. REPORT AND PLANNED ACTIONS OF THE SECRETARY OF VETERANS AFFAIRS TO ADDRESS CERTAIN HIGH-RISK AREAS OF THE DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) REPORT REQUIRED.—Not later than 180 days after the date of the enactment of this Act, the Secretary of Veterans Affairs, in consultation with the Comptroller General of the United States, shall submit to the Committees on Veterans' Affairs of the Senate and House of Representatives a report outlining the plan the Secretary has developed and the actions the Secretary has taken to address the areas of concern identified by the Comptroller General for the Department of Veterans Affairs in the 2019 High-Risk List of the Government Accountability Office (GAO-19-157SP) regarding—

(1) acquisition management; and

(2) managing risks and improving health care.

(b) ELEMENTS.—The report under subsection (a) shall include each of the following:

(1) Root causes of the areas of concern described in paragraphs (1) and (2) of subsection (a).

(2) Corrective actions and specific steps to address each root cause, including—

(A) the progress of the Secretary in implementing those actions and steps; and

(B) timelines and milestones the Secretary determines feasible to complete each corrective action.

(3) Resources the Secretary determines are necessary to implement corrective actions, including—

(A) funding;

(B) stakeholders;

(C) technology; and

(D) senior officials responsible for implementing the corrective actions and reporting results.

(4) Metrics for assessing progress in addressing the areas of concern described in paragraphs (1) and (2) of subsection (a).

(5) Key outcomes that demonstrate progress in addressing the areas of concern described in paragraphs (1) and (2) of subsection (a).

(6) Obstacles to implementation of the plan that the Secretary identifies.

(7) Recommendations of the Secretary regarding legislation or funding the Secretary determines necessary to implement the plan.

(8) Any other information the Secretary determines is relevant to understanding the progress of the Department toward the removal of the areas of concern from the High Risk List.

(c) ANNUAL UPDATES.—

(1) UPDATE REQUIRED.—Not less than once each year during the implementation period under paragraph (2), the Secretary shall submit to Congress an update regarding implementation of each element of the plan under subsection (b).

(2) IMPLEMENTATION PERIOD.—The implementation period described in this paragraph begins on the date on which the Secretary submits the report required under subsection (a) and ends on the earlier of the following dates:

(A) The date on which the Comptroller General removes the last area of concern for the Department from the most recent High-Risk List of the Government Accountability Office.

(B) The date that is eight years after the date on which the Secretary submits the plan required under subsection (a).

SEC. 3. ANNUAL REPORT BY SECRETARY OF VETERANS AFFAIRS ON IMPLEMENTATION OF PRIORITY RECOMMENDATIONS OF COMPTROLLER GENERAL OF THE UNITED STATES PERTAINING TO DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) ANNUAL REPORT REQUIRED.—Not later than 270 days after the date of the enactment of this Act, and not less than once during each of the subsequent three years, the Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall submit to the Committees on Veterans' Affairs of the Senate and House of Representatives and to the Comptroller General of the United States a report on the implementation of priority recommendations of the Comptroller General that pertain to the Department of Veterans Affairs.

(b) CONTENTS.—Each report submitted under subsection (a) shall include, for the period covered by the report, the following:

(1) The progress of the Secretary in implementing all open priority recommendations of the Comptroller General for the Department of Veterans Affairs.

(2) An explanation for each instance where the Secretary has decided not to implement, or has not fully implemented, an open priority recommendation of the Comptroller General for the Department.

(3) A summary of the corrective actions taken and remaining steps the Secretary plans to take to implement open priority recommendations of the Comptroller General.

(c) SUPPLEMENT NOT SUPPLANT CERTAIN REQUIRED REPORTS OR WRITTEN STATEMENTS.—The report under this section shall not be construed to supplant any report or written statement required under section 720 of title 31, United States Code.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to the rule, the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) and the gentleman from Tennessee (Mr. DAVID P. ROE) each will control 20 minutes.

The Chair recognizes the gentleman from California.

GENERAL LEAVE

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I ask unanimous consent that all Members may have 5 legislative days in which to revise and extend their remarks and to insert extraneous material on H.R. 4477, as amended.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Is there objection to the request of the gentleman from California?

There was no objection.

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Madam Speaker, I rise in support of H.R. 4477, as amended, the Reducing High Risk to Veterans and Veterans Services Act.

The Government Accountability Office provides important oversight across the Federal Government. As Congress' investigative arm, GAO audits and examines Department of Veterans Affairs programs and spending. The Comptroller General and his staff provide hundreds of recommendations on how to improve services and benefits. However, too often, GAO recommendations are ignored by the Department.

H.R. 4477, as amended, is bipartisan legislation offered by the Subcommittee on Oversight and Investigations' Chairman PAPPAS and Ranking Member BERGMAN that seeks to address, in a systematic manner, GAO's most notable and important findings and recommendations.

The act requires the Department of Veterans Affairs to develop a plan to address the two areas within VA identified as high risk by the Government Accountability Office. These are the Veterans Health Administration and acquisition management.

Every 2 years, the Government Accountability Office releases its High-Risk List of Federal Government programs most vulnerable to fraud, waste, abuse, or mismanagement.

Included in 2015, the Veterans Health Administration, the largest healthcare system in the country, remains on GAO's 2019 list.

This was the first year that VA acquisition management was placed on the High-Risk List as a result of inefficient use of acquisition funding and staffing resources, as well as numerous contracting challenges. VA's acquisition management is vital to VA's functioning because of its role in medical supplies procurement and construction, both of which relate directly to VA's ability to serve veterans and provide quality medical care.

The Reducing High Risk to Veterans and Veterans Services Act requires the Department of Veterans Affairs to develop a plan to address the two areas within VA identified as high risk by the Government Accountability Office.

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This plan will address the root causes of why these programs are at high risk and include specific timelines to correct the problems. VA will report to Congress on progress and ongoing challenges. The Department will also provide their views on whether Congress needs to take legislative action or provide additional resources.

This bill has the support of the American Legion, Veterans of Foreign Wars, and the DAV. I urge my colleagues to support this legislation, and I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Madam Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

I rise today in support of H.R. 4477, as amended, the Reducing High Risk to Veterans and Veterans Services Act. This bill was introduced by Congressman CHRIS PAPPAS from New Hampshire and my good friend, Congressman JACK BERGMAN from Michigan, the chairman and ranking member, respectively, of the Subcommittee on Oversight and Investigation.

Every 2 years, the Government Accountability Office, the GAO, publishes its High-Risk List identifying those activities that are considered high risk due to their vulnerabilities to fraud, waste, abuse, and mismanagement or that need transformation. GAO added managing risks and improving Department of Veterans Affairs healthcare to

its High-Risk List in 2015, and it remains there today.

Last Congress, the committee held a roundtable discussion with representatives from VA and GAO to address VA's progress towards addressing GAO's concerns. While it takes an agency, on average, 7 years to be removed from the list, VA has demonstrated little progress. Additionally, GAO added that VA Acquisition Management to its 2019 list.

H.R. 4477, as amended, would require VA to develop a plan of action to address deficiencies in acquisition management and healthcare that led GAO to place VA on their High-Risk List in 2015 and again in 2017 and again in 2019. It would also incorporate a provision under H.R. 698, a bill introduced by Representative JIM BANKS of Indiana, to direct VA to report on its efforts to address GAO's priority recommendations and GAO's top 30 open recommendations.

Our Nation's veterans and taxpayers deserve a VA that is high performing and that acts quickly to address areas of concern as they arise. This help will help ensure that they get it done.

I am grateful to Congressman PAPPAS and General BERGMAN for sponsoring this bill, which has my full support, but I would be remiss if I did not point out that this is another bill that did not go through regular order.

Madam Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I have no further speakers, and I am prepared to close.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Madam Speaker, it is my privilege to yield as much time as he may consume to the gentleman from Michigan (Mr. BERGMAN), a lieutenant general—and for those of you all who don't know what that is, it is three stars; I only made it to a major—to describe his bill.

Mr. BERGMAN. Madam Speaker, basically, when you have three stars, it just means you outlasted a lot of folks. But the point is the honor of being able to serve among marines, sailors, soldiers, airmen, and coastguardsmen is enough to make us all swell with pride because, you know, yesterday was Veteran's Day, and it is a real special day thanking the veterans of all wars for their service to our country.

I rise today in support of H.R. 4477, as amended, the Reducing High Risk to Veterans and Veterans Services Act, a bill introduced by Oversight and Investigations Subcommittee Chairman CHRIS PAPPAS and co-led by myself.

Every 2 years, GAO publishes its High-Risk List identifying those activities which are considered high risk due to their vulnerabilities to fraud, waste, abuse, and mismanagement or their need for transformation. Sometimes things don't always stay the same, and we need to move forward with the change.

As Ranking Member ROE stated, GAO added managing risks and improving VA healthcare to its list in 2015 and added VA Acquisition Management in 2019. This past May, the Comptroller General of the United States testified before the Oversight and Investigations Subcommittee, where I am proud to serve as ranking member, concerning the Department's efforts to add GAO recommendations.

Comptroller General Dodaro testified during the hearing: ''I want to emphasize hardly any area in the high-risk area gets off the list without sustained congressional oversight, as well, and action by the Congress. The engagement by the Congress is absolutely critical to the success of agencies coming off the High-Risk List.''

The intent of this bill is to focus VA on its efforts to remove these two programs from GAO's High-Risk List and give Congress the information needed to provide the sustained congressional oversight the Comptroller General said was absolutely necessary and needed to remove programs from the High-Risk List.

H.R. 4477 was amended in committee to incorporate provisions of H.R. 698, a bill introduced by Representative BANKS, which would require VA to report on its efforts to implement GAO's priority recommendations for VA.

I strongly encourage all Members to support H.R. 4477, as amended.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Madam Speaker, I encourage all Members to support the bill, and I yield back the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I urge all my colleagues to join me in passing H.R. 4477, as amended, and I yield back the balance of my time.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The question is on the motion offered by the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) that the House suspend the rules and pass the bill, H.R. 4477, as amended.

The question was taken; and (two-thirds being in the affirmative) the rules were suspended and the bill, as amended, was passed.

A motion to reconsider was laid on the table.

VA TELE-HEARING MODERNIZATION ACT

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I move to suspend the rules and pass the bill (H.R. 4771) to amend title 38, United States Code, to permit appellants to appear in disability compensation cases before the Board of Veterans' Appeals by picture and voice transmission from locations other than facilities of the Department of Veterans Affairs, as amended.

The Clerk read the title of the bill.

The text of the bill is as follows:

H.R. 4771

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America in Congress assembled,

SEC. 1. SHORT TITLE.

This Act may be cited as the ''VA Tele-Hearing Modernization Act''.

SEC. 2. HEARINGS BEFORE THE BOARD OF VETERANS' APPEALS BY MEANS OF TELECONFERENCE FROM LOCATIONS OTHER THAN FACILITIES OF THE DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Section 7107(c)(2) of title 38, United States Code, is amended—

(1) in subparagraph (A), by inserting ''or subparagraph (C) of this paragraph'' after ''subparagraph (B) of such paragraph'';

(2) in subparagraph (B), by inserting ''or subparagraph (C) of this paragraph'' after ''subparagraph (A) of such paragraph''; and

(3) by adding at the end the following new subparagraph (C):

''(C)(i) Upon notification of a Board hearing under subparagraph (A) or (B) of paragraph (1), the appellant may alternatively request a hearing by picture and voice transmission—

''(I) at a location selected by the appellant; and

''(II) via a secure internet platform established and maintained by the Secretary that protects sensitive personal information from a data breach.

''(ii) If an appellant makes a request under clause (i), the Board shall grant such request.''.

(b) DEADLINE FOR IMPLEMENTATION.—The Secretary shall implement the amendments made by subsection (a) not later than 180 days after the date of the enactment of this Act.

(c) REPORTING.—

(1) ANNUAL REPORTING REQUIREMENTS.—Section 7101(d)(2) of such title is amended—

(A) in subparagraph (E), by striking ''; and'' and inserting a semicolon;

(B) in subparagraph (F), by striking the period at the ending and inserting ''; and''; and

(C) by adding at the end the following new subparagraph:

''(G) with respect to hearings scheduled under section 7107(c)(2)(C) of this title—

''(i) the number of hearings scheduled under such section;

''(ii) the number of hearings under such section that were cancelled; and

''(iii) any statistical difference in outcomes between cases heard under such section and those held at the principal location of the Board or by picture and voice transmission at a facility of the Department.''.

(2) ONE-TIME REPORTING REQUIREMENTS.—The first report required to be submitted under section 7101(d) of title 38, United States Code, shall include the following information with respect to hearings scheduled under subparagraph (C) of paragraph (2) of subsection (c) of section 7101 of such title, as added by subsection (a):

(A) An outline of the outreach the Secretary of Veterans Affairs plans to conduct to inform veterans, families of veterans, survivors of veterans, veterans service organizations, military service organizations, congressional caseworkers, advocates for veterans, and such other stakeholders as the Secretary considers appropriate about hearings scheduled under such subparagraph, including—

(i) a description of the resources required to conduct such outreach;

(ii) a timeline for conducting such outreach; and

(iii) information related to the advantages and potential technological challenges of conducting hearings under such subparagraph.

(B) A description of any modifications to the information technology systems of the Veterans Benefits Administration and the Board of Veterans' Appeals required to carry out hearings under such subparagraph, including cost estimates and a timeline for making such modifications.

(C) A detailed description of the intra-agency partnership between the Board of Veterans' Appeals and the telehealth program of the Veterans Health Administration as the Board conducts hearings under such subparagraph, including best practices, a risk assessment overview, risk mitigation efforts, and a plan for ongoing collaboration and information sharing.

(d) COLLABORATION.—In developing the capacity and procedures to conduct hearings under subparagraph (C) of paragraph (2) of subsection (c) of section 7101 of title 38, United States Code, as added by subsection (a), the Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall collaborate with, partner with, and give weight to the advice of veterans service organizations and such other stakeholders as the Secretary considers appropriate.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to the rule, the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) and the gentleman from Tennessee (Mr. DAVID P. ROE) each will control 20 minutes.

The Chair recognizes the gentleman from California.

GENERAL LEAVE

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I ask unanimous consent that all Members may have 5 legislative days in which to revise and extend their remarks and to insert extraneous material on H.R. 4771, as amended.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Is there objection to the request of the gentleman from California?

There was no objection.

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Madam Speaker, I rise in support of H.R. 4771, as amended, introduced by Mr. CUNNINGHAM. I support this legislation that creates an easy technological fix so veterans can quickly and conveniently attend their hearings before the Board of Veterans' Appeals.

Applying for disability compensation and benefits through VA can be a long and confusing ordeal, which is further complicated in the appeals process. Currently, veterans often face difficulties traveling to VA regional offices for their Board hearings, difficulties including long wait times, scheduling challenges, or simply the distance an elderly or disabled veteran may have to travel.

Madam Speaker, the VA Tele-Hearing Modernization Act permits veterans to provide testimony before a veterans law judge via video conference from a location outside of a VA facility. This means a veteran could testify in support of his or her claim from the comfort of their own home.

Now, VA told us this piece of legislation could have an especially positive impact on hearing access for homebound or rural veterans. This bill ensures veterans have the flexibility to appeal VA's decisions in a comfortable, accessible location without affecting the security of their personal information.

The tele-hearing program is modeled after the existing telehealth program at the Veterans Health Administration and will likely improve hearing attendance and help veterans receive their benefits. A tele-hearing pilot program conducted by the Board showed increased participation in hearings as well as increased efficiency and timeliness of requested hearings.

Under this bill, VA is required to provide annual reports to Congress with information about how often the tele-hearing option is used by veterans and whether those claimants are as likely to have their claims granted as veterans using the traditional hearing methods. This report allows Congress to ensure this program is working the way it should.

I thank Representative CUNNINGHAM for introducing this bill, and I support this legislation for the step it takes to simplify the appeals process for our veterans.

Madam Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Madam Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Madam Speaker, I rise today in support of H.R. 4771, as amended, the Department of Veterans Affairs Tele-Hearing Modernization Act. This bill would expand the Board of Veterans' Appeals hearing options to include tele-hearings.

I appreciate my colleagues, Chairman ISAKSON, Chairman TAKANO, and Ranking Member TESTER, for working with me on this bill to ensure that the virtual hearing concept included in this bill represents the input of all four corners of Congress.

Madam Speaker, we all depend on and use our smartphones for just about everything we do these days. This legislation would allow veterans to use their personal device for a VA hearing.

I am happy that we are moving this legislation to make hearings more accessible to veterans, especially those in rural areas where I live or for whom travel might be physically challenging.

This bill was amended in committee to include additional reporting requirements that will help Congress monitor the implementation of this program. Specifically, the Board would be required to report on its outreach to veterans and stakeholders on the option for a tele-hearing, including the advantages and potential technological challenges of a tele-hearing, the IT modifications needed to conduct tele-hearings, and the partnership between the Board and the Veterans Health Administration, VHA, to share lessons learned from their respective programs since the tele-hearing program is modeled after the telehealth program that VA uses to increase access to care for veteran patients.

The amended bill would also require VA to collaborate with veteran service organizations and other stakeholders to ensure that those who represent veterans at these hearings will have input into how the program is developed so that it can best meet the needs of our veterans.

Madam Speaker, this bill has my full support, and I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I yield 4 minutes to the gentleman from South Carolina (Mr. CUNNINGHAM), my good friend, member of the Economic Opportunity Subcommittee, and author of H.R. 4771.

Mr. CUNNINGHAM. Madam Speaker, today I am proud to rise in support of my bill, the VA Tele-Hearing Modernization Act, which will make it easier for our Nation's veterans to appeal their claims with the Department of Veterans Affairs.

Currently, the Board of Veterans' Affairs only conducts tele-hearings from certain VA locations, meaning veterans have to travel to testify in support of their claims; and, in many cases, this forces Lowcountry veterans to drive all the way to Columbia.

My bill offers a commonsense solution to this problem by allowing veterans to teleconference into these hearings from the comfort of their own homes using their personal computers.

Further, this legislation will require these hearings to take place via a secure platform so that veterans do not have to sacrifice the security of their sensitive personal information to take advantage of this new process. This change will not only benefit those veterans who may be otherwise unable to travel for their hearing, but will also help to expedite the appeals process for veterans across the board.

With veterans given the freedom to participate in their appeals hearing from a place of their own choosing, no-shows, which add to the appeals backlog and slow down the process for everyone, will be significantly reduced, all with no additional cost to taxpayers.

□ 1645

The VA Tele-Hearing Modernization Act is exemplary of the sorts of advances that we can make when both parties come together for the sake of our veterans.

Madam Speaker, I thank Congressman KATKO for signing on as an original cosponsor. I also want to thank Chairman TAKANO and Ranking Member ROE for their leadership on the committee and for expediting this legislation, as well as their staffs for all their hard work.

Madam Speaker, I urge all my colleagues on both sides of the aisle to join in supporting this legislation for our veterans, who have sacrificed too much to need to jump through hoops for a fair hearing on their claims.

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I thank the gentleman from South Carolina (Mr. CUNNINGHAM) for his hard work.

I have no further speakers, and I am prepared to close.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Madam Speaker, I have no further speakers. I also am prepared to close.

Madam Speaker, I encourage everyone to support this. This is obviously, in rural America, how we are going to have access to healthcare in the future. It absolutely makes sense. This technology is available to almost everyone.

It makes no sense to make an infirm veteran or other patients go miles and miles and hours. This just makes sense. We have the technology to do it today, and I strongly support this and encourage my colleagues to do the same.

Madam Speaker, I yield back the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I urge all of my colleagues to join me in passing this important piece of legislation, H.R. 4771, as amended, and I yield back the balance of my time.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The question is on the motion offered by the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) that the House suspend the rules and pass the bill, H.R. 4771, as amended.

The question was taken; and (two-thirds being in the affirmative) the rules were suspended and the bill, as amended, was passed.

The title of the bill was amended so as to read: ''A bill to amend title 38, United States Code, to permit appellants to appear in cases before the Board of Veterans' Appeals by picture and voice transmission from locations other than facilities of the Department of Veterans Affairs, and for other purposes.''.

A motion to reconsider was laid on the table.

VA OVERPAYMENT ACCOUNTABILITY ACT

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I move to suspend the rules and pass the bill (H.R. 4360) to amend title 38, United States Code, to improve the due process accorded veterans with respect to recovery of overpayments made by the Department and other amounts owed by veterans to the United States, to improve the processing of veterans benefits by the Department of Veterans Affairs, and for other purposes.

The Clerk read the title of the bill.

The text of the bill is as follows:

H.R. 4360

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America in Congress assembled,

SECTION 1. SHORT TITLE.

This Act may be cited as the ''VA Overpayment Accountability Act''.

SEC. 2. REPAIR OF CREDIT.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Chapter 53 of title 38, United States Code, is amended by adding at the end the following new section:

''§ 5320. Correction of erroneous information submitted to consumer reporting agencies

''(a) CORRECTING ERRORS BY THE DEPARTMENT.—In any case in which the Secretary finds that the Department has submitted erroneous information to a consumer reporting agency about the indebtedness of any person who has been determined by the Secretary to be indebted to the United States by virtue of the participation of that person in a benefits program administered by the Secretary, the Secretary shall—

''(1) instruct the consumer reporting agency to remove such erroneous information from the consumer report of such person or take such other action as may be required to ensure that such erroneous information is not included in the report of such person; and

''(2) transmit to the consumer reporting agency such information as the consumer reporting agency may require to take such appropriate actions.

''(b) CORRECTING ERRORS BY DEBT COLLECTORS.—In any case in which the Secretary finds that a debt collector acting on behalf of the Department has submitted erroneous information to a consumer reporting agency about the indebtedness of any person who has been determined by the Secretary to be indebted to the United States by virtue of the participation of that person in a benefits program administered by the Secretary, the Secretary shall instruct the debt collector to request the consumer reporting agency remove such erroneous information from the consumer report of such person or take such other action as may be required to ensure such erroneous information is not included in the report of such person.

''(c) NOTICE.—Not later than 60 days after the date on which the Secretary issues an instruction under subsection (a)(1) or (b) with respect to a person, the Secretary shall notify the person that the Secretary issued such instruction.

''(d) DEFINITIONS.—In this section:

''(1) The terms 'consumer report' and 'consumer reporting agency' have the meanings given such terms in section 603 of the Fair Credit Reporting Act (15 U.S.C. 1681a).

''(2) The term 'debt collector' has the meaning given such term in section 803 of the Fair Debt Collection Practices Act (15 U.S.C. 1692a).''.

(b) CLERICAL AMENDMENT.—The table of sections at the beginning of chapter 53 of such title is amended by adding at the end the following new item:

''5320. Correction of erroneous information submitted to consumer reporting agencies.''.

(c) EFFECTIVE DATE.—The amendments made by this section shall take effect on the date of the enactment of this Act and shall apply with respect to deductions made under section 5314 of such title, administrative costs under section 5315 of such title, and suits filed under section 5316 of such title on or after such date.

SEC. 3. IMPROVED PROCESSING OF BENEFITS BY DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

The Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall improve the information technology of the Department of Veterans Affairs (including the eBenefits system or successor system) as may be necessary to achieve the following:

(1) NOTIFICATION OF DEBTS INCURRED.—The Secretary shall provide a notification to a person who—

(A) is entitled to a payment from the Secretary under a benefits program administered by the Secretary;

(B) incurs a debt to the United States under that benefits program; and

(C) elects to receive such notifications.

(2) REVIEW OF INFORMATION REGARDING DEPENDENTS.—A person entitled to a payment from the Secretary under a benefits program administered by the Secretary may review information relating to dependents of that person.

(3) TRACKING METRICS.—The Secretary shall be able to track—

(A) the number and amount of payments made by the Secretary to a person entitled to a payment from the Secretary under a benefits program administered by the Secretary who incurs a debt to the United States under such program;

(B) the average debt to the United States incurred by a person described in subparagraph (A);

(C) how frequently the Secretary approves and denies applications for relief under section 5302(a) of title 38, United States Code; and

(D) such other metrics the Secretary determines appropriate.

SEC. 4. AUDIT OF ERRONEOUS PAYMENTS BY VETERANS BENEFITS ADMINISTRATION; PLAN OF CORRECTION.

(a) AUDIT.—Not later than 180 days after the date of the enactment of this Act, the Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall complete an audit to determine the following:

(1) The frequency by which the Department of Veterans Affairs makes an error that results in a payment to a person by virtue of such person's participation in a benefits program administered by the Secretary that such person is not entitled to or in an amount that exceeds the amount to which the person is entitled.

(2) Whether and to what degree vacant positions in the Veterans Benefits Administration affect such frequency.

(b) PLAN.—Not later than 30 days after the completion of the audit under subsection (a), the Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall submit to the Committees on Veterans' Affairs of the Senate and House of Representatives a plan and description of resources necessary to align information technology systems to ensure that errors described in subsection (a)(1) are not the result of communication or absence of communication between information technology systems.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to the rule, the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) and the gentleman from Tennessee (Mr. DAVID P. ROE) each will control 20 minutes.

The Chair recognizes the gentleman from California.

GENERAL LEAVE

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I ask unanimous consent that all Members may have 5 legislative days in which to revise and extend their remarks and to insert extraneous material on H.R. 4360.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Is there objection to the request of the gentleman from California?

There was no objection.

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Madam Speaker, I rise in support of H.R. 4360, the VA Overpayment Accountability Act, introduced by Representative KIM.

This bill protects veterans by ensuring that the Department of Veterans Affairs reviews and updates its systems and policies to minimize overpayments in the future and mitigate negative effects on veterans.

Now, under certain circumstances, if the Department of Veterans Affairs makes accounting errors that result in overpayment of benefits, veterans are left saddled with debt. Then, within a short period of time, these veterans are required to pay these overpayments back to VA, placing an extraordinary financial burden on them.

The VA can, and sometimes does, withhold part of veterans' monthly benefit checks to recover overpayments, exacerbating these financial hardships.

In some cases, VA may send these debts to a debt collection agency, compounding veterans' financial stress.

If the information submitted by VA to a consumer reporting agency is incorrect either because VA later determines its payment was not in error or

because VA decides to waive the debt, veterans may still suffer harm to their credit. This bill makes sure VA rights this wrong.

Under this legislation, VA would be required to instruct the consumer reporting agency to remove any erroneous information from veterans' consumer reports. And if VA employs a debt collection agency and that agency then reports erroneous information to a consumer reporting agency, VA must instruct the debt agency to fix the error.

Importantly, this bill also requires VA to maintain future tracking metrics. This information tracks the number of VA overpayments, average amount of overpayment, and how often VA grants and denies veterans' requests for relief from this debt.

As we know, VA's information technology system hinders its ability to manage erroneous or duplicate payments. That is why this legislation requires an audit of overpayments, so whether it is its staffing shortages or IT failures, data can guide VA and Congress on where resources should be directed.

I wholeheartedly support this legislation to financially protect veterans, because it is an essential step that we need to take to ensure that veterans are not forced to face severe consequences due to VA's mistakes.

Madam Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Madam Speaker, I yield myself as much time as I may consume.

Madam Speaker, I rise today in support of H.R. 4360, the VA Overpayment Accountability Act.

Veterans receive overpayments for many reasons. For example, a veteran may erroneously receive drill pay and disability compensation at the same time. A veteran may reduce their course load after their GI Bill payment has been sent from the Department of Veterans Affairs to the school, or a veterans' marital status may have changed, but they continue to receive additional compensation for dependents. As a result, VA creates a debt that the veteran must pay back.

In some instances, the veteran may be aware that he or she had been overpaid and that VA will most likely ask them to return the money, but in other circumstances, they may not.

I am concerned that many overpayments are caused by VA's negligence, not the veterans.

Unexpectedly receiving a debt notification letter can create big problems for veterans and their families, especially if they can't afford to pay VA back; therefore, it is critical that the VA has the tools it needs to effectively prevent overpayments, and that if certain types of overpayments are unavoidable, VA's recoupment process is fair and considerate for veterans.

This bill is sponsored by Congressman ANDY KIM from New Jersey and is intended to ensure that veterans are not unduly harmed by VA's debt collection process.

Madam Speaker, I appreciate his leadership on this issue, and I urge my colleagues to support H.R. 4360.

Madam Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Madam Speaker, I yield 5 minutes to the gentleman from New Jersey (Mr. KIM), my good friend.

Mr. KIM. Madam Speaker, I thank the gentleman for yielding.

Madam Speaker, I rise today because America's veterans deserve America's best. They deserve the best healthcare and the best government service.

I introduced this bipartisan VA Overpayment Accountability Act with Congressman FRENCH HILL, because sometimes our veterans do not receive the best.

Through several programs, the Department of Veterans Affairs provides monthly payments to veterans and other beneficiaries. Because the VA often relies on outdated systems to provide those payments, those recipients sometimes receive overpayments at no fault of their own. When this happens, it is the veteran who pays a price.

In order to compensate for their mistake, the VA will withhold payment from veterans.

At a time in which 1.4 million veterans across the United States are struggling with poverty issues, withholding payment can have severe consequences for Americans who earned these benefits.

Because there is no limit on how much the VA can ask a vet to repay and no limit on how far back it can go to collect the debt, these sums can impact the credit and financial stability of veterans.

The VA Overpayment Accountability Act aims to fix these issues by improving the VA IT systems that are often the cause of these overpayments. It also provides credit protection for veterans who are the victims of overpayments and become targets of unfair practices.

As a grateful Nation, we should aim to honor our veterans, not send debt collectors after them because of a failure at the Department of Veterans Affairs.

Barbara Kim-Hagemann, the State Commander of the Department of New Jersey Veterans of Foreign Wars said in her endorsement remarks of this bill that it is imperative that Congress work to correct ''harsh Veterans Administration procedures in recouping benefit overpayments from veterans who are barely living paycheck to paycheck.''

Madam Speaker, on behalf of the thousands of veterans that Barbara fights for every day and the millions across our country who sacrificed in their service, I call on my colleagues to join me and Congressman HILL in this bipartisan effort to make the VA work and honor our veterans.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield 3 minutes to the gentleman from Arkansas (Mr. HILL), my good friend.

He is incredibly committed to our veterans. I have toured two different veterans' medical centers in his home State of Arkansas.

Mr. HILL of Arkansas. Mr. Speaker, I thank my friend from Tennessee and my good friend from California for their leadership of our Veterans' Affairs Committee. They are a dynamic duo. I appreciate the opportunity to be on the floor to be in support of this list of good bills tonight.

Mr. Speaker, I particularly want to thank my friend from New Jersey, Mr. KIM, for his hard work and collaboration on this important bill for our veterans.

Mr. Speaker, in the last 5 years I have served in this House, I have had over 3,200 cases completed and closed for veterans in my district.

As a former community banker, when I look at those cases and I listen to these stories, this too often is a challenge for our veterans. It is a crazy challenge. Mr. Speaker, that withholding a payment can have severe consequences for our brave veterans who are out there just doing their job, through no fault of their own and through a computer mess up or an IT problem, our veterans receive an overpayment and then suddenly get a letter a few weeks later saying, ''Oh, hey, we made a mistake. You owe us $5,000 back.''

Well, the normal American, Mr. Speaker, doesn't have that kind of financial planning expertise, and relies on the quality of our VA services to not make mistakes like that.

So it is a pleasure to work with Mr. KIM on this measure to try to improve that situation and answer the IG's own report at the VA that this is a serious problem affecting over 1.5 million veterans.

This bill tries to tackle this issue by improving Veterans Administration IT systems, which are often the cause of this challenge, and offers veterans that unknowingly are forced to go without their earned benefits for extended periods of time some recourse on being a victim of an overpayment and have their credit impaired.

I am proud to represent veterans from Camp Robinson and Little Rock Air Force Base in our central Arkansas area. I am proud to work on something that rectifies a common problem across this country.

Mr. Speaker, I thank my friend from New Jersey for his work and for the leadership of the committee for bringing this bill to the House floor.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, I want to extend, again, my gratitude for the insightful and hard work that the gentleman from New Jersey (Mr. KIM) has done with this legislation to correct an injustice

which has been occurring. I thank Congressman KIM for this very important legislation.

Mr. Speaker, I also want to extend my gratitude to the gentleman from Arkansas (Mr. HILL), whose district I have visited and whose medical center I have also visited. And I have to say that he runs a crack operation. That came out wrong.

He runs, not a crack operation, but amazing constituent services for his veterans.

You know, this unfortunate situation where the VA overpays veterans and then claws back those payments will be corrected by this legislation.

Mr. Speaker, I want to say I have no further speakers and I am prepared to close.

Mr. Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

□ 1700

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, I don't know about New Jersey and California, but a crack operation where we are is a good one, so I think I would take that as a compliment.

I thank Mr. KIM and my good friend Mr. HILL for their work on this.

It does create, as the chairman said, tremendous anxiety and problems for our veterans. It is needless. Many times, it is just a bureaucratic mistake. I think all of us have suffered those with the IRS or whomever, so this is a way to correct that. I thank these Members for bringing it up.

Mr. Speaker, I strongly support this bill, and I urge Members to.

Mr. Speaker, I yield back the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I urge all of my colleagues to join me in passing H.R. 4360, and I yield back the balance of my time.

The SPEAKER pro tempore (Mr. BEYER). The question is on the motion offered by the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) that the House suspend the rules and pass the bill, H.R. 4360.

The question was taken; and (two-thirds being in the affirmative) the rules were suspended and the bill was passed.

A motion to reconsider was laid on the table.

PROTECTING FAMILIES OF FALLEN SERVICEMEMBERS ACT

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I move to suspend the rules and pass the bill (H.R. 4356) to amend the Servicemembers Civil Relief Act to allow certain individuals to terminate contracts for telephone, multichannel video programming, or internet access service, and for other purposes, as amended.

The Clerk read the title of the bill.

The text of the bill is as follows:

H.R. 4356

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America in Congress assembled,

SECTION 1. SHORT TITLE.

This Act may be cited as the ''Protecting Families of Fallen Servicemembers Act''.

SEC. 2. TERMINATION OF CONTRACTS FOR TELEPHONE, MULTICHANNEL VIDEO PROGRAMMING, OR INTERNET ACCESS SERVICE BY CERTAIN INDIVIDUALS UNDER SERVICEMEMBERS CIVIL RELIEF ACT.

Section 305A(a) of the Servicemembers Civil Relief Act (50 U.S.C. 3956(a)) is amended by adding at the end the following new paragraph:

''(4) ADDITIONAL INDIVIDUALS COVERED.—For purposes of this section, the following individuals shall be treated as a servicemember covered by paragraph (1):

''(A) A spouse or dependent of a servicemember who dies while in military service or a spouse or dependent of a member of the reserve components who dies while performing duty described in subparagraph (C).

''(B) A spouse or dependent of a servicemember who incurs a catastrophic injury or illness (as that term is defined in section 439(g) of title 37, United States Code), if the servicemember incurs the catastrophic injury or illness while in military service or performing duty described in subparagraph (C).

''(C) A member of the reserve components performing military service or performing full-time National Guard duty, active Guard and Reserve duty, or inactive-duty training (as such terms are defined in section 101(d) of title 10, United States Code).''.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to the rule, the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) and the gentleman from Tennessee (Mr. DAVID P. ROE) each will control 20 minutes.

The Chair recognizes the gentleman from California.

GENERAL LEAVE

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I ask unanimous consent that all Members may have 5 legislative days in which to revise and extend their remarks and to insert extraneous material on H.R. 4356, as amended.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Is there objection to the request of the gentleman from California?

There was no objection.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, I rise in support of H.R. 4356, as amended, the Protecting Families of Fallen Servicemembers Act.

Mr. Speaker, this bill was introduced by Representative JOSH HARDER from California, and I thank him for his work with the committee on the bill. It expands on the work the committee did last Congress in partnership with Representative BUSTOS to improve the Servicemembers Civil Relief Act.

This bill ensures that spouses and dependents of both Active and Reserve component servicemembers who are catastrophically injured or pass away while in service to this Nation have protections under the Servicemembers Civil Relief Act, otherwise known as SCRA. Specifically, the bill allows impacted servicemembers or their families to terminate cable, internet, and phone service.

Servicemembers and families undergo difficult life transitions because of a catastrophic injury or death of loved ones. Families should have the flexibility to be at the servicemember's side during recovery. Surviving spouses and family members of fallen servicemembers should easily be able to move closer to family and friends or other support networks. Families dealing with the difficult loss or injury of their loved ones should not have to worry about contracts or cancellation fees.

I would like to note that this legislation unanimously passed the House last Congress and has been updated to reflect improvements recommended by veterans service organizations.

I also thank Dr. WENSTRUP, who served with us on the committee for several Congresses, for his focus on the issue and for working with Mr. HARDER on this bill.

Finally, I thank the Paralyzed Veterans of America for highlighting the need to include catastrophically disabled veterans and families in our work to improve the SCRA.

Mr. Speaker, I applaud the bipartisan work of Congressman LEVIN and Congressman BILIRAKIS on moving this bill through committee.

Mr. Speaker, I encourage all of my colleagues to join me in voting to pass H.R. 4356, as amended, and I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, I rise today in support of H.R. 4356, as amended, the Protecting Families of Fallen Servicemembers Act.

Mr. Speaker, this bill would amend the Servicemembers Civil Relief Act to give a spouse or dependent of a servicemember who experiences a catastrophic injury or who dies while in military service the ability to terminate telephone, multichannel video programming, or internet service contracts.

This bill would also extend SCRA protections to members of the National Guard and Reserve who are executing Active Duty orders or performing inactive duty training. These are worthwhile protections for our servicemembers and are worthy of our support.

This bill is sponsored by Congressman JOSH HARDER from California, and I appreciate his work.

Mr. Speaker, I urge my colleagues to support this bill, and I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I have no further speakers, and I am prepared to close.

Mr. Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield 3 minutes to the gentleman from Ohio (Mr. WENSTRUP), my good friend. Dr. Colonel BRAD WENSTRUP is a combat veteran of Iraq who is still on Reserve duty and has served at both Fort Belvoir Hospital and Walter Reed Hospital.

Mr. WENSTRUP. Mr. Speaker, I thank Dr. ROE for yielding.

Mr. Speaker, I rise today in support of H.R. 4356, the Protecting Families of Fallen Servicemembers Act.

Mr. Speaker, as a member of the armed services, I know how important it is to protect the families of those who serve when tragedy strikes. That is why I was proud to join Representative HARDER to introduce this legislation, which will allow the spouses and dependents of servicemembers who are killed or catastrophically injured in the line of duty to terminate their phone, internet, and TV contracts without penalty.

Last year, the Veterans Benefits and Transition Act of 2018 passed the House with overwhelming support. That legislation included a number of changes to existing law to protect our servicemembers and our Gold Star families.

However, due to a drafting error, the bill only allowed servicemembers, not their spouses and dependents, to end their phone, internet, and TV contracts without penalty. This bill corrects that error and ensures that grieving families are able to terminate contracts, giving them the freedom to relocate based on the needs of their families.

Mr. Speaker, I thank the House Veterans' Affairs Committee for advancing this legislation to the floor, and I urge all Members to support this bill.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, in closing, this is commonsense legislation—I talk about this a lot when I go home—about a grieving spouse, a husband or wife, who has lost a family member in combat in service to our country. I saw many of those this past weekend, as many of us did, as we attended veterans events.

I can't think of anything worse than being a spouse who is in a city that is unfamiliar to them, away from family, and to have these contractual obligations through our catastrophically injured veteran or a deceased veteran.

It is the right thing to do. Everywhere I go and talk about this throughout the country, our fellow Americans want this done.

Mr. Speaker, I strongly encourage my colleagues to support this much-needed legislation, and I yield back the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, I agree with my friend and colleague from Tennessee, Ranking Member ROE. This is commonsense legislation. We should not compound the suffering of a family, whether they are caretakers or grieving, with the complications that they may not be aware of, which are these continuing contractual agreements for cable, internet, or other types of contractual agreements of the sort. This bill addresses a way for families to easily terminate these contracts.

Mr. Speaker, I urge all of my colleagues to join me in passing H.R. 4356, as amended, and I yield back the balance of my time.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The question is on the motion offered by the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) that the House suspend the rules and pass the bill, H.R. 4356, as amended.

The question was taken; and (two-thirds being in the affirmative) the rules were suspended and the bill, as amended, was passed.

A motion to reconsider was laid on the table.

GI BILL PLANNING ACT OF 2019

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I move to suspend the rules and pass the bill (H.R. 4162) to amend title 38, United States Code, to extend the period under which an election must be made for entitlement to educational assistance under the All-Volunteer Educational Assistance Program of Department of Veterans Affairs, to phase out the use of such program, and for other purposes, as amended.

The Clerk read the title of the bill.

The text of the bill is as follows:

H.R. 4162

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America in Congress assembled,

SECTION 1. SHORT TITLE.

This Act may be cited as the ''GI Bill Planning Act of 2019''.

SEC. 2. PERIOD FOR ELECTION TO RECEIVE BENEFITS UNDER ALL-VOLUNTEER EDUCATIONAL ASSISTANCE PROGRAM OF DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Section 3011 of title 38, United States Code, is amended—

(1) in subsection (c)(1), by striking ''Any such election shall be made at the time the individual initially enters on active duty as a member of the Armed Forces'' and inserting ''Any such election shall be made during the 90-day period beginning on the day that is 180 days after the date on which the individual initially enters initial training''; and

(2) in subsection (b)(1), by striking ''that such individual is entitled to such pay'' and inserting ''that begin after the date that is 270 days after the date on which the individual initially enters initial training''.

(b) EFFECTIVE DATE.—The amendments made by subsection (a) shall take effect 180 days after the date of enactment of this Act.

SEC. 3. PHASE OUT OF ALL-VOLUNTEER EDUCATIONAL ASSISTANCE PROGRAM.

Subsection (a)(1)(A) of section 3011 of title 38, United States Code, as amended by section 1, is further amended by striking ''after June 30, 1985'' and inserting ''during the period beginning July 1, 1985, and ending September 30, 2029''.

SEC. 4. DETERMINATION OF BUDGETARY EFFECTS.

The budgetary effects of this Act, for the purpose of complying with the Statutory Pay-As-You-Go Act of 2010, shall be determined by reference to the latest statement titled ''Budgetary Effects of PAYGO Legislation'' for this Act, submitted for printing in the Congressional Record by the Chairman of the House Budget Committee, provided that such statement has been submitted prior to the vote on passage.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to the rule, the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) and the gentleman from Tennessee (Mr. DAVID P. ROE) each will control 20 minutes.

The Chair recognizes the gentleman from California.

GENERAL LEAVE

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I ask unanimous consent that all Members may have 5 legislative days in which to revise and extend their remarks and to insert extraneous material on H.R. 4162, as amended.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Is there objection to the request of the gentleman from California?

There was no objection.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, I rise in support of H.R. 4162, as amended, the GI Bill Planning Act of 2019.

Mr. Speaker, this bill was introduced by Representative JACK BERGMAN and Representative KATHLEEN RICE. Both of them are great members of our committee and tireless fighters for veterans. I thank Representative BERGMAN for his work on this legislation and his commitment to working with me on several issues related to veterans education and healthcare.

Mr. Speaker, with the enactment of the Post-9/11 GI Bill, the Montgomery GI Bill has become a less attractive option for many servicemembers. In most cases, the benefits are worse for servicemembers when choosing the Montgomery GI Bill instead of the Forever GI Bill. The issue is that many servicemembers sign up without knowing what they are signing up for.

For a servicemember to receive benefits through the Montgomery GI Bill, they must elect to pay into it when they first enter the military. Often, this is a chaotic period in a servicemember's life, to say the least. They are unable to give the decision much thought or do not fully understand the full impact of the decision at the time.

Also, there have been ongoing reports that some servicemembers are pressured to sign up by instructors at initial entry training or lose the benefit. This bill addresses this concern by moving the date when a servicemember elects to join the program so they can better understand and make a better informed decision.

Many end up signing up for the Montgomery GI Bill benefits only to never use them and never see them refunded. This is wrong and a waste of our servicemembers' money.

The committee will work to ensure that the Post-9/11 GI Bill is updated to ensure that future generations who may have benefited more from the Montgomery GI Bill than the Post-9/11 GI Bill do not see one bit of a drop-off in potential benefits. With the work we are doing to empower State approving agencies to improve the quality of education, now is the time for us also to improve the quality of benefits for our servicemembers.

I thank Representative BERGMAN and Representative RICE for their leadership, and I urge all of my colleagues to support the passage of H.R. 4162.

Mr. Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, I rise today in support of H.R. 4162, as amended, the GI Bill Planning Act of 2019.

Mr. Speaker, in order to be eligible for the Montgomery GI Bill, servicemembers automatically have $100 a month deducted from their paycheck for the first 12 months of their service for a total of $1,200. Currently, servicemembers have to elect to opt out of these payments just a few short days into their basic training or boot camp. From personal experience, I can say that is not the time to be making such an important decision.

This bill would extend the time the servicemember has to elect out of the Montgomery GI Bill to a 90-day period beginning 180 days after the date the servicemember enters training. It gives them 6 months to kind of think about it a little bit and then some time.

□ 1715

By delaying the decision to elect out of that Montgomery GI Bill, servicemembers will have more of an opportunity to research which GI Bill, the Post-9/11 GI Bill, or the Montgomery GI Bill is best suited to meet their educational needs in the future outside of the pressure and constraints of boot camp.

In addition, this bill would responsibly sunset the Montgomery GI Bill benefit for new enlistees in 2029. This would mean that current servicemembers or anyone who chooses this benefit before 2029, would not be impacted.

While the legacy of the Montgomery GI Bill benefit has helped thousands, it only makes sense to move to the more generous Post-9/11 GI Bill. This change would help ease confusion among student veterans and make things easier for the Department of Veterans Affairs to administer the benefit.

I am also glad that the text of my bill, H.R. 3608, which would extend in-state tuition benefits to veterans is also included in this bill. The 2014 CHOICE Act required that public schools charge veterans who are within 3 years of their discharge in-state tuition rates regardless of whether they meet the State's residency requirements in order to be eligible for GI Bill programs.

That requirement was waivable, but to date, all States and public schools are complying with it. Last Congress I was proud to coauthor the Forever GI Bill, which, among other improvements to the Post-9/11 GI Bill, eliminated the requirement that a veteran's 36 months of GI Bill benefits expire 15 years after their last discharge from Active Duty.

Now that this change has become law, it makes no sense to require that the veteran be within 3 years of their discharge to receive in-state tuition rates if they have their entire lives to use their GI Bill benefits.

I want to thank my good friend and colleague Congressman JACK BERGMAN from Michigan for all of his hard work on this bill, and I urge my colleagues to support the GI Bill Planning Act of 2019.

Mr. Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I have no further speakers and I am prepared to close. I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield 3 minutes to the gentleman from Michigan (Mr. BERGMAN), to debate his bill. General BERGMAN served as the chairman of the Subcommittee on Oversight and Investigations in the 115th Congress, and he is now the ranking member.

Mr. Speaker, I didn't get a chance to wish the gentleman a belated happy Veterans Day.

Mr. BERGMAN. Mr. Speaker, I thank the gentleman for his recognition.

Mr. Speaker, I rise today on behalf of H.R. 4162. But I would like to rise on behalf of not only the veterans, but also, the day before Veterans Day was the 244th birthday of the United States Marine Corps.

The point is, all of the members of the military who serve and have served, no matter what branch of service, we are proudly serving in the culture that we chose.

That would be, in my case, the Marine Corps. And we are honored that so many of our fellow veterans from the other services have chosen to join us in the celebration of service to our country. So it is an honor to be here, but also it is more of an honor to represent the veterans on the Veterans' Affairs Committee, so ably led by Chairman TAKANO and Ranking Member ROE.

As far as H.R. 4162, as amended, the GI Bill Planning Act of 2019, the support we have gotten across the committee on this is nothing short of spectacular and bipartisan. I would like to thank Congresswoman KATHLEEN RICE for her support in making this happen.

As Ranking Member ROE mentioned, during the first 2 weeks of boot camp, recruits are really not focused on making any big decisions, other than staying with the program and making sure that they get through boot camp. So they are not only asked to make a tough decision. They are actually required to make a very consequential decision at a time of extreme fatigue.

They must decide whether to opt out of their Montgomery GI Bill benefit or pay $1,200 to keep their eligibility for down the road later on when they are eligible to use it as a veteran.

Seventy percent of these enlistees are choosing to pay this relatively large expense, but few will ever use the Montgomery GI Bill. Rather, 97 percent of veterans today are choosing the newer Post-9/11 GI Bill, which usually amounts to a higher monetary benefit.

My legislation, the GI Bill Planning Act, would delay this decision to no earlier than 6 months after these young men and women have completed boot camp and entered service, instead of that first 2 weeks, again, very critical in their time for success in boot camp.

Additionally, this bill would responsibly end new enlistee enrollments in the outdated Montgomery GI Bill by October 2029. While the Montgomery GI Bill has helped millions of veterans since 1984, it is time to simplify benefits and sunset this bill.

Mr. Speaker, not only can this legislation save enlistees money, but it can also ensure that they are more informed in their educational benefits decisions. It is important that these motivated young men and women know that we in Congress have their backs and are thinking of them as they plan their bright futures in service to our great Nation.

I urge my colleagues to support H.R. 4162, as amended.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I, too, wish the Marine Corps a happy birthday, but as usual, they are behind the Army. Their birthday is later than the U.S. Army which is older than the Marine Corps. I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Let me just say, I wish to extend a belated happy Veterans Day to both of my colleagues, Dr. ROE and General BERGMAN. We certainly appreciate their service. I extend this congratulations and gratitude to all of our servicemembers, and I underscore all of our servicemembers, whether they be the Marines, the Army, the Air Force, the Navy, or the Coast Guard. And I understand the friendly rivalry, but I want to make sure that everyone knows whatever service they engaged, that America appreciates them.

Mr. Speaker, I have no further speakers. I am prepared to close, and I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

I, too, have no further speakers, and I am prepared to close. I recommend that all of my colleagues support this very commonsense legislation, the GI Bill.

I used the GI Bill in 1975–1976, when I got out of the Army. It was an amazing piece of legislation. It helped me then. I am appreciative to this day that my country invested $300 a month in me for 2 years, and that I got to use that. It really helped me a lot.

This bill that we have now, the Forever GI Bill, is a phenomenal benefit for young people. We know the GI Bill helped transform a generation after World War II. I believe this Forever GI Bill will transform this generation, and I wholeheartedly encourage my colleagues to support it.

I yield back the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

I wish to associate myself with the remarks of the ranking member regarding the transformative power of the GI Bill right after World War II, what it did for a generation.

I want to also take note that the Forever GI Bill was shepherded by Ranking Member ROE when he was the chairman and it still is an amazing, remarkable accomplishment that we

have made the GI Bill a lifetime benefit that can be used at any point in a veteran's lifetime. And, also, if they don't use it, they can transfer it to a spouse or their children. This is a remarkable piece of legislation.

It took cooperation of a minority working in good faith during the last session of Congress, and I think it is a remarkable accomplishment.

Mr. Speaker, I urge all of my colleagues to join me in passing H.R. 4162, as amended, and I yield back the balance of my time.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The question is on the motion offered by the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) that the House suspend the rules and pass the bill, H.R. 4162, as amended.

The question was taken.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. In the opinion of the Chair, two-thirds being in the affirmative, the ayes have it.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, on that I demand the yeas and nays.

The yeas and nays were ordered.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to clause 8 of rule XX, further proceedings on this motion will be postponed.

VA DESIGN-BUILD CONSTRUCTION ENHANCEMENT ACT OF 2019

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I move to suspend the rules and pass the bill (H.R. 3996) to amend title 38, United States Code, to provide for certain requirements relating to the use of the design-build construction method for Department of Veterans Affairs construction projects, and for other purposes.

The Clerk read the title of the bill.

The text of the bill is as follows:

H.R. 3996

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America in Congress assembled,

SECTION 1. SHORT TITLE.

This Act may be cited as the ''VA Design-Build Construction Enhancement Act of 2019''.

SEC. 2. FINDINGS; SENSE OF CONGRESS REGARDING THE DESIGN-BUILD CONSTRUCTION METHOD FOR DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS CONSTRUCTION PROJECTS.

(a) FINDINGS.—Congress makes the following findings:

(1) The Inspector General of the Department of Veterans Affairs found that, in the Aurora, Colorado, replacement medical center project, the Department decided to change its acquisition strategy from traditional design-bid-build to integrated-design and construct in the fourth year of the project, which was too late for the integrated design-construction firm to provide effective input into the design.

(2) In response to deficiencies in the Department's management of the Aurora, Colorado, replacement medical center project and in order to prevent reoccurrence of such deficiencies in the future, Congress enacted section 8103 of title 38, United States Code, which mandates that an appropriate non-Department Federal entity take over management of future super construction projects of the Department, including project design, acquisition, construction, and contract changes.

(3) It has been the policy of the Federal Government since the enactment of the Clinger-Cohen Act of 1996 (Public Law 104–106) that design-build shall be used when appropriate circumstances are present.

(b) SENSE OF CONGRESS.—It is the sense of Congress that—

(1) the unsuccessful use of the integrated-design and construct acquisition method in the Aurora, Colorado, replacement medical center project should not be interpreted to mean that design-build, as described in section 3309 of title 41, United States Code, is unsuitable for construction projects of the Department of Veterans Affairs; and

(2) when used properly by adequately trained acquisition and construction management personnel and in the appropriate circumstances, design-build is an effective construction acquisition method for the Department of Veterans Affairs, which has been demonstrated to reduce change orders, decrease the duration between design completion and beneficial occupancy, and increase warranty protections.

SEC. 3. DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS USE OF DESIGN-BUILD CONSTRUCTION METHOD.

(a) USE OF DESIGN-BUILD SELECTION PROCEDURES.—Section 8106 of title 38, United States Code, is amended by adding at the end the following new subsection:

''(d)(1) If the Secretary seeks to enter into a contract for the design and construction of a building or facility, the Secretary shall use the procedures established in section 3309 of title 41.

''(2) In the case of a super construction project for which a non-Department Federal entity provides project management services under section 8103(e) of this title, the Secretary shall not discourage the entity from using the procedures established in section 3309 of title 41.''.

(b) COVERED CERTIFICATION PROGRAM.—Section 8103(g)(6)(A) of such title is amended by inserting '', including design-build construction'' before the period at the end.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to the rule, the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) and the gentleman from Tennessee (Mr. DAVID P. ROE) each will control 20 minutes.

The Chair recognizes the gentleman from California.

GENERAL LEAVE

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I ask unanimous consent that all Members have 5 legislative days in which to revise and extend their remarks and to insert extraneous material on H.R. 3996.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Is there objection to the request of the gentleman from California?

There was no objection.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, I rise in support of H.R. 3996, the VA Design-Build Construction Enhancement Act of 2019. This bipartisan bill encourages VA to use a method of managing construction projects termed design-build in appropriate circumstances.

In addition, this bill incorporates design-build training into the VA construction management curriculum. There have been multiple internal VA and Government Accountability Office reports that have been very critical, documenting serious delays in cost overruns in VA facility construction and other projects.

At present, both veterans and taxpayers are suffering from the cumbersome VA construction process. I am confident this piece of legislation will help deliver state-of-the-art facilities to our veterans in a more effective and expeditious manner.

Design-build is a proven way to deliver construction projects in a more efficient and timely manner. This method is widely used in the private sector, and it has been used in parts of the Federal Government for over 20 years.

For those of you who are unfamiliar with this technique, design-build is a delivery method for construction projects that combines the architectural, engineering, and construction services into a single contract. It is an innovation from traditional design-bid-build construction, where design and construction are sequential and performed by different contractors, thus creating costly and lengthy timelines for delivering much-needed sites of care for our veterans.

Over the years, the Department of Veterans Affairs has faced numerous challenges when it comes to managing construction projects. I am aware that some of these challenges are caused by Congress due to the time it takes to authorize and secure funds for new builds. However, a good portion of these construction challenges are self-inflicted.

This committee is intimately aware of the Rocky Mountain Regional VA Medical Center in Aurora, Colorado. Not only was the opening of the new state-of-the-art medical center several years delayed, it was $1 billion over budget. This is a tragic disservice to our Nation's veterans and taxpayers.

Unfortunately, Aurora, Colorado, is only one of several examples of challenged VA construction projects. The VA is currently facing a multimillion-dollar backlog of construction projects. I am confident that a shift to design-build in appropriate circumstances could tremendously decrease the cost and shorten the length of time for VA construction projects.

Mr. Speaker, I urge all Members to support H.R. 3996, and I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, I rise today in support of H.R. 3996, the VA Design-Build Construction Enhancement Act of 2019.

This bill is sponsored by my good friend Congressman JIM BANKS from Indiana. Congressman BANKS is a former chairman and current ranking member of the Subcommittee on Technology Modernization and a tireless advocate for his fellow veterans.

His bill would encourage the use of the design-build construction method in the Department of Veterans Affairs by adding a reference to VA's construction statute, to existing government-

wide design-build construction procedures; prohibiting VA from discouraging other Federal agencies that manage construction projects on VA's behalf from using design-build; and incorporating design-build into VA's construction management training curriculum.

Design-build is a construction delivery method that is characterized by combining architectural, engineering, and construction services into a single contract. Design-build has been used successfully across the Federal Government since the mid-1990s.

When used appropriately, it can accelerate the completion of construction projects, reduce change orders, and increase warranty protections.

However, design-build has been used infrequently by VA, particularly after it was unfairly blamed for the troubles that plagued the replacement medical center construction project in Aurora, Colorado, which is just outside of Denver, despite not being used until 4 years into that project when the majority of the design-build had already been completed.

As the chairman said, that project was $1 billion over budget. And to put that in perspective for just regular folks like me out there where I live, that is 1,000 million dollars over budget. That is how much a billion is.

□ 1730

I believe that VA could have avoided these excessive change orders and other issues that caused the delays and cost overruns that came to characterize the Denver project had they incorporated design-build principles much earlier.

Moving forward, I hope that the Department learns from the difficult lessons that Denver taught and does not shy away from using the design-build method, when appropriate, to deliver high-quality construction projects to serve our Nation's veterans.

I thank Congressman BANKS for his work on this bill; and while I wish Chairman TAKANO had used regular order to bring it forward, I am pleased to support its passage today.

Mr. Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I have no further speakers. I am prepared to close, and I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield 3 minutes to the gentleman from Indiana (Mr. BANKS), my good friend. I have had a chance to visit his district and VA and talked to many groups in his district. There is no more passionate member of our committee than Congressman BANKS.

Mr. BANKS. Mr. Speaker, I thank the gentleman for yielding.

Mr. Speaker, I rise today in strong support of my legislation, H.R. 3996, the VA Design-Build Construction Enhancement Act.

I first want to thank Mr. PERLMUTTER, my colleague on the other side of the aisle, for his tireless support and advocacy for veterans in the Denver area and beyond and for cosponsoring this legislation with me.

Design-build has proven itself to be an innovative and effective method for managing construction projects in the private sector and in some key Federal agencies. The most prominent application of design-build was to rebuild the Pentagon after 9/11, which was completed in less than 1 year.

VA has a multibillion-dollar backlog of construction projects but has never made much use of the design-build method, despite it being available for over 20 years. Unfortunately, one of the few times the VA did use a method similar to design-build was during the troubled Aurora, Colorado, replacement medical center project that we have already heard about today.

And as Dr. ROE noted, the VA only involved the construction contractor in the design decisions after the design was already complete. Design-build seems to have been given a bad name in the VA—unfairly—as a result.

My legislation today makes it clear that design-build is available to the VA and encourages the Department to use it when appropriate, as is already stipulated by the law, and incorporates design-build training into the VA construction management curriculum.

Mr. Speaker, I want to make sure that the VA is using every available tool to deliver world-class facilities to our veterans. When used correctly, design-build can speed up construction and minimize costly change orders. That is exactly what we need in the VA, and I am committed to making sure that that happens.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I have no further speakers, and I yield myself such time as I may consume.

I think this is commonsense legislation, and certainly we can avoid what happened in Denver. That thousand million dollars could have been spent on veterans' healthcare or benefits or other much-needed projects in the VA. We don't have an endless supply of money.

I certainly appreciate Mr. BANKS' work on this.

Mr. Speaker, I urge all of my colleagues to support this legislation, and I yield back the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, let me just say that, as a former community college trustee that had responsibility for overseeing many projects that were undertaken to build out the community college district, design-build was employed in those instances. And where appropriately used, I agree with the comments by my friends from the other side of the aisle that this can make future VA construction projects more efficient and more cost-effective for our taxpayers.

Mr. Speaker, I urge all of my colleagues to join me in passing H.R. 3996, and I yield back the balance of my time.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The question is on the motion offered by the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) that the House suspend the rules and pass the bill, H.R. 3996.

The question was taken; and (two-thirds being in the affirmative) the rules were suspended and the bill was passed.

A motion to reconsider was laid on the table.

FALLEN WARRIOR BATTLEFIELD CROSS MEMORIAL ACT

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I move to suspend the rules and pass the bill (H.R. 1424) to amend title 38, United States Code, to ensure the Secretary of Veterans Affairs permits the display of Fallen Soldier Displays in national cemeteries.

The Clerk read the title of the bill.

The text of the bill is as follows:

H.R. 1424

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America in Congress assembled,

SECTION 1. SHORT TITLE.

This Act may be cited as the ''Fallen Warrior Battlefield Cross Memorial Act''.

SEC. 2. AUTHORIZATION FOR FALLEN SOLDIER DISPLAYS IN NATIONAL CEMETERIES.

Section 2403 of title 38, United States Code, is amended by adding at the end the following new subsection:

''(d)(1) Subject to standards established by the Secretary, the Secretary shall permit the display of a Fallen Soldier Display in any national cemetery.

''(2) In this subsection, the term 'Fallen Soldier Display' means a memorial monument in honor of fallen members of the Armed Forces that may include a replica of an inverted rifle, boots, helmets, and identification tag.''.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to the rule, the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) and the gentleman from Tennessee (Mr. DAVID P. ROE) each will control 20 minutes.

The Chair recognizes the gentleman from California.

GENERAL LEAVE

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I ask unanimous consent that all Members may have 5 legislative days in which to revise and extend their remarks and to insert extraneous material on H.R. 1424.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Is there objection to the request of the gentleman from California?

There was no objection.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, I rise in support of H.R. 1424, the Fallen Warrior Battlefield Cross Memorial Act, introduced by Representative ANTHONY GONZALEZ of Ohio.

This act permits the Secretary of the VA to allow the Fallen Soldier Display, also known as the Battlefield Cross Memorial, in national cemeteries.

Battlefield crosses honor fallen soldiers using symbols of their service. These symbols have evolved since their

initial use in the American Revolutionary War when they were used as a crude marker as the position of a fallen soldier. The cultural position remains today, as units in theater traditionally hold a remembrance ceremony in country to allow the unit to pay last respects to those killed in action.

These displays are meant to honor those who lost their lives in service by featuring replicas of inverted rifles, boots, helmets, and identification tags. A U.S. Army field manual states: ''The helmet and identification tags signify the dead soldier. The inverted rifle with bayonet signals a time for prayer, a break in the action to pay tribute to our comrade. The combat boots represent the final march of the last battle.''

VA's National Cemetery Administration currently allows for display of a cross, but it has not specifically addressed the Battlefield Cross Memorial. In fact, in 2017, a Battlefield Cross Memorial was removed from the Ohio Western Reserve National Cemetery.

Though the cemetery ultimately decided to restore the memorial, this legislation would ensure the Battlefield Cross Memorial would also be permitted at national cemeteries and prevent future misinterpretations.

Mr. Speaker, we recognize the sacrifices of the women and men who gave their lives in service to our Nation and the right of a community to honor its fallen heroes. I urge all Members to support H.R. 1424, and I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, I rise today in support of H.R. 1424, the Fallen Warrior Battlefield Cross Memorial Act. This bill would require the Department of Veterans Affairs' national cemeteries to allow the display of the battlefield cross, which is a monument that depicts a fallen servicemember by an inverted rifle with a helmet and dog tags on top and a pair of combat boots at the bottom. We have all seen this.

In 2017, a VA employee misinterpreted VA policy and removed a battlefield cross from the Ohio Western Reserve National Cemetery, as well as two other similar memorials in cemeteries in Illinois and Michigan. The objection to the memorials were that they contained realistic depictions of firearms.

As one Ohio veteran described, this image is one that veterans ''have seen in battlefields, on ships, on aircraft carriers, wherever we lost men. It's a symbol of respect and thanks. . . . It means a lot to veterans.''

I could not have said it better myself, Mr. Speaker; although, I do note that the battlefield cross is a powerful symbol that is used to honor all of our fallen warriors, both men and women.

In response to veterans' and congressional concerns over the incident, the Department reinstated the memorial monuments and clarified that VA cemeteries can display this image. However, this bill is necessary to codify that policy and to ensure that VA does not ban this image ever again.

This bill has my full support, and I appreciate Congressman ANTHONY GONZALEZ from Ohio for introducing it and for his leadership on this issue.

Mr. Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I have no further speakers. I am prepared to close, and I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield 3 minutes to the gentleman from Ohio (Mr. GONZALEZ), the author of this bill. I appreciate the gentleman is a new Member, but it didn't take him long to jump into gear and to recognize a wrong and to right that wrong.

Mr. GONZALEZ of Ohio. Mr. Speaker, H.R. 1424, the Fallen Warrior Battlefield Cross Memorial Act is the first piece of legislation I introduced as a Member of Congress, and it is fitting that we discuss it on the floor today, just one day after Veterans Day.

This bipartisan legislation would protect the display of these memorials at our national cemeteries and bar the Department of Veterans Affairs from removing these tributes, as they did in national cemeteries across the Midwest in 2017. This legislation comes straight from the veteran community and my northeast Ohio district.

Over the past several years, Elton Boyer, the president of the 555th Honors Detachment, made this bill his mission as he worked to erect a Battlefield Cross Memorial at Ohio Western Reserve National Cemetery in Seville. He and the honors detachments at Western Reserve collected the spent brass from the military funerals they oversaw at the cemetery with the goal to someday melt them down and form them into a heartwarming tribute to the fallen warriors laid to rest.

When Battlefield Cross Memorials were removed from the cemetery in the fall of 2017, Elton's work was put at risk. Elton wrote my predecessor, Congressman Jim Renacci, for help, stating: ''It has been said that the soldier's cross is a symbol for caring, honoring, and remembering. 'No one is left behind.'''

Elton passed away last month, but I know that he is looking upon this House today, proud of the vote we are about to take. His efforts were not in vain.

Battlefield Cross Memorials stand in cemeteries across our Nation as a tribute to the service of fallen soldiers who have given their lives for our country. They depict the soldier's boots, helmet, dog tag, and inverted rifle, and have been a noncontroversial, time-honored tradition since at least the Civil War.

As Strongsville, Ohio, VFW Commander Tim Zvoncheck told me: ''It's imperative that this custom continues to be displayed for as long as the sons and daughters of this Nation are willing to give their lives in its defense.''

Michael Kuhn, a combat veteran from Massillon, Ohio, explained to me what this memorial means to him:

> The battlefield cross encapsulates so many of the most important things to a combat vet: the rifle, the boots, the tags, and, most of all, the fallen comrade. It's extremely important for us to have those things wrapped up in one memorial for us to kneel to, grieve with, and talk to our brothers in arms that have died the ultimate death in laying down their life for us and their country. As a combat vet, you relate to very little outside of that world and always feel like an outsider. Whenever you see that combat cross, it brings a somber, quiet feeling of peace for that moment that you have that direct line to your fallen comrade.

I thank Chairman TAKANO and Ranking Member ROE for bringing H.R. 1424 to the floor today and recognizing how important this legislation is to our veteran communities, and I urge my colleagues to vote in support of the bill, H.R. 1424.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I have no further speakers. I am prepared to close, and I yield myself the balance of my time.

Mr. Speaker, I can think of no other time better than the day right after Veterans Day to bring this up and to vote on this legislation.

I have lost friends in combat in the Vietnam War and know many families, as most of us have visited with families who have lost members.

I also want to say that nowhere in the country—really, in the world—do we honor our cemeteries more than the VA does. The VA does a phenomenal job in our national cemeteries. And I have had an opportunity to travel to Europe and visit those cemeteries in Normandy, Flanders Field, Chateau-Thierry, and many others.

It is really a place of sacred honor, these cemeteries are, and it is only appropriate that we allow and have this symbol there codified by law.

I thank Congressman GONZALEZ for his first bill. He can take great pride in having this bill passed and signed into law by the President.

Mr. Speaker, I encourage all of our Members to support H.R. 1424, and I yield back the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I wish to associate myself with the remarks of the ranking member regarding the beautiful work that our Cemetery Administration does for our veteran cemeteries and the National Battle Monuments Commission for the work they do with our cemeteries abroad. They are truly the pride of our country and fitting ways to show our gratitude and respect for those who have fallen in the service of our country.

Mr. Speaker, I thank Representative GONZALEZ for his work on this bill. I urge my colleagues to join me in passing H.R. 1424, and I yield back the balance of my time.

□ 1745

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The question is on the motion offered by the gentleman from California (Mr.

TAKANO) that the House suspend the rules and pass the bill, H.R. 1424.

The question was taken; and (two-thirds being in the affirmative) the rules were suspended and the bill was passed.

A motion to reconsider was laid on the table.

DEBORAH SAMPSON ACT

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I move to suspend the rules and pass the bill (H.R. 3224) to amend title 38, United States Code, to provide for increased access to Department of Veterans Affairs medical care for women veterans, as amended.

The Clerk read the title of the bill.

The text of the bill is as follows:

H.R. 3224

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America in Congress assembled,

SECTION 1. SHORT TITLE; TABLE OF CONTENTS.

(a) SHORT TITLE.—This Act may be cited as the ''Deborah Sampson Act''.

(b) TABLE OF CONTENTS.—The table of contents for this Act is as follows:

Sec. 1. Short title; table of contents.

TITLE I—VETERANS HEALTH ADMINISTRATION

Sec. 101. Office of Women's Health in the Department of Veterans Affairs.
Sec. 102. Expansion of capabilities of women veterans call center to include text messaging.
Sec. 103. Requirement for Department of Veterans Affairs internet website to provide information on services available to women veterans.
Sec. 104. Report on Women Veterans Retrofit Initiative.
Sec. 105. Establishment of environment of care standards and inspections at Department of Veterans Affairs medical centers.
Sec. 106. Additional funding for primary care and emergency care clinicians in Women Veterans Health Care Mini-Residency Program.
Sec. 107. Establishment of women veteran training module for non-Department of Veterans Affairs health care providers.

TITLE II—MEDICAL CARE

Sec. 201. Improved access to Department of Veterans Affairs medical care for women veterans.
Sec. 202. Counseling and treatment for sexual trauma.
Sec. 203. Counseling in retreat settings for women veterans and other individuals.
Sec. 204. Improvement of health care services provided to newborn children by Department of Veterans Affairs.

TITLE III—REPORTS AND OTHER MATTERS

Subtitle A—Reports

Sec. 301. Assessment of effects of intimate partner violence on women veterans by Advisory Committee on Women Veterans.
Sec. 302. Study on staffing of Women Veteran Program Manager program at medical centers of the Department of Veterans Affairs and training of staff.
Sec. 303. Report on availability of prosthetic items for women veterans from the Department of Veterans Affairs.
Sec. 304. Study of barriers for women veterans to health care from the Department of Veterans Affairs.
Sec. 305. Report regarding veterans who receive benefits under laws administered by the Secretary of Veterans Affairs.
Sec. 306. Study on Women Veteran Coordinator program.

Subtitle B—Other Matters

Sec. 321. Anti-harassment and anti-sexual assault policy of the Department of Veterans Affairs.
Sec. 322. Support for organizations that have a focus on providing assistance to women veterans and their families.
Sec. 323. Gap analysis of Department of Veterans Affairs programs that provide assistance to women veterans who are homeless.
Sec. 324. Department of Veterans Affairs public-private partnership on legal services for women veterans.
Sec. 325. Program to assist veterans who experience intimate partner violence or sexual assault.
Sec. 326. Study and task force on veterans experiencing intimate partner violence or sexual assault.

TITLE I—VETERANS HEALTH ADMINISTRATION

SEC. 101. OFFICE OF WOMEN'S HEALTH IN THE DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) DIRECTOR OF WOMEN'S HEALTH.—Subsection (a) of section 7306 of title 38, United States Code, is amended—

(1) by redesignating paragraph (10) as paragraph (11); and

(2) by inserting after paragraph (9) the following new paragraph:

''(10) The Director of Women's Health.''.

(b) ORGANIZATION OF OFFICE.—

(1) IN GENERAL.—Subchapter I of chapter 73 of title 38, United States Code, is amended by adding at the end of the following new sections:

''§ 7310. Office of Women's Health

''(a) ESTABLISHMENT.—(1) The Under Secretary for Health shall establish and operate in the Veterans Health Administration the Office of Women's Health (hereinafter in this section referred to as the 'Office'). The Office shall be located at the Central Office of the Department of Veterans Affairs.

''(2) The head of the Office is the Director of Women's Health (hereinafter in this section referred to as the 'Director'). The Director shall report to the Under Secretary for Health.

''(3) The Under Secretary for Health shall provide the Office with such staff and other support as may be necessary for the Office to carry out effectively its functions under this section.

''(4) The Under Secretary for Health may reorganize existing offices within the Veterans Health Administration as of the date of the enactment of this section in order to avoid duplication with the functions of the Office.

''(b) PURPOSE.—The functions of the Office include the following:

''(1) To provide a central office for monitoring and encouraging the activities of the Veterans Health Administration with respect to the provision, evaluation, and improvement of women veterans' health care services in the Department.

''(2) To develop and implement standards of care for the provision of health care for women veterans in the Department.

''(3) To monitor and identify deficiencies in standards of care for the provision of health care for women veterans in the Department, to provide technical assistance to medical facilities of the Department to address and remedy deficiencies, and to perform oversight of implementation of standards of care for women veterans' health care in the Department.

''(4) To monitor and identify deficiencies in standards of care for the provision of health care for women veterans provided through the community pursuant to this title, and to provide recommendations to the appropriate office to address and remedy any deficiencies.

''(5) To oversee distribution of resources and information related to women veterans' health programming under this title.

''(6) To promote the expansion and improvement of clinical, research, and educational activities of the Veterans Health Administration with respect the health care of women veterans.

''(7) To provide, as part of the annual budgeting process, recommendations with respect to the amount of funds to be requested for furnishing hospital care and medical services to women veterans pursuant to chapter 17 of this title, including, at a minimum, recommendations that ensure that such amount of funds either reflect or exceed the proportion of veterans enrolled in the patient enrollment system under section 1705 of this title who are women.

''(8) To provide recommendations to the Under Secretary for Health with respect to modifying the Veterans Equitable Resource Allocation system to ensure that resource allocations under such system reflect the health care needs of women veterans.

''(9) To carry out such other duties as the Under Secretary for Health may require.

''(c) RECOMMENDATIONS.—If the Under Secretary for Health determines not to implement any recommendation made by the Director with respect to the allocation of resources to address the health care needs of women veterans, the Secretary shall notify the appropriate congressional committees of such determination by not later than 30 days after the date on which the Under Secretary for Health receives the recommendation. Each such notification shall include the following:

''(1) The reasoning of the Under Secretary for Health in making such determination.

''(2) An alternative, if one is selected, to such recommendation that the Under Secretary for Health will carry out to fulfill the health care needs of women veterans.

''(d) STANDARDS OF CARE.—In this section, the standards of care for the provision of health care for women veterans in the Department shall include, at a minimum, the following:

''(1) Requirement for—

''(A) at least one designated women's health primary care provider at each medical center whose duties include, to the extent practicable, providing training to other health care providers of the Department with respect to the needs of women veterans; and

''(B) at least one designated women's health primary care provider at each community-based outpatient clinic of the Department who may serve female patients as a percentage of the total duties of the provider.

''(2) Other requirements as determined by the Under Secretary for Health.

''(e) OUTREACH.—The Director shall ensure that—

''(1) not less frequently than biannually, each medical facility of the Department holds a public forum for women veterans that occurs outside of regular business hours; and

''(2) not less frequently than quarterly, each medical facility of the Department convenes a focus group of women veterans that includes a discussion of harassment occurring at such facility.

''(f) DEFINITIONS.—In this section:

''(1) The term 'appropriate congressional committees' has the meaning given that term in section 7310A of this title.

''(2) The term 'facility of the Department' has the meaning given the term in section 1701(3).

''(3) The term 'Veterans Equitable Resource Allocation system' means the resource allocation system established pursuant to section 429 of the Departments of Veterans Affairs and Housing and Urban Development, and Independent Agencies Appropriations Act, 1997 (Public Law 104–204; 110 Stat. 2929).

''§ 7310A. Annual reports on women's Health

''(a) ANNUAL REPORTS.—Not later than December 1 of each year, the Director of Women's Health shall submit to the appropriate congressional committees a report containing the matters under subsections (b) through (g).

''(b) OFFICE OF WOMEN'S HEALTH.—Each report under subsection (a) shall include a description of—

''(1) actions taken by the Office of Women's Health in the preceding fiscal year to improve the Department's provision of health care to women veterans;

''(2) any identified deficiencies related to the Department's provision of health care to women veterans and the standards of care established in section 7310 of this title, and the Department's plan to address such deficiencies;

''(3) the funding and personnel provided to the Office and whether additional funding or personnel are needed to meet the requirements of such section; and

''(4) other information that would be of interest to the appropriate congressional committees with respect to oversight of the Department's provision of health care to women veterans.

''(c) ACCESS TO GENDER-SPECIFIC SERVICES.—Each report under subsection (a) shall include an analysis of the access of women veterans to gender-specific services under contracts, agreements, or other arrangements with non-Department medical providers entered into by the Secretary for the provision of hospital care or medical services to veterans. Such analysis shall include data and performance measures for the availability of gender specific services, including—

''(1) the average wait time between the veteran's preferred appointment date and the date on which the appointment is completed;

''(2) the average driving time required for veterans to attend appointments; and

''(3) reasons why appointments could not be scheduled with non-Department medical providers.

''(d) LOCATIONS WHERE WOMEN VETERANS ARE USING HEALTH CARE.—Each report under subsection (a) shall include an analysis of the use by women veterans of health care from the Department, including the following information:

''(1) The number of women veterans who reside in each State.

''(2) The number of women veterans in each State who are enrolled in the system of patient enrollment of the Department established and operated under section 1705(a) this title.

''(3) Of the women veterans who are so enrolled, the number who have received health care under the laws administered by the Secretary at least one time during the one-year period preceding the submittal of the report.

''(4) The number of women veterans who have been seen at each medical facility of the Department during such year.

''(5) The number of appointments that women veterans have had at each such facility during such year.

''(6) If known, an identification of the medical facility of the Department in each Veterans Integrated Service Network with the largest rate of increase in patient population of women veterans as measured by the increase in unique women veteran patient use.

''(7) If known, an identification of the medical facility of the Department in each Veterans Integrated Service Network with the largest rate of decrease in patient population of women veterans as measured by the decrease in unique women veterans patient use.

''(e) MODELS OF CARE.—Each report under subsection (a) shall include an analysis of the use by the Department of general primary care clinics, separate but shared spaces, and women's health centers as models of providing health care to women veterans. Such analysis shall include the following:

''(1) The number of facilities of the Department that fall into each such model, disaggregated by Veterans Integrated Service Network and State.

''(2) A description of the criteria used by the Department to determine which such model is most appropriate for each facility of the Department.

''(3) An assessment of how the Department decides to make investments to modify facilities to a different model.

''(4) A description of what, if any, plans the Department has to modify facilities from general primary care clinics to another model.

''(5) An assessment of whether any facilities could be modified to a separate but shared space for a women's health center within planned investments under the strategic capital investment planning process of the Department.

''(6) An assessment of whether any facilities could be modified to a separate or shared space, or women's health center with minor modifications to existing plans under the strategic capital investment planning process of the Department.

''(7) An assessment of whether the Department has a goal for how many facilities should fall into each such model.

''(f) STAFFING.—Each report under subsection (a) shall include an analysis of the staffing of the Department relating to the treatment of women, including the following, disaggregated by Veterans Integrated Service Network and State (except with respect to paragraph (4)):

''(1) The number of women's health centers.

''(2) The number of patient aligned care teams of the Department relating to women's health.

''(3) The number of full- and part-time gynecologists of the Department.

''(4) The number of designated women's health care providers of the Department, disaggregated by facility of the Department.

''(5) The number of health care providers of the Department who have completed a mini-residency for women's health care through Women Veterans Health Care Mini-Residency Program of the Department during the one-year period preceding the submittal of the report, and the number that plan to participate in such a mini-residency during the one-year period following such date.

''(6) The number of designated women's health care providers of the Department who have sufficient female patients to retain their competencies and proficiencies.

''(g) ACCESSIBILITY AND TREATMENT OPTIONS.—Each report under subsection (a) shall include an analysis of the accessibility and treatment options for women veterans, including the following:

''(1) An assessment of wheelchair accessibility of women's health centers of the Department, including, with respect to each such facility, an assessment of such accessibility for each kind of treatment provided at the center, including with respect to radiology and mammography, that addresses all relevant factors, including door sizes, hoists, and equipment.

''(2) The options for women veterans to access female mental health providers and primary care providers.

''(3) The options for women veterans at medical facilities of the Department with respect to clothing sizes, including for gowns, drawstring pants, and pajamas.

''(h) DEFINITIONS.—In this section:

''(1) The term 'appropriate congressional committees' means—

''(A) the Committees on Veterans' Affairs of the House of Representatives and the Senate; and

''(B) the Committees on Appropriations of the House of Representatives and the Senate.

''(2) The term 'gender-specific services' means mammography, obstetric care, gynecological care, and such other services as the Secretary determines appropriate.''.

(2) CLERICAL AMENDMENT.—The table of sections for such chapter is amended by inserting after the item relating to section 7309A the following new items:

''7310. Office of Women's Health.

''7310A. Annual reports on women's Health.''.

(c) INITIAL REPORT.—The Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall submit the initial report under section 7310A of title 38, United States Code, as added by subsection (b), by not later than 180 days after the date of the enactment of this Act.

SEC. 102. EXPANSION OF CAPABILITIES OF WOMEN VETERANS CALL CENTER TO INCLUDE TEXT MESSAGING.

The Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall expand the capabilities of the Women Veterans Call Center of the Department of Veterans Affairs to include a text messaging capability.

SEC. 103. REQUIREMENT FOR DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS INTERNET WEBSITE TO PROVIDE INFORMATION ON SERVICES AVAILABLE TO WOMEN VETERANS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—The Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall survey the internet websites and information resources of the Department of Veterans Affairs in effect on the day before the date of the enactment of this Act and publish an internet website that serves as a centralized source for the provision to women veterans of information about the benefits and services available to them under laws administered by the Secretary.

(b) ELEMENTS.—The internet website published under subsection (a) shall provide to women veterans information regarding all of the services available in the district in which the veteran is seeking such services, including, with respect to each medical center and community-based outpatient clinic in the applicable Veterans Integrated Service Network—

(1) the name and contact information of each women veterans program manager;

(2) a list of appropriate staff for other benefits available from the Veterans Benefits Administration, the National Cemetery Administration, and such other entities as the Secretary considers appropriate; and

(3) such other information as the Secretary considers appropriate.

(c) UPDATED INFORMATION.—The Secretary shall ensure that the information described in subsection (b) that is published on the internet website required by subsection (a) is updated not less frequently than once every 90 days.

(d) OUTREACH.—In carrying out this section, the Secretary shall ensure that the outreach conducted under section 1720F(i) of title 38, United States Code, includes information regarding the internet website required by subsection (a).

(e) DERIVATION OF FUNDS.—Amounts used by the Secretary to carry out this section shall be derived from amounts made available to the Secretary to publish internet websites of the Department.

SEC. 104. REPORT ON WOMEN VETERANS RETROFIT INITIATIVE.

(a) REPORT.—Not later than 180 days after the date of the enactment of this Act, the Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall submit to the Committees on Veterans' Affairs and the Committees on Appropriations of the Senate and the House of Representatives a report on requirements to retrofit existing medical facilities of the Department of Veterans Affairs with fixtures, materials, and other outfitting measures to support the provision of care to women veterans at such facilities.

(b) ELEMENTS.—The report under subsection (a) shall include the following:

(1) An assessment of how the Secretary prioritizes retrofitting existing medical facilities to support provision of care to women veterans in comparison to other requirements.

(2) A five-year plan for retrofitting medical facilities of the Department to support the provision of care to women veterans.

SEC. 105. ESTABLISHMENT OF ENVIRONMENT OF CARE STANDARDS AND INSPECTIONS AT DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS MEDICAL CENTERS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—The Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall establish a policy under which the environment of care standards and inspections at medical centers of the Department of Veterans Affairs include—

(1) an alignment of the requirements for such standards and inspections with the women's health handbook of the Veterans Health Administration;

(2) a requirement for the frequency of such inspections;

(3) delineation of the roles and responsibilities of staff at the medical center who are responsible for compliance;

(4) the requirement that each medical center submit to the Secretary and make publicly available a report on the compliance of the medical center with the standards; and

(5) a remediation plan.

(b) REPORT.—Not later than 180 days after the date of the enactment of this Act, the Secretary shall submit to the Committees on Veterans' Affairs of the Senate and House of Representatives certification in writing that the policy required by subsection (a) has been finalized and disseminated to Department all medical centers.

SEC. 106. ADDITIONAL FUNDING FOR PRIMARY CARE AND EMERGENCY CARE CLINICIANS IN WOMEN VETERANS HEALTH CARE MINI-RESIDENCY PROGRAM.

(a) IN GENERAL.—There is authorized to be appropriated to the Secretary of Veterans Affairs $1,000,000 for each fiscal year for the Women Veterans Health Care Mini-Residency Program of the Department of Veterans Affairs to provide opportunities for participation in such program for primary care and emergency care clinicians.

(b) TREATMENT OF AMOUNTS.—The amounts authorized to be appropriated under subsection (a) shall be in addition to amounts otherwise made available to the Secretary for the purposes set forth in such subsection.

SEC. 107. ESTABLISHMENT OF WOMEN VETERAN TRAINING MODULE FOR NON-DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS HEALTH CARE PROVIDERS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Not later than one year after the date of the enactment of this Act, the Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall establish and make available to community providers a training module that is specific to women veterans.

(b) COMMUNITY PROVIDER DEFINED.—In this section, the term ''community provider'' means a non-Department of Veterans Affairs health care provider who provides health care to veterans under the laws administered by the Secretary of Veterans Affairs.

TITLE II—MEDICAL CARE

SEC. 201. IMPROVED ACCESS TO DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS MEDICAL CARE FOR WOMEN VETERANS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Subchapter II of chapter 17 of title 38, United States Code, is amended by adding at the end the following new section:

''§ 1720J. Medical services for women veterans

''(a) ACCESS TO CARE.—The Secretary shall ensure that women's health primary care services are available during regular business hours at every medical center and community based outpatient clinic of the Department.

''(b) STUDY ON EXTENDED HOURS OF CARE.—The Secretary shall conduct a study to assess—

''(1) the use of extended hours as a means of reducing barriers to care;

''(2) the need for extended hours based on interviews with women veterans and employees; and

''(3) the best practices and resources required to implement use of extended hours.

''(c) ANNUAL REPORT TO CONGRESS.—Not later than September 30 of each year, the Secretary shall submit to the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the Senate and the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the House of Representatives a report on compliance with subsection (a).''.

(b) CLERICAL AMENDMENT.—The table of sections at the beginning of such chapter is amended by inserting after the item relating to section 1720I the following new item:

''1720J. Medical services for women veterans.''.

SEC. 202. COUNSELING AND TREATMENT FOR SEXUAL TRAUMA.

Section 1720D of title 38, United States Code, is amended—

(1) in subsection (a)—

(A) in paragraph (1), by striking ''active duty, active duty for training, or inactive duty training'' and inserting ''duty, regardless of duty status or line of duty determination (as that term is used in section 12323 of title 10)''; and

(B) in paragraph (2)(A), by striking ''active duty, active duty for training, or inactive duty training'' and inserting ''duty, regardless of duty status or line of duty determination (as that term is used in section 12323 of title 10)'';

(2) by striking ''veteran'' each place it appears and inserting ''former member of the Armed Forces'';

(3) by striking ''veterans'' each place it appears and inserting ''former members of the Armed Forces''; and

(4) by adding at the end the following new subsection:

''(g) In this section, the term 'former member of the Armed Forces' includes the following:

''(1) A veteran described in section 101(2) of this title.

''(2) An individual not described in paragraph (1) who was discharged or released from the Armed Forces under a condition that is not honorable but not—

''(A) a dishonorable discharge; or

''(B) a discharge by court-martial.''.

SEC. 203. COUNSELING IN RETREAT SETTINGS FOR WOMEN VETERANS AND OTHER INDIVIDUALS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Chapter 17 of title 38, United States Code, is amended by inserting after section 1712C the following new section:

''§ 1712D. Counseling in retreat settings for women veterans and other individuals

''(a) PROGRAM.—(1) Commencing not later than January 1, 2021, the Secretary shall carry out, through the Readjustment Counseling Service of the Veterans Health Administration, a program to provide reintegration and readjustment services described in subsection (b) in group retreat settings to covered individuals, including cohorts of women veterans who are eligible for readjustment counseling services under section 1712A of this title.

''(2) The participation of a covered individual in the program under paragraph (1) shall be at the election of the individual.

''(b) COVERED SERVICES.—The services provided to a covered individual under the program under subsection (a)(1) shall include the following:

''(1) Information on reintegration into the family, employment, and community of the individual.

''(2) Financial counseling.

''(3) Occupational counseling.

''(4) Information and counseling on stress reduction.

''(5) Information and counseling on conflict resolution.

''(6) Such other information and counseling as the Secretary considers appropriate to assist the individual in reintegration into the family, employment, and community of the veteran.

''(c) BIENNIAL REPORTS.—Not later than December 31, 2022, and each even-numbered year thereafter, the Secretary shall submit to the Committees on Veterans' Affairs of the House of Representatives and the Senate a report on the program under subsection (a)(1).

''(d) COVERED INDIVIDUAL DEFINED.—In this section, the term 'covered individual' means—

''(1) Any veteran who is enrolled in the system of annual patient enrollment under section 1705 of this title.

''(2) Any survivor or dependent of a veteran who is eligible for medical care under section 1781 of this title.''.

(b) CLERICAL AMENDMENT.—The table of sections at the beginning of such chapter is amended by inserting after the item relating to section 1712C the following new item:

''1712D. Counseling in retreat settings for women veterans and other individuals.''.

SEC. 204. IMPROVEMENT OF HEALTH CARE SERVICES PROVIDED TO NEWBORN CHILDREN BY DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) EXPANSION.—Section 1786 of title 38, United States Code, is amended—

(1) in subsection (a), in the matter preceding paragraph (1), by striking ''seven days'' and inserting ''14 days''; and

(2) by adding at the end the following new subsection:

''(f) ANNUAL REPORT.—Not later than 60 days after the end of each fiscal year, the Secretary shall submit to the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the Senate and the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the House of Representatives a report on the health care services provided under subsection (a) during

such fiscal year, including the number of newborn children who received such services during such fiscal year.''.

(b) AUTHORITY TO FURNISH MEDICALLY NECESSARY TRANSPORTATION FOR NEWBORN CHILDREN OF CERTAIN WOMEN VETERANS.—Such section is further amended—

(1) in subsection (a)—

(A) in the matter before paragraph (1)—

(i) by inserting ''and transportation necessary to receive such services'' after ''described in subsection (b)''; and

(ii) by inserting '', except as provided in subsection (e),'' after ''14 days'';

(B) in paragraph (1), by striking ''or'';

(C) in paragraph (2), by striking the period at the end and inserting ''; or''; and

(D) by adding at the end the following new paragraph:

''(3) another location, including a health care facility, if the veteran delivers the child before arriving at a facility described in paragraph (1) or (2).'';

(2) in subsection (b), by inserting before the period at the end the following: '', including necessary health care services provided by a facility other than the facility where the newborn child was delivered (including a specialty pediatric hospital) that accepts transfer of the newborn child and responsibility for treatment of the newborn child''; and

(3) by inserting before subsection (f), as added by subsection (a), the following new subsections:

''(c) TRANSPORTATION.—(1) Transportation furnished under subsection (a) to, from, or between care settings to meet the needs of a newborn child includes costs for either or both the newborn child and parents.

''(2) Transportation furnished under subsection (a) is transportation by ambulance, including air ambulance, or other appropriate medically staffed modes of transportation—

''(A) to another health care facility (including a specialty pediatric hospital) that accepts transfer of the newborn child or otherwise provides post-delivery care services when the treating facility is not capable of furnishing the care or services required; or

''(B) to a health care facility in a medical emergency of such nature that a prudent layperson reasonably expects that delay in seeking immediate medical attention would be hazardous to life or health.

''(3) Amounts paid by the Department for transportation under this section shall be derived from the Medical Services appropriations account of the Department.

''(d) REIMBURSEMENT OR PAYMENT FOR HEALTH CARE SERVICES OR TRANSPORTATION.—(1) Pursuant to regulations the Secretary shall prescribe to establish rates of reimbursement and any limitations thereto under this section, the Secretary shall directly reimburse a covered entity for health care services or transportation services provided under this section, unless the cost of the services or transportation is covered by an established agreement or contract. If such an agreement or contract exists, its negotiated payment terms shall apply.

''(2)(A) Reimbursement or payment by the Secretary under this section on behalf of an individual to a covered entity shall, unless rejected and refunded by the covered entity within 30 days of receipt, extinguish any liability on the part of the individual for the health care services or transportation covered by such payment.

''(B) Neither the absence of a contract or agreement between the Secretary and a covered entity nor any provision of a contract, agreement, or assignment to the contrary shall operate to modify, limit, or negate the requirements of subparagraph (A).

''(3) In this subsection, the term 'covered entity' means any individual, transportation carrier, organization, or other entity that furnished or paid for health care services or transportation under this section.

''(e) EXCEPTION.—Pursuant to such regulations as the Secretary shall prescribe to carry out this section, the Secretary may furnish more than 14 days of health care services described in subsection (b), and transportation necessary to receive such services, to a newborn child based on medical necessity if the child is in need of additional care, including a case in which the newborn child has been discharged or released from a hospital and requires readmittance to ensure the health and welfare of the newborn child.''.

(c) TREATMENT OF CERTAIN EXPENSES ALREADY INCURRED.—Pursuant to such regulations as the Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall prescribe, the Secretary may provide reimbursement under section 1786 of title 38, United States Code, as amended by subsection (a), health care services or transportation services furnished to a newborn child during the period beginning on May 5, 2010, and ending on the date of the enactment of this Act, if the Secretary determines that, under the circumstances applicable with respect to the newborn, such reimbursement appropriate.

TITLE III—REPORTS AND OTHER MATTERS

Subtitle A—Reports

SEC. 301. ASSESSMENT OF EFFECTS OF INTIMATE PARTNER VIOLENCE ON WOMEN VETERANS BY ADVISORY COMMITTEE ON WOMEN VETERANS.

Section 542(c)(1) of title 38, United States Code, is amended—

(1) in subparagraph (B), by striking ''and'' at the end;

(2) by redesignating subparagraph (C) as subparagraph (D); and

(3) by inserting after subparagraph (B) the following new subparagraph (C):

''(C) an assessment of the effects of intimate partner violence on women veterans; and''.

SEC. 302. STUDY ON STAFFING OF WOMEN VETERAN PROGRAM MANAGER PROGRAM AT MEDICAL CENTERS OF THE DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS AND TRAINING OF STAFF.

(a) STUDY.—The Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall conduct a study on the use of the Women Veteran Program Manager program of the Department of Veterans Affairs to determine—

(1) if the program is appropriately staffed at each medical center of the Department;

(2) whether each medical center of the Department is staffed with a Women Veteran Program Manager; and

(3) whether it would be feasible and advisable to have a Women Veteran Program Ombudsman at each medical center of the Department.

(b) REPORT.—Not later than 270 days after the date of the enactment of this Act, the Secretary shall submit to the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the Senate and the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the House of Representatives a report on the study conducted under subsection (a).

(c) TRAINING.—The Secretary shall ensure that all Women Veteran Program Managers and Women Veteran Program Ombudsmen receive the proper training to carry out their duties.

SEC. 303. REPORT ON AVAILABILITY OF PROSTHETIC ITEMS FOR WOMEN VETERANS FROM THE DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

Not later than one year after the date of the enactment of this Act, the Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall submit to the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the Senate and the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the House of Representatives a report on the availability from the Department of Veterans Affairs of prosthetic items made for women veterans, including an assessment of the availability of such prosthetic items at each medical facility of the Department. The report shall—

(1) address efforts on research, development, and employment of additive manufacture technology (commonly referred to as ''3D printing'') to provide prosthetic items for women veterans; and

(2) include a survey with a representative sample of 50,000 veterans (of which women shall be overrrepresented) in amputee care program on satisfaction with prosthetics furnished or procured by the Department that replace appendages or their function.

SEC. 304. STUDY OF BARRIERS FOR WOMEN VETERANS TO HEALTH CARE FROM THE DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) STUDY REQUIRED.—The Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall conduct a comprehensive study of the barriers to the provision of comprehensive health care by the Department of Veterans Affairs encountered by women who are veterans. In conducting the study, the Secretary shall—

(1) survey women veterans who seek or receive hospital care or medical services provided by the Department of Veterans Affairs as well as women veterans who do not seek or receive such care or services;

(2) administer the survey to a representative sample of women veterans from each Veterans Integrated Service Network; and

(3) ensure that the sample of women veterans surveyed is of sufficient size for the study results to be statistically significant and is a larger sample than that of the study referred to in subsection (b)(1).

(b) USE OF PREVIOUS STUDIES.—In conducting the study required by subsection (a), the Secretary shall build on the work of the studies of the Department of Veterans Affairs titled—

(1) ''National Survey of Women Veterans in Fiscal Year 2007–2008''; and

(2) ''Study of Barriers for Women Veterans to VA Health Care 2015''.

(c) ELEMENTS OF STUDY.—In conducting the study required by subsection (a), the Secretary shall conduct research on the effects of the following on the women veterans surveyed in the study:

(1) The barriers associated with seeking mental health care services, including with respect to provider availability, telehealth access, and family, work, and school obligations.

(2) The effect of driving distance or availability of other forms of transportation to the nearest medical facility on access to care.

(3) The effect of access to care in the community.

(4) The availability of child care.

(5) The acceptability of integrated primary care, women's health clinics, or both.

(6) The comprehension of eligibility requirements for, and the scope of services available under, hospital care and medical services.

(7) The perception of personal safety and comfort in inpatient, outpatient, and behavioral health facilities.

(8) The gender sensitivity of health care providers and staff to issues that particularly affect women.

(9) The effectiveness of outreach for health care services available to women veterans.

(10) The location and operating hours of health care facilities that provide services to women veterans.

(11) The perception of women veterans regarding the motto of the Department of Veterans Affairs.

(12) Such other significant barriers as the Secretary considers appropriate.

(d) DISCHARGE BY CONTRACT.—The Secretary shall enter into a contract with a qualified independent entity or organization to carry out the study and research required under this section.

(e) MANDATORY REVIEW OF DATA BY CERTAIN DEPARTMENT DIVISIONS.—

(1) IN GENERAL.—The Secretary shall ensure that the head of each division of the Department of Veterans Affairs specified in paragraph (2) reviews the results of the study conducted under this section. The head of each such division shall submit findings with respect to the study to the Under Secretary for responsibilities relating to health care services for women veterans.

(2) SPECIFIED DIVISIONS.—The divisions of the Department of Veterans Affairs specified in this paragraph are the following:

(A) The Under Secretary for Health.

(B) The Office of Women's Health.

(C) The Center for Women Veterans established under section 318 of title 38, United States Code.

(D) The Advisory Committee on Women Veterans established under section 542 of such title.

(f) REPORT.—Not later than 30 months after the date of the enactment of this Act, the Secretary shall submit to Congress a report on the study required under this section. The report shall include recommendations for such administrative and legislative action as the Secretary considers appropriate. The report shall also include the findings of the head of each division of the Department specified under subsection (e)(2) and of the Under Secretary for Health.

SEC. 305. REPORT REGARDING VETERANS WHO RECEIVE BENEFITS UNDER LAWS ADMINISTERED BY THE SECRETARY OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) REPORT.—Not later than 180 days after the date of the enactment of this Act, the Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall publish a report regarding veterans who receive benefits under laws administered by the Secretary, including the Transition Assistance Program under sections 1142 and 1144 of title 10, United States Code.

(b) DATA.—The data regarding veterans published in the report under subsection (a)—

(1) shall be disaggregated by—

(A) sex;

(B) minority group member status; and

(C) minority group member status listed by sex.

(2) may not include any personally identifiable information.

(c) MATTERS INCLUDED.—The report under subsection (a) shall include—

(1) identification of any disparities in the use of benefits under laws administered by the Secretary; and

(2) an analysis of the cause of such disparities and recommendations to address such disparities.

(d) MINORITY GROUP MEMBER DEFINED.—In this section, the term ''minority group member'' has the meaning given that term in section 544 of title 38, United States Code.

SEC. 306. STUDY ON WOMEN VETERAN COORDINATOR PROGRAM.

Not later than 180 days after the date of the enactment of this Act, the Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall submit to the Committees on Veterans' Affairs of the House of Representatives and the Senate a report containing a study on the Women Veteran Coordinator program of the Veterans Benefits Administration of the Department of Veterans Affairs. Such study shall identify the following:

(1) If the program is appropriately staffed at each regional benefits office of the Department.

(2) Whether each regional benefits office of the Department is staffed with a Women Veteran Coordinator.

(3) The position description of the Women Veteran Coordinator.

(4) Whether an individual serving in the Women Veteran Coordinator position concurrently serves in any other position, and if so, the allocation of time the individual spends in each such position.

(5) A description of the metrics the Secretary uses to determine the success and performance of the Women Veteran Coordinator.

Subtitle B—Other Matters

SEC. 321. ANTI-HARASSMENT AND ANTI-SEXUAL ASSAULT POLICY OF THE DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Subchapter II of chapter 5 of title 38, United States Code, is amended by adding at the end the following new section:

''§ 533. Anti-harassment and anti-sexual assault policy

''(a) ESTABLISHMENT.—The Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall establish a comprehensive policy to end harassment and sexual assault, including sexual harassment and gender-based harassment, throughout the Department of Veterans Affairs. This policy shall include the following:

''(1) A process for employees and contractors of the Department to respond to reported incidents of harassment and sexual assault committed by any non-Department individual within a facility of the Department, including with respect to accountability or disciplinary measures.

''(2) A process for employees and contractors of the Department to respond to reported incidents of harassment and sexual assault of any non-Department individual within a facility of the Department.

''(3) A process for any non-Department individual to report harassment and sexual assault described in paragraph (1), including an option for confidential reporting, and for the Secretary to respond to and address such reports.

''(4) Clear mechanisms for non-Department individuals to readily identify to whom and how to report incidents of harassment and sexual assault committed by another non-Department individual.

''(5) Clear mechanisms for employees and contractors of the Department to readily identify to whom and how to report incidents of harassment and sexual assault and how to refer non-Department individuals with respect to reporting an incident of harassment or sexual assault.

''(6) A process for, and mandatory reporting requirement applicable to, any employee or contractor of the Department who witnesses harassment or sexual assault described in paragraph (1) or (2) within a facility of the Department, regardless of whether the individual affected by such harassment or sexual assault wants to report such harassment or sexual assault.

''(7) The actions possible, including disciplinary actions, for employees or contractors of the Department who fail to report incidents of harassment and sexual assault described in paragraph (1) or (2) that the employees or contractors witness.

''(8) On an annual or more frequent basis, mandatory training for employees and contractors of the Department regarding how to report and address harassment and sexual assault described in paragraphs (1) and (2), including bystander intervention training.

''(9) On an annual or more frequent basis, the distribution of the policy under this subsection and anti-harassment and anti-sexual assault educational materials by mail or email to each individual receiving a benefit under a law administered by the Secretary.

''(10) The prominent display of anti-harassment and anti-sexual assault messages in each facility of the Department, including how non-Department individuals may report harassment and sexual assault described in paragraphs (1) and (2) at such facility and the points of contact under subsection (b).

''(11) The posting on internet websites of the Department, including the main internet website regarding benefits of the Department and the main internet website regarding health care of the Department, of anti-harassment and anti-sexual assault banners specifically addressing harassment and sexual assault described in paragraphs (1) and (2).

''(b) POINTS OF CONTACT.—The Secretary shall designate, as a point of contact to receive reports of harassment and sexual assault described in paragraphs (1) and (2) of subsection (a)—

''(1) at least one individual, in addition to law enforcement, at each facility of the Department (including Vet Centers under section 1712A of this title), with regard to that facility;

''(2) at least one individual employed in each Veterans Integrated Service Network, with regards to facilities in that Veterans Integrated Service Network;

''(3) at least one individual employed in each regional benefits office;

''(4) at least one individual employed at each location of the National Cemetery Administration; and

''(5) at least one individual employed at the Central Office of the Department to track reports of such harassment and sexual assault across the Department, disaggregated by facility.

''(c) ACCOUNTABILITY.—The Secretary shall establish a policy to ensure that each facility of the Department and each director of a Veterans Integrated Service Network is responsible for addressing harassment and sexual assault at the facility and the Network. Such policy shall include—

''(1) a remediation plan for facilities that experience five or more incidents of sexual harassment, sexual assault, or combination thereof, during any single fiscal year; and

''(2) taking appropriate actions under chapter 7 or subchapter V of chapter 74 of this title.

''(d) DATA.—The Secretary shall ensure that the in-take process for veterans at medical facilities of the Department includes a survey to collect the following information:

''(1) Whether the veteran feels safe at the facility and whether any events occurred at the facility that affect such feeling.

''(2) Whether the veteran wants to be contacted later by the Department with respect to such safety issues.

''(e) WORKING GROUP.—(1) The Secretary shall establish a working group to assist the Secretary in implementing policies to carry out this section.

''(2) The working group established under paragraph (1) shall consist of representatives from—

''(A) veterans service organizations;

''(B) State, local, and Tribal veterans agencies; and

''(C) other persons the Secretary determines appropriate.

''(3) The working group established under paragraph (1) shall develop, and the Secretary shall carry out—

''(A) an action plan for addressing changes at the local level to reduce instances of harassment and sexual assault;

''(B) standardized media for veterans service organizations and other persons to use in print and on the internet with respect to reducing harassment and sexual assault; and

''(C) bystander intervention training for veterans.

''(f) REPORTS.—The Secretary shall submit to the Committees on Veterans' Affairs of

the Senate and the House of Representatives an annual report on harassment and sexual assault described in paragraphs (1) and (2) of subsection (a) in facilities of the Department. Each such report shall include the following:

''(1) Results of harassment and sexual assault programming, including the End Harassment program.

''(2) Results of studies from the Women's Health Practice-Based Research Network of the Department relating to harassment and sexual assault.

''(3) Data collected on incidents of sexual harassment and sexual assault.

''(4) A description of any actions taken by the Secretary during the year preceding the date of the report to stop harassment and sexual assault at facilities of the Department.

''(5) An assessment of the implementation of the training required in subsection (a)(7).

''(6) A list of resources the Secretary determines necessary to prevent harassment and sexual assault at facilities of the Department.

''(g) DEFINITIONS.—In this section:

''(1) The term 'non-Department individual' means any individual present at a facility of the Department who is not an employee or contractor of the Department.

''(2) The term 'sexual harassment' has the meaning given that term in section 1720D of this title.''.

(b) CLERICAL AMENDMENT.—The table of sections at the beginning of such chapter is amended by adding after the item relating to section 532 the following new item:

''533. Anti-harassment and anti-sexual assault policy.''.

(c) DEFINITION OF SEXUAL HARASSMENT.—Section 1720D(f) of such title is amended by striking ''repeated,''.

(d) DEADLINE.—The Secretary shall commence carrying out section 533 of such title, as added by subsection (a), not later than 180 days after the date of enactment of this Act.

SEC. 322. SUPPORT FOR ORGANIZATIONS THAT HAVE A FOCUS ON PROVIDING ASSISTANCE TO WOMEN VETERANS AND THEIR FAMILIES.

Section 2044(e) of title 38, United States Code, is amended by adding at the end the following new paragraph:

''(4) There is authorized to be appropriated $20,000,000 for fiscal year 2020 to provide, under subsection (a), financial assistance to organizations that have a focus on providing assistance to women veterans and their families.''.

SEC. 323. GAP ANALYSIS OF DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS PROGRAMS THAT PROVIDE ASSISTANCE TO WOMEN VETERANS WHO ARE HOMELESS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—The Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall complete an analysis of programs of the Department of Veterans Affairs that provide assistance to women veterans who are homeless or precariously housed to identify the areas in which such programs are failing to meet the needs of such women.

(b) REPORT.—Not later than 270 days after the date of the enactment of this Act, the Secretary shall submit to the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the Senate and the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the House of Representatives a report on the analysis completed under subsection (a).

SEC. 324. DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS PUBLIC-PRIVATE PARTNERSHIP ON LEGAL SERVICES FOR WOMEN VETERANS.

(a) PARTNERSHIP REQUIRED.—The Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall establish a partnership with at least one nongovernmental organization to provide legal services to women veterans.

(b) FOCUS.—The focus of the partnership established under subsection (a) shall be on the 10 highest unmet needs of women veterans as set forth in the most recently completed Community Homelessness Assessment, Local Education and Networking Groups for Veterans (CHALENG for Veterans) survey.

SEC. 325. PROGRAM TO ASSIST VETERANS WHO EXPERIENCE INTIMATE PARTNER VIOLENCE OR SEXUAL ASSAULT.

(a) PROGRAM REQUIRED.—The Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall carry out a program to assist former members of the armed forces who have experienced or are experiencing intimate partner violence or sexual assault in accessing benefits from the Department of Veterans Affairs, including coordinating access to medical treatment centers, housing assistance, and other benefits from the Department.

(b) COLLABORATION.—The Secretary shall carry out the program under subsection (a) in collaboration with—

(1) intimate partner violence shelters and programs;

(2) rape crisis centers;

(3) State intimate partner violence and sexual assault coalitions; and

(4) such other health care or other service providers that serve intimate partner violence or sexual assault victims as determined by the Secretary, particularly those providing emergency services or housing assistance.

(c) AUTHORIZED ACTIVITIES.—In carrying out the program under subsection (a), the Secretary may conduct the following activities:

(1) Training for community-based intimate partner violence or sexual assault service providers on—

(A) identifying former members of the Armed Forces who have been victims of intimate partner violence or sexual assault;

(B) coordinating with local service providers of the Department; and

(C) connecting former members of the Armed Forces with appropriate housing, mental health, medical, and other financial assistance or benefits from the Department.

(2) Assistance to service providers to ensure access of veterans to intimate partner violence and sexual assault emergency services, particularly in underserved areas, including services for Native American veterans (as defined in section 3765 of title 38, United States Code).

(3) Such other outreach and assistance as the Secretary determines necessary for the provision of assistance under subsection (a).

(d) INTIMATE PARTNER VIOLENCE AND SEXUAL ASSAULT OUTREACH COORDINATORS.—

(1) IN GENERAL.—In order to effectively assist veterans who have experienced intimate partner violence or sexual assault, the Secretary may establish local coordinators to provide outreach under the program required by subsection (a).

(2) LOCAL COORDINATOR KNOWLEDGE.—The Secretary shall ensure that each coordinator established under paragraph (1) is knowledgeable about—

(A) the dynamics of intimate partner violence and sexual assault, including safety concerns, legal protections, and the need for the provision of confidential services;

(B) the eligibility of veterans for services and benefits from the Department that are relevant to recovery from intimate partner violence and sexual assault, particularly emergency housing assistance, mental health care, other health care, and disability benefits; and

(C) local community resources addressing intimate partner violence and sexual assault.

(3) LOCAL COORDINATOR ASSISTANCE.—Each coordinator established under paragraph (1) shall assist intimate partner violence shelters and rape crisis centers in providing services to veterans.

SEC. 326. STUDY AND TASK FORCE ON VETERANS EXPERIENCING INTIMATE PARTNER VIOLENCE OR SEXUAL ASSAULT.

(a) NATIONAL BASELINE STUDY.—

(1) IN GENERAL.—Not later than one year after the date of the enactment of this Act, the Secretary of Veterans Affairs, in consultation with the Attorney General, shall conduct a national baseline study to examine the scope of the problem of intimate partner violence and sexual assault among veterans and spouses and intimate partners of veterans.

(2) MATTERS INCLUDED.—The study under paragraph (1) shall—

(A) include a literature review of all relevant research on intimate partner violence and sexual assault among veterans and spouses and intimate partners of veterans;

(B) examine the prevalence of the experience of intimate partner violence among—

(i) women veterans;

(ii) veterans who are minority group members (as defined in section 544 of title 38, United States Code, and including other minority populations as the Secretary determines appropriate);

(iii) urban and rural veterans;

(iv) veterans who are enrolled in a program under section 1720G of title 38, United States Code;

(v) veterans who are in intimate relationships with other veterans; and

(vi) veterans who are described in more than one clause of this subparagraph;

(C) examine the prevalence of the perpetration of intimate partner violence by veterans; and

(D) include recommendations to address the findings of the study.

(3) REPORT.—Not later than 30 days after the date on which the Secretary completes the study under paragraph (1), the Secretary shall submit to the Committees on Veterans' Affairs of the House of Representatives and the Senate a report on such study.

(b) TASK FORCE.—Not later than 90 days after the date on which the Secretary completes the study under subsection (a), the Secretary, in consultation with the Attorney General and the Secretary of Health and Human Services, shall establish a national task force (in this section referred to as the ''Task Force'') to develop a comprehensive national program, including by integrating facilities, services, and benefits of the Department of Veterans Affairs into existing networks of community-based intimate partner violence and sexual assault services, to address intimate partner violence and sexual assault among veterans.

(c) CONSULTATION WITH STAKEHOLDERS.—In carrying out this section, the Task Force shall consult with—

(1) representatives from veteran service organizations and military service organizations;

(2) representatives from not fewer than three national organizations or State coalitions with demonstrated expertise in intimate partner violence prevention, response, or advocacy; and

(3) representatives from not fewer than three national organizations or State coalitions, particularly those representing underserved and ethnic minority communities, with demonstrated expertise in sexual assault prevention, response, or advocacy.

(d) DUTIES.—The duties of the Task Force shall include the following:

(1) To review existing services and policies of the Department and develop a comprehensive national program to address intimate partner violence and sexual assault prevention, response, and treatment.

(2) To review the feasibility and advisability of establishing an expedited process to secure emergency, temporary benefits, including housing or other benefits, for veterans who are experiencing intimate partner violence or sexual assault.

(3) To review and make recommendations regarding the feasibility and advisability of establishing dedicated, temporary housing assistance for veterans experiencing intimate partner violence or sexual assault.

(4) To identify any requirements regarding intimate partner violence assistance or sexual assault response and services that are not being met by the Department and make recommendations on how the Department can meet such requirements.

(5) To review and make recommendations regarding the feasibility and advisability of providing direct services or contracting for community-based services for veterans in response to a sexual assault, including through the use of sexual assault nurse examiners, particularly in underserved or remote areas, including services for Native American veterans.

(6) To review the availability of counseling services provided by the Department and through peer network support, and to provide recommendations for the enhancement of such services, to address—

(A) the perpetration of intimate partner violence and sexual assault; and

(B) the recovery of veterans, particularly women veterans, from intimate partner violence and sexual assault.

(7) To review and make recommendations to expand services available for veterans at risk of perpetrating intimate partner violence.

(e) REPORT.—Not later than one year after the date of the enactment of this Act, and not less frequently than annually thereafter by October 1 of each year, the Task Force shall submit to the Secretary of Veterans Affairs and Congress a report on the activities of the Task Force, including any recommendations for legislative or administrative action.

(f) DEFINITIONS.—In this section:

(1) The term ''Native American veteran'' has the meaning given that term in section 3765 of title 38, United States Code.

(2) The term ''State'' has the meaning given that term in section 101 of title 38, United States Code.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to the rule, the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) and the gentleman from Tennessee (Mr. DAVID P. ROE) each will control 20 minutes.

The Chair recognizes the gentleman from California.

GENERAL LEAVE

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I ask unanimous consent that all Members may have 5 legislative days in which to revise and extend their remarks and to insert extraneous material on H.R. 3224, as amended.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Is there objection to the request of the gentleman from California?

There was no objection.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, I rise in support of H.R. 3224, the Deborah Sampson Act, introduced by Representative JULIA BROWNLEY, the chairwoman of the Veterans Affairs' Health Subcommittee.

This bill comprises 15 bipartisan bills that transform and improve comprehensive access to healthcare, benefits, and other resources for America's 2 million women veterans.

This bill is named after Deborah Sampson, a Revolutionary War veteran from Massachusetts who served in the Continental Army for 17 months and was wounded in battle more than once.

Deborah Sampson was neither the first nor the only woman to serve in the Continental Army, nor was she the first woman to be granted a pension by Congress, but she was the most persistent.

Over 38 years, Congress granted her a pension, backpay, and ultimately her husband was granted a survivor's pension after her death.

Mr. Speaker, it is because of the similar persistence of women warriors who followed in Deborah Sampson's footsteps that we are now considering this bill today.

The Deborah Sampson Act creates an Office of Women's Health that reports directly to the Undersecretary of Health. This office will be responsible for internal oversight and resource allocation, including inputs to the annual budgeting process.

Currently, 10 percent of VA facilities do not have gender-specific care for women. H.R. 3224, as amended, also increases staffing and training for women's health primary care providers so that every single woman veteran has access to gender-specific care at her nearest VA facility.

Mr. Speaker, 75 percent of women veterans do not use VA care, often because they don't realize that they are eligible. This legislation seeks to expand communication outreach capabilities of the department to connect more women to VA benefits and healthcare.

Mr. Speaker, the Deborah Sampson Act also authorizes counseling in retreat settings, expands counseling at vet centers for members of the Reserve and National Guard who are survivors of military sexual trauma, and improves resources for veterans experiencing intimate-partner violence and women veterans facing homelessness.

Throughout this Congress we have addressed the issue of widespread sexual harassment and assault at VA facilities. At least one in four women veterans experience sexual and gender harassment at VA facilities, and that must end.

No veteran, caregiver, employee, contractor, or other public visitor should experience sexual harassment or assault at VA.

H.R. 3224, as amended, requires that VA develop a comprehensive policy that includes bystander intervention, mandatory reporting mechanisms for employees, confidential reporting mechanisms for veterans, and holds leadership accountable for addressing sexual harassment and assault at VA facilities.

Today, nearly one in four new recruits joining the military is a woman. Women veterans are the fastest growing demographic in the veterans' community, and VA must be prepared to welcome them.

Mr. Speaker, I urge all Members to support H.R. 3224, and I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

Mr. Speaker, I rise today in support of H.R. 3224, as amended, the Deborah Sampson Act.

For as long as the United States has been a reality, brave women have been stepping up to serve on behalf of her and defending her from her enemies.

This bill is named after one of those amazing women, Deborah Sampson, who so believed in the ideals of the American Revolution that she disguised herself as a man so that she could join in the fight for freedom and independence.

Deborah Sampson's spirit of bravery, patriotism, and commitment to service are still very much alive in the approximately 2 million women veterans in the United States today and the almost 400,000 women serving on Active Duty or in the Guard and Reserves.

Those women have fought in defense of the American Dream—on the frontlines, in the Pentagon, and everywhere in between, in every branch of the armed services. And, once they leave the military, they are, increasingly, seeking care from the Department of Veterans Affairs. In fact, the number of women using the VA healthcare system has more than tripled since 2001 and is expected to continue rising significantly in the years ahead.

VA leaders have been working to make the department more welcoming to women veterans, but the fact remains that the VA healthcare system was designed for men.

That is, perhaps, most upsettingly evidenced by the VA study published last December that found that a full quarter of the women veterans who seek care from the VA are subjected to inappropriate or unwanted comments from male veterans on VA grounds.

That is tragic and unacceptable, just like it is anytime the VA falls short of providing the high-quality care, benefits, and services that women veterans have earned and certainly deserve, which still, sadly, happens all too often.

The Deborah Sampson Act is legislation introduced by Congresswoman JULIA BROWNLEY from California—and she is to be applauded for that—the chairwoman of the Subcommittee on Health and the bipartisan Women Veterans Task Force that would help put an end to this.

The bill would create an Office of Women's Health within the VA, require VA to establish an environment of care standards for women veterans and ensure that VA medical facilities are retrofitted to meet those standards, require and fund VA programs to train providers in VA medical facilities and in the community on women's health,

and improve access to care for women veterans and their newborn children.

It also includes provisions that would help all veterans, women and men alike, who experience military sexual trauma, intimate-partner violence, sexual assault, or sexual harassment to get the support and care that they need.

Mr. Speaker, there have been a lot of allegations made by Chairman TAKANO, and I make the following remarks with a heavy heart.

There have been a lot of allegations made by Chairman TAKANO and others in the 2 weeks since the Deborah Sampson Act was marked up in the committee about how I and my Republican colleagues feel about this legislation and about the women that it is intended to serve.

So let me be crystal clear. I stand here in strong support of the Deborah Sampson Act and all the good it would do for the millions of women veterans that it would serve.

I intend to call for a recorded vote on this bill, and I fully expect the vote to prove that there is overwhelming bipartisan support for this legislation.

Mr. Speaker, when I left the Army in 1974, I returned home to Tennessee to finish my residency in obstetrics and gynecology and spend the better part of my life caring for women in private practice.

My dedication to ensuring that women, whether they be civilian or veteran, have the care that they need is personal, deeply felt, and informed by three decades of direct action on behalf of the women who are my patients, my friends, my family, my neighbors, my colleagues, and my fellow veterans.

That is why it is so disappointing that, when my Republican colleagues and I walked out of the committee markup where this bill was being considered in protest to the chairman's actions surrounding it, he decided to launch a baseless, identity-politics fueled attack on me and other Republican members of the committee by alleging that we were walking out on women veterans.

Nothing can be further from the truth. The chairman knows full well that our decision to leave that markup had nothing to do with our support for the Deborah Sampson Act, much less our support for women veterans, and everything to do with the unprecedented partisanship that he displayed when this bill was being considered by our committee.

So I would like to take this opportunity this afternoon to correct the record.

Chairman TAKANO has called this bill historic and monumental, yet, during the committee's consideration of it, he allowed one Democrat member, Congresswoman BROWNLEY, exactly 4 minutes to talk about it before cutting off all debate for every other member in the room by invoking a procedural tactic that hadn't been used by our committee in more than a decade.

And I will say this: I never used this when I was chairman, nor did Chairman MILLER.

He did that to avoid debate on certain Republican amendments that he erroneously characterized as toxic and partisan. They were offered in good faith to address barriers to care for veteran women and men across the country that we have been requesting the chairman to act on for the better part of a year.

One of the amendments that the chairman refused to debate or vote on was offered by Congressman ANDY BARR from Kentucky to prevent those charged with a serious crime, including violent or sexual crimes against children, from caring for children while their veteran parent is receiving care from VA until their case has been favorably resolved.

The lack of childcare services is a serious barrier to care for veterans, including many women veterans, as the chairman himself has mentioned many times.

Our committee rightly acted on a bill, H.R. 840, which passed the House in February, to break down that barrier by authorizing VA to provide childcare for veterans who are engaged in VA treatment. But if the veterans cannot rest assured that their children are safe in the VA childcare program, they won't use it—they won't use the care—and the lack of childcare services will continue to prevent veterans from getting the care that they need.

Congressman BARR's amendment would close a loophole in that bill that would allow an individual charged with a serious offense—like child molestation—but who is awaiting his or her day in court to be responsible for caring for a veteran's child in a VA childcare program while their case is pending before the courts.

Mr. Speaker, I know that there are a lot of things that we cannot agree on, but protecting vulnerable children should never be one of those things. Yet Chairman TAKANO has repeatedly refused to address this issue and employed a rarely used procedural tactic in our committee to disallow debate and votes on it twice in recent months.

He has also failed to even respond to 11 committee members who wrote him in July asking for a legislative hearing on Congressman BARR's legislation. It defies understanding.

Another amendment that the chairman has repeatedly refused to allow our committee to debate was offered by Congressman CHIP ROY from Texas to prohibit VA from sending the name of a veteran or other beneficiary to the Federal Bureau of Investigation's National Instant Criminal Background Check System, NICS, solely because VA has determined that a person has a service-connected disability or solely because a fiduciary has been appointed on their behalf, without the order or finding of a judge, a magistrate, or other judicial authority that the person is a danger to themselves or others.

Infringing on a law-abiding American citizen's constitutionally protected rights should never occur in a free society unless a very high bar has been met. For example, criminals must be convicted in a court of law before their names are provided to the NICS list; but, under current practice, VA sends veterans' names to the NICS list if they have been appointed a fiduciary to help manage their compensation benefits.

This is because, once VA decides that an individual needs help with their finances, even though there may be no evidence the individual is a danger to themselves or anyone else, a VA bureaucrat sends that person's name to the FBI to be added to the NICS list and the veteran loses their second amendment right to own a firearm. And these are the very people who gave us those rights, protected those rights.

Legislation that the House passed on a party-line vote earlier this year, H.R. 1112, would compound this injustice by requiring VA to also report a veteran or beneficiary to the NICS if they have been adjudicated by VA as having a mental illness when the veteran files for a disability claim—for example, PTSD or depression.

I have personally heard from veterans across the country—and I mean from Long Island to Los Angeles—who tell me that they don't seek VA care and benefits that they have earned through their hard-fought service for our country because they fear they will lose their Second Amendment rights if they do so.

This is unacceptable at any time and is particularly unacceptable during a national suicide crisis when we know that 14 of the 20 veteran and servicemember suicide deaths per day already occur among those who are not engaged in VA care prior to their deaths.

Veterans risk their lives to protect our rights. The least we can do for them is to protect theirs. But Chairman TAKANO has once again refused to do that, despite making a public vow 8 months ago before the American Legion that he would act, as chairman, to protect the Second Amendment rights of our Nation's veterans.

He also, once again, failed to respond to 12 committee members who wrote him in July asking for a legislative hearing to discuss veterans' Second Amendment issues.

There are precious few avenues available to the minority party in Congress to influence the legislative agenda of the majority party.

□ 1800

Since February, my Republican colleagues and I have been asking Chairman TAKANO, publicly and privately, to address these issues in our committee. Our requests have been ignored. Our letters have gone unanswered.

The only remaining option we have left is to attempt to amend bills being marked up by the committee so that we can have an open debate and an up-

or-down vote on these issues. If we win, we win. If we lose, we lose.

We attempted to amend the Deborah Sampson Act with these amendments 2 weeks ago, on the advice of the Parliamentarian about the appropriateness of these particular amendments, which address serious issues facing female and male veterans alike in each one of our States and districts, to this particular bill. But the chairman denied us even this opportunity.

That kind of partisanship has never been how this committee has operated as long as I have been there. Under the 8 previous years of Republican chairmen, debate was never cut off when Democratic members offered difficult amendments during committee markups. We allowed our Democratic colleagues the opportunity to have their say, and we took tough votes when we needed to.

Mr. Speaker, I wish that we could have had such a different conversation today, the day after Veterans Day, than this one. But I would be remiss in my duty as ranking member if I did not call out this behavior and ways in which it fails our Nation's veterans.

Chairman TAKANO has spoken movingly about how he wants us to use his chairmanship to stand up for the rights of minority veterans, and I commend him for that and have stood alongside him in doing that work, including in May, when we stood side-by-side to launch the bipartisan Women Veterans Task Force.

Yet, I urge him now, in carrying out that commitment, not to spurn the historical bipartisan traditions of the Veterans' Affairs Committee, not to trounce on the rights of the minority members of that committee, not to cut corners in favor of expediency over doing our due diligence, and not to cast aspersions against me or any other member of our committee when we could be debating the issues at hand like our constituents sent us here to do.

Despite our deep disagreements here, I consider Chairman TAKANO a friend, and I know him to be a good and fair man who is motivated by a sincere desire to do the right thing for the millions of veterans and their families who have sacrificed so much for this great Nation. That desire is shared by me and every member of our committee, Republican and Democrat alike. I do not doubt that for a second.

I also do not doubt our ability, under the chairman's leadership, to put this unfortunate recent chapter of the committee's history behind us and return to the productive bipartisan tradition that our committee has known and respected throughout the United States Congress and the Nation. In doing so, we will, once again, live up to the example that our Nation's veterans, including Deborah Sampson herself, have set.

I thank the chairman in advance for that. I stand ready to assist him however I can, as ranking member and as his friend.

Mr. Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself such time as I may consume.

I appreciate the final comments that the ranking member made, I believe in good faith and sincerity, and they were words of generosity. But I have to rebut some of the claims that he has made.

While I spent 6 years of my time in Congress in the minority, and in the minority on this committee, I can tell you that the minority staff and I, and other members of the minority, did offer amendments in good faith, but we never did so in order to derail or to obstruct passage of important and meaningful legislation. Therefore, the ranking member, while he was chairman, can point to many great pieces of legislation, including the Forever GI Bill and numerous other bills. It was a very productive Congress in the last Congress because the minority worked with him.

Look, bipartisan spirit means that the minority also works in good faith. Ms. BROWNLEY, in order to bring the Deborah Sampson Act to the floor under suspension, made some significant concessions, for which there was nothing offered in return.

Mr. BARR's amendment on crimes against children has been offered on the floor as a motion to recommit, interesting enough, to Ms. BROWNLEY's bill on childcare on the floor. That bill was voted down. It was voted down on the House floor, and I can only believe that this very same legislative language was offered as an amendment to the Deborah Sampson bill in defiance of the House already expressing its will on that bill.

I refute the contention that it was offered in good faith before we brought Ms. BROWNLEY's legislation on the Deborah Sampson Act in committee.

The ranking member fails to mention that three of the amendments related to antilabor legislation, which was hostile to labor. To say that this was offered in good faith when he knows that the legislation we were bringing forward was intended to be suspension legislation, normally, the majority and the minority come to an agreement for a very expeditious legislative hearing when it comes to suspension bills.

Finally, I will mention that I watched the ranking member try to subvert the landmark H.R. 8, the universal background checks bill, by raising this issue of the NICS list and trying to whip up opposition by our veterans service organizations, so I have seen him act in a different context against H.R. 8.

Why he sought in committee to attach legislation related to guns to a women's health bill and to expanding opportunities for women veterans to utilize fully the benefits they have earned, I cannot fully comprehend that attempt.

I can say, in many instances, I responded to the ranking member's requests to actually go outside of regular order for the minority's benefit.

Let me say that I want to use this time now to yield 3 minutes the gentlewoman from California (Ms. BROWNLEY), the author of this truly historic legislation, chairwoman of our Subcommittee on Health, and also the author of the legislation.

Ms. BROWNLEY of California. Mr. Speaker, I thank the chairman for bringing my bill, the Deborah Sampson Act, to the floor. And I thank the ranking member for his support as well.

In 1782, Deborah Sampson disguised herself as a man so she could serve in the Revolutionary War to protect and defend our democracy. She was wounded in that war. Her forehead had a gash from a sword, and she was shot in the leg. But serving as a man made her invisible.

Too many decades later, Congress finally granted her petitions for the benefits she deserved, and she became one of the first American women recognized for her military service.

Women have served on land, air, and sea in every conflict in our Nation's history, yet their remarkable and brave service is often overlooked.

Through my work as chair of the Women Veterans Task Force, I have met with countless women veterans across the country who, like Deborah Sampson, feel invisible. Their service often goes unnoticed, while veteran men around them are always thanked.

Sadly, women veterans are often harassed when they go to the VA for help. This denies them the equitable access to the benefits and care they have earned and deserve.

On a recent visit to VA's only women-centric residential substance abuse rehabilitation program, an Army veteran told me the program saved her life. When women-focused resources exist, women veterans use them, and they thrive.

That is why this bill is vital for America's 2 million women veterans. It will ensure that women have consistent access to comprehensive, gender-specific care and services. It will help stop harassment and ensure that women veterans are fully recognized for their service.

In 1836, John Quincy Adams stood on the House floor and called Debra Sampson's ''heroism, fidelity, and courage'' of the ''very highest and noblest order.'' Congress recognized Debra Sampson's service and, in doing so, ensured that she was no longer invisible.

To America's women veterans of today, I stand here to say: We see you, and you are invisible no longer.

I would like to thank Representatives Allred, Brindisi, Correa, Cunningham, Delgado, Levin, Lee, Pappas, Rose, Underwood, Velazquez, and Wild, who contributed to this legislation.

I urge my colleagues to support H.R. 3224 to fully recognize and honor women veterans' service.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, may I inquire as to how much time I have remaining.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The gentleman from California has 9½ minutes remaining. The gentleman from Tennessee has 6½ minutes remaining.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield 3 minutes to the gentleman from Lexington, Kentucky (Mr. BARR), my good friend who is a member of our Veterans' Affairs Committee. He has been a tireless supporter of veterans. I have been in his district on several occasions, and the veterans have no better friend than Congressman BARR.

Mr. BARR. Mr. Speaker, I thank my good friend, Dr. ROE. I wish the gentleman a happy belated Veterans Day, and I hope he had a good weekend. I certainly did back home in Lexington, Kentucky, at Veterans Park with the Veterans Park Elementary School choir singing to our great veterans back home.

Mr. Speaker, I rise today in strong support of H.R. 3224, as amended, the Deborah Sampson Act.

As my colleagues before me have already pointed out, women have served our country since the very earliest days of the American Revolution. But as the fastest growing segment of our veteran population, they are only now starting to get the recognition that they deserve.

I am proud to be here today to support this bill that will ensure that the Department of Veterans Affairs provides them the care and benefits that their service and their sacrifices have entitled them to.

And I commend the gentlewoman from New York for her leadership on this important legislation.

I do have to say, Mr. Speaker, however, that any characterization that my Republican colleagues on the Veterans' Affairs Committee and I feel anything less than pride in the many women who have served and the many women who continue to serve today, and a steadfast commitment to support them and to meet their needs, is simply untrue. Had my colleagues or I been allowed to speak on this bill in committee, that would have been very evident to any Member of this House.

What my colleagues and I do object to are the overly partisan tactics that were deployed by the majority when this important bill was being considered.

I am new to the Veterans' Affairs Committee in this Congress, but I know that the committee has a long tradition of bipartisanship, where Members check their party affiliations at the door and do not shy away from debates or disagreements in the spirit of living up to the very democratic ideals that our veterans fought to defend. Unfortunately, we seem to have lost sight of that great tradition this year.

As Dr. ROE referenced in his comments earlier, I have been trying since February to address an unintended consequence of a House-passed bill that could allow an accused child molester who is awaiting prosecution to care for a veteran's child in a VA childcare program.

I do not know any parent in any political party who would want one of their own children to be cared for by someone who has been charged with a serious crime, like a sexual assault against a minor, before they have been fully cleared. Yet, the majority has twice used parliamentary procedures rarely if ever seen in the Veterans' Affairs Committee to refuse to allow our committee to consider my legislation to prevent that from happening to the child of one of our Nation's veterans.

Most recently, the majority did that when this bill, the Deborah Sampson Act, was being considered. Their actions were so unexpected that my colleagues and I left the markup when it became clear that the chairman was not going to allow us, or any other Member, the opportunity to speak, much less offer amendments, and declared that we were done voting on the bill.

I resent the comment that this amendment was not offered in good faith.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The time of the gentleman has expired.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield the gentleman from Kentucky another 30 seconds.

Mr. BARR. Mr. Speaker, I can assure you, as the former president of Prevent Child Abuse Kentucky, this amendment was offered very much in good faith.

It is disappointing, and it is deeply ironic, given that lack of childcare, while certainly not solely a woman's issue, is a well-known barrier to care for many women veterans, as my Democratic colleagues have pointed out over this past year.

□ 1815

Given that, it continues to astound me that the chairman would not allow us to even discuss my amendment—much less vote on it—and then immediately send a press release out after the markup accusing me and my fellow Republicans of walking out on the women veterans that my amendment would have helped to better serve.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, it is the essence of bad faith to stand on this floor and imply that Democrats do not want or care about the safety of our children.

Let's be clear that the gentleman from Tennessee offered this as a motion to recommit, this language, to Ms. BROWNLEY's bill and then, after fervently arguing why it was so necessary to be included in Ms. BROWNLEY's bill, turned around and voted with every other Member of this Chamber for Ms. BROWNLEY's bill. I cite that as evidence that there are some crocodile tears being cried here.

I now yield 2 minutes to the gentlewoman from Illinois (Ms. UNDERWOOD), my good friend and a member of the House Veterans Affairs' Subcommittee on Health.

Ms. UNDERWOOD. Mr. Speaker, I rise today in strong support of H.R. 3224, the Deborah Sampson Act.

This past Sunday, our office honored over 200 Vietnam war period veterans in my district in northern Illinois at a pinning ceremony to show our appreciation for their service to our country.

Today, the day after Veterans Day, I am so proud to be on the House floor to continue our work on behalf of veterans.

I would first like to thank Representative BROWNLEY and my other colleagues who have worked so hard to compile this important bill in the House.

In addition to providing better access to resources and benefits offered by the VA, the Deborah Sampson Act contains several provisions to ensure that women veterans have equitable access to high-quality, gender-specific healthcare.

I am proud that my bill, the Caring for Our Women Veterans Act, is included in the Deborah Sampson Act.

We know that the VA is committed to providing care to all veterans, but many VA facilities are not sufficiently equipped to provide comprehensive care to women veterans. The Caring for Our Women Veterans Act, now sections 305 to 307 of the Deborah Sampson Act, will empower the VA to fulfill its mission to honor all veterans.

The legislation requires VA to report locations where gender-specific services are used, how facilities can be improved, and where specialty staff is most needed to effectively care for women veterans.

This legislation will provide VA with the data it needs to effectively upgrade clinics and hospitals; to hire, train, and retain staff; and, most importantly, to provide earned healthcare to women veterans. These changes are long overdue, and it is now even more pressing that this legislation is passed.

Women have served honorably in the Armed Forces since the founding of these United States, and women veterans are the fastest growing group within the veteran population.

We have a collective responsibility to care for our veterans when they return home, and the Deborah Sampson Act helps achieve that by removing barriers that women veterans face on a daily basis. I urge my colleagues on both sides of the aisle to support my bill, the Caring for Our Women Veterans Act, and the underlying Deborah Sampson Act.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield 1 minute to the gentleman from California (Mr. CORREA), my good friend.

Mr. CORREA. Mr. Speaker, I rise in support of H.R. 3224, the Deborah

Sampson Act, as amended. I am proud to join my colleague, Representative BROWNLEY of California, in support of this most important bill to improve the healthcare provided for America's more than 2 million women veterans.

I thank the chairwoman of the House Veterans' Affairs Subcommittee on Health for including my bipartisan bill, Improving Oversight of Women Veterans' Care Act.

In 2016, the Government Accountability Office reported that the Veterans Health Administration had limited information on the VA medical centers' compliance with certain health standards for women veterans and access to gender-specific care provided by non-VA doctors.

In response, this legislation requires an annual report on the access of gender-specific services provided under community care contracts, including the average wait and driving times.

This bill is also directing the VA to establish a report on facilities' compliance with environment of care standards.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The time of the gentleman has expired.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield an additional 20 seconds to the gentleman from California.

Mr. CORREA. Mr. Speaker, I urge my colleagues to pass H.R. 3224.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield 1 minute to the gentlewoman from Pennsylvania (Ms. WILD), my good friend.

Ms. WILD. Mr. Speaker, I rise today in strong support of this bill.

Today, in my community and across our country, far too many Americans lack adequate access to fair housing, quality healthcare, and simple legal services, and too many of those Americans are veterans.

Today, women continue to take on new roles and responsibilities in every branch of our armed services. According to Iraq and Afghanistan Veterans of America, more than 345,000 women have deployed since 9/11.

When these women return home, they face different challenges than their male counterparts, and they are disproportionately affected by crises that affect veterans of both genders, like homelessness, with women veterans making up the fastest growing portion of the homeless vet population.

Last week, I had the privilege of speaking with women veterans in my district about these issues and other issues, and I heard how critical these problems are for them.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The time of the gentlewoman has expired.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield an additional 20 seconds to the gentlewoman from Pennsylvania.

Ms. WILD. That is why I am so proud to have introduced the Improving Legal Services for Female Veterans Act, which is included in the Deborah Sampson Act.

The very least that our men and women in uniform should be able to expect once they come home is that they won't have to fight for basic dignity, support, and opportunity after they put their lives on the line for our country.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I have no further speakers, and I am prepared to close. I reserve the balance of my time.

Mr. DAVID P. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself the balance of my time.

Mr. Speaker, certainly I think, on our side of the aisle, we are going to call for a recorded vote on this. This bill will pass overwhelmingly, and I congratulate Congresswoman BROWNLEY, who is a good friend, for bringing this legislation forward. She has worked tirelessly for this, and I think you are going to see great support. The VA has a long way to go in doing this.

I will say this. If I am privileged enough to get reelected to this body and to be placed on the Veterans' Affairs Committee again and to chair this committee, I will make this statement right here on the floor now: I will not treat the minority the same way we have been treated.

The only way we have been able to bring legislation up on this floor when we are shut out is the amendment process, and we can debate it and vote it up or down. That is what Americans do.

We should bring these bills up, and if they don't float on their merit in the majority, I am a big boy, I understand that. If you lose, you lose, and if you win, you win. But we should be allowed to be heard.

Mr. Speaker, I yield back the balance of my time.

Mr. TAKANO. Mr. Speaker, I yield myself the balance of my time.

Mr. Speaker, I am very pleased to hear that the ranking member recommends to his colleagues and all Members of the House that they support this excellent legislation by Representative BROWNLEY.

The minority knew in committee that this was excellent legislation. I am sorry to see that they chose procedural games to play politics with an excellent piece of legislation that they now say they are supporting, and I am very pleased that they are going to support this legislation.

I urge my colleagues to pass this excellent bill. We worked hard to put this legislation in the form that would be acceptable to all Members of the House, and that is why we are moving this legislation under suspension of the rules.

Mr. Speaker, I urge all my colleagues to support this bill, and I yield back the balance of my time.

Mr. SABLAN. Mr. Speaker, I rise in support of H.R. 3224, the Deborah Sampson Act, which removes barriers faced by women veterans accessing health care and benefits from the Department of Veterans Affairs.

Our country has more than 2 million women veterans who live in every Congressional district, including the Northern Mariana Islands.

And the number of women veterans seeking VA health care has doubled since 2000.

While the women veteran population continues to grow, the VA has not kept up in providing the care and services tailored to their unique health care needs.

The Deborah Sampson Act, which I cosponsored, improves women's care at the VA by requiring at least one designated women's health provider in each VA facility, retrofitting existing medical facilities to improve privacy and environmental care conditions, and expanding access to newborn care. The bill also increases funding for legal and support services to focus on unmet needs among women veterans, like prevention of eviction and foreclosure and child support issues.

Passage of H.R. 3224 is critical to ensuring the VA has the capacity and resources to meet the current and future needs of women veterans.

I thank the gentlelady from California, Ms. BROWNLEY, for her leadership on this legislation and urge my colleagues to support H.R. 3224.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The question is on the motion offered by the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) that the House suspend the rules and pass the bill, H.R. 3224, as amended.

The question was taken.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. In the opinion of the Chair, two-thirds being in the affirmative, the ayes have it.

Mr. ROE of Tennessee. Mr. Speaker, on that I demand the yeas and nays.

The yeas and nays were ordered.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to clause 8 of rule XX, further proceedings on this motion will be postponed.

CONTINUATION OF NATIONAL EMERGENCY WITH RESPECT TO IRAN—MESSAGE FROM THE PRESIDENT OF THE UNITED STATES (H. DOC. NO. 116–79)

The SPEAKER pro tempore laid before the House the following message from the President of the United States; which was read and, together with the accompanying papers, referred to the Committee on Foreign Affairs and ordered to be printed:

To the Congress of the United States:

Section 202(d) of the National Emergencies Act (50 U.S.C. 1622(d)) provides for the automatic termination of a national emergency unless, within 90 days before the anniversary date of its declaration, the President publishes in the *Federal Register* and transmits to the Congress a notice stating that the emergency is to continue in effect beyond the anniversary date. In accordance with this provision, I have sent to the *Federal Register* for publication the enclosed notice stating that the national emergency with respect to Iran declared in Executive Order 12170 of November 14, 1979, is to continue in effect beyond November 14, 2019.

Our relations with Iran have not yet normalized, and the process of implementing the agreements with Iran,

dated January 19, 1981, is ongoing. For this reason, I have determined that it is necessary to continue the national emergency declared in Executive Order 12170 with respect to Iran.

DONALD J. TRUMP.

THE WHITE HOUSE, *November 12, 2019.*

CONTINUATION OF NATIONAL EMERGENCY WITH RESPECT TO PROLIFERATION OF WEAPONS OF MASS DESTRUCTION—MESSAGE FROM THE PRESIDENT OF THE UNITED STATES (H. DOC. NO. 116–80)

The SPEAKER pro tempore laid before the House the following message from the President of the United States; which was read and, together with the accompanying papers, referred to the Committee on Foreign Affairs and ordered to be printed:

To the Congress of the United States:

Section 202(d) of the National Emergencies Act (50 U.S.C. 1622(d)) provides for the automatic termination of a national emergency unless, within 90 days before the anniversary date of its declaration, the President publishes in the *Federal Register* and transmits to the Congress a notice stating that the emergency is to continue in effect beyond the anniversary date. In accordance with this provision, I have sent to the *Federal Register* for publication the enclosed notice, stating that the national emergency with respect to the proliferation of weapons of mass destruction that was declared in Executive Order 12938 of November 14, 1994, is to continue in effect beyond November 14, 2019.

DONALD J. TRUMP.

THE WHITE HOUSE, *November 12, 2019.*

ANNOUNCEMENT BY THE SPEAKER PRO TEMPORE

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Proceedings will resume on motions to suspend the rules previously postponed. Votes will be taken in the following order:

H.R. 4162,

H.R. 3224, and

Agreeing to the Speaker's approval of the Journal, if ordered.

The first electronic vote will be conducted as a 15-minute vote. Pursuant to clause 9 of rule XX, remaining electronic votes will be conducted as 5-minute votes.

GI BILL PLANNING ACT OF 2019

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to clause 8 of rule XX, the unfinished business is the vote on the motion to suspend the rules and pass the bill (H.R. 4162) to amend title 38, United States Code, to extend the period under which an election must be made for entitlement to educational assistance under the All-Volunteer Educational Assistance Program of Department of Veterans Affairs, to phase out the use of such program, and for other purposes, as amended, on which the yeas and nays were ordered.

The Clerk read the title of the bill.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The question is on the motion offered by the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) that the House suspend the rules and pass the bill, as amended.

The vote was taken by electronic device, and there were—yeas 408, nays 0, not voting 22, as follows:

[Roll No. 610]

YEAS—408

Abraham
Adams
Aderholt
Aguilar
Allen
Allred
Amash
Amodei
Armstrong
Arrington
Axne
Babin
Bacon
Baird
Balderson
Banks
Barr
Barragán
Bass
Beatty
Bera
Bergman
Beyer
Biggs
Bilirakis
Bishop (GA)
Bishop (NC)
Bishop (UT)
Blumenauer
Blunt Rochester
Bonamici
Bost
Boyle, Brendan F.
Brady
Brindisi
Brooks (AL)
Brooks (IN)
Brown (MD)
Brownley (CA)
Buchanan
Buck
Bucshon
Budd
Burchett
Burgess
Bustos
Butterfield
Byrne
Calvert
Carbajal
Cárdenas
Carson (IN)
Carter (GA)
Carter (TX)
Cartwright
Case
Casten (IL)
Castor (FL)
Castro (TX)
Chabot
Cheney
Chu, Judy
Cicilline
Cisneros
Clark (MA)
Clarke (NY)
Clay
Cleaver
Cline
Cloud
Clyburn
Cohen
Cole
Collins (GA)
Comer
Conaway
Connolly
Cook
Cooper
Correa
Costa
Courtney
Cox (CA)
Craig
Crawford
Crenshaw
Crist
Crow
Cuellar
Cunningham
Curtis
Davids (KS)
Davidson (OH)
Davis (CA)
Davis, Rodney
DeFazio
DeGette
DeLauro
DelBene
Delgado
Demings
DeSaulnier
DesJarlais
Deutch
Diaz-Balart
Dingell
Doggett
Doyle, Michael F.
Duncan
Dunn
Emmer
Engel
Escobar
Eshoo
Espaillat
Estes
Evans
Ferguson
Finkenauer
Fitzpatrick
Fleischmann
Fletcher
Flores
Fortenberry
Foster
Foxx (NC)
Frankel
Fudge
Fulcher
Gaetz
Gallagher
Gallego
Garamendi
García (IL)
Garcia (TX)
Gianforte
Gibbs
Gohmert
Golden
Gomez
Gonzalez (OH)
Gooden
Gosar
Gottheimer
Granger
Graves (GA)
Graves (LA)
Graves (MO)
Green (TN)
Green, Al (TX)
Griffith
Grijalva
Grothman
Guest
Guthrie
Haaland
Hagedorn
Harder (CA)
Harris
Hartzler
Hastings
Hayes
Heck
Hern, Kevin
Herrera Beutler
Hice (GA)
Higgins (LA)
Higgins (NY)
Hill (AR)
Himes
Holding
Hollingsworth
Horn, Kendra S.
Horsford
Houlahan
Hoyer
Hudson
Huffman
Huizenga
Hunter
Jackson Lee
Jayapal
Jeffries
Johnson (GA)
Johnson (LA)
Johnson (OH)
Johnson (SD)
Johnson (TX)
Jordan
Joyce (OH)
Joyce (PA)
Kaptur
Katko
Keating
Keller
Kelly (MS)
Kelly (PA)
Kennedy
Khanna
Kildee
Kilmer
Kim
Kind
King (IA)
King (NY)
Kinzinger
Kirkpatrick
Krishnamoorthi
Kuster (NH)
Kustoff (TN)
LaHood
LaMalfa
Lamb
Lamborn
Langevin
Larsen (WA)
Larson (CT)
Latta
Lawrence
Lawson (FL)
Lee (CA)
Lee (NV)
Lesko
Levin (CA)
Levin (MI)
Lewis
Lieu, Ted
Lipinski
Loebsack
Lofgren
Long
Lowenthal
Lowey
Lucas
Luetkemeyer
Luján
Luria
Lynch
Malinowski
Maloney, Carolyn B.
Maloney, Sean
Marshall
Massie
Mast
Matsui
McAdams
McBath
McCarthy
McCaul
McClintock
McCollum
McGovern
McHenry
McKinley
McNerney
Meadows
Meeks
Meng
Meuser
Miller
Mitchell
Moolenaar
Mooney (WV)
Moore
Morelle
Moulton
Mucarsel-Powell
Mullin
Murphy (FL)
Murphy (NC)
Nadler
Napolitano
Neal
Neguse
Newhouse
Norcross
Norman
Nunes
O'Halleran
Ocasio-Cortez
Omar
Palazzo
Pallone
Palmer
Panetta
Pappas
Pascrell
Payne
Pence
Perlmutter
Perry
Peters
Peterson
Phillips
Pingree
Porter
Posey
Pressley
Price (NC)
Quigley
Raskin
Ratcliffe
Reed
Reschenthaler
Rice (NY)
Rice (SC)
Richmond
Riggleman
Roby
Rodgers (WA)
Roe, David P.
Rogers (AL)
Rogers (KY)
Rose (NY)
Rose, John W.
Rouda
Rouzer
Roy
Roybal-Allard
Ruiz
Ruppersberger
Rutherford
Ryan
Sánchez
Sarbanes
Scalise
Scanlon
Schakowsky
Schiff
Schneider
Schrader
Schrier
Schweikert
Scott (VA)
Scott, Austin
Scott, David
Sensenbrenner
Serrano
Sewell (AL)
Shalala
Sherrill
Shimkus
Simpson
Sires
Slotkin
Smith (MO)
Smith (NE)
Smith (NJ)
Smith (WA)
Soto
Spanberger
Spano
Speier
Stanton
Stauber
Stefanik
Steil
Steube
Stevens
Stewart
Stivers
Suozzi
Swalwell (CA)
Takano
Taylor
Thompson (CA)
Thompson (MS)
Thompson (PA)
Tipton
Titus
Tlaib
Tonko
Torres (CA)
Torres Small (NM)
Trahan
Trone
Underwood
Upton
Van Drew
Vargas
Veasey
Vela
Velázquez
Wagner
Walberg
Walden
Walker
Walorski
Waltz
Wasserman Schultz
Watkins
Watson Coleman
Weber (TX)
Webster (FL)
Welch
Wenstrup
Westerman
Wexton
Wild
Williams
Wilson (SC)
Womack
Woodall
Wright
Yarmuth
Yoho
Young
Zeldin

NOT VOTING—22

Davis, Danny K.
Dean
Gabbard
Gonzalez (TX)
Hurd (TX)
Kelly (IL)
Loudermilk
Marchant
McEachin
Olson
Pocan
Rooney (FL)
Rush
Sherman
Smucker
Thornberry
Timmons
Turner
Visclosky
Waters
Wilson (FL)
Wittman

□ 1859

So (two-thirds being in the affirmative) the rules were suspended and the bill, as amended, was passed.

The result of the vote was announced as above recorded.

A motion to reconsider was laid on the table.

DEBORAH SAMPSON ACT

The SPEAKER pro tempore (Ms. BROWNLEY of California). Pursuant to clause 8 of rule XX, the unfinished business is the vote on the motion to suspend the rules and pass the bill (H.R. 3224) to amend title 38, United States Code, to provide for increased access to Department of Veterans Affairs medical care for women veterans, as amended, on which the yeas and nays were ordered.

The Clerk read the title of the bill.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. The question is on the motion offered by

the gentleman from California (Mr. TAKANO) that the House suspend the rules and pass the bill, as amended.

This is a 5-minute vote.

The vote was taken by electronic device, and there were—yeas 399, nays 11, not voting 20, as follows:

[Roll No. 611]

YEAS—399

Abraham
Adams
Aderholt
Aguilar
Allen
Allred
Amodei
Armstrong
Arrington
Axne
Babin
Bacon
Baird
Balderson
Banks
Barr
Barragán
Bass
Beatty
Bera
Bergman
Beyer
Bilirakis
Bishop (GA)
Bishop (UT)
Blumenauer
Blunt Rochester
Bonamici
Bost
Boyle, Brendan F.
Brady
Brindisi
Brooks (AL)
Brooks (IN)
Brown (MD)
Brownley (CA)
Buchanan
Bucshon
Budd
Burchett
Burgess
Bustos
Butterfield
Byrne
Calvert
Carbajal
Cárdenas
Carson (IN)
Carter (GA)
Carter (TX)
Cartwright
Case
Casten (IL)
Castor (FL)
Castro (TX)
Chabot
Cheney
Chu, Judy
Cicilline
Cisneros
Clark (MA)
Clarke (NY)
Clay
Cleaver
Cline
Cloud
Clyburn
Cohen
Cole
Collins (GA)
Comer
Conaway
Connolly
Cook
Cooper
Correa
Costa
Courtney
Cox (CA)
Craig
Crawford
Crenshaw
Crist
Crow
Cuellar
Cunningham
Curtis
Davids (KS)
Davis (CA)
Davis, Rodney
Dean
DeFazio
DeGette
DeLauro
DelBene
Delgado
Demings
DeSaulnier
DesJarlais
Deutch
Diaz-Balart
Dingell
Doggett
Doyle, Michael F.
Duncan
Dunn
Emmer
Engel
Escobar
Eshoo
Espaillat
Estes
Evans
Ferguson
Finkenauer
Fitzpatrick
Fleischmann
Fletcher
Flores
Fortenberry
Foster
Foxx (NC)
Frankel
Fudge
Fulcher
Gaetz
Gallagher
Gallego
Garamendi
García (IL)
Garcia (TX)
Gianforte
Gibbs
Gohmert
Golden
Gomez
Gonzalez (OH)
Gooden
Gottheimer
Granger
Graves (GA)
Graves (LA)
Graves (MO)
Green (TN)
Green, Al (TX)
Griffith
Grijalva
Grothman
Guest
Guthrie
Haaland
Hagedorn
Harder (CA)
Hartzler
Hastings
Hayes
Heck
Hern, Kevin
Herrera Beutler
Higgins (LA)
Higgins (NY)
Hill (AR)
Himes
Holding
Hollingsworth
Horn, Kendra S.
Horsford
Houlahan
Hoyer
Hudson
Huffman
Huizenga
Jackson Lee
Jayapal
Jeffries
Johnson (GA)
Johnson (LA)
Johnson (OH)
Johnson (SD)
Johnson (TX)
Jordan
Joyce (OH)
Joyce (PA)
Kaptur
Katko
Keating
Keller
Kelly (MS)
Kelly (PA)
Kennedy
Khanna
Kildee
Kilmer
Kim
Kind
King (IA)
King (NY)
Kinzinger
Kirkpatrick
Krishnamoorthi
Kuster (NH)
Kustoff (TN)
LaHood
LaMalfa
Lamb
Lamborn
Langevin
Larsen (WA)
Larson (CT)
Latta
Lawrence
Lawson (FL)
Lee (CA)
Lee (NV)
Lesko
Levin (CA)
Levin (MI)
Lewis
Lieu, Ted
Lipinski
Loebsack
Lofgren
Long
Lowenthal
Lowey
Lucas
Luetkemeyer
Luján
Luria
Lynch
Malinowski
Maloney, Carolyn B.
Maloney, Sean
Marshall
Mast
Matsui
McAdams
McBath
McCarthy
McCaul
McClintock
McCollum
McGovern
McHenry
McKinley
McNerney
Meadows
Meeks
Meng
Meuser
Miller
Mitchell
Moolenaar
Mooney (WV)
Moore
Morelle
Moulton
Mucarsel-Powell
Mullin
Murphy (FL)
Murphy (NC)
Nadler
Napolitano
Neal
Neguse
Newhouse
Norcross
Nunes
O'Halleran
Ocasio-Cortez
Olson
Omar
Palazzo
Pallone
Palmer
Panetta
Pappas
Pascrell
Payne
Pence
Perlmutter
Perry
Peters
Peterson
Phillips
Pingree
Porter
Posey
Pressley
Price (NC)
Quigley
Raskin
Ratcliffe
Reed
Reschenthaler
Rice (NY)
Rice (SC)
Richmond
Riggleman
Roby
Rodgers (WA)
Roe, David P.
Rogers (AL)
Rogers (KY)
Rose (NY)
Rose, John W.
Rouda
Rouzer
Roy
Roybal-Allard
Ruiz
Ruppersberger
Rutherford
Ryan
Sánchez
Sarbanes
Scalise
Scanlon
Schakowsky
Schiff
Schneider
Schrader
Schrier
Schweikert
Scott (VA)
Scott, Austin
Scott, David
Sensenbrenner
Serrano
Sewell (AL)
Shalala
Sherrill
Shimkus
Simpson
Sires
Slotkin
Smith (MO)
Smith (NE)
Smith (NJ)
Smith (WA)
Soto
Spanberger
Spano
Speier
Stanton
Stauber
Stefanik
Steil
Steube
Stevens
Stewart
Stivers
Suozzi
Swalwell (CA)
Takano
Thompson (CA)
Thompson (MS)
Thompson (PA)
Tipton
Titus
Tlaib
Tonko
Torres (CA)
Torres Small (NM)
Trahan
Trone
Underwood
Upton
Van Drew
Vargas
Veasey
Vela
Velázquez
Wagner
Walberg
Walden
Walker
Walorski
Waltz
Wasserman Schultz
Waters
Watkins
Watson Coleman
Weber (TX)
Webster (FL)
Welch
Wenstrup
Westerman
Wexton
Wild
Williams
Wilson (SC)
Womack
Woodall
Wright
Yarmuth
Yoho
Young
Zeldin

NAYS—11

Amash
Biggs
Buck
Davidson (OH)
Gosar
Harris
Hice (GA)
Hunter
Massie
Norman
Taylor

NOT VOTING—20

Bishop (NC)
Davis, Danny K.
Gabbard
Gonzalez (TX)
Hurd (TX)
Kelly (IL)
Loudermilk
Marchant
McEachin
Pocan
Rooney (FL)
Rush
Sherman
Smucker
Thornberry
Timmons
Turner
Visclosky
Wilson (FL)
Wittman

□ 1909

So (two-thirds being in the affirmative) the rules were suspended and the bill, as amended, was passed.

The result of the vote was announced as above recorded.

A motion to reconsider was laid on the table.

THE JOURNAL

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Pursuant to clause 8 of rule XX, the unfinished business is the question on agreeing to the Speaker's approval of the Journal, which the Chair will put de novo.

The question is on the Speaker's approval of the Journal.

Pursuant to clause 1, rule I, the Journal stands approved.

AFFORDABLE DRUG COSTS

(Mr. PAYNE asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute and to revise and extend his remarks.)

Mr. PAYNE. Mr. Speaker, I rise today to praise my colleagues in this Chamber for the support of the Lower Drug Costs Now Act.

This bill will make it easier for elderly and disabled citizens to get the life-saving and life-preserving medications they need at prices they can afford.

It would finally give Medicare the power to negotiate directly with the drug companies to get these prices lower. Once they agree on a new price, this bill would make that price available to the American people with private insurance as well as those with Medicare. Then it would take some of the savings from these lowered prices and use it to find new cures for cancer and other diseases through NIH.

Mr. Speaker, I am proud of this bill and my party's continued commitment to people over profits.

□ 1915

HONORING OUR VETERANS

(Mr. WILSON of South Carolina asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute and to revise and extend his remarks.)

Mr. WILSON of South Carolina. Mr. Speaker, on Saturday, we marked the 30th anniversary of the fall of the Berlin Wall. This momentous day marks a turning point in history.

I am thankful for the leadership of President Ronald Reagan with Pope John Paul II and Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher for this triumph.

Veterans worked to put their vision of democracy into action with victory over communism by peace through strength. U.S. military veterans can cite that we have more countries today living in freedom and democracy than in the history of the world.

Yesterday, we observed Veterans Day, an opportunity to recognize freedom is not free. From tearing down the Berlin Wall 30 years ago to the recent operation in Syria to remove the murderous leader of ISIS, the continued resolve our servicemembers have to protect American families is steadfast. We will honor these sacrifices and veterans and military families, and they shall always be appreciated.

In conclusion, God bless our troops, and we will never forget September the 11th in the global war on terrorism.

CAREER COUNSELORS

(Mr. LANGEVIN asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute and to revise and extend his remarks.)

Mr. LANGEVIN. Mr. Speaker, in schools across my home State of Rhode Island and across the country, career counselors provide students with the guidance they need to navigate their academic and career pathways. It is therefore critical that these counselors have up-to-date information about all the options available to their students, including career and technical education, or CTE.

When counselors ensure students are aware of high-quality CTE programs and local workforce trends, they can make informed choices about their futures, whether that means pursuing a bachelor's degree or an apprenticeship. That is why, during National Career Development Week, I am proud to introduce the Counseling for Career Choice Act with my good friend and CTE Caucus co-chair, ''GT'' THOMPSON.

Our bipartisan bill would encourage States to develop career counseling frameworks with the input of educators, businesses, and other community leaders to provide counselors with the resources and training to best support their students. That will ultimately help lead to them reaching their career goals in life.

Mr. Speaker, I urge my colleagues to cosponsor our legislation.

VETERANS DAY

(Mr. THOMPSON of Pennsylvania asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute and to revise and extend his remarks.)

Mr. THOMPSON of Pennsylvania. Mr. Speaker, I rise today to recognize and honor our Nation's veterans, the men and women who have made the decision to commit their lives to service and to defend our great Nation, among America's most courageous.

This past July, I had the honor and privilege of traveling to Fort Drum, New York, to attend the final reenlistment and promotion of my son, Logan, to sergeant first class of the United States Army. My wife, Penny, and I could not be more proud.

There are more than 20 million veterans living in the United States today, and, as elected officials, we have the opportunity and responsibility to equip them to succeed while they are defending our Nation and to ease their burdens when they return to civilian life.

Our men and women in uniform have committed their lives to protecting this great Nation, and we are forever indebted to them for their service and their sacrifice.

CELEBRATING THE 550TH ANNIVERSARY OF THE BIRTH OF GURU NANAK SAHIB

(Mr. SUOZZI asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute.)

Mr. SUOZZI. Mr. Speaker, I rise today to extend my greeting to my friends in the Sikh community who are celebrating the 550th anniversary of the birth of Guru Nanak Sahib, the founder of the Sikh religion.

''Sat Sri Akal.''

According to Sikh tradition, Guru Nanak's birth and many events in his life demonstrate that he had been marked with divine grace. During his life, he traveled to many places proclaiming the message of one God who dwells in each and every one of his creations and constitutes eternal truth.

Guru Nanak set up a unique spiritual, social, and political platform based upon equality, fraternal love, goodness, and virtue—attributes we could use more of in our world today.

The anniversary of Guru Nanak's birth is the perfect time to reflect on the contributions of the Sikh community to world peace and understanding.

The strength of the United States lies in our rich diversity. We are truly blessed with the people of many faiths and cultures, including the Sikhs, who have contributed so much to the fabric of our American communities and the entire world.

Mr. Speaker, ''Waheguru ji ka Khalsa, Waheguruji ki Fateh.'' Purity belongs to the Creator, all victory belongs to Him.

HABERSHAM SCHOOL STATE CHAMPION VOLLEYBALL TEAM

(Mr. CARTER of Georgia asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute and to revise and extend his remarks.)

Mr. CARTER of Georgia. Mr. Speaker, I rise today to recognize the Habersham School for winning the State volleyball championship in Georgia on October 19, 2019. I could not be more proud of their excellent representation of the First Congressional District of Georgia. Now a powerhouse team in the Georgia Association of Private and Parochial Schools has won back-to-back titles.

In the championship match this year, a number of Habersham players rose to the challenge on the State's largest stage: Krista Poppell had 33 assists and 10 digs; Jordan Christy chipped in 28 kills; Makenzie Sparks had 5 kills; and Anna Thompson included 4 kills.

The team had an overall 32–6 record for the year.

Congratulations to every member of the volleyball team at Habersham School.

FREEDOM, DEMOCRACY, AND JUSTICE FOR POLITICAL PRISONERS IN TURKEY

(Ms. JACKSON LEE asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute and to revise and extend her remarks.)

Ms. JACKSON LEE. Mr. Speaker, this past weekend, we honored the men and women of the United States military, the veterans that we so much admire and respect.

I had the privilege of attending a number of veterans' commemorations, and that is why I intend to reintroduce my Battle Buddy bill, called the New Battle Buddy bill, to ensure that those leaving the Armed Forces and those already veterans have a buddy to assist them in times of crisis.

They are freedom loving, and we are reminded of the words of President John F. Kennedy who said: The price of freedom is high, but Americans are willing to pay the price.

That is why I also congratulate freedom-loving Turkish Americans and express my sadness and disappointment that the President of Turkey now comes to the United States, where, in his own country, freedom is not real. The locking up of political opposition, journalists and others, the question is: Why would he be extended an invitation for a state visit?

It is important for the United States to stand for her values of freedom, democracy, and justice. It is time to free the political prisoners in Turkey and, as well, to respond to the devastation of the Kurds.

BEVERLY HURD, VETERAN OF THE MONTH

(Mr. SPANO asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute and to revise and extend his remarks.)

Mr. SPANO. Mr. Speaker, I rise today to share the inspiring story of a World War II veteran from my district. At 102 years young, Beverly Hurd is a unique personification of what heroism is about.

In 1944, Bev put her teaching career on hold and enlisted in the U.S. Navy. While stationed at Corry Field in Pensacola, Florida, she was able to apply her teaching skills as a ground school instructor. During her time there, she developed critical classified reconnaissance films that were used in troop training.

Once discharged, Bev used her GI Bill to earn her teaching degree and return to the classroom. She went from serving in uniform to serving at home and, for nearly 40 years, educated generations of great minds.

Beverly Hurd modeled selflessness and sacrifice at a time when the doors were barely open for females to do so, and she played a critical role, both in protecting democracy and in expanding the role of women in our military service.

I thank Bev for her service, her sacrifice, and for being a great role model for generations of younger American women.

30TH ANNIVERSARY OF FALL OF BERLIN WALL

(Ms. KAPTUR asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute.)

Ms. KAPTUR. Mr. Speaker, this week, freedom lovers around the world celebrate the 30th anniversary of the fall of the Berlin Wall.

Constructed in 1961, the infamous Berlin Wall symbolized Soviet brutality and forced separation between liberty and tyranny. Yet, no wall could contain the persistent surge for liberty by the captive people of Central and Eastern Europe.

In Poland's shipyards, a workers' solidarity movement, led by visionary and valiant labor leader Lech Walesa, brought democracy to the Polish people and millions of others as the Soviet Union collapsed.

In Leipzig, Germany, 100,000 protestors and their peaceful demonstrations led to the once-unimaginable reunification of a civilized Germany.

Yet, as democracy spread, many assumed liberty's work in the region was done and that the roots of democracy were firmly entrenched.

Tragically, yet again, maligned Russian influence haunts the region as Putin wages his illegal war in Ukraine, today's scrimmage line for liberty on the European continent. Outmoded ethno-national narratives are being fed that, in the past, led to centuries of bloody conflict.

Mr. Speaker, now more than ever, democratic nations must unite so that liberty, justice, and equality is for all people across our globe.

HIRE VETS MEDALLION

(Mr. CLINE asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute and to revise and extend his remarks.)

Mr. CLINE. Mr. Speaker, yesterday was Veterans Day, and while we were all back in our district and while we should thank our veterans every day for standing in defense of our Nation, November 11 is a day when we all can join together as Americans to thank these courageous heroes.

I rise today to congratulate one specific business, Tactical and Survival Specialties, Incorporated, of Harrisonburg for being awarded the U.S. Department of Labor's HIRE Vets Medallion.

This prestigious honor is the only program within the Federal Government that recognizes the meaningful and verifiable efforts undertaken by job creators to hire and retain our veterans.

Tactical and Survival Specialties, Incorporated, was founded by retired U.S. Navy Senior Chief Petty Officer Bill Strang in 1980, and the business is one of the oldest tactical equipment suppliers in the United States. TSSi is committed to providing state-of-the-art equipment to military, law enforcement, and disaster response professionals all over the world.

I applaud TSSi on being one of a select few awardees across the Nation, and I thank all the employers who have demonstrated outstanding efforts to hire, train, and retain our veterans.

AMERICAN LEGION POST 469, LONGPORT, NEW JERSEY

(Mr. VAN DREW asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute and to revise and extend his remarks.)

Mr. VAN DREW. Mr. Speaker, I am here today to thank the American Legion Post 469 of Longport, south Jersey, for their work to honor our wounded veterans and their families with their annual Wounded Warrior Week in south Jersey.

During the week, the Legion hosts a wounded warrior and their family with an all-expenses-paid vacation to south Jersey that includes a parade with a police escort and numerous preplanned outings that include: fishing trips, days at the beach, and nights on the famous Ocean City, New Jersey, boardwalk.

All of this is a celebration that brings together the south Jersey community to honor our heroes in the military and to display the gratitude the citizens of the United States have for the many sacrifices of our soldiers and the many sacrifices that they make.

I thank the American Legion Post 469 for their continuous efforts to uplift our heroes in the Armed Forces and for having a positive impact on the south Jersey community.

I also thank Joseph Hahn for being a hero and thank the wonderful community that has hosted this year after year. And may God bless them and may God bless our heroes.

□ 1930

COMMEMORATING NATIONAL APPRENTICESHIP WEEK

(Mr. GROTHMAN asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute and to revise and extend his remarks.)

Mr. GROTHMAN. Mr. Speaker, as some of our other Members have, I rise to commemorate the observance of National Apprenticeship Week.

Whether you are talking to people who are manufacturers, whether you are talking to people in the medical community, you know that one of the biggest problems we have in America today is we don't have enough people to fill the vital jobs that are necessary for our economy and necessary for the health of our citizens.

To a certain extent, this is because the educational system has let people down, allowing them to spend tens of thousands of dollars and go tens of thousands of dollars in debt without getting the skills needed in these two vital areas.

For too long, we have just focused on a vague 4-year degree path, but we are right now in a position in which we are ruining people's lives or putting them in a very difficult position as they become 30 years old, 35 years old, and still don't have a job commensurate with repaying these loans.

Apprenticeships are good for employers, good for workers, and good for our country.

As Members of Congress, people on the Education Committee and others must do more to expand and promote the apprenticeship program.

DACA BEFORE THE SUPREME COURT

(Mr. ENGEL asked and was given permission to address the House for 1 minute and to revise and extend his remarks.)

Mr. ENGEL. Mr. Speaker, it is with great frustration that I rise today to speak on the Supreme Court hearing arguments today in three cases relating to former President Obama's DACA policy.

President Trump's decision to rescind DACA has thrust fear into hundreds of thousands of Dreamers. These individuals are active members of our society who pay taxes, create jobs, and help drive our Nation forward. To subject these individuals to the threat of deportation is absolutely wrong.

I have heard directly from many constituents who depend on DACA, and I am heartbroken by the trauma and fear they now face.

My colleagues and I did our job earlier this year in passing H.R. 6, the American Dream and Promise Act; however, Senator MCCONNELL has failed to consider this important legislation. As a result, we are now dependent on the Supreme Court offering a favorable decision that upholds DACA.

I urge Senator MCCONNELL to bring H.R. 6 for a vote and hope the Supreme Court will give a favorable decision on these cases.

CALLING FOR THE RELEASE OF AUSTIN TICE

The SPEAKER pro tempore (Mr. MORELLE). Under the Speaker's announced policy of January 3, 2019, the gentlewoman from the District of Columbia (Ms. NORTON) is recognized for 60 minutes as the designee of the majority leader.

GENERAL LEAVE

Ms. NORTON. Mr. Speaker, I ask unanimous consent that all Members may have 5 legislative days in which to revise and extend their remarks and include extraneous material on the subject of this Special Order.

The SPEAKER pro tempore. Is there objection to the request of the gentlewoman from the District of Columbia?

There was no objection.

Ms. NORTON. Mr. Speaker, I want to recognize my equal partner in this Special Order, my very good friend from Texas, Representative AL GREEN.

Representative GREEN represents the parents and, for that matter, the place where Austin Tice, the person about whom we are speaking today, was born.

He and I have partnered because Austin Tice, though born in Texas, moved to the District of Columbia. Like many in the House and Senate, we have grave concerns about Austin Tice and want to express those concerns and call upon those who are keeping him in Syria to let him go.

Mr. Speaker, I can't say enough about how strongly bipartisan this matter is—bipartisan, yes—and bicameral. There are dozens upon dozens of Members of the House and the Senate who have written the President to ask him to do all he can to bring Austin Tice home from what we believe is captivity in Syria.

Despite the difficulties our country is having, as I speak, with Syria, this, we

believe, is not a lost cause. In fact, we are encouraged that there are Americans who Syria has let come home. Sam Goodwin is one. Canadian Kristian Baxter is another.

So we do more than hold out hope that we can bring Austin Tice home.

So, let me explain who Austin Tice is and why he has attracted such concern and interest in the House of Representatives and in the Senate.

First of all, I want to pay tribute to his mother and father, Marc and Debra Tice, who have never lost hope that they can bring their son home, have visited Members of the House and Senate, and have never stopped seeking his return to the United States.

Let me tell you why he is of special concern to me. Austin Tice not only lived in the District of Columbia and will continue to live here when he returns; Austin Tice was a U.S. marine. He served in the Armed Forces of the United States.

When he came home, he enrolled in Georgetown Law school and had only a year to go when he left the law school, because he so yearned to be a reporter, and went to Syria in the early days of the civil war.

Now, because he didn't speak to a lawyer first, he entered Syria without a visa. That is why he is being held. It is not the kind of reason you would expect someone to be held in a foreign country.

After all, Syria holds more American hostages, than any country in the world or any group that is holding people—we think about half a dozen.

You wouldn't think that not having a valid visa could be anything but easily corrected, but he has been there, we believe—now he will turn 38, or he may have turned 38 by now—for 7 years with no word from him.

And that is why we come to the floor of the House tonight, because we are very concerned because we cannot be in touch with him. Despite working through the appropriate intermediary, the Czechoslovakian embassy, we have not been able to receive word.

Austin Tice left for Lebanon, by car, from Damascus. Then he fell into rebel hands and was detained at the checkpoint. That is the last we have heard of him.

January 3, the very first day of the 116th Congress, my partner and I introduced a resolution for Syria to return Austin Tice, and that was as soon as the House commenced this session.

Frankly, I am concerned that, as I note in our House resolution, that there has been a video clip on YouTube. That clip shows Austin Tice blindfolded and being prodded up a hillside by masked militants.

You can imagine, since we haven't heard from him since, why we are on the floor this evening.

The Syrian Government has not acknowledged that they are even detaining Austin Tice or his whereabouts. Officials of the United States, however, believe that Austin Tice is alive, and they believe that he is being held either by the government of Bashar al-Assad or by some group affiliated with that government.

The FBI has offered a $1 million reward for information leading to the return of Austin Tice, and we are pleased that so many journalism organizations are working for his return.

It is important to note that Austin Tice was anything but a combatant. He was a journalist. He only went to Syria because he wanted to talk with the people who were living through an awful civil war. He was freelance, so he wasn't working through any powerful media, and his concern and his interest in journalism is what drove him, not any undermining of Syria or even views on the Syrian Government. He was acting as a journalist to find out what was happening.

Now, we recognize that Syria does not have a policy of never releasing American citizens. We refer to Sam Goodwin, 30 years old, who also made a mistake. He crossed—just like Austin Tice, he just made a mistake. He crossed the border from Iraq into northeast Syria without a visa because he was trying to visit every country in the world, all the innocence of that. And it was that kind of innocence that I think we should assign to Austin Tice because he is much like Sam Goodwin in that regard.

We call upon the Syrian Government to understand Austin Tice in that context, the naivete of a young man without legal advice, simply seeking knowledge, not seeking to undermine a government or to in any way interfere with the government.

There are others who have been held and who are believed to be in custody whose families are beginning to speak out. It is important to note that many families whose relatives are held in Syria do not speak out because they are concerned that, in doing so, they will be acting against the best interests of the family member held.

So, you can see how concerned the parents of Austin Tice must be that they have felt they had to speak out after 7 years.

Bear in mind that the United States has leverage with Syria, because this country is the largest single humanitarian donor to Syria. We are providing or have provided more than $8 billion in humanitarian assistance for those displaced inside of Syria and the region since the start of that crisis in Syria.

The U.S. Government itself is supporting emergency food assistance, shelter, safe drinking water, urgent medical care, humanitarian protection activities, and other urgent relief. And I believe, if the Syrian Government understands or considers humanitarian aid from the United States, they will see that they have nothing to lose by freeing this American citizen.

Last month, the President told reporters that he himself was interested in working on securing the release of hostages in Syria. However, we do not know what action the President has taken and call upon him to become involved, as he said he would.

The only intervention we know of is his intervention into the captivity in North Korea of Otto Warmbier, but by the time he got home, it was too late, and he died shortly after being released.

However, we believe that this Austin Tice is alive and can, in fact, come home safe to us.

We believe that, in any negotiations with Syria, the fate of our hostages should be front and center. We are pleased that Senator LINDSEY GRAHAM has indicated exactly that as well, again showing the bipartisan and bicameral concern about those being held in Syria.

On August the 11th of this year, Austin Tice's parents wrote an op-ed that appeared in papers around the country on the birthday of Austin Tice. They said: ''We wish we could remind him of how glad we are he was born, how blessed we are to be his parents, and how truly we believe the world is a better place for having him in it.''

Those are the words of his parents.

We are on the floor of the House today to speed Austin Tice home.

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Mr. Speaker, I want to ask my partner to come to the floor now, Representative AL GREEN, who, of course, is the Representative from the home State of Austin Tice's parents and where Austin Tice was born and raised.

I yield to the gentleman from Texas (Mr. GREEN).

Mr. GREEN of Texas. Mr. Speaker, I thank the gentlewoman for more than her kind words. I thank her for her many years of service here in the House of Representatives. She has acquitted herself as a Congressperson par excellence: Yale, M.A.; Yale, L.L.B.; in Congress for, lo, these many years, yet not able to vote as other Congresspeople do.

Mr. Speaker, I believe that the gentlewoman and I will see the day that she will cast that first vote. I thank her for all of her endeavors. I especially thank her for what she is doing for Austin Tice.

The Tice family, Marc and Debra, are the equivalent of family with me. I have known them for many years now. I know how sincere they are with the efforts to bring their son home.

I know of their trips to Lebanon. I know that they have corresponded with people that some of us might not find suitable for such correspondence. But because they want their son, they are willing to talk to anyone who has intelligence that might lead to his return.

I know that they have made a difference in the lives of others who have friends, relatives, children, if you will, captured because they have worked with the State Department to help fashion protocols. They have worked with two Presidents. They want their

son home, but they also want to see justice for all persons who are being held captive.

Their son, Austin, is an all-American lad, at 38 years of age now. I am 71. Anybody under 71 is young to me.

He is an all-American person, if you will. Yes, he has served his country in the military. Yes, he was an Eagle Scout. Yes, he did attend Georgetown, Georgetown Law, as a matter of fact. Yes, he was a freelance journalist.

He was one of those persons who would dare to go to distant places, dare to risk life and limb so that we might know the truth about circumstances in places where the eyes of cameras do not pierce.

Yes, he was a person who had the courage, intestinal fortitude, to go into Syria without the consent of the government. I wish he hadn't done it, but I understand why he did it. I understand that he wanted to let people know about the conditions.

I am not sure that he went with preconceived notions, but I am sure of this: that he would tell the truth, that he would present the truth, that we would know the truth, whatever that truth might be.

I regret that he has been held captive now for some 7 years. He truly is a great American.

But more than this, for me, he represents the son I never had. I have no children. But if I had a son, I would want him to be like Austin Tice. I would want my son to have the courage to not measure his life by days and years, not measure his life by heartthrobs, passions, and tears. I would want my son to use the truest measure under God's Sun, and that is, what for others in your lifetime have you done?

Austin Tice was trying to help somebody. He wasn't there to help himself. He wanted to help others. That is the kind of son I would like to have, a courageous person who would dare to go where others dare not, a person who understood the risk but also understood the need.

Sometimes people like this have to stand alone, but they know that it is better to stand alone than not stand at all.

He is a hero. I miss him. His parents miss him. This country misses him.

I would ask that those who can reach the proper authorities in Syria—perhaps it is the President. Perhaps there are people who can get to the President. But I would ask that you would send this message: As a gesture of goodwill, let Austin Tice come home. As a gesture of an attempt to span some chasms that have been created, let us bring Austin Tice back.

This could be the genesis of something bigger than we know, giving Austin Tice his freedom.

I can tell you this: There are some Members of Congress who will be appreciative. There are American people who won't forget it. And there is an opportunity available to mend some fences.

I pray that this word will get to the appropriate authorities.

Mr. President, if this word gets to you, I would have you know that I am the kind of Congressperson who is willing to come to Syria. I am willing to come and be there to thank you and to welcome Austin Tice back into the hands of an agent of the United States Government.

This is a great opportunity. I beg that we take advantage of it.

Mr. and Mrs. Tice, I want you to know that we have not given up. We will not give in. We want Austin returned, and we will do everything, and we will leave no stone unturned, until this takes place.

Mr. Speaker, I thank the gentlewoman for the time.

Ms. NORTON. Mr. Speaker, I don't think there could have been a more eloquent statement than the statement we have just heard from my good friend, AL GREEN.

I am inclined to believe that if the Syrian authorities were listening, even they could not resist the eloquence, the depth of Representative GREEN's very intelligent but heartfelt statement.

I know that statement is much appreciated by Austin Tice's parents, who have had to go these 7 years alone, with only your help as their Member of Congress.

I am also grateful to the Members of Congress who, after all, don't necessarily represent anyone connected with Austin Tice, as AL GREEN and I do, for their generosity in coming to the floor. I would like to call upon Representative LORI TRAHAN from Massachusetts to ask her to say a few words at this time.

I yield to the gentlewoman from Massachusetts (Mrs. TRAHAN).

Mrs. TRAHAN. Mr. Speaker, I thank the gentlewoman from the District of Columbia (Ms. NORTON) and the gentleman from Texas (Mr. GREEN) for their dedication to the Tice family.

Mr. Speaker, I rise today to call attention to an issue of critical importance for our country. Our fellow American, Austin Tice, is in his eighth year of captivity in Syria, where we believe he was unjustly detained and is reported to be held by the Syrian Government or its affiliates.

Austin was risking his health and safety as a freelance reporter, endeavoring to shed light on the suffering of the Syrian people for the world to see. His reporting has appeared in The Washington Post, McClatchy, and other news outlets.

As a fellow graduate of Georgetown's School of Foreign Service, Austin was also a former Marine Corps captain who served tours in Iraq and Afghanistan. Austin was no stranger to risk.

Regardless, he knew the importance of the work he was undertaking. His dedication to service represents the very best our country has to offer.

There is every reason for us to believe that Austin is still alive, and I have joined with my colleagues to call on our administration to use the full resources of the United States Government to bring Austin home.

I had the privilege of meeting Austin's parents, Marc and Debra, a couple of months ago. I am awestruck by their hope, their perseverance, and their commitment to seeing their son returned home once and for all.

I am comforted that there is strong bipartisan support behind this effort. I know we can get this done if we work together.

I again thank the gentlewoman from the District of Columbia. I appreciate so much her organizing this Special Order and a coalition of bipartisan legislators to keep focus on this very important issue. We won't stop until we bring Austin Tice home.

Ms. NORTON. Mr. Speaker, I thank my good friend from Massachusetts whose relationship with Austin Tice—she didn't know him, but there is a school tie there.

It shows you that people, when they hear about Austin Tice's captivity, are inclined to the eloquence of Mrs. TRAHAN, who just spoke about him, spoke about him without knowing him, spoke with such enviable and praiseworthy remarks.

I thank her so much. I know that I speak for his parents in thanking her as well.

Mr. Speaker, I now want to introduce one of my good friends from the region. We were so pleased to welcome her into our delegation, and I am anxious to hear what she has to say because she, too, is neither from Texas nor the District of Columbia, and yet, with selflessness, she has asked to express her views on the captivity of Austin Tice.

I yield to the gentlewoman from Virginia (Ms. SPANBERGER), my good friend, at this time.

Ms. SPANBERGER. Mr. Speaker, I thank Congresswoman HOLMES NORTON for organizing this Special Order. I am grateful for the comments that she has made.

To the gentleman from Texas (Mr. GREEN), his passionate plea to see Austin Tice freed was moving, and I am proud to associate myself with many of his comments.

I rise today because Austin Tice has been in captivity for 2,647 days. Those have been 2,647 days of fear and anguish for his parents, his friends, his classmates, and his community. They have also represented 2,647 days of Austin's remarkable life and his determination and his will to live despite his captivity.

Austin is a journalist with a deep sense of service. He is also a veteran. Seven years ago, he traveled to Syria to report on the plight of Syria's children. He wanted to shed light on the consequences of a complex and unrelenting war on the youth of Syria. And in Syria, he was abducted. It was that 2,647 days ago that he was abducted.

He remains held in Syria, and we have every reason to believe that Austin is still alive. He is being held in

Syria. In September, I joined a letter sent by Republicans and Democrats directly to the President of the United States. In that letter, we called on the administration to use every diplomatic tool in our toolbox to secure Austin's safe return home.

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Austin's parents have been among his strongest advocates. They have made countless trips to Washington, D.C., and across the Middle East working to secure his release. They have been pillars of strength as they have fought to bring their son home.

I had the opportunity and the honor to meet Marc when he was in Washington, D.C.; and to see the tenacity and strength and devotion to his child was awe inspiring. It also makes me understand how he could be a parent to a young man who would go out and seek adventure and seek truth and seek information as a journalist.

It is my hope that we can come together as a body to bring Austin Tice home. I never met Austin Tice, but I am in awe of his story as an adventurer, as a journalist, as a veteran, as someone who has traveled the world seeking information and stories.

I have been compelled to take part in this event tonight, and I thank my colleagues for their tireless efforts on behalf of Austin Tice, their work to bring him home, their work to bring a voice to his story and knowledge of his continued capture and detainment in Syria. I thank them for their work, and I look forward to continuing, in small part, to work with them where I am able, where I can be of aid to bring information and light to Austin's story and to continue to be an advocate to bring him home.

It is my hope that in some days we will be able, here on the House floor, to celebrate the homecoming of an American, of a veteran, of a journalist, of a man who sought to tell the story of children in Syria.

Ms. NORTON. Mr. Speaker, I certainly want to thank my good friend, Representative SPANBERGER, for those compelling remarks. Once again, we are hearing from a Member who, as she says, did not know Austin Tice.

I hope that Debra and Marc Tice, when they see Representative SPANBERGER give such eloquent and intelligent and deeply felt remarks, are comforted to know that they are not alone in seeking the release of their son.

Mr. Speaker, there are a number of Members, not to mention all of the many Members of the House and Senate, who have signed on letters to the President for help with Austin Tice, but it is worth noting again that, on the very first day of Congress, Rep. AL GREEN introduced H. Res. 17.

That resolution, introduced with Representative AL GREEN, sought, from the very beginning of the 116th Congress, to draw attention to Austin Tice, and we will not cease drawing just that kind of attention until we have learned where Austin Tice is and when he is coming home.

The resolution that we introduced expressed concern over the detention of Austin Tice and laid out many of the factual matters that the Members have offered here today. In that resolution, we not only expressed our concern regarding the detention of Austin Tice, we asked the State Department and the intelligence community and the interagency Hostage Recovery Fusion Cell to jointly continue investigations and to pursue all information. We have every reason to believe that that is being done by our agencies.

We encouraged, in our resolution, the State Department and the Special Presidential Envoy for Hostage Affairs to engage directly with Syrian officials to facilitate Austin's safe release. In our resolution, we encourage the State Department to work with foreign governments known to have diplomatic influence with the Government of Syria, and we request the State Department and the intelligence community to continue to work with and to inform Congress and Austin Tice's family regarding his safe release and his condition at this time.

We, I think, in bringing this very young man to the attention of the American people, we have shown our concern and have shown that we remain hopeful.

In this case, no word is good word; it is word, that he is alive, we believe. The best word would be word to the parents, Debra and Marc Tice, that he is on his way home safe and sound.

Let me pledge on behalf of the many Members of the House and Senate who have written the President, let me assure these parents, Marc and Debra Tice: This Special Order devoted to your son, Austin Tice, is not the end of the work we will continue to do until we bring your son, Austin Tice, home. We appreciate the devotion you have shown as parents, and we mean to honor that devotion by continuing to do all we can in the Congress to make sure that Austin Tice is returned to you safe and sound.

Mr. Speaker, I yield back the balance of my time.

Mr. MCGOVERN. Mr. Speaker, I want to thank the gentlelady from the District of Columbia, the Honorable ELEANOR HOLMES NORTON, for leading this special order today on the life of Austin Tice.

In November 2016, I had the privilege of meeting for the first time, Austin Tice's mother, Debra. It was at the Newseum, where Reporters Without Borders and the Newseum were launching a campaign that ran a banner on the Newseum's facade featuring Austin.

The banner was showing on the International Day to End Impunity for Crimes Against Journalists. The banner had a simple message next to a photo of Austin's face, "Held captive for being a journalist since August 2012."

Austin Tice is the only American journalist being held captive in Syria. The banner at the Newseum is supposed to continue to run until he is safely returned home to his family.

Today, November 12, 2019, Austin remains in captivity. I had the privilege of meeting his parents Marc and Debra Tice in September. They brought me up-to-date on Austin's captivity, and the many efforts to press for his freedom.

Austin Tice is a graduate of the Georgetown School of Foreign Service and many of Georgetown's students and faculty have taken up his cause. He served as a Marine officer and returned home to study at the Georgetown School of Law. But when he saw the carnage inside Syria, he felt a calling to report on the Syrian human crisis. Working as a freelance journalist and photographer for McClatchey newspapers, his images, interviews and reports soon appeared in the Washington Post, McClatchey, Agence France-Presse and other news media.

He intended to leave Syria after his 31st birthday, on August 11, 2012, after he filed his last story. On August 14th, he left for Lebanon by car from Damascus. Shortly after, we know that he was stopped and detained at a checkpoint, most likely in rebel control. Five weeks later, a video was posted on a pro-government website by people who appeared to be Islamist militants. There has been no contact with his captors.

Marc and Debra continue their efforts to find and release their son. The State Department believes that he is still alive. Other countries have offered their services as intermediaries. And national and international campaigns have been mounted to support him, his family, and the many other journalists from many nations who are in captivity or held hostage around the world.

Congress has sent several letters, introduced bills, and like today, taken to the floor of the House of Representatives to raise his case and declare our sympathy and solidarity with his family, friends and colleagues.

We will not stop until Austin is free and reunited with his family.

LEAVE OF ABSENCE

By unanimous consent, leave of absence was granted to:

Mr. DANNY K. DAVIS of Illinois (at the request of Mr. HOYER) for today.

ADJOURNMENT

Ms. NORTON. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House do now adjourn.

The motion was agreed to; accordingly (at 8 o'clock and 7 minutes p.m.), under its previous order, the House adjourned until tomorrow, Wednesday, November 13, 2019, at 10 a.m. for morning-hour debate.

BUDGETARY EFFECTS OF PAYGO LEGISLATION

Pursuant to the Statutory Pay-As-You-Go Act of 2010 (PAYGO), Mr. YARMUTH hereby submits, prior to the vote on passage, the attached estimate of the costs of H.R. 4625, the Protect the GI Bill Act, as amended, for printing in the CONGRESSIONAL RECORD.

ESTIMATE OF PAY-AS-YOU-GO EFFECTS FOR H.R. 4625

	By fiscal year, in millions of dollars—											
	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026	2027	2028	2029	2020–2024	2020–2029
Statutory Pay-As-You-Go Impact	7	32	37	10	−10	−16	−14	−15	−16	−17	77	0

Components may not sum to totals because of rounding.

Pursuant to the Statutory Pay-As-You-Go Act of 2010 (PAYGO), Mr. YARMUTH hereby submits, prior to the vote on passage, the attached estimate of the costs of H.R. 4162, the GI Bill Planning Act of 2019, as amended, for printing in the CONGRESSIONAL RECORD.

ESTIMATE OF PAY-AS-YOU-GO EFFECTS FOR H.R. 4162

	By fiscal year, in millions of dollars—											
	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026	2027	2028	2029	2020–2024	2020–2029
Statutory Pay-As-You-Go Impact	−6	6	12	11	11	−4	−4	−5	−10	−11	34	0

Components may not sum to totals because of rounding.

EXECUTIVE COMMUNICATIONS, ETC.

Under clause 2 of rule XIV, executive communications were taken from the Speaker's table and referred as follows:

2881. A letter from the Administrator, Agricultural Marketing Service, Dairy Program, Department of Agriculture, transmitting the Department's final rule — Establishment of a Milk Donation Reimbursement Program [Doc. No.: AMS-DA-19-0001] (RIN: 0581-AD87) received November 7, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); to the Committee on Agriculture.

2882. A letter from the Deputy Chief Financial Officer, Department of Energy, transmitting a letter reporting violations of the Antideficiency Act by the Department of Energy, pursuant to 31 U.S.C. 1517(b); Public Law 110-161, Sec. 1517(b); (121 Stat. 2285); to the Committee on Appropriations.

2883. A letter from the Under Secretary of Defense, Personnel and Readiness, Department of Defense, transmitting a letter authorizing Vice Admiral Charles A. Richard, United States Navy, to wear the insignia of the grade of admiral, pursuant to 10 U.S.C. 777a(b)(4); Public Law 111-383, Sec. 505(a)(1); (124 Stat. 4208); to the Committee on Armed Services.

2884. A letter from the Under Secretary, Personnel and Readiness, Department of Defense, transmitting the Department's report on Career Progression Tracks of the Armed Forces for Women in Combat Arms Units, pursuant to Public Law 114-328, Sec. 597; (130 Stat. 2154); to the Committee on Armed Services.

2885. A letter from the Chief, Law Enforcement Division, Department of the Army, Department of Defense, transmitting the Department's final rule — Military Police Investigation [Docket ID: USA-2018-HQ-0023] (RIN: 0702-AB01) received November 4, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); to the Committee on Armed Services.

2886. A letter from the Acting Principal Director, Defense Pricing and Contracting, Defense Acquisition Regulations Systems, Department of Defense, transmitting the Department's final rule — Defense Federal Acquisition Regulation Supplement: Repeal of DFARS Provision Related to Disclosure of Information for Litigation Support (DFARS Case 2019-D021) [Docket: DARS-2019-0065] (RIN: 0750-AK58) received November 1, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); to the Committee on Armed Services.

2887. A letter from the Acting Principal Director, Defense Pricing and Contracting, Defense Acquisition Regulations System, Department of Defense, transmitting the Department's final rule — Defense Federal Acquisition Regulation Supplement: Nonmanufacturer Rule for 8(a) Participants (DFARS Case 2019-D004) [Docket: DARS-2019-0015] (RIN: 0750-AK39) received November 1, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); to the Committee on Armed Services.

2888. A letter from the Acting Principal Director, Defense Pricing and Contracting, Defense Acquisition Regulations Systems, Department of Defense, transmitting the Department's final rule — Defense Federal Acquisition Regulation Supplement: Reliability and Maintainability in Weapon System Design (DFARS Case 2019-D003) [Docket: DARS-2019-0026] (RIN: 0750-AK38) received November 1, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); to the Committee on Armed Services.

2889. A letter from the Acting Principal Director, Defense Pricing and Contracting, Defense Acquisition Regulations System, Department of Defense, transmitting the Department's final rule — Defense Federal Acquisition Regulation Supplement: Modification of DFARS Clause ''Obligation of the Government'' (DFARS Case 2018-D046) [Docket: DARS-2019-0029] (RIN: 0750-AK11) received November 1, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); to the Committee on Armed Services.

2890. A letter from the Acting Principal Director, Defense Pricing and Contracting, Defense Acquisition Regulations Systems, Department of Defense, transmitting the Department's final rule — Defense Federal Acquisition Regulation Supplement: Modification of DFARS Clause ''Protection Against Compromising Emanations'' (DFARS Case 2019-D015) [Docket: DARS-2019-0061] (RIN: 0750-AK52) received November 1, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); to the Committee on Armed Services.

2891. A letter from the Assistant to the Board, Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System, transmitting the Board's Major final rule — Changes to Applicability Thresholds for Regulatory Capital and Liquidity Requirements [Regulations Q, WW; Docket No.: R-1628] (RIN: 7100-AF21) received November 4, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); to the Committee on Financial Services.

2892. A letter from the Administrator, Wage and Hour Division, Department of Labor, transmitting the Department's final rule — Authorizing Electronic Payments of Civil Money Penalties (RIN: 1235-AA28) received November 7, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); to the Committee on Education and Labor.

2893. A letter from the Deputy Assistant General Counsel for Regulatory Affairs, Pension Benefit Guaranty Corporation, transmitting the Department's final rule — Benefits Payable in Terminated Single-Employer Plans; Interest Assumptions for Paying Benefits received November 4, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); to the Committee on Education and Labor.

2894. A letter from the Assistant Secretary, Bureau of Legislative Affairs, Department of State, transmitting the Department's Country Reports on Terrorism 2018, pursuant to Sec. 140 of the Foreign Relations Authorization Act for FY 1988 and 1989, as amended (22 U.S.C. 2656f); to the Committee on Foreign Affairs.

2895. A letter from the Chairman, Council of the District of Columbia, transmitting D.C. Act 23-132, ''School Sunscreen Safety Temporary Amendment Act of 2019'', pursuant to Public Law 93-198, Sec. 602(c)(1); (87 Stat. 814); to the Committee on Oversight and Reform.

2896. A letter from the Chairman, Council of the District of Columbia, transmitting D.C. Act 23-134, ''Primary Date Alteration Amendment Act of 2019'', pursuant to Public Law 93-198, Sec. 602(c)(1); (87 Stat. 814); to the Committee on Oversight and Reform.

2897. A letter from the Chairman, Council of the District of Columbia, transmitting D.C. Act 23-155, ''Al and Mary Arrighi Way Designation Act of 2019'', pursuant to Public Law 93-198, Sec. 602(c)(1); (87 Stat. 814); to the Committee on Oversight and Reform.

2898. A letter from the Chairman, Council of the District of Columbia, transmitting D.C. Act 23-156, ''Educational Research Practice Partnership Technical Temporary

Amendment Act of 2019'', pursuant to Public Law 93-198, Sec. 602(c)(1); (87 Stat. 814); to the Committee on Oversight and Reform.

2899. A letter from the Chairman, Council of the District of Columbia, transmitting D.C. Act 23-152, ''Joy Evans Therapeutic Center Designation Act of 2019'', pursuant to Public Law 93-198, Sec. 602(c)(1); (87 Stat. 814); to the Committee on Oversight and Reform.

2900. A letter from the Auditor, Office of the District of Columbia Auditor, transmitting a final report: BEGA Mishandled Whistleblower Complaint on Housing Procurement, pursuant to Public Law 93-198, Sec. 455(d); (87 Stat. 803); to the Committee on Oversight and Reform.

2901. A letter from the Auditor, Office of the District of Columbia Auditor, transmitting a final report: D.C. Department of Health Has Systems to Monitor Nursing Homes But Some Risks Remain, pursuant to Public Law 93-198, Sec. 455(d); (87 Stat. 803); to the Committee on Oversight and Reform.

2902. A letter from the National President, Women's Army Corps Veterans' Association, transmitting the Association's annual audit from MDA Professional Group, PC for the year ending June 30, 2019, pursuant to 36 U.S.C. 3111; Public Law 98-584, Sec. 12; (98 Stat. 3099); to the Committee on the Judiciary.

2903. A letter from the Secretary, Judicial Conference of the United States, transmitting the Electronic Public Access Fee Schedule, pursuant to 28 U.S.C. 1913 note; Public Law 102-140, Sec. 303(b); (105 Stat. 810); to the Committee on the Judiciary.

2904. A letter from the Management and Program Analyst, FAA, Department of Transportation, transmitting the Department's final rule — Airworthiness Directives; Airbus SAS Airplanes [Docket No.: FAA-2019-0404; Product Identifier 2019-NM-007-AD; Amendment 39-19754; AD 2019-20-01] (RIN: 2120-AA64) received November 1, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); to the Committee on Transportation and Infrastructure.

2905. A letter from the Under Secretary, Acquisition and Sustainment, Department of Defense, transmitting the Department's Small Business Strategy, October 2019, pursuant to 10 U.S.C. 2283 note; Public Law 115-232, Sec. 851(b)(2)(A); (132 Stat. 1884); jointly to the Committees on Armed Services and Small Business.

2906. A letter from the Regulations Coordinator, Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services, Department of Health and Human Services, transmitting the Department's Major final rule and interim final rule — Medicare Program; CY 2020 Revisions to Payment Policies under the Physician Fee Schedule and Other Changes to Part B Payment Policies; Medicare Shared Savings Program Requirements; Medicaid Promoting Interoperability Program Requirements for Eligible Professionals; Establishment of an Ambulance Data Collection System; Updates to the Quality Payment Program; etc.. [CMS-1715-F and IFC] (RIN: 0983-AT72) received November 5, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); jointly to the Committees on Energy and Commerce and Ways and Means.

2907. A letter from the Regulations Coordinator, Center for Medicare and Medicaid Services, Department of Health and Human Services, transmitting the Department's Major final methodology — Basic Health Program; Federal Funding Methodology for Program Years 2019 and 2020 [CMS-2407-FN] (RIN: 0938-ZB42) received November 5, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); jointly to the Committees on Energy and Commerce and Ways and Means.

2908. A letter from the Regulations Coordinator, Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services, Department of Health and Human Services, transmitting the Department's Major final rule — Medicare Program: Changes to Hospital Outpatient Prospective Payment and Ambulatory Surgical Center Payment Systems and Quality Reporting Programs; Revisions of Organ Procurement Organizations Conditions of Coverage; Prior Authorization Process and Requirements for Certain Covered Outpatient Department Services; Potential Changes to the Laboratory Date of Service Policy; etc. [CMS-1717-FC] (RIN: 0938-AT74) received November 5, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); jointly to the Committees on Energy and Commerce and Ways and Means.

2909. A letter from the Regulations Coordinator, Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services, Department of Health and Human Services, transmitting the Department's Major final rule — Medicare Program; End-Stage Renal Disease Prospective Payment System, Payment for Renal Dialysis Services Furnished to Individuals With Acute Kidney Injury, End-Stage Renal Disease Quality Incentive Program, Durable Medical Equipment, Prosthetics, Orthotics and Supplies (DMEPOS) Fee Schedule Amounts, DMEPOS Competitive Bidding Program (CBP) Amendments, Standard Elements for a DMEPOS Order, etc. [CMS-1713-F] (RIN: 0938-AT70) received November 5, 2019, pursuant to 5 U.S.C. 801(a)(1)(A); Public Law 104-121, Sec. 251; (110 Stat. 868); jointly to the Committees on Energy and Commerce and Ways and Means.

REPORTS OF COMMITTEES ON PUBLIC BILLS AND RESOLUTIONS

Under clause 2 of rule XIII, reports of committees were delivered to the Clerk for printing and reference to the proper calendar, as follows:

Mr. THOMPSON of Mississippi: Committee on Homeland Security. H.R. 3699. A bill to codify the Transportation Security Administration's responsibility relating to securing pipelines against cybersecurity threats, acts of terrorism, and other nefarious acts that jeopardize the physical security or cybersecurity of pipelines, and for other purposes (Rept. 116–279). Referred to the Committee of the Whole House on the state of the Union.

Ms. VELÁZQUEZ: Committee on Small Business. H.R. 1615. A bill to transfer the responsibility of verifying small business concerns owned and controlled by veterans or service-disabled veterans to the Small Business Administration, and for other purposes; with an amendment (Rept. 116–280, Pt. 1). Referred to the Committee of the Whole House on the state of the Union.

Mr. TAKANO: Committee on Veterans' Affairs. H.R. 3224. A bill to amend title 38, United States Code, to provide for increased access to Department of Veterans Affairs medical care for women veterans; with an amendment (Rept. 116–281). Referred to the Committee of the Whole House on the state of the Union.

Ms. WATERS: Committee on Financial Services. H.R. 3141. A bill to limit the collection of annual premiums under the FHA program for mortgage insurance for single family housing, and for other purposes; with an amendment (Rept. 116–282). Referred to the Committee of the Whole House on the state of the Union.

DISCHARGE OF COMMITTEE

Pursuant to clause 2 of rule XIII, the Committee on Veterans' Affairs discharged from further consideration. H.R. 1615 referred to the Committee of the Whole House on the state of the Union.

PUBLIC BILLS AND RESOLUTIONS

Under clause 2 of rule XII, public bills and resolutions of the following titles were introduced and severally referred, as follows:

By Mr. HUFFMAN (for himself, Mr. CASE, and Mr. GROTHMAN):

H.R. 5032. A bill to amend chapter 73 of title 38, United States Code, to direct the Secretary of Veterans Affairs to establish a rural recruitment office within the Department of Veterans Affairs to recruit health care professionals, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Veterans' Affairs.

By Mr. BYRNE:

H.R. 5033. A bill to expand the eligibility of veterans for hospital care and medical services provided by non-Department of Veterans Affairs medical providers under the Veterans Choice Program; to the Committee on Veterans' Affairs.

By Mr. COHEN (for himself, Ms. OCASIO-CORTEZ, Ms. BONAMICI, Mrs. WATSON COLEMAN, Ms. WILD, Ms. SCHAKOWSKY, Mr. DANNY K. DAVIS of Illinois, and Ms. NORTON):

H.R. 5034. A bill to amend the Fair Debt Collection Practices Act to prohibit debt collectors from collecting, or attempting to collect, on a debt of a consumer with respect to which the statute of limitations has expired, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Financial Services.

By Mr. MICHAEL F. DOYLE of Pennsylvania:

H.R. 5035. A bill to amend the Communications Act of 1934 to extend expiring provisions relating to the retransmission of signals of television broadcast stations, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Energy and Commerce.

By Mr. PAPPAS (for himself, Ms. LEE of California, Mrs. HAYES, Ms. NORTON, Mr. CASTEN of Illinois, Mr. NADLER, Mr. THOMPSON of Mississippi, Ms. MOORE, Mr. RUSH, Mr. JOHNSON of Georgia, Mr. DOGGETT, Mr. CISNEROS, Mr. WELCH, Ms. TLAIB, Ms. SHALALA, Ms. BLUNT ROCHESTER, Mr. ESPAILLAT, Ms. ESCOBAR, Mr. COHEN, Ms. SPEIER, Ms. PRESSLEY, Ms. JUDY CHU of California, Mr. POCAN, Ms. HAALAND, Mr. SMITH of Washington, Ms. DELAURO, Mr. DEFAZIO, Mr. BLUMENAUER, Mr. KHANNA, Ms. DEGETTE, Mr. RYAN, Ms. MENG, Ms. SÁNCHEZ, Ms. DELBENE, Ms. SCHAKOWSKY, Mr. CARSON of Indiana, Mr. HASTINGS, Mrs. LEE of Nevada, Mrs. FLETCHER, Mr. MICHAEL F. DOYLE of Pennsylvania, Mr. SERRANO, Mr. CÁRDENAS, Mrs. NAPOLITANO, Mr. ENGEL, Mr. SOTO, Ms. BONAMICI, Mr. TRONE, Mr. SIRES, Ms. ROYBAL-ALLARD, Mr. GOMEZ, Mrs. DAVIS of California, Mr. COOPER, Mr. KENNEDY, Mr. FOSTER, Ms. SCHRIER, Ms. MUCARSEL-POWELL, Ms. FRANKEL, Mr. DESAULNIER, Mrs. LAWRENCE, Miss RICE of New York, Mr. GARCÍA of Illinois, Mr. SHERMAN, Ms. BASS, Mr. PAYNE, Ms. VELÁZQUEZ, Mr. TAKANO, Ms. KUSTER of New Hampshire, Mr. SCHIFF, Mr. MOULTON, Mr. SEAN PATRICK MALONEY of New York, Mrs. CAROLYN B. MALONEY of New York, Mr. BRENDAN F. BOYLE of Pennsylvania, Mr. LARSEN of Washington, Mrs. DEMINGS, Ms. SHERRILL, Ms. WASSERMAN SCHULTZ, Ms. JAYAPAL, Ms. BROWNLEY of California, Mrs. LOWEY,

Ms. WEXTON, Mr. QUIGLEY, Mr. LOEBSACK, Mr. KEATING, Ms. PLASKETT, Mr. CICILLINE, Ms. MCCOLLUM, Ms. KELLY of Illinois, Mr. GALLEGO, Mr. HIGGINS of New York, Mr. GRIJALVA, Mr. LEVIN of Michigan, Mr. RASKIN, Mrs. WATSON COLEMAN, Ms. JACKSON LEE, Mr. CRIST, Mr. MCNERNEY, Mrs. TRAHAN, and Mr. KILDEE):

H.R. 5036. A bill to prohibit the Secretary of Health and Human Services from taking any action to implement, enforce, or otherwise give effect to the final rule, entitled ''Protecting Statutory Conscience Rights in Health Care; Delegations of Authority''; to the Committee on Energy and Commerce.

By Mr. MURPHY of North Carolina (for himself, Mr. BUTTERFIELD, Mr. HOLDING, Mr. PRICE of North Carolina, Ms. FOXX of North Carolina, Mr. WALKER, Mr. ROUZER, Mr. HUDSON, Mr. BISHOP of North Carolina, Mr. MCHENRY, Mr. MEADOWS, Ms. ADAMS, and Mr. BUDD):

H.R. 5037. A bill to designate the facility of the United States Postal Service located at 3703 North Main Street in Farmville, North Carolina, as the ''Walter B. Jones, Jr. Post Office''; to the Committee on Oversight and Reform.

By Ms. LOFGREN (for herself, Mr. NEWHOUSE, Mr. PETERSON, Mr. SIMPSON, Mr. NADLER, Mr. DIAZ-BALART, Ms. SÁNCHEZ, Mr. LAMALFA, Mr. PANETTA, Mr. AMODEI, Mr. COX of California, Mr. BAIRD, Mr. COSTA, Mrs. BROOKS of Indiana, Mr. HARDER of California, Mr. COLE, Mr. BRINDISI, Mr. CURTIS, Ms. JUDY CHU of California, Mr. RODNEY DAVIS of Illinois, Ms. FUDGE, Mr. GIBBS, Mr. LAWSON of Florida, Mrs. RODGERS of Washington, Ms. SLOTKIN, Mr. MITCHELL, Mr. CORREA, Mr. NUNES, Ms. TORRES SMALL of New Mexico, Mr. REED, Ms. GARCIA of Texas, Ms. STEFANIK, Mr. DAVID SCOTT of Georgia, Mr. STIVERS, Mr. CARBAJAL, Mr. UPTON, Mr. SCHRADER, Mr. YOUNG, Ms. CRAIG, Mr. WALDEN, Mr. CÁRDENAS, Mr. FITZPATRICK, Ms. SPANBERGER, Mr. VELA, Mrs. TORRES of California, Ms. SCHRIER, Mr. SMUCKER, Mr. PETERS, Mr. TIPTON, and Mr. CROW):

H.R. 5038. A bill to amend the Immigration and Nationality Act to provide for terms and conditions for nonimmigrant workers performing agricultural labor or services, and for other purposes; to the Committee on the Judiciary, and in addition to the Committees on Ways and Means, Education and Labor, and Financial Services, for a period to be subsequently determined by the Speaker, in each case for consideration of such provisions as fall within the jurisdiction of the committee concerned.

By Mr. LIPINSKI:

H.R. 5039. A bill to lower the prices of excessively costly life-sustaining prescription drugs under part D of the Medicare program by requiring the Secretary of Health and Human Services to negotiate their prices, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Energy and Commerce, and in addition to the Committee on Ways and Means, for a period to be subsequently determined by the Speaker, in each case for consideration of such provisions as fall within the jurisdiction of the committee concerned.

By Mr. CURTIS (for himself and Mr. HUFFMAN):

H.R. 5040. A bill to direct the Director of the Bureau of Land Management to study the effects of drone incursions on wildfire suppression, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Natural Resources, and in addition to the Committee on Agriculture, for a period to be subsequently determined by the Speaker, in each case for consideration of such provisions as fall within the jurisdiction of the committee concerned.

By Mrs. MCBATH (for herself, Ms. MOORE, Mr. COLE, and Mr. KATKO):

H.R. 5041. A bill to amend the Family Violence Prevention and Services Act to make improvements; to the Committee on Education and Labor.

By Mr. CLYBURN (for himself, Ms. ADAMS, and Mr. CLAY):

H.R. 5042. A bill to amend the Internal Revenue Code of 1986 to reform rules related to qualified opportunity zones; to the Committee on Ways and Means.

By Mr. BEYER (for himself, Mr. PANETTA, and Ms. SCHAKOWSKY):

H.R. 5043. A bill to amend the Internal Revenue Code of 1986 to impose a surtax on high income individuals; to the Committee on Ways and Means.

By Mr. BOST (for himself, Mr. LOWENTHAL, Mr. BRINDISI, Mr. BANKS, Mr. CISNEROS, Mr. BILIRAKIS, Mr. PAPPAS, Mr. COX of California, and Mr. RODNEY DAVIS of Illinois):

H.R. 5044. A bill to grant a Congressional Gold Medal, collectively, to the men and women of the United States Armed Forces and Merchant Marine, as well as citizen and non-citizen civilians who served honorably with the U.S. military, who were surrendered, captured, or abandoned to become prisoners of war (POWs) of Imperial Japan throughout the Japanese Empire in the Pacific Theater of World War II from December 7, 1941 to September 2, 1945; to the Committee on Financial Services, and in addition to the Committee on House Administration, for a period to be subsequently determined by the Speaker, in each case for consideration of such provisions as fall within the jurisdiction of the committee concerned.

By Mr. CORREA (for himself, Mrs. NAPOLITANO, Mr. KILMER, Ms. NORTON, and Ms. SCHAKOWSKY):

H.R. 5045. A bill to amend title 38, United States Code, to require the Secretary of Veterans Affairs to provide child care assistance to veterans receiving certain training or vocational rehabilitation, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Veterans' Affairs.

By Mr. CROW (for himself, Mr. GALLAGHER, Mr. BROWN of Maryland, Mr. BACON, Mr. GALLEGO, Mr. WALTZ, Mr. MOULTON, Mr. FITZPATRICK, Mr. GOLDEN, Mr. MAST, Mr. CISNEROS, Mr. BAIRD, Ms. HOULAHAN, Mr. RESCHENTHALER, Mr. PANETTA, Mr. STEUBE, Mr. LAMB, Mr. TAYLOR, Mr. ROSE of New York, Mr. LOUDERMILK, Ms. SLOTKIN, Mr. CRENSHAW, Mr. DEFAZIO, Mr. KINZINGER, Mrs. LURIA, Mr. RIGGLEMAN, Ms. SPANBERGER, Mr. YOUNG, Ms. SHERRILL, Mr. STEWART, Mr. GUTHRIE, and Mr. BANKS):

H.R. 5046. A bill to authorize the location of a memorial on the National Mall to commemorate and honor the members of the Armed Forces that served on active duty in support of the Global War on Terrorism, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Natural Resources.

By Mr. DEFAZIO (for himself and Ms. TITUS):

H.R. 5047. A bill to require the Administrator of General Services to conduct an annual audit of properties leased to private parties, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Transportation and Infrastructure.

By Mr. DELGADO (for himself, Ms. STEFANIK, Mr. YOUNG, and Mr. MAST):

H.R. 5048. A bill to amend title 38, Unites States Code, to authorize the Secretary of Veterans Affairs to provide aid to counties for establishment, expansion, and improvement of veterans' cemeteries; to the Committee on Veterans' Affairs.

By Mr. FOSTER (for himself, Mr. TAKANO, Mr. MCNERNEY, Mr. QUIGLEY, and Ms. TITUS):

H.R. 5049. A bill to secure Federal access to scientific literature and other subscription services by requiring Federal agencies and legislative branch research arms to make recommendations on increasing agency library access to serials, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Oversight and Reform.

By Mr. GARCÍA of Illinois (for himself, Mr. GROTHMAN, Ms. GARCIA of Texas, and Mr. GREEN of Texas):

H.R. 5050. A bill to amend the Truth in Lending Act to extend the consumer credit protections provided to members of the Armed Forces and their dependents under title 10, United States Code, to all consumers; to the Committee on Financial Services.

By Mr. GONZALEZ of Ohio:

H.R. 5051. A bill to increase transparency and accountability with respect to World Bank lending for China, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Financial Services.

By Mr. LUJÁN (for himself, Mr. GOMEZ, Mr. YOUNG, Ms. JAYAPAL, Mr. LIPINSKI, Ms. NORTON, Mr. RASKIN, Ms. ROYBAL-ALLARD, Mr. SMITH of Washington, Ms. VELÁZQUEZ, Ms. JACKSON LEE, and Ms. SCHAKOWSKY):

H.R. 5052. A bill to amend title 38, United States Code, to include local government minimum wage requirements in determining the hourly minimum wage applicable for purposes of the work-study allowance under the educational assistance programs administered by the Secretary of Veterans Affairs; to the Committee on Veterans' Affairs.

By Ms. SCANLON (for herself, Mr. ARMSTRONG, Mr. RESCHENTHALER, Mr. KATKO, and Mr. JEFFRIES):

H.R. 5053. A bill to exempt juveniles from the requirements for suits by prisoners, and for other purposes; to the Committee on the Judiciary.

By Mr. SCHRADER (for himself, Ms. BONAMICI, Mr. WALDEN, Mr. BLUMENAUER, and Mr. DEFAZIO):

H.R. 5054. A bill to ensure that United States Government personnel, including members of the Armed Forces and contractors, assigned to United States diplomatic missions are given the opportunity to designate next-of-kin for certain purposes in the event of the death of the personnel; to the Committee on Foreign Affairs.

By Mr. SHERMAN (for himself and Mr. ZELDIN):

H.R. 5055. A bill to amend the Congressional Budget and Impoundment Control Act of 1974 to prohibit the use of guarantee fees as offsets; to the Committee on Rules, and in addition to the Committee on the Budget, for a period to be subsequently determined by the Speaker, in each case for consideration of such provisions as fall within the jurisdiction of the committee concerned.

By Mr. STEUBE (for himself, Mr. ROSE of New York, and Mr. COX of California):

H.R. 5056. A bill to amend title 38, United States Code, to allow individuals who are entitled to Post-9/11 educational assistance to use such assistance to repay Federal student loans; to the Committee on Veterans' Affairs.

By Mr. TONKO (for himself and Mr. MCKINLEY):

H.R. 5057. A bill to clarify the treatment of pass-through status under the Medicare outpatient payment system for certain drugs; to the Committee on Energy and Commerce, and in addition to the Committee on Ways

and Means, for a period to be subsequently determined by the Speaker, in each case for consideration of such provisions as fall within the jurisdiction of the committee concerned.

By Ms. FRANKEL (for herself, Ms. LEE of California, Mrs. NAPOLITANO, Mrs. LAWRENCE, Mr. JOHNSON of Georgia, Mr. LEVIN of Michigan, Mr. ESPAILLAT, Ms. TLAIB, Mr. BLUMENAUER, Ms. NORTON, Ms. WILD, Mr. PAPPAS, Ms. DELAURO, Mr. GRIJALVA, Ms. CASTOR of Florida, Ms. TITUS, Ms. SPEIER, Mr. SCHIFF, Mr. RASKIN, Mr. CARSON of Indiana, Mrs. TORRES of California, Ms. DEGETTE, Ms. SCHAKOWSKY, Mr. COHEN, Mr. DEUTCH, Mr. PETERS, Ms. JAYAPAL, Mr. MCGOVERN, Mrs. LOWEY, Mr. HASTINGS, Mr. KENNEDY, Mrs. DAVIS of California, Mr. SMITH of Washington, Mrs. WATSON COLEMAN, Mr. WELCH, Mr. CONNOLLY, Mr. KEATING, and Mr. BROWN of Maryland):

H. Res. 688. A resolution recognizing 25 years since the 1994 International Conference on Population and Development (ICPD) in Cairo, Egypt and reaffirming the goals and ideals of the ICPD Programme of Action, including comprehensive sexual and reproductive health and rights; to the Committee on Foreign Affairs.

By Mr. GARAMENDI (for himself, Mr. COSTA, Ms. STEVENS, Ms. LOFGREN, Ms. SPANBERGER, and Mr. COOK):

H. Res. 689. A resolution recognizing the significance of the 550th birth anniversary of Guru Nanak, the founder of Sikhism, to Sikh Americans and Sikhs worldwide; to the Committee on Oversight and Reform.

By Ms. CLARKE of New York (for herself and Ms. KELLY of Illinois):

H. Res. 690. A resolution commending Alice Allison Dunnigan for her barrier-breaking career in journalism; to the Committee on Oversight and Reform.

By Mr. KING of New York (for himself, Mr. YOHO, Mr. ENGEL, and Mr. SUOZZI):

H. Res. 691. A resolution honoring the accomplishments and charitable contributions of Peter Morgan Alonso of the New York Mets upon his being named the National League Jackie Robinson Rookie of the Year; to the Committee on Oversight and Reform.

By Mr. LOEBSACK (for himself, Mr. LOWENTHAL, Mr. GRIJALVA, Ms. LEE of California, Mr. MOULTON, and Mr. SOTO):

H. Res. 692. A resolution expressing support for the designation of the week beginning on November 11, 2019, as ''National School Psychology Week''; to the Committee on Education and Labor.

PRIVATE BILLS AND RESOLUTIONS

Under clause 3 of rule XII,

Mr. DOGGETT introduced A bill (H.R. 5058) for the relief of Alirio Palacios Gamez, Hilda Veronica Ramirez Mendez, and Jayro Ivan Juarez Ramirez; which was referred to the Committee on the Judiciary.

CONSTITUTIONAL AUTHORITY STATEMENT

Pursuant to clause 7 of rule XII ofthe Rules of the House of Representatives, the following statements are submitted regarding the specific powers granted to Congress in the Constitution to enact the accompanying bill or joint resolution.

By Mr. HUFFMAN:

H.R. 5032.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article IV, Section 3, clause 2 of the United States Constitution.

By Mr. BYRNE:

H.R. 5033.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article 1, Section 8, Clause 18 of the U.S. Constitution: The Congress shall have Power to make all Laws which shall be necessary and proper for carrying into Execution the foregoing Powers, and all other Powers vested by this Constitution in the Government ofthe United States, or in any Depa11ment or Officer thereof

By Mr. COHEN:

H.R. 5034.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article 1, section 8, clause 3 (relating to the power to regulate foreign and interstate commerce).

By Mr. MICHAEL F. DOYLE of Pennsylvania:

H.R. 5035.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article I, Section 8 ofthe Constitution: the Congress shall have Power ''to regulate Commerce with foreign Nations, and among the several State, and with the Indian Tribes.''

By Mr. PAPPAS:

H.R. 5036.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article I Section 8 Clause 10 provides Congress with the power ''to make all Laws which shall be necessary and proper for carrying into Execution the foregoing Powers, and all other Powers vested by this Constitution in the Government ofthe United States, or in any Department or Officer thereof.''

By Mr. MURPHY of North Carolina:

H.R. 5037.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article 1, Section 8, Clause 7 of the United States Constitution, known as the Postal Clause, empowers Congress to ''establish Post Offices and Post Roads''

By Ms. LOFGREN:

H.R. 5038.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article I, Section 8, clause 4 provides Congress with the power to establish a ''uniform rule of Naturalization.''

By Mr. LIPINSKI:

H.R. 5039.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article 1, Section 8, Clause 3.

By Mr. CURTIS:

H.R. 5040.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article VI, Section 3, Clause 2

By Mrs. MCBATH:

H.R. 5041.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

The Commerce Clause (Article 1, Section 8, Clause 3 ofthe U.S. Constitution): Congress has the power ''to regulate commerce with foreign nations, and among the several states, and with the Indian Tribes.''

By Mr. CLYBURN:

H.R. 5042.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article I, Section 8

By Mr. BEYER:

H.R. 5043.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article 1, Section 8: The Congress shall have Power to lay and collect Taxes, Duties, Imposts and Excises, to pay the Debts and provide for the common Defence and general Welfare of the United States; but all Duties, Imposts and Excises shall be uniform throughout the United States.

By Mr. BOST:

H.R. 5044.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article I, Section 8, Clause 1

By Mr. CORREA:

H.R. 5045.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

(1) The U.S. Constitution including Article 1, Section 8.

By Mr. CROW:

H.R. 5046.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article I, Section 8, Clause 17—

To exercise exclusive Legislation in all Cases whatsoever, over such District (not exceeding ten Miles square) as may, by Cession of particular States, and the Acceptance of Congress, become the Seat of the Government of the United States, and to exercise like Authority over all Places purchased by the Consent of the Legislature of the State in which the Same shall be, for the Erection of Forts, Magazines, Arsenals, dock-Yards, and other needful Buildings

By Mr. DEFAZIO:

H.R. 5047.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article I, Section 8, Clause 1, Clause 3, and Clause 18 of the Constitution.

By Mr. DELGADO:

H.R. 5048.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article 1 Section 8, Clause 1 of the Constitution of the United States.

By Mr. FOSTER:

H.R. 5049.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

This bill is enacted pursuant to the power granted to Congress under Article I, Section 8, Clauses 1 and 18 of the United States Constitution.

By Mr. GARCÍA of Illinois:

H.R. 5050.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article I, Section 8, Clause 3

By Mr. GONZALEZ of Ohio:

H.R. 5051.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article I, Section 8

By Mr. LUJÁN:

H.R. 5052.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article 1, Section 8

By Ms. SCANLON:

H.R. 5053.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article 1, Section 8

By Mr. SCHRADER:

H.R. 5054.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

U.S. Const. art. 1, §1; and

U.S. Const. art. 1, §8, cl. 18.

By Mr. SHERMAN:

H.R. 5055.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article I, Section 8

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By Mr. STEUBE:

H.R. 5056.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

To regulate Commerce with foreign Nations, and among the several States, and with the Indian Tribes;

To establish an uniform Rule of Naturalization, and uniform Laws on the subject of Bankruptcies throughout the United States;

To coin Money, regulate the Value thereof, and of foreign Coin, and fix the Standard of Weights and Measures;

To provide for the Punishment of counterfeiting the Securities and current Coin of the United States;

To establish Post Offices and Post Roads;

To promote the Progress of Science and useful Arts, by securing for limited Times to Authors and Inventors the exclusive Right to their respective Writings and Discoveries;

To constitute Tribunals inferior to the supreme Court;

To define and punish Piracies and Felonies committed on the high Seas, and Offenses against the Law of Nations;

To declare War, grant Letters of Marque and Reprisal, and make Rules concerning Captures on Land and Water;

To raise and support Armies, but no Appropriation of Money to that Use shall be for a longer Term than two Years;

To provide and maintain a Navy;

To make Rules for the Government and Regulation of the land and naval Forces;

To provide for calling forth the Militia to execute the Laws of the Union, suppress Insurrections and repel Invasions;

To provide for organizing, arming, and disciplining, the Militia, and for governing such Part of them as may be employed in the Service of the United States, reserving to the States respectively, the Appointment of the Officers, and the Authority of training the Militia according to the discipline prescribed by Congress;

To exercise exclusive Legislation in all Cases whatsoever, over such District (not exceeding ten Miles square) as may, by Cession of particular States, and the acceptance of Congress, become the Seat of the Government of the United States, and to exercise like Authority over all Places purchased by the Consent of the Legislature of the State in which the Same shall be, for the Erection of Forts, Magazines, Arsenals, dock-Yards, and other needful Buildings; And

To make all Laws which shall be necessary and proper for carrying into Execution the foregoing Powers, and all other Powers vested by this Constitution in the Government of the United States, or in any Department or Officer thereof.

By Mr. TONKO:

H.R. 5057.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Article I, Section 8, Clause 1

By Mr. DOGGETT:

H.R. 5058.

Congress has the power to enact this legislation pursuant to the following:

Clause 1 of Section 8 of Article I of the United States Constitution.

ADDITIONAL SPONSORS

Under clause 7 of rule XII, sponsors were added to public bills and resolutions, as follows:

H.R. 3: Mrs. DINGELL and Ms. FINKENAUER.

H.R. 20: Mr. MURPHY of North Carolina and Mr. GIANFORTE.

H.R. 38: Mr. MURPHY of North Carolina.

H.R. 141: Ms. FRANKEL.

H.R. 172: Mr. BIGGS.

H.R. 180: Ms. FUDGE.

H.R. 230: Mrs. DEMINGS.

H.R. 309: Mr. FOSTER, Ms. SPEIER, Ms. MCCOLLUM, Mr. TAKANO, Mrs. NAPOLITANO, Mr. JOHNSON of Georgia, Ms. MUCARSEL-POWELL, Ms. VELÁZQUEZ, MR. VARGAS, Ms. HAALAND, Mr. KILDEE, and Mrs. WATSON COLEMAN.

H.R. 350: Mr. MURPHY of North Carolina.

H.R. 554: Ms. STEVENS.

H.R. 557: Mr. VELA.

H.R. 587: Mr. MCCAUL.

H.R. 763: Mr. BISHOP of Georgia and Mr. SEAN PATRICK MALONEY of New York.

H.R. 836: Mr. ALLRED.

H.R. 912: Mr. MULLIN and Mrs. FLETCHER.

H.R. 934: Mr. HUFFMAN.

H.R. 935: Ms. Sánchez, Mr. LARSON of Connecticut, Mr. SUOZZI, and Ms. BROWNLEY of California.

H.R. 943: Mr. JORDAN and Mr. BISHOP of Georgia.

H.R. 945: Mr. SOTO.

H.R. 962: Mr. MURPHY of North Carolina.

H.R. 1002: Mr. CORREA, Mrs. BEATTY, Ms. PINGREE, Ms. SCHRIER, and Mr. WELCH.

H.R. 1003: Ms. JOHNSON of Texas.

H.R. 1011: Mr. TED LIEU of California and Ms. MCCOLLUM.

H.R. 1154: Ms. SEWELL of Alabama.

H.R. 1171: Mr. SCHNEIDER.

H.R. 1228: Mr. WELCH.

H.R. 1289: Ms. BROWNLEY of California.

H.R. 1367: Mr. HARDER of California, Mr. POCAN, and Mr. MCEACHIN.

H.R. 1398: Mr. FERGUSON, Ms. SCHRIER, Mr. BRENDAN F. BOYLE of Pennsylvania, Mr. OLSON, Mr. CUNNINGHAM, and Mr. SOTO.

H.R. 1497: Mr. SIRES and Mr. PAYNE.

H.R. 1498: Mr. VARGAS and Mr. BLUMENAUER.

H.R. 1550: Mr. JOHNSON of South Dakota.

H.R. 1597: Mr. CLAY, Mr. FLORES, Ms. HAALAND, Mr. GOTTHEIMER, and Mr. DELGADO.

H.R. 1643: Mr. THOMPSON of Mississippi and Ms. HAALAND.

H.R. 1688: Mr. STAUBER.

H.R. 1700: Mr. GOODEN.

H.R. 1709: Mr. FITZPATRICK.

H.R. 1767: Mr. SUOZZI, Mr. AMODEI, Ms. HOULAHAN, Mr. CICILLINE, and Mr. RUPPERSBERGER.

H.R. 1773: Mr. TAYLOR and Mrs. RADEWAGEN.

H.R. 1869: Mr. HASTINGS.

H.R. 1873: Mr. LAMALFA, Mr. BERA, Mr. RICE of South Carolina, Mr. DEFAZIO, Mr. PENCE, and Ms. WEXTON.

H.R. 1878: Ms. FRANKEL and Ms. LEE of California.

H.R. 1975: Mrs. RODGERS of Washington.

H.R. 1981: Mr. LARSEN of Washington.

H.R. 1992: Ms. ESCOBAR and Mr. KIND.

H.R. 2014: Mr. BIGGS.

H.R. 2086: Mr. LAHOOD.

H.R. 2137: Ms. WASSERMAN SCHULTZ.

H.R. 2150: Ms. BARRAGÁN.

H.R. 2155: Mr. CARSON of Indiana.

H.R. 2207: Mr. MURPHY of North Carolina.

H.R. 2214: Mr. CUELLAR.

H.R. 2235: Mr. OLSON, Mr. RYAN, and Mr. BISHOP of Georgia.

H.R. 2264: Ms. SCHAKOWSKY.

H.R. 2283: Mr. UPTON, Ms. LOFGREN, and Ms. NORTON.

H.R. 2311: Mr. BLUMENAUER.

H.R. 2315: Mrs. BEATTY.

H.R. 2339: Ms. JUDY CHU of California and Ms. DEAN.

H.R. 2354: Mr. PANETTA and Mr. LEVIN of California.

H.R. 2382: Mr. SIMPSON, Mr. COLE, and Mr. GIANFORTE.

H.R. 2402: Mr. SHERMAN.

H.R. 2408: Mr. MICHAEL F. DOYLE of Pennsylvania.

H.R. 2442: Mr. BLUMENAUER and Ms. JUDY CHU of California.

H.R. 2482: Mrs. LOWEY and Mr. LOEBSACK.

H.R. 2509: Mr. SIMPSON and Mr. STEWART.

H.R. 2517: Mr. THOMPSON of Mississippi.

H.R. 2550: Mr. DAVID SCOTT of Georgia and Mr. CORREA.

H.R. 2571: Mr. BURGESS.

H.R. 2584: Mr. RODNEY DAVIS of Illinois and Mr. LOEBSACK.

H.R. 2651: Mr. SOTO.

H.R. 2653: Mr. CISNEROS.

H.R. 2731: Mr. KELLY of Mississippi and Mr. CASTRO of Texas.

H.R. 2747: Ms. VELÁZQUEZ and Ms. LEE of California.

H.R. 2767: Mr. CROW and Ms. JUDY CHU of California.

H.R. 2771: Mr. BROOKS of Alabama, Mr. GRAVES of Missouri, and Mr. MULLIN.

H.R. 2775: Mr. HIGGINS of New York.

H.R. 2802: Ms. HOULAHAN and Mr. BLUMENAUER.

H.R. 2818: Mr. LOWENTHAL and Ms. PINGREE.

H.R. 2846: Mr. CROW.

H.R. 2863: Mr. MALINOWSKI and Mr. THOMPSON of Mississippi.

H.R. 2881: Mr. MCCAUL.

H.R. 2895: Ms. CRAIG.

H.R. 2896: Mr. MCGOVERN.

H.R. 2953: Mr. BISHOP of Utah.

H.R. 2975: Mr. LYNCH.

H.R. 2985: Mr. WILLIAMS and Ms. ESHOO.

H.R. 2991: Mr. SOTO.

H.R. 3077: Mr. KHANNA, Mr. LAWSON of Florida, Mr. CÁRDENAS, Mr. CARBAJAL, Mr. DESAULNIER, Mr. KENNEDY, Mr. DEFAZIO, Mrs. FLETCHER, Mr. HOLLINGSWORTH, Ms. SHALALA, Mr. FLEISCHMANN, Mr. HUFFMAN, and Mr. PETERSON.

H.R. 3121: Ms. JAYAPAL.

H.R. 3157: Mr. RUPPERSBERGER and Mr. POCAN.

H.R. 3165: Mr. LEVIN of Michigan and Mr. LUJÁN.

H.R. 3219: Ms. BROWNLEY of California.

H.R. 3224: Mr. DELGADO, Mr. LEVIN of California, Mr. CICILLINE, Mr. LAMB, Ms. HAALAND, Mr. BEYER, and Ms. HOULAHAN.

H.R. 3235: Ms. LOFGREN.

H.R. 3303: Mr. BLUMENAUER.

H.R. 3350: Mr. CONNOLLY and Mr. GOSAR.

H.R. 3373: Ms. WILD.

H.R. 3378: Ms. SHALALA.

H.R. 3381: Mr. DESAULNIER.

H.R. 3391: Mr. KHANNA, Ms. JAYAPAL, Mr. MCNERNEY, Mrs. DINGELL, and Mrs. TORRES of California.

H.R. 3396: Ms. BLUNT ROCHESTER.

H.R. 3458: Mr. HECK.

H.R. 3463: Ms. TORRES SMALL of New Mexico and Ms. SEWELL of Alabama.

H.R. 3473: Ms. MENG.

H.R. 3495: Mr. MCKINLEY, Mr. ROY, Mr. FLORES, Mr. HAGEDORN, and Mr. PENCE.

H.R. 3497: Mr. SIMPSON.

H.R. 3509: Mr. GOLDEN and Mr. NORCROSS.

H.R. 3555: Mr. MOULTON.

H.R. 3593: Ms. JAYAPAL.

H.R. 3600: Ms. KUSTER of New Hampshire.

H.R. 3612: Mr. GARAMENDI, Ms. SCHAKOWSKY, and Mr. MALINOWSKI.

H.R. 3689: Mr. SOTO.

H.R. 3735: Mr. RESCHENTHALER.

H.R. 3749: Mr. CROW.

H.R. 3760: Mrs. DEMINGS and Mr. MEEKS.

H.R. 3762: Ms. WILSON of Florida, Mr. BRENDAN F. BOYLE of Pennsylvania, Mrs. WATSON COLEMAN, Mr. DEFAZIO, and Mr. MCKINLEY.

H.R. 3796: Mr. KELLY of Pennsylvania and Ms. ROYBAL-ALLARD.

H.R. 3824: Ms. UNDERWOOD and Mr. KINZINGER.

H.R. 3934: Mr. CUELLAR.

H.R. 3951: Mr. CLEAVER.

H.R. 3957: Ms. ROYBAL-ALLARD and Mr. SOTO.

H.R. 3961: Ms. UNDERWOOD, Mr. TAKANO, Mr. PAPPAS, Ms. DEGETTE, and Ms. MENG.

H.R. 3968: Mr. SMITH of Missouri.
H.R. 3975: Mr. CARSON of Indiana and Mr. WOMACK.
H.R. 3977: Mr. HARDER of California and Mr. O'HALLERAN.
H.R. 4009: Mr. STIVERS.
H.R. 4052: Mr. MALINOWSKI.
H.R. 4056: Ms. MCCOLLUM and Ms. CRAIG.
H.R. 4073: Mr. DOGGETT.
H.R. 4097: Ms. NORTON and Ms. SPANBERGER.
H.R. 4161: Mr. MARCHANT.
H.R. 4187: Mr. BISHOP of Utah.
H.R. 4193: Mr. TED LIEU of California.
H.R. 4194: Mr. PANETTA and Mr. TONKO.
H.R. 4230: Mr. SIRES and Ms. WILD.
H.R. 4248: Mr. WELCH.
H.R. 4280: Mr. HUFFMAN, Mr. TAKANO, Ms. ROYBAL-ALLARD, and Mr. HASTINGS.
H.R. 4296: Mr. THOMPSON of Mississippi and Mr. CARSON of Indiana.
H.R. 4321: Ms. JACKSON LEE.
H.R. 4331: Mr. YOHO and Mr. TED LIEU of California.
H.R. 4348: Ms. KAPTUR.
H.R. 4393: Mr. SOTO, Mr. BROOKS of Alabama, and Mr. DEFAZIO.
H.R. 4404: Mr. CARSON of Indiana.
H.R. 4429: Mr. BALDERSON, Mr. MULLIN, and Mr. PAYNE.
H.R. 4477: Mr. COHEN.
H.R. 4487: Mr. HARDER of California and Mr. COOK.
H.R. 4489: Mrs. TRAHAN, Mr. HARDER of California, Ms. HAALAND, Ms. DELBENE, and Ms. KELLY of Illinois.
H.R. 4523: Ms. JAYAPAL.
H.R. 4540: Mr. FOSTER, Ms. LOFGREN, Ms. ESCOBAR, Ms. LEE of California, Mr. CISNEROS, Mr. LOWENTHAL, and Mrs. BEATTY.
H.R. 4581: Mr. BAIRD.
H.R. 4591: Mr. HUFFMAN.
H.R. 4618: Mr. WELCH.
H.R. 4625: Mr. COHEN.
H.R. 4639: Ms. DEAN and Mr. THOMPSON of Mississippi.
H.R. 4674: Mr. CASTEN of Illinois and Mr. SIRES.
H.R. 4680: Mr. POCAN, Mr. DAVID SCOTT of Georgia, Ms. ESCOBAR, Ms. MATSUI, and Mr. TRONE.
H.R. 4681: Mr. CLAY and Mr. SUOZZI.
H.R. 4685: Mr. SUOZZI.
H.R. 4691: Ms. MUCARSEL-POWELL.
H.R. 4694: Ms. SPANBERGER.
H.R. 4704: Mr. TRONE.
H.R. 4722: Mr. ROUDA, Ms. PRESSLEY, and Ms. DELBENE.
H.R. 4724: Mr. GRIJALVA.
H.R. 4754: Mr. GROTHMAN and Mr. MEEKS.
H.R. 4764: Mr. SWALWELL of California and Mr. HASTINGS.
H.R. 4768: Mr. CUELLAR and Ms. HAALAND.
H.R. 4795: Mr. FITZPATRICK.
H.R. 4804: Ms. LEE of California.
H.R. 4810: Mrs. WALORSKI and Mr. BILIRAKIS.
H.R. 4820: Mr. CUELLAR.
H.R. 4861: Mr. TONKO.
H.R. 4884: Mr. MCGOVERN.
H.R. 4890: Mr. CISNEROS, Mrs. WATSON COLEMAN, and Mr. POCAN.
H.R. 4903: Mr. CONAWAY, Mr. MURPHY of North Carolina, Mr. WRIGHT, Mr. CHABOT, Mr. WALKER, Mr. KELLY of Pennsylvania, and Mr. MULLIN.
H.R. 4906: Mr. FITZPATRICK, Ms. GARCIA of Texas, and Ms. SLOTKIN.
H.R. 4913: Mr. WELCH and Mr. OLSON.
H.R. 4914: Mr. COLE.
H.R. 4924: Mr. SHERMAN.
H.R. 4934: Mr. BUCK, Mr. SHIMKUS, Mr. BAIRD, Mr. LUETKEMEYER, Mr. CRAWFORD, Mrs. LESKO, and Mr. OLSON.
H.R. 4945: Mr. HOLLINGSWORTH and Mr. THOMPSON of Pennsylvania.
H.R. 4959: Mr. JOYCE of Pennsylvania, Mr. STEWART, and Mrs. RODGERS of Washington.
H.R. 4980: Mr. DUNN and Ms. MATSUI.
H.R. 4995: Mr. CARSON of Indiana.
H.R. 5004: Ms. JUDY CHU of California.
H.R. 5006: Mr. ROGERS of Alabama.
H.R. 5011: Mr. CLEAVER and Mr. SUOZZI.
H.R. 5014: Ms. JACKSON LEE.
H.R. 5017: Mr. ROUDA.
H.R. 5018: Mr. GAETZ, Mr. HICE of Georgia, and Mr. POSEY.
H.R. 5021: Mr. CLEAVER, Mr. MEEKS, Mr. García of Illinois, Ms. OCASIO-CORTEZ, and Ms. TLAIB.
H.R. 5026: Mr. FITZPATRICK and Ms. SCANLON.
H.J. Res. 38: Mr. PANETTA.
H.J. Res. 78: Mr. NORMAN, Mr. WEBER of Texas, and Mr. BABIN.
H.J. Res. 79: Mr. PANETTA, Mr. ALLRED, and Mr. COSTA.
H. Con. Res. 20: Ms. WILD and Mr. BISHOP of North Carolina.
H. Con. Res. 37: Mr. SMITH of Washington.
H. Con. Res. 49: Mr. THOMPSON of California.
H. Res. 23: Ms. TLAIB and Mr. LEWIS.
H. Res. 49: Mr. TRONE and Mr. WATKINS.
H. Res. 152: Ms. SCANLON.
H. Res. 255: Mr. CHABOT.
H. Res. 259: Mr. POCAN.
H. Res. 446: Mr. RASKIN and Ms. SPANBERGER.
H. Res. 517: Mr. AGUILAR, Ms. JAYAPAL, and Mr. NORCROSS.
H. Res. 672: Mr. TRONE, Mr. JOHNSON of Ohio, Mr. GONZALEZ of Texas, and Mrs. RODGERS of Washington.
H. Res. 673: Mr. HECK, Mrs. BEATTY, and Mrs. DINGELL.
H. Res. 676: Mr. DUNCAN.
H. Res. 678: Mr. GAETZ, Mr. HICE of Georgia, Mr. BALDERSON, Mr. JOYCE of Ohio, Miss GONZÁLEZ-COLÓN of Puerto Rico, Mr. RODNEY DAVIS of Illinois, Mr. WEBER of Texas, Mr. RIGGLEMAN, Mr. WRIGHT, and Mr. VAN DREW.
H. Res. 686: Mr. GOSAR.

PETITIONS, ETC.

Under clause 3 of rule XII, petitions and papers were laid on the clerk's desk and referred as follows:

59. The SPEAKER presented a petition of Mr. Gregory D. Watson, a citizen of Austin, TX, relative to Urging Congress to propose, pursuant to Article V, an amendment to the United States Constitution that would, in addition to congressional proposal, likewise allow an identically-worded suggested federal constitutional amendment, approved by the legislatures of at least two-thirds of the several states, as an alternate means of proposing future amendments and that would further provide for a same-day nationwide referendum as the exclusive method of ratifying any further amendments; etc.; to the Committee on the Judiciary.

60. Also, a petition of City Council of Pittsburgh, PA, relative to Resolution No. 526, imploring the Pennsylvania General Assembly, as well as the Congress of the United States, to pass within the next 30 days common-sense safety measures; and to work across the aisle and enact critical legislation; to the Committee on the Judiciary.

61. Also, a petition of Legislature of Guam, relative to Substitute Resolution No. 94-35 (COR), ''Relative to seeking compensation for cancer and other illnesses caused by exposure to ionizing radiation; and to further expressing the support of I Mina'trentai Singko Na Liheslaturan Guahan (the 35th Legislature) for the passage of S. 947 and H.R. 3783, the ''Radiation Exposure Compensation Act Amendments of 2019'', introduced by the U.S. Senate on March 28, 2019, and the U.S. House of Representatives on July 16, 2019, which would amend the ''Radiation Exposure Compensation Act'' to include Guam as a downwind area''; jointly to the Committees on the Judiciary, Education and Labor, and Energy and Commerce.

62. Also, a petition of City Commission of Traverse City, MI, relative to a Resolution urging the United States Congress to enact the Energy Innovation and Carbon Dividend Act of 2019; jointly to the Committees on Ways and Means, Energy and Commerce, and Foreign Affairs.

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of America

Congressional Record

PROCEEDINGS AND DEBATES OF THE 116th CONGRESS, FIRST SESSION

Vol. 165 WASHINGTON, TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 12, 2019 *No. 180*

Senate

The Senate met at 3 p.m. and was called to order by the President pro tempore (Mr. GRASSLEY).

PRAYER

The Chaplain, Dr. Barry C. Black, offered the following prayer:

Let us pray.

Gracious God, our rock of ages in life's shifting sands, give our lawmakers this day the abiding assurance of Your presence.

May they strive to be Your instruments, accomplishing Your will, living by Your power, and being used by You for Your glory. Enable them to experience Your contentment and peace facing life's chaos with quiet hearts and vibrant faith.

Lord, refresh their spirit, quicken their thinking, reinforce their judgment, and empower them to fulfill Your purposes on Earth.

We pray in Your mighty Name. Amen.

PLEDGE OF ALLEGIANCE

The President pro tempore led the Pledge of Allegiance, as follows:

I pledge allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America, and to the Republic for which it stands, one nation under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

RESERVATION OF LEADER TIME

The PRESIDING OFFICER (Mrs. BLACKBURN). Under the previous order, the leadership time is reserved.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The Senator from Iowa is recognized.

Mr. GRASSLEY. Madam President, I ask permission to speak as in morning business for 3 minutes.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Without objection, it is so ordered.

100TH ANNIVERSARY OF THE AMERICAN LEGION

Mr. GRASSLEY. Madam President, I come to the floor to recognize the accomplishments of an organization that has done great service to communities and veterans across the United States.

This month marks 100 years since the American Legion received its charter from Congress and formally adopted its constitution. When it was established in Paris in March of 1919, the American Legion stated its aims, in part, ''to perpetuate the principles of justice, freedom, and democracy for which we have fought.''

The accomplishments of the American Legion since that time are numerous and profound. They include successfully lobbying for the creation of what was then called the Veterans Bureau, which would later become the VA, the Department of Veterans Affairs.

The American Legion also conducted pioneering research into PTSD and drafted the original GI bill that helped to educate so many World War II veterans after that war and gave a big boost to the expanding U.S. economy post-World War II.

American Legion members complete 3.7 million hours of community service each year. I happen to be a member of the Sons of the American Legion. As part of that organization, I am blessed to have had the American Legion make a meaningful impact in my life.

When I was a young high school student in Iowa, I was proud to participate in Boys State, where I learned the rights, privileges, and responsibilities of citizenship. The American Legion still does that every year in Iowa and I suppose in every State. Iowans are fortunate to have the enduring presence of the American Legion in our communities.

This August, two Iowans were recognized nationally for their dedication to the American Legion. Bruce Feuerbach of Keystone was elected national vice commander of the American Legion, and Nicole Clapp of Gladbrook was elected national president of the American Legion Auxiliary.

Many more accomplishments are sure to come from the American Legion's Iowa department. I congratulate the American Legion on its 100th year of service and thank all members for their dedication to Iowa and to our Nation.

I want to point out that there was a Major General MacNider, Mason City, IA, who was the fourth national commander of the American Legion and probably one of those who was dedicated to establishing this organization early on.

I yield the floor.

RECOGNITION OF THE MAJORITY LEADER

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The majority leader is recognized.

UNITED STATES-MEXICO-CANADA TRADE AGREEMENT

Mr. MCCONNELL. Madam President, I was privileged to spend a good chunk of the day yesterday with the hardworking men and women of North American Stainless in Carroll County, KY. They are a high-quality stainless steel manufacturing firm that is actually the largest fully integrated stainless steel producer in the entire United States.

They produce about one-third of all U.S. stainless. The company brings 1,500 jobs to its rural community that is Kentucky's 8th largest manufacturer by total employment. I joined them yesterday to celebrate an important legislative accomplishment that I was able to spearhead back in July: the long overdue Senate ratification of a bipartisan tax treaty protocol with Spain. By passing this new protocol, we cleared away a mess of confusing and unfair double taxation, the threat of which had stunted growth and investment right here at home.

I got to hear again, firsthand, what a significant difference the approval of

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this simple bipartisan tax treaty will make for this American manufacturer. I was happy to hear the CEO announce that the company can now move forward with a major $30 million capital investment in developing its facility and its workforce as a direct result of the ratification of that treaty.

It was just another reminder that the economic policies we vote on here, often on a bipartisan basis, make an enormous difference for workers and job creators in each of our States.

While we applauded the Spain tax treaty and the new prosperity it will unlock, it was impossible to overlook the fact that USMCA is still being blocked over in the House of Representatives. By one analysis, 12 million American jobs are dependent upon trade with Mexico and Canada. Together they make up a $500 billion market for U.S. exports. It is no surprise that updating our trading relationships with both of our North American neighbors would stand to have a major positive effect on our economy.

To be more specific, according to data from the International Trade Commission, the USMCA would generate about 176,000 new American jobs. It would pump nearly $70 billion into the U.S. economy, and the already massive markets for U.S. products would be expected to grow by tens of billions more.

For months, Speaker PELOSI and House Democrats have been claiming they notionally support this agreement and want to get to yes, but month after month, this happy talk has seemingly led to no tangible progress, just more heel-dragging. Hard-working Kentuckians, people like our farmers and our cattlemen, keep writing to me and asking Congress to pass the USMCA, but Speaker PELOSI will not make time for it.

House Democrats have enough time to continue their 3-year-old obsession with impeaching the President, but they cannot find the time to pass a landmark trade deal that will create 176,000 new American jobs. Just saying their priorities out loud indicates how backward they are.

HONG KONG

Mr. MCCONNELL. Madam President, now, on a totally different matter, Hong Kong has been rocked by more violence as citizens continue resisting the Chinese Communist Party's encroachment on their autonomy and freedoms.

On Monday, it appears the local police shot a 21-year-old protester at nearly point-blank range. The police have arrested hundreds of demonstrators, reportedly as young as 12 and as old as 82. Tear gas, rubber bullets, and other violent measures have now become standard fare.

A few days earlier, a number of democracy-supporting Hong Kong legislators were swept up in a government crackdown. These elected officials were either arrested or given summons just a few weeks before local elections.

These continuing government escalations are inconsistent with the Hong Kong Basic Law, with international agreements, and with the will of Hongkongers. Brutalizing their own people will not circumvent the core issue here: Beijing's insatiable thirst for control.

I have advocated for Hong Kong since I wrote our Nation's Hong Kong Policy Act back in 1992. I know many of us in this body now want to extend and expand that law in a targeted manner that focuses pressure on the Chinese Communist Party and its agents who are responsible for undermining Hong Kong's autonomy while minimizing the collateral economic damage to the very Hongkongers we want to help.

I am eager to continue working with colleagues, such as Senator RISCH, Senator GRAHAM, Senator RUBIO, and others, toward a strong and procedurally workable solution. Meanwhile, I appreciate statements by administration leaders such as Vice President PENCE and Secretary Pompeo that show a clear-eyed perspective on China's Orwellian tactics and bad intentions.

I urge the administration to use the significant leverage and authorities it already has, particularly under the Global Magnitsky Act, to hold individuals accountable.

Hong Kong is not the only recent reminder that we live in a dangerous world in which America's interests, allies, and ideals are constantly threatened. Press reports this morning indicated that Israel is suffering yet another round of terror, including more than 160 rocket launches fired against civilian targets in Israel. This comes after Israeli forces appear to have eliminated one high-ranking leader in the terrorist group Palestinian Islamic Jihad, in Gaza, and targeted another PIJ terrorist in Damascus, Syria.

The United States stands with our ally Israel against PIJ, Hamas, and Hezbollah terrorists who have long sought to erase the Jewish State. If these reports are accurate, it will be no surprise that one of these terrorist leaders was holed up in Damascus.

Syria, under Assad, stands alongside Iran as the chief patron of anti-Israel terrorism. This is just another reminder that the United States and some of our closest allies have a strong say in the future of Syria and that a victory for Assad will be a victory for Iran and for terrorism.

So every hour seemingly brings more evidence of our troubled world, but, just as with the trade agreements, critical legislation in this area is currently frozen in place. It is another casualty of Democrats' apparent inability to make headway on anything besides fighting with the White House.

For the second time in 2 months, Senate Democrats recently voted once again to filibuster the annual funding for our Armed Forces—for our men and women in uniform—and while Senate Democrats block appropriations for defense, House Democrats are now slow-walking the authorizing legislation—the NDAA. Since the first NDAA was passed way back in 1961, Congress has never failed to pass a bipartisan NDAA by the end of the year—not once. Yet with House Democrats fixated on impeachment, I understand that Chairman ADAM SMITH and his fellow Democrats are now dragging their heels on the conference committee that is needed to complete this bill. These House Democrats passed a uniquely partisan NDAA earlier this year, unlike the Senate's bipartisan version, and now they are slow-walking the conference committee.

These are among our most basic governing responsibilities: passing an NDAA and funding our Armed Forces. The United States of America cannot operate at less than full strength on the world stage because Democrats are too busy—too busy—impeaching the Commander in Chief.

NOMINATIONS

Mr. MCCONNELL. Madam President, on one final matter, while our Democratic colleagues continue to block the Senate from moving forward with defense funding here on the floor, we will use this time to confirm more of the President's well-qualified nominees to the executive branch and to the Federal bench.

Later this week we will consider the nomination of Steven J. Menashi to be U.S. circuit judge for the Second Circuit. Mr. Menashi is a graduate of Dartmouth College and Stanford University Law School. He has accrued an impressive record in private practice and earned clerkships on the D.C. Circuit and the Supreme Court with Justice Alito.

First, we will consider the nomination of Chad Wolf to serve in a senior leadership position post at the Department of Homeland Security. Mr. Wolf's experience at the Department dates back to the immediate aftermath of the September 11th terrorist attacks. He has had a hand in arranging our Nation's critical homeland security infrastructure. The current Acting Secretary of DHS has called him a ''proven, thoughtful, and principled executive,'' and a former Assistant Secretary at the Department said, ''Chad knows the issues cold.''

I hope my colleagues will join me in advancing each of these nominations later this week.

CONCLUSION OF MORNING BUSINESS

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Morning business is closed.

EXECUTIVE SESSION

EXECUTIVE CALENDAR

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Under the previous order, the Senate will proceed to executive session to resume consideration of the following nomination, which the clerk will report.

The legislative clerk read the nomination of Chad F. Wolf, of Virginia, to be Under Secretary for Strategy, Policy, and Plans, Department of Homeland Security. (New Position)

Mr. MCCONNELL. I suggest the absence of a quorum.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The clerk will call the roll.

The legislative clerk proceeded to call the roll.

Mr. SCHUMER. Madam President, I ask unanimous consent that the order for the quorum call be rescinded.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Without objection, it is so ordered.

RECOGNITION OF THE MINORITY LEADER

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The Democratic leader is recognized.

IMMIGRATION

Mr. SCHUMER. Madam President, today, the Supreme Court heard oral arguments in the case against the President's decision to cancel DACA, the program that grants legal status to over 600,000 Dreamers who were brought to this country through no fault of their own, who voluntarily came forward and registered with the government in exchange for protected status, who work in our factories and our hospitals, who teach and learn in our schools and serve in our military. Before the highest Court in the land, President Trump and his administration cruelly argued that these Dreamers do not belong in America and must be ripped away from their families and sent back to countries that many of them do not even remember.

The President once tweeted: ''Does anybody really want to throw out good, educated and accomplished young people who have jobs, some serving in the military? Really!'' Now the same President is saying some Dreamers are ''very tough, hardened criminals,'' and his administration has argued they should be deported. Donald Trump's hypocrisy when it comes to Dreamers knows no bounds. After flip-flopping again and again on the issue and after failing to lead an effort to pass comprehensive immigration reform, it is abjectly shameful that President Trump is trying to get the Supreme Court to do his dirty work and put the Dreamers under threat of mass deportation.

When the DACA Program was established in 2012, under a long tradition of administrative discretion, it changed the lives of thousands and thousands of Dreamers for the better, and it made our country better. Yet, because of President Trump and his relentless scapegoating of immigrants—his cynical use of trying to tell too many of the American people that the Dreamers are the reason they are not doing well, which is despicable—these hard-working and patriotic Americans are haunted by the possibility they could be forced to leave this country at any moment—be pulled away from their families, their jobs, their homes. It is cruel. It is counterproductive. It undermines American values and all that America stands for.

Thankfully, one of the first things the House Democrats did when they won the majority was to pass a permanent legislative solution for DACA recipients and TPS holders. It is legislation I wholeheartedly support. Now it is up to the Supreme Court to defend the program. It is up to Majority Leader MCCONNELL to bring the Dream and Promise Act to the Senate floor.

My good friend Senator DURBIN, who has been a champion for Dreamers for as long as I can remember, will ask for the Senate's consent this evening to take up these bills. I thank him for his moral and continued strong leadership on this issue. I could not agree more with what he is trying to do. It is time to do the right thing for Dreamers and enshrine DACA into law.

We will see how my Republican friends respond. After all, the House has done its job. Where are the Senate Republicans who claim to stand with the Dreamers? We will see this evening.

From my home in Brooklyn, I can see the great lady in the harbor who welcomed my ancestors many years ago. If America is to remain the greatest Nation in the world and a beacon of hope and freedom for people everywhere—a light among nations—we must live up to our best values. That means we must stand totally and wholeheartedly with the Dreamers and all 11 million who now live in the shadows.

NOMINATIONS

Madam President, on nominations, we are here at the beginning of another week in the Senate. As is the norm under Leader MCCONNELL, we will not be debating legislation like the Dream Act in order to improve the lives of average Americans. Instead, we will vote on another slate of controversial Trump administration nominees.

First up is the nomination of Chad Wolf to serve as an Under Secretary at the Department of Homeland Security. Mr. Wolf has had leadership roles within the DHS through much of Trump's Presidency and has troubling ties to President Trump's disastrous family separation policy, the Muslim ban, and the national emergency declaration at the southern border. Despite testifying that he was not involved in the family separation policy, Mr. Wolf reportedly suggested the policy in a memo he sent to then-Attorney General Sessions. He is ashamed to admit it. He knows it was wrong, but he did it anyway. This man does not deserve to be an Under Secretary at DHS.

The circumstances of Mr. Wolf's nomination are also very strange. Wolf is not only already serving as an Under Secretary in an acting capacity, but President Trump has named him as the incoming Secretary of DHS in an acting capacity. President Trump never bothered to nominate a replacement for departing DHS Secretary McAleenan, who left yesterday. Yet the Senate is being asked to confirm someone to a job he is not even going to perform. Indeed, if Mr. Wolf is confirmed, we may never vote on who will be the actual Secretary of DHS, which is a major Cabinet-level department.

This is completely unacceptable. The administration is having trouble finding people to fill these jobs. They know the cruelty they will be asked to enforce, and they know that Donald Trump will treat them poorly. So he can't find anybody to take these positions. Hence, we have this awkward game of musical chairs. Rather than working with Congress to find a DHS Secretary whom we could support, the Trump administration is trying a legal end-around that subverts our constitutional duty to advise and consent.

Regardless of your ideology or views on immigration, my fellow Senators should oppose Wolf's nomination on constitutional grounds.

After the Senate considers Mr. Wolf, we will consider the nomination of Steven Menashi to serve on the Second Circuit Court of Appeals.

I have rarely met a nominee as low as Mr. Menashi. He has a troubling record on race, women's equality, LGBTQ rights, and the rights of immigrants. His conduct before the Committee on the Judiciary was insulting, and recent reports describe how, during his tenure while working at the Department of Education, he played a leading role in designing an illegal effort to deny debt relief to thousands of students who had been swindled by for-profit colleges. That is right. The Senate is going to be asked to confirm someone, Mr. Menashi, to be a judge who designed an illegal scheme to deny debt relief so as to defraud students. The man has no principles. The man has no conscience. The man has no morals. He should not be on the bench.

AGENT ORANGE

Madam President, finally, about our veterans and Agent Orange, yesterday, our Nation observed Veterans Day. It was a chance for all of us to say thank you to the millions of brave Americans who have served our country. It was a day not only to celebrate their achievements and express a deep and abiding gratitude for their service but also to recognize that for many veterans, sacrifices have come as a result of military service and that those sacrifices are not yet over. I want to shed light on one particular issue today.

There are now hundreds of thousands of veterans who suffer from diseases that have been linked to Agent Orange, which is a chemical that was used by our military during the Vietnam war. One's exposure to Agent Orange can lead to a host of complications—diabetes, leukemia, and more. The VA has

long provided benefits to veterans who suffer from these conditions. It has provided healthcare and compensation so as to help to defer the hardships veterans have faced from the wounds from which they still suffer after having been on the battlefield.

In response to more recent studies, in 2017, VA Secretary Shulkin decided to add bladder cancer, hypertension, Parkinson's-like symptoms, and hypothyroidism to the list of Agent Orange-related conditions that are eligible for benefits, which would have improved the lives of 83,000 vets. Shockingly, once again, within this cruel administration—it doesn't even care about our veterans—it was reported that OMB Director and White House Chief of Staff Mulvaney has decided to block benefits for these new conditions because he is worried about the cost. It is disgraceful.

Let me repeat.

Despite the recommendation of President Trump's VA Secretary and the recommendation of the National Academy of Medicine, Mulvaney has decided to block health benefits to sick veterans. Many of these veterans are retired, and many don't have a steady income. These benefits could make the difference between life and death, but Mick Mulvaney—the same Mick Mulvaney who thought $1.5 trillion was an acceptable cost to give billionaires and corporations in a giant tax cut, which created a huge deficit—now believes that the cost of helping 83,000 sick veterans is just too high.

This is incomprehensibly cruel. When are the American people going to wake up and see what the Trump administration is doing? He gives tax breaks to billionaires but no benefits to veterans who are suffering from the result of Agent Orange exposure?

My home State of New York has 240,000 veterans from the Vietnam era. Many of them were exposed to Agent Orange without realizing it. Just yesterday, the Buffalo News profiled the life of Vietnam veteran Dick Gabel, who was drafted into the Army at age 19. In his approximately 2 years of service, he was shot in the leg. He recovered and was sent back to the war. He lost many of his closest friends along the way. After he came home, for decades, Dick worked with kids in his hometown to make Veterans Day an annual highlight, and he brought together hundreds of veterans to volunteer at local schools. Just last year, he was diagnosed with leukemia, possibly because of his exposure to Agent Orange.

There are likely thousands of veterans in New York who are like Dick—fighting illnesses that are directly linked to Agent Orange and their military service in Vietnam. Yet, because they got the wrong disease, the Trump administration is blocking their health benefits.

So today—a day after millions of Americans, myself included, marched in the parades across our country to honor our vets—I demand that Chief of Staff Mulvaney reverse this cruel and unfair decision immediately.

I yield the floor.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The Senator from Maryland.

TURKEY AND SYRIA

Mr. VAN HOLLEN. Madam President, I start by thanking the Democratic leader for his leadership in raising those important issues before the Senate this afternoon.

I bring another issue before the Senate, that being my strong opposition to President Trump's shameful decision to invite Turkish President Erdogan to the White House tomorrow. It is a decision that has alarmed our allies and comforted our adversaries. It is a decision that undermines our values and our national security interests, and it is a decision that sends a terrible message to the world about how to get invited to President Trump's White House.

In just the last 5 weeks, Turkish President Erdogan has taken the following actions: No. 1, he has launched an attack on a key ally of ours—in fact, the key ally—in our fight against ISIS terrorists, that being the Syrian Democratic Forces, led by the Syrian Kurds. No. 2, President Erdogan and his forces have killed over 200 in these attacks, displaced over 300,000, and enabled the release of over 100 ISIS prisoners. No. 3, Erdogan is using jihadi proxies that include a lot of al-Qaida elements, and they are committing gross human rights abuses, including what the Trump administration has acknowledged as being war crimes. There are also reports that the Turkish-backed proxy forces are using the chemical agent white phosphorus. No. 4, Erdogan and his forces have violated the so-called safe zone agreement that was reached by Vice President PENCE in Ankara a few weeks ago. After President Erdogan entered into that agreement with Vice President PENCE, which has been violated, he turned around and decided to cut a separate deal with Putin and Russia, thereby giving Russia even more leverage than it already had in Syria.

In addition, Erdogan boasted that he organized a hit squad to assassinate the top commander of our Syrian Kurdish allies, General Mazloum. President Erdogan did that even after President Trump acknowledged that our Syrian Kurdish allies had given us important information that had helped us to kill ISIS leader Baghdadi. In fact, Erdogan has compared the military leader of our Syrian Kurdish allies—those who bore the brunt of the fight against ISIS—with the ISIS leader whom we just killed, Baghdadi. President Erdogan did all of that in just the last 5 weeks.

What did President Trump do?

Instead of calling upon the House and the Senate to pass the economic sanctions bill that had been introduced, he rewarded Erdogan for all of those actions with a coveted White House meeting.

That is not the way we should be treating somebody who has just spent the last 5 weeks thumbing his nose at the United States, undermining our interests, endangering our allies, strengthening Russia, Assad, and Iran, and increasing threats to our ally Israel.

It sends a terrible message to the world: Go ahead and undermine the national security interests of the United States, and the President of the United States will invite you over for dinner.

I have teamed up with Senator GRAHAM and others on a bipartisan basis, and I want to thank the Presiding Officer for her support on that sanctions legislation to hold Turkey accountable.

Here is what Senator GRAHAM said about President Erdogan just 3 weeks ago: ''If you want to get Erdogan's attention, you have to treat him like the thug he is.'' That is Senator GRAHAM speaking. Yet Erdogan, time and again over the last 5 weeks and before, has essentially spit in the eye of the United States, and now he is coming to Washington for a White House meeting. This is very difficult to explain. I am not sure any of us has the answer as to why President Trump is doing this.

The Washington Post had an article on October 17 headlined ''In Turkey's President, Trump seems to have found a soul mate.'' If you read through the article, you can see that President Trump does seem to have an affinity for President Erdogan of Turkey, and clearly President Erdogan likes to get on the phone with President Trump because whenever he does, President Erdogan seems to get his way.

Now he will come for a face-to-face meeting, and I am sure President Erdogan expects to get his way again. Why would he think that? Well, because the last time they talked, President Erdogan clearly took away from the conversation that it was just fine with President Trump if Turkey attacked our Syrian Kurdish allies. President Erdogan clearly believed he had the green light. In fact, after they hung up from that phone call, President Erdogan sent his forces and used proxy forces to attack our Syrian Kurdish allies, and President Trump tweeted that we were withdrawing some of our Special Forces from the area—Special Forces that had helped deter Turkish aggression against our Syrian Kurdish allies.

It is very rare for retired senior military leaders in the United States to criticize a sitting Commander in Chief, but the betrayal of our Syrian Kurdish allies and the terrible message that sent around the world about the unreliability of the United States compelled many of those former leaders to warn about the consequences. I think it is important for the Senate to hear some comments from people who are respected for what they have done for our country.

ADM William McRaven, former commander of the U.S. Special Operations Command, who worked with our Syrian

Kurdish allies in the fight against ISIS, said: ''He's''—referring to President Trump—''obviously left our allies the Kurds on the battlefield. . . . We feel like we've betrayed them. He's undermined our NATO allies . . . the international community has lost faith in America.'' That is from Admiral McRaven.

GEN Joseph Votel, former commander of U.S. Central Command and also somebody who has personal experience working alongside our Syrian Kurdish allies in the fight against ISIS, said: ''This policy abandonment threatens to undo five years' worth of fighting against ISIS and will severely damage American credibility and reliability in any future fights where we need strong allies.''

General Petraeus, former commander of U.S. Central Command and former commander of NATO's mission in Afghanistan and in Iraq, said: ''Well, I think we have abandoned our Syrian Kurdish partners. They took over 10,000 losses as the defeat of the Islamic State was carried out.''

Secretary James Mattis, Secretary of Defense under President Trump and former commander of U.S. Central Command, said: ''In this case, if we don't keep the pressure on, then ISIS will resurge.''

Secretary Mattis made it clear that by abandoning our Syrian Kurdish allies, we gave more oxygen to ISIS. In fact, we learned over the weekend that ISIS was claiming responsibility for the murder of an Armenian Catholic priest and his son. Their funeral services are today.

Another former high-level U.S. military commander who has spoken is ADM James Stavridis. He is the former commander of U.S. European Command and NATO Supreme Allied Commander in Europe. Here is what he had to say: ''This is heart-rending for anybody who has shed blood, who has deployed forward. . . . I'm getting so many inputs from all around the military . . . they know how this hurts at a very personal level. . . . It's not only the betrayal of the Kurds, it is the way it is going to allow those embers on the floor of the forest fire that we thought were out to kind of re-flash.'' He is saying, in other words, giving more oxygen to the ISIS embers that we were working toward extinguishing.

Gen. John Allen, former commander of NATO International Security Assistance Force and U.S. Forces—Afghanistan, was even blunter: ''There is blood on Trump's hands for abandoning our Kurdish allies.''

Those are from former top U.S. military leaders, patriots who fought with our Syrian Kurdish allies in the fight against ISIS.

There is also a statement from Brett McGurk. So who is Brett McGurk? Brett McGurk was the Presidential Envoy for the Global Coalition to Counter ISIS. He had that position under the previous President and for President Trump for a time. Here is what Brett McGurk had to say: ''I've worked for three presidents and participated in a number of foreign leader calls. I cannot recall a President that seems to believe—and then parrots—whatever a foreign leader tells him on the phone. Such information is often false, intended to influence more than inform.'' Yet what we saw was that when President Trump hung up on that phone call with President Erdogan, he essentially green-lighted that operation. That is why President Erdogan likes to get President Trump on the phone directly or talk to him directly, which he is going to get a chance to do tomorrow.

Probably the most damning of all the comments I have heard—and this was not unique, but it was unique in the way it was characterized—came from the mother of a cadet at the Naval Academy. What was interesting is that she has been a loyal supporter of President Trump. She supported him, she voted for him, and she stuck with him, but after the betrayal of our Syrian Kurdish allies, she said that she no longer could trust him and that she worried that her son at the Naval Academy would essentially be left to the whims of a Commander in Chief whom she could no longer trust. That was all before President Trump invited President Erdogan to the White House.

What we should be doing is passing tough economic sanctions. What we should be doing is holding Turkey and President Erdogan accountable for undermining our security and helping to give new oxygen to ISIS. That is why the House of Representatives passed a bipartisan sanctions bill by a whopping veto-proof vote of 403 to 16. That is why Senator GRAHAM and I have introduced bipartisan sanctions legislation in the U.S. Senate, which has more than 14 bipartisan cosponsors and growing. I do want to thank the Presiding Officer for her efforts to hold President Erdogan accountable with this legislation. There is also other legislation introduced by Senator MENENDEZ and Senator RISCH.

Here is what I know: The most important thing is that this body, the Senate, should act right now. We have the House bill sitting at the desk. We have the bill introduced by Senator GRAHAM and me sitting at the desk. Right now we should just pass those sanctions bills and send a message to President Erdogan that while he may be going to the White House tomorrow, he does not have support in the Congress.

I have talked about Erdogan's actions for the last 5 weeks. I would like to take us back 5 years from the period we are in right now. In the fall of that year, mid-September 2014, ISIS terrorist forces were encircling the Syrian Kurdish town of Kobani. Kobani is a town on the Syrian side of the Turkey-Syria border. ISIS was laying siege to that town. They had already taken a lot of the surrounding villages, and they were closing in on this last Syrian Kurdish stronghold.

The Syrian Kurds were totally outnumbered by ISIS, and the Syrian Kurds asked the United States for help. It took us a little longer than it should have—took us weeks, not days—but we agreed to help supply our Syrian Kurdish allies with weapons and equipment in the fight against ISIS.

We asked Turkey if they would help us supply weapons to the Syrian Kurds because Kobani is right there on the Syria-Turkey border. Turkey refused. President Erdogan said no. So the United States, at greater risk to our own forces, had to airdrop weapons and supplies into Iraq from U.S. aircraft, and with that help, our Syrian Kurdish forces were able to stop ISIS from taking over Kobani and began to push them out and, again with our help, primarily from the air, pushed them out. In that fight over the last 5 years, the Syrian Kurds have lost over 11,000 men and women, soldiers and others. That is what they have lost in the fight with us against ISIS.

Turkey, on the other hand, not only did not lift a finger in that fight, but for the past 5 years and even more the years before, they turned a blind eye to ISIS fighters transiting through Turkey, so ISIS was growing stronger as a result of their negligence.

I want to close by responding to those who say: Well, you know what, Turkey is a NATO ally, and so we should invite President Erdogan over to the White House.

I see on the floor my friend and colleague, Senator DURBIN from Illinois, and he, along with myself and others, has made this point repeatedly. We would like Turkey to be a strong NATO ally. Over the years of NATO alliance, they have in the past been a good partner, but under President Erdogan's leadership, they have taken Turkey in a very different direction.

The issue is not whether the United States wants Turkey to be a member of NATO; the question is, Does Turkey really want to stay in the alliance? Because everything they have done shows they are violating the values and principles of our alliance.

President Erdogan decided to purchase the Russian-made S–400 anti-aircraft system against our strong objection. This is a system that would have put our F–35 pilots at risk and undermined NATO security. President Erdogan said he didn't care. He went ahead with the S–400 purchase, and those S–400s are sitting in Turkey right now.

He was willing to work with Russia, Iran, Assad to undermine our interests in the area. We have talked today about how he attacked our Syrian Kurdish allies. He has repeatedly threatened the European Parliament, European Union, with releasing refugees if they do not cooperate with him and don't turn a blind eye to the fact that he has locked up more journalists than any other country on earth, including Iran, Egypt, North Korea, and Saudi Arabia.

So, Madam President, the fact that the President of the United States has invited Erdogan to the White House, after everything Erdogan has done to undermine our values and security, is a shame on the United States. It will undermine our national security interests. It has already alarmed our allies and heartened our adversaries.

It is important that all of us—all of us in this House and Senate—on a bipartisan basis, speak out—as we have been doing—against the shameful chapter in our American foreign policy and national security.

Madam President, I yield the floor.

Mr. GRASSLEY. Madam President.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The gentleman from Iowa is recognized.

COUNTERFEITERS

Mr. GRASSLEY. Today I am here to discuss the critical need to protect American businesses and consumers from the dangers of counterfeits, particularly counterfeit goods sold online.

Counterfeits do incredible damage to our country's economic competitiveness. They harm intellectual property right holders and the reputation of online marketplaces, undermine the integrity of our supply chains, and even threaten the health and safety of consumers. So it is Congress's responsibility to use its oversight and legislative authority to identify ways to prevent these illicit goods from entering our borders.

Over the past year, I have worked with the Finance Committee Ranking Member WYDEN to investigate how counterfeiters use e-commerce to sell their phony goods to consumers. Last week, we concluded our investigation and issued a report detailing our findings.

Based on the information presented to Senator WYDEN and this Senator by right holders, trade associations, e-commerce platforms, and common carriers, we made five findings in this report, and we identified two legislative recommendations for Congress in this report. I believe these recommendations will enhance existing efforts within the Federal Government to prevent the sale of counterfeits online.

I will talk briefly about our findings today, and I look forward to working with my colleagues—both Republican and Democrat—to identify additional areas for congressional action.

As chairman of the Senate Finance Committee, I recognize the value of intellectual property rights and their impacts on society and the economy. Intellectual property rights allow businesses to generate new ideas and develop creative solutions to everyday problems that can make our lives healthier, safer, and more productive. I also understand businesses and innovators rely on those rights to help drive and recoup their investments.

In my own State of Iowa, intellectual property represents more than $14.4 billion in annual exports for the State, more than 94,000 jobs, and supports more than 2,000 small businesses with less than 500 employees. However, counterfeits are increasingly threatening these achievements and the hard work of the people that innovate. It has been estimated that international trade for counterfeit goods in 2016 accounted for $509 billion of world trade.

Counterfeits are found in both physical and online marketplaces, and almost every industry is affected. Scam artists target electronics, automotive parts, and even children's toys, to ripoff consumers and to make a profit. Counterfeits can also harm consumers. Many consumers do not know that counterfeits can be dangerous and that some have been found to contain lead, excessive small parts, and even unsafe chemicals.

In 2018, the Government Accountability Office—or GAO, as we know it around Washington—examined how e-commerce marketplaces are further enabling the sale of counterfeits. GAO found that counterfeiters use online marketplaces to sell fakes to consumers because they can hide their identity by using false or incomplete names. Counterfeiters also post legitimate photos or fake reviews for their products, which makes it harder for consumers to determine whether they are buying a legitimate or fake good.

The Grassley-Wyden investigation showed that the breadth and variety of goods sold online makes it nearly impossible to prevent the sale of all counterfeits. Right holders also told us that their enforcement efforts are hindered in part because the U.S. Customs and Border Protection shares very limited—and often heavily redacted—importation information with these right holders. But right holders need importation information to identify counterfeit sellers and report suspected counterfeit listings.

Counterfeits also pose a threat to e-commerce and to common carriers. Counterfeits smear the reputation of e-commerce and threaten the integrity of the common carrier supply chain network. As such, these parties are critical partners in the fight against the sale of counterfeit goods. However, Customs and Border Protection does not have the authority to share importation information with these parties when it identifies a counterfeit at our border.

During our investigation, these parties told us that this information would give them the ability to better protect our country's intellectual property and allow them to remove more counterfeit listings and block counterfeit sellers. We must look at this problem holistically and with the understanding that right holders, e-commerce platforms, and common carriers are critical partners in the fight against the sale of counterfeit goods and those counterfeit goods being sold online. By sharing more importation information, these parties can better protect the intellectual property rights of our innovators, as well as the health and safety of e-commerce consumers.

Our investigation is but a first step. I will continue to use my oversight authority to look for innovative solutions to protect intellectual property right holders and consumers from the negative effects of counterfeits.

Madam President, I yield the floor.

The PRESIDING OFFICER (Mr. CASSIDY). The Senator from Illinois.

IMMIGRATION

Mr. DURBIN. Mr. President, I was honored today to attend the second hearing I have attended in the Supreme Court of the United States. If you stand right here on the floor of the Senate and look east through these glass doors, you can almost see the Supreme Court buildings directly across the street. The Supreme Court is, many times, the last stop when it comes to human rights and civil rights. After all the work that has been done by the Congress, by the President, many times, it is the Supreme Court that has the last word.

In the case of Plessy v. Ferguson, when the Supreme Court held that segregation was constitutional, that last word was a disappointment. And Korematsu v. The United States, when the Supreme Court upheld the internment of Japanese Americans during World War II, that was another disappointment.

But other times, the Supreme Court has risen to the challenge: The famous case of Brown vs. Board of Education, which finally struck down the concept of separate but equal; Obergefell vs. Hodges, where the Supreme Court recognized the right to marriage equality.

Well, today, the Supreme Court faces another human rights issue involving another group. Just a few hours ago, the street between the Capitol and the Supreme Court was literally filled with thousands and thousands of demonstrators. The issue before the Court today was the fate of DACA, the Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals.

This measure, DACA, is one that I have worked on for many years—many years. Nineteen years ago, I introduced the DREAM Act. Before that, the term ''Dreamer'' was hardly ever applied in the conversation about immigration, but now, it has become standard and really defines this group of Americans, people living in America.

In their case, they came to the United States, brought here by their parents, when they were children. They may have had legal entry into the United States, but at some point in their lives, they no longer were legal. They became undocumented, in the words of the law. Most of these young people never knew that status until they reached their teenage years and their parents finally told them the truth of their legal condition.

They had no control over the decision of their parents to come to this country or file the necessary papers. Frankly, many of them were shocked to learn that they were undocumented. They went to school with our kids. They grew up in our communities.

They played on the sports teams. They probably attended the same churches and temples and synagogues as our own kids. They were just part of the group. But they knew—they privately knew they were not. They knew that they were one knock on the door away from being deported from the United States.

It was because of one of these young people that I decided to introduce that DREAM Act legislation 19 years ago. Her name is Tereza Lee, brought to the United States at the age of 2 from Korea by her parents to Chicago. She grew up in a family that struggled to make ends meet. Her father wanted to be a minister, but never quite put that church together. Her mother worked in a dry-cleaning establishment to feed the family. She went to public schools, and as luck would have it, there was a program at one of these schools called the Merit Music program that gave her a chance to learn how to play the piano.

She started playing, and she followed her father around to these churches. Then she took it seriously, and she became an amazing pianist to the point where, when she finished the public high school, she was offered an opportunity to go on for music education at the Manhattan Conservatory of Music. When she filled out her application and reached the point where they asked her nationality and citizenship, she asked her mom: What am I supposed to put on here? Her mom said: I am not sure. We better call Senator DURBIN's office.

They did, and we checked the law, and the law is very harsh. For Tereza Lee—who had lived 15 or 16 years in the United States, beat the odds by finishing high school and developing this great talent at the piano—the law told her that she had to leave the United States for 10 years and apply to return. That is the law.

It seemed unfair to me that a young woman, brought here at the age of 2, should face that as her only legal choice, so I introduced the DREAM Act. It said, if you were brought here as a child, raised in the United States, went to school, and had no criminal record of significance, that you should be given a chance—the chance to make it in the United States to earn your way to legal status and citizenship.

That is what the DREAM Act was all about. We passed it in the House and in the Senate, but never in the same Congress, so it is still not the law of the land. It was 8 years ago when I appealed to my former colleague in the Senate, Barack Obama, as President, to try to help, and he did.

By Executive action, he created DACA, which said that young people like Tereza Lee could apply, go through a criminal background check, fill out the necessary forms, pay the filing fee, and be allowed to stay in the United States for 2 years at a time, renewable, not to be deported, and be able to legally work.

After President Obama came up with DACA, over 780,000 young people came forward and became protected by DACA. It really changed their lives. For the first time in their lives, they had some government-recognized status. They were no longer just undocumented. Then amazing things happened. They went on and pursued an education, a career, a life, a future. They started realizing their dreams. It was a good and positive thing all around.

Then, President Trump came into office. Initially, he was very complimentary of Dreamers, saying positive things about them, but, unfortunately, over a period of time he changed his attitude about this issue. On September 5, 2017, President Trump announced he was going to end the DACA Program, end the protection for these young people.

It was a sad day and a challenge for us to decide what to do, to try to pass legislation in the Congress that would protect these young people, and we rolled up our sleeves and put together several bipartisan measures in the Senate. President Trump rejected every single one of them. He wasn't going to have it. He was opposed to our enacting legislation that dealt with it.

That repeal of DACA has created uncertainty for hundreds of thousands. A lawsuit was filed in an effort to try to protect them, and the courts said their protection would continue while the case was being argued. The case worked its way through the courts and ended up, this morning, at the U.S. Supreme Court across the street.

I was proud to lead 172 current and former Members of Congress on a bipartisan amicus brief in support of DACA. Now it is clearly up to the Justices in the Supreme Court to follow the law and to reject what I consider to be President Trump's illegal repeal of DACA, but only Congress can provide a permanent solution for Dreamers.

The U.S. House of Representatives has responded to President Trump's cruel decision to repeal DACA by passing the Dream and Promise Act on a strong bipartisan vote of 237 to 187. This legislation is based on the DREAM Act I originally introduced 19 years ago. This bipartisan legislation would give Dreamers a chance to earn their citizenship. The bill passed the House. It is here. It is now up to Senator MITCH MCCONNELL of Kentucky, the Republican leader, to call the Dream and Promise Act for a vote in the U.S. Senate.

Mr. President, I want to make a unanimous consent request in relation to that measure and ask for a consent after we debate my UC request to complete my remarks. I see a Senator on the floor who I believe is here to object. I want to be courteous to her because she has been in the Chair for a while. Can I have a unanimous consent to return to the debate after I make my unanimous consent request?

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Is there objection?

Without objection, it is so ordered.

UNANIMOUS CONSENT REQUEST—H.R. 6

Mr. DURBIN. Mr. President, for clarity, I ask unanimous consent to bring to the floor the Dream and Promise Act for a vote in the Senate—a measure which would address the very issue that is before the Supreme Court today. I am making this on behalf of Senator SCHUMER, Senator LEAHY, Senator ROSEN, Senator TIM KAINE, Senator MENENDEZ, and Senator CARDIN.

As if in legislative session, I ask unanimous consent that the Senate proceed to the immediate consideration of Calendar No. 112, H.R. 6; further, that the bill be considered read a third time and passed, and the motion to reconsider be considered made and laid upon table, with no intervening action or debate.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Is there objection?

Mrs. BLACKBURN. Mr. President, I am reserving the right to object, and I will object.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The Senator from Tennessee.

Mrs. BLACKBURN. Mr. President, I would like to articulate the reason for the objection to the legislation that is brought forward by my friend the Senator from Illinois.

Once again, I found it necessary for the good of the order to object to a unanimous consent request brought by our friends in the minority. Once again, they are attempting to bypass the Senate's rules on behalf of a piece of legislation this body has not had time to debate, to deliberate, or to consider in committee.

The American Dream and Promise Act passed the House of Representatives by a near party-line vote; unsurprising, considering the bill addresses the contentious issue of immigration law. This bill, supported by the Senator from Illinois, would offer temporary legal status to 2½ million undocumented immigrants.

Those affected immigrants have tried to remain in the United States under the Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals, or the DACA Program—a backstop made possible by nothing more than an Executive memo signed by former President Barack Obama.

I think this is important for us to realize that it was an Executive memo that put this program in place. It is not a Federal law. President Trump ended the DACA Program in 2017, arguing the Obama administration's attempt to subvert immigration law on such a massive scale was unlawful and possibly unconstitutional. Soon after, President Trump offered a path to legalization for DACA recipients, but our friends in the minority refused to take him up on that offer.

We have to remember this: There was a path to legalization for DACA recipients that was offered by President Donald Trump. Our friends in the minority said: No; no, we do not want that.

They continued with the issue. I will tell you, every Dreamer in the country should be outraged by the minority's

refusal to come to the table and negotiate on an offer that was on the table. I encourage my friends on the other side of the aisle to remember that the Supreme Court affirmed a lower court decision to maintain an injunction on the nationwide DAPA Program—a scheme similar to DACA but aimed at parents, as opposed to children.

Although that decision set no legal precedent, it did open up an opportunity for the new administration—and for each and every one of us in the Senate—to rebuild various fixes in our immigration system without running afoul of existing legal barriers.

As my friend the Senator from Illinois likes to point out, Senators from both sides of the aisle have been working on this issue—it has been with us for years—and it is imperative we find a consensus solution.

If the minority wishes to offer peace of mind and a path forward to Dreamers, they should do it in such a way that allows the American people to hold each and every one of us accountable for repercussions. We should do this through regular order. I reiterate my objection to the minority whip's motion.

I yield the floor.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Does the Senator object?

Mrs. BLACKBURN. Mr. President, yes, I do object.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Objection is heard.

Mr. DURBIN. Mr. President, for the record, how many pieces of legislation did we consider in the Senate last week? None. The week before? None. How many months has this measure been sitting in the Senate, the Republican-controlled Senate? Five months, and for five months the Republican leader has not considered it worthy to even bring it before the Senate for debate.

I don't control the agenda. Senator MCCONNELL does. He has decided this measure is not worth debating on the floor of the U.S. Senate.

When I come and make a unanimous consent request to bring this measure to the floor, it isn't as if we are taking away an option, which the Republican leader is using. He is not. When we look back to the debate or at least the effort to find a compromise with President Trump on this issue, it is next to impossible. He is surrounded by people who are completely against DACA and Dreamers. Stephen Miller is a good illustration of one. It used to be Jeff Sessions. He is no longer with the administration. Every time the President starts to lean toward DACA and the Dreamers, these people intervene and stop him, and negotiations come to an end.

It is time for us in the Senate not to wait for a permission slip from President Trump to pass legislation. I am prepared to bring this matter to the floor and to accept the decision on the amendments on the floor. We are in the minority. We will lose some of these amendments. So be it. Let's let the Senate be the Senate and deliberate these measures. To argue that I shouldn't be asking to bring it to the floor because it has to go through regular order, the obvious question is: When is Senator MCCONNELL going to pursue regular order on a measure that has been sitting here for 5 months?

Let me say a word, if I can, while we are on the subject, about the people who are involved. We can talk about Senate procedure and law all we wish, but what we should do is discuss the real people who are involved.

In 1,000 days in office, this President has issued 11,000 tweets. No surprise, is it? There are 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10 a day. He issued one this morning about the young people who are in question here. I would like to read President Donald Trump's tweet from this morning, as the case was headed to the Supreme Court. Here is what he tweeted:

> Many of the people in DACA, no longer very young, are far from ''angels.'' Some are very tough, hardened criminals. President Obama said he had no legal right to sign order, but would anyway. If Supreme Court remedies with overturn, a deal will be made with Dems for them to stay!

May I address one particular aspect of the tweet of the President of the United States on this subject affecting the fate of 780,000 young people living in the United States? Probably the best thing is not to do it generically but to talk about specifics.

Let me tell you a story about two DACA recipients, both attending Loyola University in Chicago—the city I am honored to represent. They both came to Washington, DC, today, and sat in the Supreme Court during the argument. I am going to leave it up to my Members and colleagues in the Senate, as well as those who are following this debate, to reach their own conclusion about these two whom I am about to tell the story of. You decide whether this man is a tough and hardened criminal. His name is Cesar Montelongo. He grew up in the State of New Mexico. He was a pretty good student. In fact, he was an excellent student. He graduated from high school with a grade point average of 4.0 and ranked third in his class. He went on to New Mexico State University, where he was a triple major in biology, microbiology, and Spanish, as well as two minors in chemistry and biochemistry. Cesar graduated with a 3.9 GPA.

This hardened criminal then went on to earn a master's degree in biology, with a minor in molecular biology, while working as a teaching assistant. Then DACA came along. For the first time in his life, he had a chance to apply for medical school. He never thought that could happen. He applied and was accepted at Loyola University's Chicago Stritch School of Medicine. It is quite an achievement.

The Presiding Officer, who is also a medical doctor, I am sure understands that, but he did one better. He enrolled in the M.D.-Ph.D. program at Loyola University. He was just in my office upstairs, and he told me that in a matter of 2 or 3 years, he will have completed his Ph.D. in microbiology, and then he can go on to complete his medical degree and his residency.

This tough, hardened criminal—according to the President—has designs on becoming a medical researcher in the United States of America. When he completes this highly competitive program, he will have a medical degree and a doctorate degree in science.

He is one of dozens of DACA recipients at the Stritch School. My hat is off to Loyola University. They have admitted more DACA students to their medical school than any other medical school in the United States. They are amazing students. I have met them. Many, if not all of them, have promised to come back to my State of Illinois, having had this chance to go to medical school in Chicago, and serve in underserved areas after they have become practicing doctors. Loyola doesn't give them any special treatment in the selection process. They are not eligible for any Federal financial assistance.

I just want to thank them and say to the President of the United States: Before you put out a tweet calling Cesar Montelongo or people like him hardened criminals, Mr. President, take a minute and meet these young people.

While you are at it, meet this young lady too. She was just in my office. Her name is Fernanda Herrera Vera. When she was 2 years old, her family brought her from Mexico to the United States. When she was 7, her family was forced to leave Guntersville, AL, when her father lost his job due to his immigration status. The family settled in Gadsden, AL, where Fernanda attended a private Catholic school on a scholarship.

When she was 10, her parents opened a restaurant. Every day after school, she went to the restaurant to wait tables and help run the restaurant, doing her homework in her spare time. During Fernanda's junior year of high school, Alabama passed the harshest anti-immigration law in the country, which forced her family to close down their restaurant.

Alabama barred Dreamers from attending even public colleges, but thanks to DACA, Fernanda was able to attend a private school, Samford University in Birmingham, AL. Her parents worked hard to pay tuition. She qualified for no Federal financial assistance. Her dad worked 80 hours a week at a chicken plant so that she could go to college. She graduated from Samford in 2017, and her experience has driven her to become an immigration activist. She worked at the Alabama Coalition for Immigrant Justice.

After President Trump repealed DACA in 2017, Fernanda came to Washington for a 4-day hunger fast with other DACA recipients on the Capitol lawn.

Last year, Fernanda was admitted to the Loyola University Chicago School

of Law. But this spring, her mother was pulled over in Georgia for driving with a broken taillight. Her mother is now in deportation proceedings.

It is tough enough to go to school without Federal financial help. It is tough enough to work your way through it. It is tough enough not to know how the Supreme Court is going to rule tomorrow or the day after and whether it will change your fate. It is tough enough to know that any knock at the door could mean deportation for members of your family. Yet she has persevered.

A hardened criminal, Mr. President?

Fernanda's dream is to become an immigration lawyer. She wants to help people just like her mom.

Without DACA, Cesar Montelongo will not become a doctor. Fernanda Herrera Vera will not become an attorney. Will America be a better country if they are forced to leave, if they are deported? I don't think so.

Cesar, Fernanda, and hundreds of thousands of other Dreamers are counting on the Supreme Court to do the right thing and reject President Trump's repeal of DACA. They are also counting on those of us who serve in the Senate to stop making excuses and solve this crisis.

A bill has passed the House. I tried to bring it to the floor of the Senate, and there was an objection today. It isn't because we are overwhelmed with work. As you can see, we spend a lot of time making speeches.

Since Senator MCCONNELL refuses to take any action to address the plight of the Dreamers, I am going to continue to make this unanimous consent request. Next week, I don't want the excuse to be that we are not following regular order, but in the meantime, I hope the Senate Judiciary Committee will take up this measure, as they have so many times over the last 15 years or so, and bring it to the floor of the Senate.

Once and for all, could we be the U.S. Senate for a week? Could we actually consider a piece of legislation here that addresses an issue that is critically important to hundreds of thousands of people living in the United States of America?

What a relief it would be to see this Senate actually as a Senate, to see Members on the floor debating issues. I am not going to win every debate. Every amendment I want is not going to pass, but I am prepared to accept the outcome. Let's do what the Senate was elected to do.

I am sorry there was an objection today. As long as I am a U.S. Senator, I am going to continue to come to the floor of the Senate to advocate for Cesar, Fernanda and all of the Dreamers. It would be an American tragedy to deport these two promising young people.

Now it is in the hands of Senator MITCH MCCONNELL, the Republican majority leader, to give the Dream and Promise Act a vote and to say to those 780,000 who do not know what their future will be just days or weeks from now that there is an answer: We want you to be part of America.

I yield the floor.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The Senator from Texas.

Mr. CORNYN. Mr. President, I know my friend from Illinois, Senator DURBIN, is sincere in his desire to get some relief for the DACA recipients, whose case is now pending before the U.S. Supreme Court. I share a desire to give them some certainty. That is why I supported what President Trump offered in February of 2018, which was a pathway to citizenship not only for the individuals who had applied for and received deferred action under President Obama's administration but for all those who were eligible but did not apply.

What continues to confuse me is how our Democratic colleagues will routinely vote against that offer, which was incredibly generous. I don't think any other President in my lifetime would have had the boldness and the courage to offer a pathway to citizenship for 1.8 million DACA-eligible young people, but President Trump did, and our Democratic colleagues turned it down. That leads me to wonder about their sincerity. Do they like this political issue more than they have a desire to find a solution to the problem?

I agree that these young people, who through no fault of their own came to the United States because their parents brought them here, are the most sympathetic and deserving cohort of immigrants in the country. I wish we could work together to come up with a solution. But at some point you have to wonder whether our Democratic colleagues prefer not to solve the problem but would rather try to portray this as a political football for partisan advantage in the runup to the next election.

That is tragic—toying with the lives of these young people, stoking their insecurity, telling them you are on their side but on the other hand voting against an offer to provide them a pathway toward citizenship. I don't know how you reconcile those two positions.

PRESCRIPTION DRUG COSTS

Mr. President, on another matter, I introduced a bill with our colleague from Connecticut, Senator BLUMENTHAL, to address the rising costs at the pharmacy counter. Senator BLUMENTHAL is a Democrat. I am a Republican. He is from Connecticut. I am from Texas. But we both heard the same thing from our constituents: Prescription drugs—particularly the out-of-pocket costs to consumers—are too high, especially with the huge deductibles and the huge copays under the Affordable Care Act.

Over the last several months, we have dug into the reasons behind those high costs, and it is safe to say there is a lot that concerns us.

One of the most egregious forms of abuse we have seen deals with the patent system. Under the patent system, if you come up with a new lifesaving drug, then you are guaranteed the exclusive right to make and to sell that drug, and you are protected from any competition for a period of time. But after that period of time expires, what is supposed to happen is that generic alternatives are supposed to be available to compete and bring down the price for consumers. That is the case for 90 percent of the drugs we take.

Our country offers the most robust protection in the world for intellectual property. We know companies are unlikely to pour extensive time, money, and resources into developing these new cures unless, at the end of it, there is some reward. I get that, and I support that.

But the patent system is designed to provide a limited time period during which the manufacturer can be the sole seller on the market before generic alternatives can become available and before competitors can enter the market. What is happening is that some companies are abusing that system and extending that period of exclusivity by filing tens—sometimes in excess of 100 patents.

In one case involving a drug called HUMIRA, which is one of the best selling drugs in the world, there are four approved competitors in Europe. In the United States, HUMIRA has in excess of 120 separate patents designed to crowd out and prevent any competition while maintaining their exclusivity in the marketplace.

That is what is called the patent thicketing. It involves using intricate webs of patents to keep competition at bay for as long as possible, meaning that your profits and your exclusive rights to sell this drug are high.

There is also something called product hopping, which occurs when a company develops a reformulation of an existing drug about to lose its exclusivity and then pulls the original product off the market. This is done not because the new formula is more effective necessarily but because pulling the original drug off the market before it loses its exclusivity prevents generic competitors. That is called product hopping.

The bill Senator BLUMENTHAL and I introduced aims to stop these anticompetitive behaviors, allow competitors to come to market sooner, and bring down prices for consumers. The Affordable Prescriptions for Patients Act streamlines the litigation process by limiting the number of patents companies can use when they are litigating their patent rights. Ultimately, we believe—and I believe it is borne out by the Congressional Budget Office scoring—this would allow competitors to resolve patent issues faster and bring those generic drugs to market sooner. This is how we improve competition and lower prices without getting in the way of lifesaving innovation.

The added benefit to this bill is the Federal savings it would provide for

taxpayers. The Congressional Budget Office says that this bill would lower Federal spending by more than half a billion dollars over 10 years. That is not a panacea, but it is a good start. This is just savings to the Federal Government for Medicare and Medicaid. There would undoubtedly be more savings for consumers who get their health coverage through private health insurance.

It checks every box. It checks innovation, increases competition, lowers prices for patients, and saves money for taxpayers. On top of that, this bill has a raft of bipartisan cosponsors. This is not a partisan bill; this is a bipartisan bill. In addition to Senator BLUMENTHAL, five other Democrats have endorsed the bill, including both the Democratic whip and the assistant Democratic leader.

I am sure it comes as no surprise that this bill sailed through the Judiciary Committee without a single Senator voting against it. It was unanimous. During simpler times, it would have quickly passed the full Senate and moved on to the House for their consideration and then gone on to the President for his signature. But we all know things aren't quite that easy these days, and even bipartisan bills get caught up in the political crosshairs.

According to a report in POLITICO, the minority leader from New York, Senator SCHUMER, is blocking this bill from passing in the Senate. He is blocking one of his own Member's bills—and one to lower prescription drug prices, of all things. While the American people suffer from the crush of high costs at the pharmacy, he stonewalls, and it is to the detriment of just about everybody—except one group.

I know there are some drug manufacturers that must be thrilled with his blocking the bill that would reduce their compensation and increase competition. You see, the army of special interests who have been fighting my bill since day one when it was introduced is ecstatic that the Democratic leader is blocking this bill, but I am not, and I don't think the rest of the Senate is either because this is a noncontroversial, bipartisan bill. The only thing that Democrats are doing by continuing to hold up this bill is to carry water for one of Washington's most prominent special interest groups. As long as they do, it will be to the detriment of the American people.

I know this frustration is bipartisan because my friend Senator BLUMENTHAL is just as frustrated by this ridiculous holdup as I am. We have tried to reason with the minority leader. We have tried to negotiate. We have tried to get him to allow the bill to come to the floor, but we have had no luck so far.

Last week, I came to the Senate floor to ask unanimous consent to pass this bill, and what happened next felt like a scene from a bad made-for-TV political drama. The minority leader, who was unwilling to come to the floor and block the bill himself, tried to have one of the cosponsors of my bill do it for him, the Senator from Illinois. He would rather force his own member to block a popular bipartisan bill, which happens to have my name on it, than allow it to pass on its own.

Well, as you can imagine, that didn't go very well. So then it was on to plan B. They wanted to link the fate of our bill, which passed unanimously in the Judiciary Committee, with another bill that hasn't even passed out of committee.

The other bill was introduced by our friends, Senators Grassley and Durbin, and aims to provide greater transparency on drug prices, something that is definitely needed, and I don't object to it. But these bills are in very different places in the legislative process, and some Members on our side have concerns about a bill coming to the floor that hasn't even been through the committee of jurisdiction.

Now, to the minority leader this is just another creative way to stop passage of a noncontroversial bill and attach a free rider onto the bill, which, in essence, is a poison pill. The result is the same. Nothing passes.

As I said, the bill Senator BLUMENTHAL and I have introduced is bipartisan. It is not controversial. It went through regular order. Every member of the Judiciary Committee had a chance to vote on it, and no one voted against it. We checked on our side, and there is no objection. We have run a hotline on the Democratic side, only to find that the Democratic leader is the one himself who is blocking it.

Well, unfortunately, politics, once again, has overwhelmed our collective good judgment and good sense. I know the Democratic leader doesn't want any bills to pass that Republicans can use to tell their constituents that they are listening to their concerns and acting on those concerns in the run up to the next election. He doesn't really care about the merits of the legislation or that it would, in fact, help New Yorkers. It is politically inconvenient, and that, clearly, is his top priority.

The American people deserve better. With the House working day and night to remove the President from office and the next election less than a year away, the opportunities for us to pass any sort of bipartisan legislation are getting slimmer and slimmer.

I plan to return to the floor later this week with my colleague from Connecticut to ask unanimous consent that this bill be passed. If the Democratic leader is going to block the bill, I want it to be clear to the American people and the people who would benefit from the passage of the bill being signed into law. I want them to see him do it and to hold him accountable for his misguided politics.

I hope the minority leader will rethink his decision to block this bill so that we can all work together to deliver bipartisan results for our constituents.

I yield the floor.

I suggest the absence of a quorum.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The clerk will call the roll.

The senior assistant legislative clerk proceeded to call the roll.

Ms. ROSEN. Mr. President, I ask unanimous consent that the order for the quorum call be rescinded.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Without objection, it is so ordered.

The Senator from Nevada.

NOMINATION OF CHAD F. WOLF

Ms. ROSEN. Mr. President, I rise today in opposition to this administration's nomination of Chad Wolf to be Under Secretary for Strategy, Policy, and Plans at the Department of Homeland Security. I stand here today opposed not only to Mr. Wolf's nomination but also to the way in which this administration is circumventing the constitutional requirement of advice and consent to make Mr. Wolf the head of the third largest Department in the Federal Government.

By the President's own admission, Mr. Wolf is slated to immediately be appointed to serve indefinitely in the position of Acting Secretary of Homeland Security. Thus, our votes tonight and tomorrow are effectively to confirm Chad Wolf to be Acting Secretary of the entire Department of Homeland Security, despite limited vetting, no committee vote, and no confirmation hearing for this position.

But this is about more than just an egregious attempt to bypass the Senate's role of advice and consent for Cabinet nominees. Rather, this evening's vote will advance a nominee who played an integral role in this administration's cruel family separation policy, and tonight's vote is about the refusal of this administration to address its treatment of detained children.

That is why I was so disappointed to see cloture filed on Chad Wolf's nomination. I placed a hold on Mr. Wolf's nomination to be Under Secretary as a result of the ongoing humanitarian crisis at the southern border, which began and grew during Mr. Wolf's tenure as chief of staff to DHS Secretary Nielsen.

Between July 2017 and June 2018, while Mr. Wolf held the position of chief of staff, 2,800 migrant children were separated from their parents and held in DHS custody under this administration's cruel, so-called ''zero tolerance'' immigration policy.

Even today, we don't know the extent of the damage. Just last week, reports identified 1,500 more children who were separated from their parents during that time. We do, however, know from emails that Chad Wolf played a leading role in developing, suggesting, and implementing this inhumane policy.

When I asked him if he had helped to develop the administration's family separation policy, he said: ''No, ma'am.'' When I asked him if he had concerns with the policy of indefinitely separating children from their parents, Mr. Wolf said: ''My job wasn't to determine if it was the right or wrong policy.''

When I asked him how he became aware of the policy, he stated that he learned about it in April of 2018. Emails now show that Mr. Wolf had been participating in meetings discussing family separation as far back as December of 2017. The emails showed that Mr. Wolf provided then-Secretary Nielsen a list of 16 options to limit immigration, one of which was to separate families.

Even before these emails came to light, I found Mr. Wolf's failure to take responsibility for his direct involvement in the administration's cruel family separation policy to be both misleading and disingenuous, which is why I voted against his nomination in committee.

I also placed a hold on both Mr. Wolf's nomination and that of DHS CFO nominee Troy Edgar until the inhumane and substandard conditions for children at CBP processing and detention facilities improved significantly. Reports from journalists, attorneys, and advocates detailed ongoing horrific conditions, making it clear that DHS was not taking the actions needed to care for and treat migrant children at the southern border.

I witnessed these conditions firsthand. When I toured detention facilities at the border earlier this year, what I saw was entirely consistent with the news and DHS inspector general reports about the horrific and inhumane conditions there: children freezing, scared, and unsure of what would happen to them next. The children didn't know if they would ever see their parents again. Even the parents didn't know when their next meal would be, when their next shower would be, and how long they would be there. The anxiety and despair was palpable.

Amidst this crisis at the border, I placed a hold on Mr. Wolf. My requests of the Department were simple—that every child under the care of the United States of America be treated humanely. I requested that DHS hire more pediatricians for CBP facilities, that they bring on child welfare professionals to care for and provide services to the children in CBP custody, and that they increase NGO access to CBP facilities.

Regarding these specific requests, DHS has not adequately addressed the concerns. This is why I maintain my hold on Mr. Wolf's nomination and why my hold on Mr. Edgar will remain until these conditions improve.

With this in mind, we cannot allow a nominee like Mr. Wolf to move forward, especially when we know he is going to be moved right up to Acting Secretary, a position where the President can keep him indefinitely without a confirmation hearing and without the advice and consent of the Senate.

It is an end run around our constitutional role, one of the most important checks we have on the executive branch. It is also not the process we should accept for filling a Cabinet-level position in the third largest Department in the Federal Government, one charged with the critical job of protecting our homeland.

I urge my colleagues on both sides of the aisle to vote against cloture on Mr. Wolf's nomination tonight and against his confirmation tomorrow, and I pledge to work with all of you and the administration to identify nominees to lead the Department whom we can all support.

I yield the floor.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The Senator from Wisconsin.

Mr. JOHNSON. Mr. President, I rise today to ask the Senate to confirm Mr. Chad Wolf to be the Under Secretary of the Office of Strategy, Policy, and Plans at the Department of Homeland Security.

The Under Secretary of the Office of Strategy, Policy, and Plans leads an office of over 150 employees with an annual budget of over $37 million to develop and implement DHS policy, long-term goals, and strategic plans. Chad Wolf has extensive experience in homeland security policy, starting in 2002 working as the chief of staff helping to stand up the new Transportation Security Administration after 9/11 and then as the Assistant Administrator for that agency.

He left government and spent over a decade working on homeland security policy issues as a consultant in the private sector. Mr. Wolf returned to public service and the Department of Homeland Security in 2017, serving as chief of staff at TSA, chief of staff to the Secretary, and now as the Assistant Secretary of Strategy, Plans, Analysis & Risk. Since February of this year, he has been the senior official performing the duties of the Under Secretary of the Office of Strategy, Policy, and Plans, the office for which we are now considering his nomination.

The Senate Committee on Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs approved his nomination on a bipartisan basis on July 24. As we all know, the Department has a number of Senate-confirmed leadership positions vacant. Currently, 7 of the 18 DHS offices requiring Senate confirmation are vacant. Three of those vacant positions have nominees that have been languishing on the Senate floor for months after being approved by my committee with bipartisan support.

Mr. Wolf's nomination has been pending in the Senate for almost 9 months. Troy Edgar, the nominee to be the Department's Chief Financial Officer, has been pending in the Senate for 8 months, and William Bryan, the nominee to be Under Secretary for Science and Technology, has been pending for over 4 months. All three nominees were approved by my committee with bipartisan support. We are holding a hearing to consider Mr. Peter Gaynor as the President's nominee to head FEMA this week.

Dedicated Americans serving at DHS in acting positions are doing admirable jobs under oftentimes difficult circumstances. I trust that Chad Wolf will do the same if he is asked to step aside from his role as Under Secretary to serve temporarily as Acting Secretary upon Kevin McAleenan's departure.

I fully expect and I call upon the President to nominate a permanent Secretary for the Department of Homeland Security. When he does, my committee will consider the nominee expeditiously. We need confirmed leadership at DHS to help direct the Department as it works to keep Americans safe.

We need confirmed leadership at DHS to help direct the Department as it works to keep Americans safe. I am grateful to Chad Wolf for his willingness to serve in this position, and I encourage my colleagues to support his confirmation.

Mr. President, I suggest the absence of a quorum.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The clerk will call the roll.

The legislative clerk proceeded to call the roll.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The Senator from Michigan.

Mr. PETERS. Mr. President, I ask unanimous consent that the order for the quorum call be rescinded.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Without objection, it is so ordered.

Mr. PETERS. Mr. President, today, I rise to oppose the nomination of Chad Wolf. Officially, we are considering Mr. Wolf's nomination to serve as Under Secretary for Strategy, Policy, and Plans at the Department of Homeland Security. In that role Mr. Wolf would lead the DHS policy office, an important but little-known part of the Department.

However, that is not the role that Mr. Wolf will actually have. We have recently learned that the President has much bigger plans for Mr. Wolf. The President plans to make Mr. Wolf the next Acting Secretary for the entire Department of Homeland Security. Instead of running the policy office, which has a staff of about 160 people and an annual budget of $35 million, Mr. Wolf will lead all of DHS, the third largest executive agency, with a 240,000-person workforce and a budget of over $75 billion.

Let's be clear, for all intents and purposes, we are essentially about to vote on the confirmation of a new Secretary of Homeland Security, a position responsible for protecting this Nation from a vast and evolving array of threats. Despite the importance of this position and this vote, we have not been given a full opportunity to meaningfully examine Mr. Wolf's ability to take on this profoundly important and challenging role.

Based on my evaluation of his qualifications to serve as Under Secretary, I do not believe Mr. Wolf has the experience needed to lead this critical Cabinet Department.

I would like to recognize that Mr. Wolf does have several years of Homeland Security policy experience. In his

current role within the Department's policy office, Mr. Wolf has engaged in productive dialogue with the Homeland Security Committee. In particular, I have personally appreciated his willingness to recognize the growing threat of domestic terrorism and White supremacist violence and the need for the Department to do more to keep our communities safe.

However, Mr. Wolf's tenure as chief of staff to former DHS Secretary Nielsen raises serious concerns about his judgment and, in particular, his involvement in some of this administration's most misguided and harmful policies. As part of the Senate's constitutional responsibility to provide advice and consent, I have repeatedly asked DHS to provide documents directly related to Mr. Wolf's time as Secretary Nielsen's top adviser. However, the Department has failed to comply, leaving Congress without the information needed to fully and fairly evaluate Mr. Wolf's qualifications to serve as Under Secretary, let alone run the entire Department of Homeland Security.

Unfortunately, this disregard for Congress's constitutional role as a check on the executive branch is not an isolated occurrence. Instead, it appears to be a defining feature of this administration.

The Constitution requires that the President's nominees to hold key positions receive the advice and consent of the Senate. The Framers knew this arrangement was necessary to ensure that those who hold the most powerful and influential positions in government are accountable not solely to the President but to Congress and, most importantly, to the American people.

However, this President has shown a willingness to abandon the foundational principle of advice and consent and to test the limits of his legal authority to unilaterally install acting officials of his choosing. This has resulted in far too many critical positions going unfilled.

At the Department of Homeland Security, all three top positions—Secretary, Deputy Secretary, and Under Secretary for Management have been vacant for more than 7 months, and the President has yet to name a nominee for any of those roles. Other key DHS components have seen temporary leaders come and go for months—even years—without a nominee for the Senate to consider. This President has declared that he prefers ''acting'' officials because it ''gives [him] more flexibility.''

Leadership turnover and acting officials are a part of every administration, but widespread and deliberate reliance on temporary leaders defies the constitutional principle of advice and consent, harms the Department's critical national security missions, and puts the American people at risk. The dedicated men and women at DHS who are working tirelessly to keep our country safe deserve much better. The American people deserve much better.

To his credit, I believe Mr. Wolf recognizes the untenable situation caused by the President's refusal to submit nominees to the Department's highest offices. When asked about the impact of vacancies across the top ranks of DHS, he stated ''I believe having Senate-confirmed leaders in the senior levels of any cabinet agency is a benefit to the morale of the workforce and the success of the agency.''

I continue to urge the President to nominate qualified, principled leaders to lead the Department of Homeland Security. I remain committed to working with my colleagues on both sides of the aisle to carry out our constitutional duty to provide advice and consent by promptly, fairly, and thoroughly vetting the President's nominees. I am also committed to working across the aisle in Congress to ensure that the Department of Homeland Security has the resources and authorities it needs to keep Americans safe and to provide oversight—robust oversight—of the Department's actions and use of taxpayer dollars.

I have sought to fully and carefully weigh Mr. Wolf's qualifications for Policy Under Secretary. Unfortunately, due to the lack of transparency in Mr. Wolf's involvement in very troubling Department decisions, I cannot support his current nomination, much less his elevation to Acting Secretary.

If he is confirmed, I will do my part to support Mr. Wolf and help him be successful in an incredibly important job while also working to hold him accountable. But today, I will be voting no on his confirmation, and I urge my colleagues to do the same.

I yield the floor.

I suggest the absence of a quorum.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The clerk will call the roll.

The legislative clerk proceeded to call the roll.

Mr. CRAPO. Mr. President, I ask unanimous consent that the order for the quorum call be rescinded.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Without objection, it is so ordered.

CLOTURE MOTION

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Pursuant to rule XXII, the Chair lays before the Senate the pending cloture motion, which the clerk will state.

The legislative clerk read as follows:

CLOTURE MOTION

We, the undersigned Senators, in accordance with the provisions of rule XXII of the Standing Rules of the Senate, do hereby move to bring to a close debate on the nomination of Chad F. Wolf, of Virginia, to be Under Secretary for Strategy, Policy, and Plans, Department of Homeland Security. (New Position).

Mitch McConnell, Roger F. Wicker, Mike Rounds, Rick Scott, John Barrasso, Kevin Cramer, Richard Burr, Steve Daines, James E. Risch, John Cornyn, John Boozman, John Hoeven, James Lankford, Todd Young, David Perdue, John Thune, Lamar Alexander.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. By unanimous consent, the mandatory quorum call has been waived.

The question is, Is it the sense of the Senate that debate on the nomination of Chad F. Wolf, of Virginia, to be Under Secretary for Strategy, Policy, and Plans, Department of Homeland Security, shall be brought to a close?

The yeas and nays are mandatory under the rule.

The clerk will call the roll.

The legislative clerk called the roll.

(Ms. ERNST assumed the Chair.)

Mr. THUNE. The following Senator is necessarily absent: the Senator from South Dakota (Mr. ROUNDS).

Mr. DURBIN. I announce that the Senator from New Jersey (Mr. BOOKER), the Senator from California (Ms. HARRIS), the Senator from Rhode Island (Mr. REED), the Senator from Vermont (Mr. SANDERS), and the Senator from Massachusetts (Ms. WARREN) are necessarily absent.

The PRESIDING OFFICER (Ms. MCSALLY). Are there any other Senators in the Chamber desiring to vote?

The yeas and nays resulted—yeas 54, nays 40, as follows:

[Rollcall Vote No. 353 Ex.]

YEAS—54

Alexander	Fischer	Paul
Barrasso	Gardner	Perdue
Blackburn	Graham	Portman
Blunt	Grassley	Risch
Boozman	Hawley	Roberts
Braun	Hoeven	Romney
Burr	Hyde-Smith	Rubio
Capito	Inhofe	Sasse
Cassidy	Isakson	Scott (FL)
Collins	Johnson	Scott (SC)
Cornyn	Kennedy	Shelby
Cotton	Lankford	Sinema
Cramer	Lee	Sullivan
Crapo	Manchin	Thune
Cruz	McConnell	Tillis
Daines	McSally	Toomey
Enzi	Moran	Wicker
Ernst	Murkowski	Young

NAYS—40

Baldwin	Hassan	Rosen
Bennet	Heinrich	Schatz
Blumenthal	Hirono	Schumer
Brown	Jones	Shaheen
Cantwell	Kaine	Smith
Cardin	King	Stabenow
Carper	Klobuchar	Tester
Casey	Leahy	Udall
Coons	Markey	Van Hollen
Cortez Masto	Menendez	Warner
Duckworth	Merkley	Whitehouse
Durbin	Murphy	Wyden
Feinstein	Murray	
Gillibrand	Peters	

NOT VOTING—6

Booker	Reed	Sanders
Harris	Rounds	Warren

The PRESIDING OFFICER. On this vote, the yeas 54, the nays are 40.

The motion is agreed to.

JUDICIAL CONFIRMATIONS

Ms. BLACKBURN. Madam President, over the past few months, pro-democracy protestors in Hong Kong have captivated the American consciousness with one of the most stunning mass protests in recent memory. Hong Kong people are no strangers to suppression. They are used to the censorship, digital stalking, and persecution embraced by their overlords in Beijing, and they have seen firsthand the dangers of tyranny.

Watching these protests play out got me thinking about the core values that

we as the American people share with the Hong Kong people and with so many others around the globe. There is really an interesting dichotomy at play: You can turn on the TV right now and see an entire population fighting desperately on behalf of free speech, self-expression, and the right to question their leaders' decisions.

Meanwhile, just a few countries away, the loudest voices in the newsroom are begging for just the opposite. Here in the U.S., Americans are constantly being asked if freedom is really worth the fight. Is it worth the never-ending battle to maintain it? The answer is absolutely.

When Americans look at the protests in Hong Kong, they do not see a foreign policy gray area; they see scores of revolutionaries fighting an evil regime. They identify with the disrupters, and they cheer for the underdogs who do not pull their punches, which is why, in 2016, they sent a disrupter to the White House.

They watch the hysteria that is cable news commentary and get the sense that the people on the screen have completely missed the point. The fight is not and never will be about one person or one movement. It is about the decision to protect liberty or to let liberty die; to protect justice or to let it die. To dismiss this point is to disparage the most important feature of the collaborative American psyche. When asked if freedom is worth fighting for, the answer will always be yes.

The calculus flows into discussions on almost every aspect of American life. Most recently, at home and in this Chamber, debate has centered on the ideological makeup of the Federal judiciary. We have repeatedly asked ourselves: Will the judges we are confirming respect and protect the core values of the American people? The answer is yes, they absolutely will.

This is not the first time the American public has swung back around to consider our ''first principles.'' We talked about them in the early 90s and again—perhaps more passionately—in the early 2000s. Last week, I was fortunate enough to attend an event at the White House celebrating our success in confirming well-qualified, constitutionalist judges to the Federal bench. We have filled 158 vacancies since 2017, and we are far from done.

I am sure, however, that my friends in the minority wish we would give it a rest, but we won't. After all, they have had to work overtime trying to convince the American people that our job is to impose by judicial decree policies that were rejected at the ballot box. They want to do this without the benefit of legislative debate or public comment, which means that confirming constitutionalist judges is far from being in their best interest.

So here they come, insisting that ''constitutionalist'' is a dog whistle for racism, sexism, homophobia, and holding regressive and extreme ideas.

What a ridiculous strategy. The bipartisan nominees this body has confirmed proved they are capable of resisting the urge to get creative with the law when it suits the loudest voices in the room. Instead, they apply the same foresight employed by the Founding Fathers. These judges know that permitting the government more powers to mold and manipulate society will give rise to a government that will never resist the temptation to overstep its bounds.

Our courts are not courts of public opinion, and my friends in the minority would do well to remember the cost of treating them as such. Constitutionalism is our legacy and our inheritance. I urge my colleagues to remember this because we are going to vote to confirm judges who have proven themselves committed to defending our core values and the rule of law in the United States of America.

Madam President, I yield the floor.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The Senator from Oklahoma.

Mr. INHOFE. Madam President, I ask unanimous consent that I be recognized as in morning business for such time as I use.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Without objection.

CHINA

Mr. INHOFE. Madam President, I am here today to talk about an important vote that I took 19 years ago, a vote about free trade from China. Now, you might say it is a little out of character, coming down to the floor and talking about free trade and China, because normally I am down here talking about how China is investing in their military at unprecedented rates or how they are passing us up in terms of our military, which we saw in the last administration.

The reality is that when it comes to China—which is entirely controlled by a tyrannical Communist party—you cannot separate their trade behavior from their military like you can in a democratic government. China asserts its power both economically and militarily to the detriment of the free world.

So 19 years ago, I came down to the Senate floor and took a stand against the tyrannical regime in China. The vote was on whether or not to allow the Chinese Government normalized trade relationships with the United States that would pave the way for China to join the World Trade Organization.

At that time, it was not popular—it was not popular for any Member of the Senate who stood in the way of free trade agreements, much less a Republican. But as I saw it then, the vote did much more than open up trade. It granted favors to an authoritarian regime, despite their openly predatory actions, without demanding concessions in return. My colleagues claimed that opening China to free trade would cause China to change their behavior. Clearly, that did not happen, but I will get to that in a minute.

Filled with the false hope and empty promises, the trade agreement sailed through the Senate, 83 to 15, and was signed by then-President Clinton. Now, I am the only one of those 15 ''no'' votes still serving in the United States Senate. Today, 19 years later, we have seen the reality of what I thought would happen. At the time, I said—and I am quoting from my speech 19 years ago—''We cannot allow the pursuit of dollars to blind us to certain realities about the ruling communist regime in China, including''—keep in mind, I am going to read all eight of these that I had mentioned 19 years ago—''repeated threats against the United States and Taiwan''—still going on today; ''massive military modernization and buildup''—still going on; ''proliferation of dangerous weapons to rogue states. Theft of U.S. nuclear secrets''—still going on; ''demonstrated strategy to exploit commercial relationships to acquire advanced military technology,'' that is still going on today; ''attempts to corrupt the U.S. political system. Violation of international agreements. Brutal repression of dissidents.'' We know that is happening.

I continued: ''To ignore these actions in the belief that they can be separated from what we do in our trading relationship is dangerously misguided. China's trade surpluses are helping to finance the regime's military buildup and aggressive foreign policy, while strengthening its hold on economic and political power.''

I do not take any pride in being right, because the outcome has been devastating for the American workers. China has stolen our technology and personnel secrets and taken millions of U.S. jobs over the past two decades. The facts today show it.

Let's go through quickly a few of what we predicted two decades ago and see where we are today. First, the threats against the United States and Taiwan, that is pretty clear. Just look at China's reaction to the recent routine arms sale to Taiwan of tanks and Stinger missiles. Keep in mind, China has known since 1979 that we sell arms to Taiwan to aid in their self-defense. Everyone knows that.

They threatened that they were prepared to go to war to defend their ''unity and territorial integrity''—over a routine arms sale. In the past year alone, Beijing has frequently threatened to use force against any who opposed the Communist Party's designs on Taiwan, so despite free trade, China has not stopped their threatening behavior toward the United States and Taiwan.

Secondly, massive military modernization and buildup. We know that is still going on. It is obvious to everyone that China has not changed their behavior on this because of free trade. It has emboldened them. China has become more aggressive as our free trade system has subsidized their economy.

Some key facts: Over the last decade, the Chinese Government has grown their military spending—look at the chart when I read this—has grown their

military spending by 83 percent. That is over the last decade. Meanwhile, during the last 5 years of the Obama administration, we decreased our military spending by 25 percent. We decreased our military spending while China had increased theirs by 83 percent.

That is why, today, China is able to build ships at a faster rate than we are and is on pace to surpass the number of vessels by 2030. That is why China is investing heavily in cyber capabilities, aviation, artillery, and hypersonic weapons—hypersonic weapons, the most sophisticated new weapons they have, the weapons that move at five times the speed of sound. Actually, before the Obama administration, we were ahead of both China and Russia. At the end of that administration, we are behind them, and we are catching up now. Each capability, if not superior to ours, has the potential to do us significant harm.

In 2018, I visited our allies in Southeast Asia, where I saw the Chinese military buildup in the South China Sea for myself.

You remember the islands they created. This is not taking over territory; it is creating territory because those islands weren't there. They have islands in the South China Sea. The Chinese, at last count, I believe, were at seven islands. When you go in and look at it, you become convinced they are preparing for a world war III.

China, prior to that time—this is only 3 years ago—had always done their military in their home territory. It has always been in China until they went in Djibouti—that is the northern part of Africa—and they started their own activity there. Now they are all the way down to Tanzania, in that part of the world.

The Department of Defense official expects the Chinese to open more bases, too, in the Middle East, in China, in Southeast Asia, and in the Pacific. They are all strategically important locations.

When I talked to our allies in the Pacific, they are concerned, and many are beginning to hedge their bets because they see what China is doing. We are talking about the South China Sea. We are talking about our own allies who have historically been our allies. All of a sudden, they are starting to have second thoughts. They are seeing what China is doing, but they don't see us doing anything. After 8 years of President Obama's weak leadership, it is getting more difficult for us to prove to them that we are actually interested in standing up to China's aggression.

Third, the theft of U.S. secrets—we know about that. There is an old saying: What China doesn't have, it steals. That is even more apparent today than it was in 2000. China is still actively pursuing and stealing some of our most valuable military secrets. Just last year, China hacked a Navy contractor and stole massive amounts of classified data. That practice isn't new, but it is still having serious impacts on our ability to get ahead of China's militarily.

We are seeing an alarming rise in how China steals industrial secrets. They do it out in the open—for example, by forcing any American business that wants to operate in China to form a partnership with a Chinese business. They have been doing that for a long period of time, and we have been going along with it. Sadly, these partnerships are nothing more than a way for the Chinese Communist Party to access and steal proprietary ideas and technology.

They also do it in nefarious ways—through exploiting educational relationships on college campuses or stealing biomedical research during the peer-review process.

This is no small thing. One in five American companies has been a victim of Chinese intellectual property theft. That matters because nearly 80 percent of our economy is based on intangibles—the very things the Chinese are stealing.

It is safe to say that this is another area where the regime in Beijing has been emboldened by free trade at the expense of American innovation and economic growth.

China hasn't changed its position on exploiting commercial relationships either. For the past two decades, China has taken advantage of countries—weaponizing their debt and working to control ports, infrastructure, and other territory, posing a very real threat to U.S. interests. There is no place where this is more apparent than in Africa, where I keep hearing: ''America will tell you what you need; China will build it for you.'' Of course, they don't follow through and talk about how they use all Chinese resources to do this. They use Chinese labor. But it is of no value to Africa.

I have been to Africa probably more than any other Member, as I have been very active in that area and have seen some of the threats that face us on that continent, and I have seen the Chinese debt trap hobble more promising governments.

But it goes far beyond the developing world and extends right into our own backyard. Just look at the recent issue with the NBA, where the general manager of the Houston Rockets tweeted a message in support of the Hong Kong protesters. The backlash was swift. China stopped airing Rockets games or streaming them online, and their online retailers pulled merchandise from online stores.

We have also seen U.S. hotels, aviation companies—even the Gap—being forced to edit and self-censor to remove any reference that even tangentially refers to Taiwan, Tibet, or Hong Kong not being a part of the People's Republic China, all to appease the Communist Party. The jewelry company Tiffany was pressured to remove an advertisement of a woman covering her eye because images of a protester in Hong Kong with a wounded eye got international attention.

We live in a democracy, and we don't dictate to private businesses what they should or should not do. This is not the case in China. Yet, if we continue down the road of self-censorship, the party's demands will escalate, and it will be harder and harder to exercise freedom of expression.

Fourth, lastly, brutal repression of dissidents—that was true 19 years ago, and it is true today. More than anything, I would like to say this was an area where free trade had forced the Chinese Communist Party to change its behavior. That is what we were all told would happen, but it didn't happen. We know it is not true.

We all know about the atrocities that are going on in Xinjiang Province, where the government is forcing a Muslim minority into concentration camps, although they call them reeducation centers. We all know what is going on in Hong Kong, where Beijing is repressing a democratic demonstration with brutal tactics. I remember being in Hong Kong at the time China reasserted what they call their leadership, their ownership, to Hong Kong. It has been on and off all these years. Right now, that effort—disagreement is still taking place.

Outside of the areas that, despite China's best efforts, have attracted international attention, we still know about the atrocities the Chinese Communist Party quietly inflicts on journalists and Christian minorities in house churches and in communities across China every day.

I have just painted a very bleak picture of U.S.-China relations and how unrestricted trade didn't force the ruling party in Beijing to change its behavior, but the good news is, help is finally on the way. After the trade deal was enacted—I am talking about President Trump's trade deal—I kept speaking out against the Chinese Communist Party, calling attention to their human rights abuses, their military buildup, their manipulative trade tactics, and their economic bullying. I pushed every President until now to stand up to the economic powerhouse before it was too late and they outmatched us. I tried that with Republicans and Democrats alike, and it didn't work.

Now we have the first President since 2000 to take China seriously. President Trump is clear-eyed about the regime in Beijing. He knows that our trade relations have been unfair and imbalanced, and he understands that we need real and permanent fixes in order to have any long-term stability. This is something that has been going on for a long period of time, and he is now changing this. He is getting criticized, obviously.

I have to say this: It hurts our farmers in the State of Oklahoma. However, I would say that they are very understanding that someone is finally willing to take on China.

He has effectively applied tariffs, both to punish the Chinese Government for its manipulative trade practices and also to support critical industries in the United States.

The result: China's economy has slowed to its lowest point since 1992—and that is if you believe their official numbers. These are their numbers. It has slowed down their economy. That has not happened before.

The economic pressure brought them to the table, ready to make a real deal—one that is fair and accountable. So far, we have gotten phase 1—a preliminary first deal—and the outcome is good for farmers in Oklahoma and across the country. For the first time, China has agreed to purchase $40 billion to $50 billion worth of American agricultural goods. That would be the highest level since 2012. That is a good start.

The fight against China's economic manipulation and influence is not over. It can't just be limited to shrinking the trade deficit through greater purchases of American goods. Future parts of any agreement need to be sure to address the concerns that Presidents of both parties neglected for decades, including theft of intellectual property and industrial secrets, forced technology transfer, reciprocal access to markets, and subsidies to China's state-owned enterprises.

All of this needs to be placed into the proper context of the Communist Party's ambitions on the world stage: to rewrite the rules of the international system, to make the world safe for authorities to suppress democracy and abuse human rights, and to achieve global military superiority by midcentury.

President Trump's stand against China on trade has provoked a lot of discussion about our competition with China. We have to remember that this is not a competition against China but a competition for influence—the kind of influence that decides what kind of world our kids and grandkids are going to live in. Next week, my wife and I will be celebrating our 60th wedding anniversary. We have 20 kids and grandkids. They are the ones who will be living in that world I just described.

In this competition, we can't afford to be naive. The Chinese Communist Party has a very different version of the world it would like to create, so even as we keep talking about the tariffs, we have to remember that our values are still America's most precious commodity. It is our values—free people and truly free markets—that must guide us in the competition ahead.

Every part of this speech I gave on the Senate floor 19 years ago has become a reality, and President Trump knows this. Maybe we better listen to him.

With that, I yield the floor.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The Senator from New Jersey.

Mr. MENENDEZ. Madam President, I am going to yield the floor.

LEGISLATIVE SESSION

MORNING BUSINESS

Mr. INHOFE. Mr. President, I ask unanimous consent that the Senate proceed to legislative session and be in a period of morning business, with Senators permitted to speak therein for up to 10 minutes each.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Without objection, it is so ordered.

SMALL REFINERY WAIVERS AND ETHANOL

Mr. DURBIN. Madam President, on behalf of the corn and soybean farmers in my State, I object to ''small refinery relief language'' in the fiscal year 2020 Interior appropriations bill that suggests that the Environmental Protection Agency, EPA, disregard Department of Energy determinations on small refinery hardships. The provision encourages EPA to continue allowing refiners to stop blending biofuels with no transparency or evidence of hardship.

Fourteen years ago in this Chamber, I helped enact the renewable fuels standard, RFS, which required petroleum-based vehicle fuels to include a minimum volume of ethanol and biodiesel in them. Both fuels are produced from corn and soybeans, driving economic activity throughout Illinois and the Midwest.

The law has been a tremendous success. We have created new markets for corn and soybeans and helped supply motorists with affordable fuel. We have provided a greener alternative to MTBE and other additives. And now the United States is the world's largest producer of ethanol, generating commerce and creating jobs, both on and off the farm.

In fact, I can hardly think of a national policy in this generation that has achieved greater success for rural economic growth than biofuels. In the wake of the gasoline shortages of the 1970s, the farm financial crisis of the 1980s, the clean air discussions of the 1990s, the oil price spikes of the 2000s, and rural economic conditions of today, biofuels became part of the solution. For more than 40 years, farmers and policymakers built an industry unique to the heartland of this country.

Yet in just 2 years, President Trump has wrestled American biofuels to its knees. He singlehandedly has delivered one crippling blow after another. Each action he has taken contributes to the gradual dismantling of this enterprise. With his involvement, or outright neglect, ethanol prices, profits, and blending are the lowest in history, and thousands of rural jobs have been lost.

The President claims his support for ethanol and biodiesel is strong. I say: believe it when you see it. Because when this President issues declarations of victory on biofuels, facilities stay shuttered and the markets stay stalled.

Congressional frustration on this topic is bipartisan and growing, although some farm State lawmakers and interests still stare at their shoes while a President who shares their political affiliation burns this industry to the ground. Long after the alarm bells were ringing and klaxons were sounding, those who should have known better at the outset, whose earlier responses were accolades, now find themselves at path's end, hoodwinked.

As a member of the Senate Agriculture Committee, I pressed the EPA to approve E15, a 15 percent blend of ethanol in gasoline, for year-round sales as soon as possible. And I applauded that final decision in June. For Illinois, E15 could boost 14 ethanol facilities and 20,000 downstate jobs. For motorists, E15 could save up to 10 cents per gallon.

But pull back the curtain, and the President has allowed EPA to issue 85 secret waivers that allow oil refineries to stop blending biofuels into gasoline. Economists have confirmed that shatters demand for E15. Waivers mean that E15 is a fake victory by President Trump.

After increasing pressure and outcry, on October 4, President Trump publicized an agreement ostensibly designed to restore the lost ethanol demand caused by his waivers back to the 15 billion gallon floor—even 16 billion gallons, claimed the President. Ten days later, the Trump administration stunned observers by publishing details that watered down these numbers and slashed the ethanol deal by half, while stakeholders were coached that nothing has changed.

The language in the Interior appropriations bill suggests that EPA continue to thumb its nose at corn and soybean producers while issuing small oil refinery waivers. Meanwhile, Big Oil is doing just fine. In May, the Department of Energy reported that net income for top U.S. oil companies like Exxon and Chevron has totaled $28 billion, the most profitable in five years. For farmers, however, net income has plummeted 50 percent from its record highs during the Obama administration.

For years, farmers and policymakers of multiple backgrounds and persuasions have come together, in good faith, to carefully build a new industry that benefits consumers, farmers, and rural residents. This pioneering innovation is rooted in the heritage of rural values, all in jeopardy of crumbling because the void between this President's words and acts.

I urge my colleagues to work to support rural America by ending EPA's efforts to issue these waivers without any concern for transparency or economic impact.

Ms. STABENOW. Mr. President, I support the sentiments of my colleague from Illinois in objecting to the ''small refinery relief'' language in the fiscal year 2020 Interior appropriations bill. In the past, this language has been invoked by the Trump administration's

Environmental Protection Agency, EPA, to disregard the Department of Energy's recommendations regarding small refinery hardships under the renewable fuel standard, RFS, and waive additional gallons of renewable fuels from our fuel supply. These actions, permitted by President Trump, hurt rural America and our farmers.

The RFS is an important driver of Michigan jobs and our bio-based economy. This Administration's continued abuse of refinery waivers undermine the integrity of the RFS program and hurt our farmers, biofuel producers, and rural communities in Michigan and across the country. I strongly oppose this report language and encourage my colleagues to support rural America's interests by calling to end the Trump administration's abuse of small refinery exemptions.

Ms. SMITH. Mr. President, I would like to add my support to the statement given by my colleague from Illinois. On behalf of the corn and soybean farmers in my State and on behalf of the biofuel industry in my State, I strongly oppose the ''small refinery relief'' language in the fiscal year 2020 Interior appropriations bill. This ''relief language'' will allow the EPA to continue to exempt refiners from blending biofuels without any evidence of actual hardship.

Small refinery waivers from the EPA are wreaking havoc on our Nation's rural economy. Across the country, ethanol plants and biodiesel plants are halting production or being forced to shut down. These biofuel plants often are the local cornerstone of the community, supporting thousands of rural jobs across the country, and serving as important markets for farmers to process millions of bushels of corn, soybeans, and other commodities. Farmers are struggling after years of low prices, extreme weather and a chaotic trade agenda, and instead of providing certainty and relief for our farmers, this administration chose to destroy more markets and further harm rural communities.

The problems caused by small-refinery waiver abuse are seen across the upper Midwest, but they hit the agricultural communities in my state of Minnesota particularly hard. Two months ago, the Corn Plus ethanol plant in Winnebago closed. When I traveled there, I talked to farmers and community members and heard directly about how the loss of that facility will impact their lives. The Corn Plus plant closed, but throughout Minnesota ethanol plants are idling and cutting back, impacting workers and hurting local farmers. For example, a recent Renewable Fuels Association analysis of the impact of idling at the Green Plains plant in Fairmont, MN, found that local corn prices were reduced, leading to an $8.4 million loss for local farmers who typically sell to the plant.

Last week, Tim Rudnicki, executive director for the Minnesota Bio-Fuels Association traveled to Michigan to testify at the EPA public hearing on their wholly inadequate Trump administration proposed ''fix'' to the waiver abuse problems. In Mr. Rudnicki's remarks, he said that the current EPA is ''driving renewable biofuels backwards and toward the cliff.'' I couldn't agree more. This has to stop, and Congress needs to make it stop because it has become clear that the current Administration has put big oil ahead of our farmers and our rural communities.

In the wake of the EPA's continued efforts to undercut the integrity of the RFS by misusing its waiver authority, I urge my colleagues to support this country's rural communities by ending the EPA's abuse of the small refinery exemptions.

Ms. KLOBUCHAR. Mr. President, I join my colleagues today in expressing my opposition to the language in the fiscal year 2020 Interior appropriations bill related to the Environmental Protection Agency's ability to issue small refinery waivers under the renewable fuel standard without taking into account the Department of Energy's recommendations.

The Trump administration continues to undermine the renewable fuel standard by granting small refinery waivers to multi-billion-dollar oil companies. Since the beginning of the administration, a total of 85 waivers have been issued, reducing demand for more than 4 billion gallons of renewable fuel. That is why I have repeatedly called on the Trump administration to stop issuing any further waivers, immediately reallocate the remaining gallons, and make public the information regarding any recipients of these exemptions.

We need more transparency and openness about the Environmental Protection Agency's, EPA, use of small refinery waivers—who is applying for and receiving them, how are they documenting their economic hardship, and how is EPA considering that hardship in the context of interagency recommendations. The ''small refinery relief'' provision in the appropriations bill will allow EPA to avoid answering these questions and continue issuing waivers without providing evidence of hardship.

It is for this reason that I am opposed to the ''small refinery relief'' language in the fiscal year 2020 Interior appropriations bill. While the administration must cease issuing any further improper refinery exemptions, as I have been calling for since these abuses began, we can start supporting our farmers and rural communities by removing this harmful provision from the Interior appropriations bill during conference negotiations. Especially at a time when they are facing trade uncertainty, low prices, and difficult weather, our farmers deserve better.

IMMIGRATION

Mr. LEAHY. Madam President, today the Supreme Court heard arguments in one of the most consequential immigration cases in modern American history. The future of more than 700,000 DACA recipients—our Nation's Dreamers—hangs in the balance and their fate is inherently intertwined with the fate of the American Dream itself.

Dreamers, by definition, are law-abiding immigrants brought to the United States as children—through no choice of their own—now simply seeking the chance to contribute to the only country they have ever known as home. Dreamers, by definition, do not pose any kind of public safety or national security threat. They are our neighbors, our first responders, our defenders, and our teachers. Nearly a thousand Dreamers serve in our Armed Forces, risking their lives to preserve the freedoms of millions of American citizens. Dreamers are Americans in every way, except on paper. Americans know this, and have roundly rejected the baseless, un-American vitriol spread by President Trump—yet again this morning, just hours before the argument—that some Dreamers are ''hardened criminals.''

So it is no wonder that the overwhelming majority of Americans support providing legal protections to our Nation's Dreamers. And it is no surprise that leaders of industry in every major sector of our economy have called for providing legal status and a path to citizenship for Dreamers, recognizing their enormous contributions to our economy.

The depth of opposition to President Trump's decision to heartlessly terminate DACA is matched only by the breadth of agreement among courts that the Trump administration is just plain wrong on the law. Five out of six Federal courts that considered the Trump administration's effort to end DACA blocked President Trump from actually doing so and they have rejected the Trump administration's laughable argument that its decision to end DACA is simply unreviewable by the courts.

I am hopeful that the Supreme Court sides with the near unanimous consensus among lower courts. I am hopeful that it joins the united chorus of Americans who envision a legally protected place in our society for this group of immigrants that embodies the American dream.

Regardless of how the Supreme Court rules, Congress is by no means a bystander. Congress still has the authority and the responsibility to do what is right. Just a few months ago, the House passed a bipartisan bill, the American Dream and Promise Act, which would enact critical protections for Dreamers and provide temporary safe haven to targeted groups of immigrants whose home countries have been crippled by natural disasters or civil conflict. The Senate could easily take up this bill today or it could take up the bipartisan Senate bill, the Dream Act of 2019, authored by Senators GRAHAM and DURBIN, which would provide

meaningful safeguards to our Dreamers. Either way, Senate inaction is simply not acceptable to the millions of Americans in both parties who see the prospect of mass deportations of Dreamers as antithetical to who we are as the United States of America.

As we wait for our Nation's highest Court to rule on this case, it is essential for Americans to express their views about the future of Dreamers to their elected representatives. This case, after all, is not just about the specific Dreamers who would benefit from DACA's continued existence, and it not just about the Trump administration's anti-immigrant impulses and policies. This is about whether our proud past as a nation of immigrants and refugees—a country that became one out of many—has a bright future. That future should not be left solely to the courts nor should it be left to languish in Majority Leader MCCONNELL's legislative graveyard. This future will be shaped, in part, by what we choose to do now, in the present and it is beyond time for the Senate to come together and do what is right.

(At the request of Mr. SCHUMER following statement was ordered to be printed in the RECORD.)

VOTE EXPLANATION

● Mr. REED. Madam President, I was unavoidably absent for the vote this evening due to a delayed flight. Had I been present, I would have voted no on cloture on the nomination of Executive Calendar No. 87, Chad F. Wolf to be Under Secretary for Strategy, Policy, and Plans, Department of Homeland Security.●

REMEMBERING KAY HAGAN

Mr. ISAKSON. Madam President, today I would like to remember in the RECORD former U.S. Senator Kay Hagan of North Carolina.

Senator Hagan and I served together on the Senate Committee on Health, Education, Labor, and Pensions, where she served both North Carolina and the United States well during her years in the Senate. We also worked together closely on housing issues affecting Americans as a result of the 2008 economic downturn and housing crisis.

Kay and I served as Senate coleaders of the annual Congressional Civil Rights Pilgrimage to historic sites of the civil rights movement in Alabama in 2013. I was honored to have her by my side along with U.S. Representative JOHN LEWIS of Georgia during this moving event, which culminated with an emotional crossing of the Edmund Pettus Bridge in Selma, where Congressman LEWIS was beaten during the 1965 march he led there. Upon return, Senator Hagan wrote about the moment Montgomery chief of police Kevin Murphy personally apologized to Congressman LEWIS on behalf of the Montgomery Police Department for the department's failure to protect the Freedom Riders while removing his police badge and presenting it to Congressman LEWIS. She shared how this experience served as an emotional reminder to her of the oath she took to protect and serve the people of North Carolina.

That was how Kay worked. That trip, along with our legislative efforts together in Washington, cemented the high respect I have had for her and her work on many issues affecting the Southeast.

I honor of Kay Hagan, I was proud to cosponsor a Senate resolution saluting her life and service.

I also hope she would have appreciated our vote to advance the Kay Hagan Tick Act in the Health, Education, Labor, and Pensions Committee. My older sister died at a very young age from the fatal results of a tick bite, and it was tragic to see Senator Hagan succumb to complications of the tickborne Powassan virus. This legislation was named for her to improve research, prevention, diagnostics and treatment for tick-borne diseases.

I appreciate her service to the country, and my prayers are with Chip, her family and all those who loved her. Her legacy will live on.

TRIBUTE TO STAFF SERGEANT DANIEL P. KELLER

Mr. PAUL. Madam President, I want to recognize the accomplishments of SSgt Daniel P. Keller for his heroic actions while in combat in Afghanistan. On 16 August 2017, while assigned as a joint terminal attack controller for Combined Joint Special Operations Air Component Afghanistan, Staff Sergeant Keller performed his duty to his country and his teammates with fierce determination and unquestionable courage.

While on a mission, his assault force struck an improvised explosive device and came under heavy fire from the enemy. Despite being wounded, Staff Sergeant Keller used his most potent weapon, the ability to call in airpower, to strike enemy positions while simultaneously returning fire with his personal weapon. Most admirably, Staff Sergeant Keller took direct action to ensure the successful evacuation of 13 critically wounded casualties while under continuous enemy fire. Upon saving his wounded comrades, Staff Sergeant Keller continued to engage the enemy and guaranteed follow-on forces were well prepared to continue the fight.

For his valiant service, Staff Sergeant Keller received the Air Force Cross, our Nation's second highest medal for combat valor. His citation for this award stated that ''his personal courage, quick actions and tactical expertise whilst under fire directly contributed to the survival of the 130 members of his assault force, including 31 wounded in action.''

I would like to offer my most profound appreciation to Staff Sergeant Keller for his willingness to go above and beyond the call of duty to ensure his mission while saving American lives. His courage and dedication should serve as an example to us all and remind us of our solemn duty to the men and women who volunteer to defend our great Nation.

ADDITIONAL STATEMENTS

TRIBUTE TO NANCY J. FLETCHER

● Mr. INHOFE. Mr. President, I rise to offer a tribute to Nancy J. Fletcher, a long-serving chief executive of a respected national trade association whose leadership has benefited Oklahoma and the Nation.

Nancy Fletcher led the Outdoor Advertising Association of America, now known as the Out of Home Advertising Association of America, for nearly 30 years as president and CEO.

An attorney, Ms. Fletcher shares my deep respect for property rights, as spelled out in the takings clause of the Fifth Amendment: private property shall not be taken for public use without just compensation.

Ahead of Ms. Fletcher's retirement, I recall some of her important contributions to the Nation and to Oklahoma. After the terrorist attacks on September 11, 2001, Ms. Fletcher and her colleagues in the industry immediately posted messages of national unity and resolve.

During her long leadership, technology changed all types of media, including out of home media. As some billboards were converted to digital electronic displays, Ms. Fletcher pioneered partnerships with law enforcement, emergency managers, and the National Center for Missing & Exploited Children. These partnerships, including with the National Weather Center in Norman, have had positive benefits for communicating emergency services, featuring tip lines to locate fugitives and share information to help missing children return home.

Please join me in extending congratulations to Nancy Fletcher for her successful leadership of the Outdoor Advertising Association of America and her contributions to the public good.●

50TH ANNIVERSARY OF ALABAMA AGRICULTURAL & MECHANICAL UNIVERSITY

● Mr. JONES. Madam President, I rise today to recognize Alabama Agricultural & Mechanical University, AAMU on their 50th anniversary as a university. As an 1890 land-grant institution and one of Alabama's 14 historically Black colleges and universities, HBCUs, Alabama A&M has long upheld a legacy of impressive scholarship and service. It is an honor to celebrate the achievements of an institution of such importance to my State.

Alabama A&M first opened its doors on May 1, 1875, as the Huntsville Normal School following its founding by a

former slave, Dr. William Hooper Councill. With just $1,000 in annual appropriations, 61 students, and 2 instructors in its first year, the institution evolved throughout multiple iterations of its 144-year history into what it is today. Due to its success with industrial education and private funding from the Slater and Peabody Funds, the Alabama Legislature authorized a name change to the ''State Normal and Industrial School in Huntsville.'' In 1891, the school became a recipient of the Federal land-grant fund in order to further fund training in agricultural and mechanical arts at the college level. Following several name changes and a location move from Huntsville to Normal, AL, the school became a junior college in 1919 under the name ''The State Agricultural and Mechanical Institute for Negroes.'' Twenty years later, the school was permitted by the State board of education to offer work at a senior college level. In 1941, the first graduation class since 1920 received bachelor degrees. The school became a fully accredited member of the association in 1963, following a ''Class A'' rating by the Southern Association of Colleges and Secondary Schools in 1946. Alabama Agricultural and Mechanical University received its final name on June 26, 1969, per a resolution from the Alabama State Board of Education.

The campus, situated on The Hill near downtown Huntsville, has received visits from 19 Nobel laureates. Students at AAMU have access to advanced degree programs including Ph.D. degrees in applied physics, food science, plant and soil science, and reading and literacy. Alabama A&M University is one of the leading producers of African Americans with PhDs in physics.

AAMU has also graduated many notable alumni from star athletes, to world class entertainers, to leaders and pioneers in the civil rights movement. Jearl Miles-Clark, an Olympic Gold medalist who competed in the 400 and 800 meter races and the 400 meter relay, graduated from AAMU in 1989. NFL legend, John Stallworth, played football at AAMU and was an All-Southern Intercollegiate Athletic Conference receiver in 1972 and 1973 before joining the NFL as a wide receiver for the Pittsburgh Steelers. Stallworth went on to compete in four Super Bowls and was inducted into the Pro Football Hall of Fame in 2002. American Idol winner and popular R&B artist Ruben Studdard received a football scholarship to attend AAMU, where he majored in music education. Joseph Lowery, a United Methodist minister and leader in the civil rights movement, also attended AAMU. Lowery later succeeded Martin Luther King, Jr, as the third president of the Southern Christian Leadership Conference. Vivian Malone Jones, one of the first two Black students to enroll at the University of Alabama, earned her first bachelor's degree from AAMU in business education. She later went on to receive the first bachelor's degree awarded by the University of Alabama to a Black student, following her study of business management. These are only a handful of the remarkable scholars and activists, AAMU has had a hand in educating and training.

Under the leadership of its 11th president, Dr. Andrew Hugine, Jr., the university comprises over 70 buildings on more than 1,000 acres, is home to more than 6,000 students, is a designated ''Gold Military Friendly'' institution and serves as a regional, State, national, and international resource while maintaining its mission of educating the underserved and uplifting the people of Alabama, the Nation, and the world through excellence in education.

Please join me in celebrating Alabama A&M on this auspicious occasion and wishing both their students, faculty, and administrators future success in all of their endeavors for another 50 years.●

RECOGNIZING MAC'S VACS

● Mr. RISCH. Madam President, as a member and former chairman of the Senate Committee on Small Business and Entrepreneurship, each month I recognize and celebrate the American entrepreneurial spirit by highlighting the success of a small business in my home State of Idaho. However, in honor of Veterans Day on November 11, this month I will honor a veteran-owned small business for each of the 10 days the Senate is in legislative session. The personal sacrifices made by America's veterans have protected the very freedoms and values that give each of us and our children the ability to achieve the American dream. The skills veterans learn as members of the military are invaluable and undoubtedly contribute to Idaho's flourishing veteran business community. I am proud of the sacrifices veterans have made to protect our country and that they are choosing Idaho to call home when they complete their service in the military.

As your U.S. Senator from the great State of Idaho, it is my pleasure to recognize Mac's Vacs in Lewiston as the Idaho Small Business of the Day for November 12, 2019. Mac's Vacs was founded in 1950 and is owned and operated by U.S. Air Force veteran Dennis Prine. The company first opened in a garage and has since moved into a local storefront in the same neighborhood. After serving in the Air Force, Prine acquired Mac's Vacs in the 1980s and has expanded and improved its services since.

Mac's Vacs offers a variety of appliance services for customers, including vacuum sales and service, central vacuum systems, commercial chemicals, and more. Prine even offers technical assistance through a YouTube channel. The company's mission to provide quality products, knowledge, and service to customers has proven fundamental to the success of the business.

Congratulations to Dennis Prine and all of the employees at Mac's Vacs for being selected as the Veteran-owned Idaho Small Business of the Day for November 12, 2019. You make our great State proud, and I look forward to your continued growth and success.●

MESSAGES FROM THE PRESIDENT

Messages from the President of the United States were communicated to the Senate by Ms. Roberts, one of his secretaries.

EXECUTIVE MESSAGES REFERRED

In executive session the Presiding Officer laid before the Senate messages from the President of the United States submitting sundry nominations which were referred to the appropriate committees.

(The messages received today are printed at the end of the Senate proceedings.)

PRESIDENTIAL MESSAGES

REPORT RELATIVE TO THE CONTINUATION OF THE NATIONAL EMERGENCY THAT WAS ORIGINALLY DECLARED IN EXECUTIVE ORDER 12938 OF NOVEMBER 14, 1994, WITH RESPECT TO THE PROLIFERATION OF WEAPONS OF MASS DESTRUCTION—PM 36

The PRESIDING OFFICER laid before the Senate the following message from the President of the United States, together with an accompanying report; which was referred to the Committee on Banking, Housing, and Urban Affairs:

To the Congress of the United States:

Section 202(d) of the National Emergencies Act (50 U.S.C. 1622(d)) provides for the automatic termination of a national emergency unless, within 90 days before the anniversary date of its declaration, the President publishes in the *Federal Register* and transmits to the Congress a notice stating that the emergency is to continue in effect beyond the anniversary date. In accordance with this provision, I have sent to the *Federal Register* for publication the enclosed notice, stating that the national emergency with respect to the proliferation of weapons of mass destruction that was declared in Executive Order 12938 of November 14, 1994, is to continue in effect beyond November 14, 2019.

DONALD J. TRUMP.

THE WHITE HOUSE, *November 12, 2019*.

REPORT RELATIVE TO THE CONTINUATION OF THE NATIONAL EMERGENCY THAT WAS ORIGINALLY DECLARED IN EXECUTIVE ORDER 12170 OF NOVEMBER 14, 1979, WITH RESPECT TO IRAN—PM 37

The PRESIDING OFFICER laid before the Senate the following message from the President of the United States, together with an accompanying report; which was referred to the Committee on Banking, Housing, and Urban Affairs:

To the Congress of the United States:

Section 202(d) of the National Emergencies Act (50 U.S.C. 1622(d)) provides for the automatic termination of a national emergency unless, within 90 days before the anniversary date of its declaration, the President publishes in the *Federal Register* and transmits to the Congress a notice stating that the emergency is to continue in effect beyond the anniversary date. In accordance with this provision, I have sent to the *Federal Register* for publication the enclosed notice stating that the national emergency with respect to Iran declared in Executive Order 12170 of November 14, 1979, is to continue in effect beyond November 14, 2019.

Our relations with Iran have not yet normalized, and the process of implementing the agreements with Iran, dated January 19, 1981, is ongoing. For this reason, I have determined that it is necessary to continue the national emergency declared in Executive Order 12170 with respect to Iran.

DONALD J. TRUMP.

THE WHITE HOUSE, *November 12, 2019*.

MEASURES READ THE FIRST TIME

The following bill was read the first time:

S. 2840. A bill to authorize appropriations for fiscal year 2020 for military activities of the Department of Defense, for military construction, and for defense activities of the Department of Energy, and for other purposes.

REPORTS OF COMMITTEES

The following reports of committees were submitted:

By Mr. JOHNSON, from the Committee on Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs, with an amendment in the nature of a substitute:

S. 1877. A bill to establish procedures and consequences in the event of a failure to complete regular appropriations (Rept. No. 116–158).

INTRODUCTION OF BILLS AND JOINT RESOLUTIONS

The following bills and joint resolutions were introduced, read the first and second times by unanimous consent, and referred as indicated:

By Ms. ROSEN (for herself and Mr. BARRASSO):

S. 2830. A bill to amend title 38, United States Code, to extend the period under which an election must be made for entitlement to educational assistance under the All-Volunteer Educational Assistance Program of the Department of Veterans Affairs, to phase out the use of such program, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Veterans' Affairs.

By Mrs. CAPITO (for herself and Ms. SINEMA):

S. 2831. A bill to amend title 51, United States Code, to modify the national space grant college and fellowship program, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation.

By Mr. MARKEY (for himself and Mr. WYDEN):

S. 2832. A bill to assist those subject to politically motivated charges in Turkey, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Foreign Relations.

By Mr. MERKLEY (for himself, Mr. BROWN, Mr. REED, and Mr. VAN HOLLEN):

S. 2833. A bill to amend the Truth in Lending Act to extend the consumer credit protections provided to members of the Armed Forces and their dependents under title 10, United States Code, to all consumers; to the Committee on Banking, Housing, and Urban Affairs.

By Mr. SULLIVAN (for himself and Ms. HIRONO):

S. 2834. A bill to amend the Federal Credit Union Act to exclude extensions of credit made to veterans from the definition of a member business loan; to the Committee on Banking, Housing, and Urban Affairs.

By Ms. ROSEN (for herself and Mr. ROBERTS):

S. 2835. A bill to include information regarding VA home loans in the Informed Consumer Choice Disclosure required to be provided to a prospective FHA borrower who is a veteran, to amend title 10, United States Code, to authorize the provision of a certificate of eligibility for VA home loans during the preseparation counseling for members of the Armed Forces, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Banking, Housing, and Urban Affairs.

By Mrs. MURRAY (for herself, Ms. BALDWIN, Mr. MERKLEY, Ms. HASSAN, Ms. HIRONO, Mrs. GILLIBRAND, Mr. LEAHY, Mr. MARKEY, Mrs. SHAHEEN, Mr. BOOKER, Mr. BLUMENTHAL, Mrs. FEINSTEIN, Mr. MENENDEZ, Mr. VAN HOLLEN, Mr. BROWN, Ms. ROSEN, Mr. SANDERS, Ms. HARRIS, Ms. KLOBUCHAR, Ms. WARREN, Ms. CANTWELL, Mr. WYDEN, Mr. MURPHY, Ms. CORTEZ MASTO, Mr. KAINE, Mr. BENNET, Ms. DUCKWORTH, Ms. SMITH, Ms. STABENOW, and Mr. CARDIN):

S. 2836. A bill to prohibit the Secretary of Health and Human Services from taking any action to implement, enforce, or otherwise give effect to the final rule, entitled ''Protecting Statutory Conscience Rights in Health Care; Delegations of Authority''; to the Committee on Health, Education, Labor, and Pensions.

By Mr. CARDIN (for himself, Mr. VAN HOLLEN, Ms. WARREN, Mr. KING, Mr. MERKLEY, and Mrs. FEINSTEIN):

S. 2837. A bill to amend title 51, United States Code, to require a National Aeronautics and Space Administration initiative on reduction of greenhouse gas emissions and noise emissions from aircraft, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation.

By Mr. GRASSLEY (for himself, Ms. ERNST, Mrs. BLACKBURN, Mr. SULLIVAN, Ms. MURKOWSKI, and Mr. PERDUE):

S. 2838. A bill to amend the Ted Stevens Olympic and Amateur Sports Act to improve the transparency of the United States Center for Safe Sport, to provide grant accountability, and to protect victims of abuse from retaliation, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation.

By Mr. KENNEDY:

S. 2839. A bill to amend the Bank Holding Company Act of 1956 to regulate industrial bank holding companies, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Banking, Housing, and Urban Affairs.

By Mr. INHOFE:

S. 2840. A bill to authorize appropriations for fiscal year 2020 for military activities of the Department of Defense, for military construction, and for defense activities of the Department of Energy, and for other purposes; read the first time.

SUBMISSION OF CONCURRENT AND SENATE RESOLUTIONS

The following concurrent resolutions and Senate resolutions were read, and referred (or acted upon), as indicated:

By Mr. MURPHY:

S. Res. 417. A resolution commemorating the 81st anniversary of Kristallnacht, or the Night of Broken Glass; to the Committee on Foreign Relations.

By Mrs. BLACKBURN (for herself, Mr. VAN HOLLEN, Mr. LEAHY, Mr. KAINE, Mr. WYDEN, Ms. DUCKWORTH, Mr. MARKEY, Mr. RUBIO, and Mr. BLUMENTHAL):

S. Res. 418. A resolution expressing the sense of the Senate regarding the Government of Turkey's crackdown on dissent related to its incursion into northeast Syria, and broader human rights violations; to the Committee on Foreign Relations.

By Mr. TESTER (for himself and Mr. ISAKSON):

S. Res. 419. A resolution permitting the collection of clothing, toys, food, and housewares during the holiday season for charitable purposes in Senate buildings; considered and agreed to.

ADDITIONAL COSPONSORS

S. 225

At the request of Mr. ISAKSON, the name of the Senator from Louisiana (Mr. KENNEDY) was added as a cosponsor of S. 225, a bill to provide for partnerships among State and local governments, regional entities, and the private sector to preserve, conserve, and enhance the visitor experience at nationally significant battlefields of the American Revolution, War of 1812, and Civil War, and for other purposes.

S. 433

At the request of Ms. COLLINS, the name of the Senator from Florida (Mr. RUBIO) was added as a cosponsor of S. 433, a bill to amend title XVIII of the Social Security Act to improve home health payment reforms under the Medicare program.

S. 457

At the request of Mr. CORNYN, the name of the Senator from Virginia (Mr. WARNER) was added as a cosponsor of S. 457, a bill to require that $1 coins issued during 2019 honor President George H.W. Bush and to direct the Secretary of the Treasury to issue bullion coins during 2019 in honor of Barbara Bush.

S. 514

At the request of Mr. TESTER, the name of the Senator from Alabama (Mr. JONES) was added as a cosponsor of S. 514, a bill to amend title 38, United States Code, to improve the benefits and services provided by the Department of Veterans Affairs to women veterans, and for other purposes.

S. 525

At the request of Mr. PAUL, the name of the Senator from North Carolina (Mr. TILLIS) was added as a cosponsor of S. 525, a bill to preserve and protect the free choice of individual employees to form, join, or assist labor organizations, or to refrain from such activities.

S. 595

At the request of Mr. CASSIDY, the name of the Senator from North Carolina (Mr. TILLIS) was added as a cosponsor of S. 595, a bill to amend title XVIII of the Social Security Act to provide for the coordination of programs to prevent and treat obesity, and for other purposes.

S. 743

At the request of Mr. ISAKSON, the names of the Senator from Wyoming (Mr. ENZI), the Senator from Pennsylvania (Mr. CASEY), the Senator from Hawaii (Ms. HIRONO), the Senator from South Dakota (Mr. THUNE), the Senator from Delaware (Mr. CARPER), the Senator from Minnesota (Ms. KLOBUCHAR), the Senator from Oklahoma (Mr. LANKFORD), the Senator from South Carolina (Mr. GRAHAM) and the Senator from Ohio (Mr. PORTMAN) were added as cosponsors of S. 743, a bill to award a Congressional Gold Medal to the soldiers of the 5307th Composite Unit (Provisional), commonly known as ''Merrill's Marauders'', in recognition of their bravery and outstanding service in the jungles of Burma during World War II.

S. 846

At the request of Mr. CORNYN, the name of the Senator from New Mexico (Mr. HEINRICH) was added as a cosponsor of S. 846, a bill to amend title 49, United States Code, to limit certain rolling stock procurements, and for other purposes.

S. 866

At the request of Mr. VAN HOLLEN, the name of the Senator from Virginia (Mr. WARNER) was added as a cosponsor of S. 866, a bill to amend part B of the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act to provide full Federal funding of such part.

S. 879

At the request of Mr. VAN HOLLEN, the name of the Senator from New York (Mr. SCHUMER) was added as a cosponsor of S. 879, a bill to provide a process for granting lawful permanent resident status to aliens from certain countries who meet specified eligibility requirements, and for other purposes.

S. 890

At the request of Mr. WYDEN, the name of the Senator from Oregon (Mr. MERKLEY) was added as a cosponsor of S. 890, a bill to authorize the Sergeant at Arms to protect the personal technology devices and accounts of Senators and covered employees from cyber attacks and hostile information collection activities, and for other purposes.

S. 933

At the request of Mr. WHITEHOUSE, the name of the Senator from Hawaii (Ms. HIRONO) was added as a cosponsor of S. 933, a bill to improve data collection and monitoring of the Great Lakes, oceans, bays, estuaries, and coasts, and for other purposes.

S. 1172

At the request of Mr. VAN HOLLEN, the name of the Senator from Connecticut (Mr. MURPHY) was added as a cosponsor of S. 1172, a bill to require full funding of part A of title I of the Elementary and Secondary Education Act of 1965 and the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act.

S. 1268

At the request of Ms. STABENOW, the name of the Senator from Minnesota (Ms. KLOBUCHAR) was added as a cosponsor of S. 1268, a bill to amend title XVIII of the Social Security Act to ensure that hospitals receive adequate payment for the acquisition of hematopoietic stem cells under the Medicare program, and for other purposes.

S. 1399

At the request of Mr. MERKLEY, the name of the Senator from Montana (Mr. TESTER) was added as a cosponsor of S. 1399, a bill to amend title VIII of the Public Health Services Act to revise and extend nursing workforce development programs.

S. 1583

At the request of Mr. DURBIN, the name of the Senator from Michigan (Mr. PETERS) was added as a cosponsor of S. 1583, a bill to amend the Lead-Based Paint Poisoning Prevention Act to provide for additional procedures for families with children under the age of 6, and for other purposes.

S. 1590

At the request of Mr. MERKLEY, the name of the Senator from Rhode Island (Mr. REED) was added as a cosponsor of S. 1590, a bill to amend the State Department Basic Authorities Act of 1956 to authorize rewards for thwarting wildlife trafficking linked to transnational organized crime, and for other purposes.

S. 1675

At the request of Mr. MENENDEZ, the name of the Senator from Michigan (Ms. STABENOW) was added as a cosponsor of S. 1675, a bill to impose requirements on the payment of compensation to professional persons employed in voluntary cases commenced under title III of PROMESA.

S. 1757

At the request of Ms. ERNST, the names of the Senator from Maine (Mr. KING), the Senator from Wyoming (Mr. BARRASSO), the Senator from Washington (Ms. CANTWELL), and the Senator from Kansas (Mr. ROBERTS) were added as cosponsors of S. 1757, a bill to award a Congressional Gold Medal, collectively, to the United States Army Rangers Veterans of World War II in recognition of their extraordinary service during World War II.

S. 1804

At the request of Ms. CORTEZ MASTO, the name of the Senator from Oregon (Mr. WYDEN) was added as a cosponsor of S. 1804, a bill to require the Secretary of Housing and Urban Development to issue guidelines relating to the appropriate inclusion of residential manufactured homes in Consolidated Plans, and for other purposes.

S. 1820

At the request of Mrs. GILLIBRAND, the name of the Senator from Vermont (Mr. SANDERS) was added as a cosponsor of S. 1820, a bill to improve the integrity and safety of horseracing by requiring a uniform anti-doping and medication control program to be developed and enforced by an independent Horseracing Anti-Doping and Medication Control Authority.

S. 1838

At the request of Mr. CARDIN, the name of the Senator from Maryland (Mr. VAN HOLLEN) was added as a cosponsor of S. 1838, a bill to amend the Hong Kong Policy Act of 1992, and for other purposes.

S. 1908

At the request of Mrs. GILLIBRAND, the name of the Senator from Massachusetts (Ms. WARREN) was added as a cosponsor of S. 1908, a bill to amend the Richard B. Russell National School Lunch Act to improve the efficiency of summer meals.

S. 2054

At the request of Mr. MARKEY, the name of the Senator from Iowa (Ms. ERNST) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2054, a bill to posthumously award the Congressional Gold Medal, collectively, to Glen Doherty, Tyrone Woods, J. Christopher Stevens, and Sean Smith, in recognition of their contributions to the Nation.

S. 2085

At the request of Ms. ROSEN, the name of the Senator from Ohio (Mr. PORTMAN) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2085, a bill to authorize the Secretary of Education to award grants to eligible entities to carry out educational programs about the Holocaust, and for other purposes.

S. 2216

At the request of Mr. PETERS, the name of the Senator from Tennessee (Mr. ALEXANDER) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2216, a bill to require the Secretary of Veterans Affairs to formally recognize caregivers of veterans, notify veterans and caregivers of clinical determinations relating to eligibility for caregiver programs, and temporarily extend benefits for veterans who are determined ineligible for the

family caregiver program, and for other purposes.

S. 2327

At the request of Mr. BLUMENTHAL, the name of the Senator from Illinois (Mr. DURBIN) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2327, a bill to amend title 38, United States Code, to modify the eligibility requirements for transfer of unused entitlement to Post-9/11 Educational Assistance, and for other purposes.

S. 2330

At the request of Mr. MORAN, the names of the Senator from Alaska (Ms. MURKOWSKI), the Senator from Colorado (Mr. GARDNER) and the Senator from Michigan (Mr. PETERS) were added as cosponsors of S. 2330, a bill to amend the Ted Stevens Olympic and Amateur Sports Act to provide for congressional oversight of the board of directors of the United States Olympic and Paralympic Committee and to protect amateur athletes from emotional, physical, and sexual abuse, and for other purposes.

S. 2346

At the request of Mr. WICKER, the name of the Senator from Washington (Ms. CANTWELL) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2346, a bill to improve the Fishery Resource Disaster Relief program of the National Marine Fisheries Service, and for other purposes.

S. 2417

At the request of Mr. KENNEDY, the name of the Senator from Idaho (Mr. RISCH) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2417, a bill to provide for payment of proceeds from savings bonds to a State with title to such bonds pursuant to the judgment of a court.

S. 2473

At the request of Mr. ISAKSON, the name of the Senator from Georgia (Mr. PERDUE) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2473, a bill to extend certain provisions of the Caribbean Basin Economic Recovery Act until September 30, 2030, and for other purposes.

S. 2541

At the request of Ms. MURKOWSKI, the name of the Senator from California (Ms. HARRIS) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2541, a bill to amend the Indian Health Care Improvement Act to authorize advance appropriations for the Indian Health Service by providing 2-fiscal-year budget authority, and for other purposes.

S. 2546

At the request of Ms. MURKOWSKI, the name of the Senator from West Virginia (Mrs. CAPITO) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2546, a bill to amend the Employee Retirement Income Security Act of 1974 to require a group health plan or health insurance coverage offered in connection with such a plan to provide an exceptions process for any medication step therapy protocol, and for other purposes.

S. 2602

At the request of Mr. BURR, the name of the Senator from Michigan (Mr. PETERS) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2602, a bill to exclude vehicles to be used solely for competition from certain provisions of the Clean Air Act, and for other purposes.

S. 2615

At the request of Mr. CASSIDY, the names of the Senator from Rhode Island (Mr. WHITEHOUSE) and the Senator from Kansas (Mr. MORAN) were added as cosponsors of S. 2615, a bill to amend the Internal Revenue Code of 1986 to improve the historic rehabilitation tax credit, and for other purposes.

S. 2630

At the request of Mr. LEE, the name of the Senator from Mississippi (Mrs. HYDE-SMITH) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2630, a bill to repeal the wage requirements of the Davis-Bacon Act.

S. 2638

At the request of Ms. DUCKWORTH, the name of the Senator from Montana (Mr. DAINES) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2638, a bill to amend title 49, United State Code, to require small hub airports to construct areas for nursing mothers, and for other purposes.

S. 2671

At the request of Mr. BOOKER, the name of the Senator from Oregon (Mr. WYDEN) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2671, a bill to build safer, thriving communities, and save lives by investing in effective violence reduction initiatives.

S. 2703

At the request of Ms. CANTWELL, the name of the Senator from Massachusetts (Mr. MARKEY) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2703, a bill to enhance the recognition of, and response to, aircraft failure conditions, and for other purposes.

S. 2745

At the request of Mr. INHOFE, the name of the Senator from Missouri (Mr. HAWLEY) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2745, a bill to amend title 18, United States Code, to prohibit discrimination by abortion against an unborn child on the basis of Down syndrome.

S. 2764

At the request of Mr. GRASSLEY, the name of the Senator from New Hampshire (Ms. HASSAN) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2764, a bill to amend the Controlled Substances Act to clarify how controlled substance analogues that are imported or offered for import are to be regulated, and for other purposes.

S. 2765

At the request of Mr. ENZI, the name of the Senator from Texas (Mr. CORNYN) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2765, a bill to improve Federal fiscal controls and the congressional budget process.

S. 2787

At the request of Mr. WYDEN, the name of the Senator from Colorado (Mr. BENNET) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2787, a bill to amend the Internal Revenue Code of 1986 to require reporting for qualified opportunity funds, to make modifications to opportunity zones, and for other purposes.

S. 2794

At the request of Mr. CRAPO, the name of the Senator from Idaho (Mr. RISCH) was added as a cosponsor of S. 2794, a bill to provide for the creation of the Missing Armed Forces Personnel Records Collection at the National Archives, to require the expeditious public transmission to the Archivist and public disclosure of Missing Armed Forces Personnel records, and for other purposes.

S. RES. 98

At the request of Mrs. BLACKBURN, the name of the Senator from Alabama (Mr. JONES) was added as a cosponsor of S. Res. 98, a resolution establishing the Congressional Gold Star Family Fellowship Program for the placement in offices of Senators of children, spouses, and siblings of members of the Armed Forces who are hostile casualties or who have died from a training-related injury.

S. RES. 150

At the request of Mr. MENENDEZ, the names of the Senator from Pennsylvania (Mr. CASEY) and the Senator from Colorado (Mr. BENNET) were added as cosponsors of S. Res. 150, a resolution expressing the sense of the Senate that it is the policy of the United States to commemorate the Armenian Genocide through official recognition and remembrance.

S. RES. 371

At the request of Mr. COONS, the name of the Senator from Maryland (Mr. VAN HOLLEN) was added as a cosponsor of S. Res. 371, a resolution reaffirming the support of the United States for the people of the Republic of South Sudan and calling on all parties to uphold their commitments to peace and dialogue as outlined in the 2018 revitalized peace agreement.

S. RES. 395

At the request of Mr. BLUMENTHAL, the name of the Senator from Pennsylvania (Mr. CASEY) was added as a cosponsor of S. Res. 395, a resolution recognizing the 40th anniversary of the Iran Hostage Crisis, and for other purposes.

At the request of Mr. ISAKSON, the name of the Senator from Indiana (Mr. BRAUN) was added as a cosponsor of S. Res. 395, supra.

STATEMENTS ON INTRODUCED BILLS AND JOINT RESOLUTIONS

By Mr. CARDIN (for himself, Mr. VAN HOLLEN, Ms. WARREN, Mr. KING, Mr. MERKLEY, and Mrs. FEINSTEIN):

S. 2837. A bill to amend title 51, United States Code, to require a National Aeronautics and Space Administration initiative on reduction of greenhouse gas emissions and noise emissions from aircraft, and for other purposes; to the Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation.

Mr. CARDIN. Mr. President, today, I am pleased to introduce new legislation called the Cleaner, Quieter Airplanes Act. This legislation sets an ambitious goal for accelerating the National Aeronautics & Space Administration's (NASA) important, ongoing work on electric aircraft propulsion and other technologies to be integrated on new aircraft that are both cleaner and quieter. It challenges us to bring about a transformational shift in our aviation industry to airplanes that produce less greenhouse gas pollution and less noise: 50 percent less by 2030 for regional transport aircraft and by 2040 for larger aircraft serving transcontinental markets.

To achieve this goal, this bill proposes $1.2 billion in funding for NASA over six years, with a ramp-up and then a decline in the annual amounts. This funding will push NASA to accelerate its work and to expand its collaboration with industry partners to get this done.

A growing number of Maryland citizens have expressed concerns about airplane noise in their communities. We all want a thriving aviation industry. Air travel is important to our way of life, and it is a key sector of our economy, accounting for more than 5 percent of our total gross domestic product (GDP) in 2014 and supporting more than 10 million jobs.

As air traffic volumes increase, however, we are increasing our communities' exposure to noise pollution that has an adverse impact on our quality of life. We need to find new solutions for supporting our need for air travel while addressing these concerns about noise.

This legislation is also about finding new and innovative ways to fight climate change. Today, transportation is the leading source of greenhouse gas emissions in the United States. Aviation accounts for approximately 3 percent of all emissions. Three percent may not sound like much, but consider that emissions from aviation are expected to triple by 2050 and could account for as much as 25 percent of global emissions. If we want to continue flying as we do now while protecting ourselves from the perils of climate change, now is the time to act.

There is some exciting innovation happening right now, with companies working on new, electric aircraft technologies—including work by large, established companies and by smaller start-ups. We have heard from some of them, and two things they have said stand out.

The first is that government-funded research undertaken by NASA is critical to the development and testing of new technologies in electric aircraft. The work that NASA does in collaboration with industry partners addresses a wide array of technical challenges, like how to make certain electrical components work at high altitudes and what sorts of air frame designs might best enable new kinds of propulsion.

The second thing we hear is that if we do not act with greater urgency, we risk allowing other countries to pass us by in a critical industry. Europe, in particular, is moving quickly with strong government investments in research, development, and demonstration of new, electric aircraft technologies.

If we fail to match this ambition and build these skills at home, we will be left out of this drive to innovate and our businesses and workers will be at a competitive disadvantage. This will become even more difficult as other countries embrace new, stricter standards for aircraft noise and greenhouse gas pollution.

So there are a few reasons for the urgency behind this legislation. It responds to the need to support research and development in our aviation industry to remain competitive with other countries. It responds to the need for new ideas to combat climate change. And it responds to our need for air travel with fewer noise impacts on our neighborhoods. This legislation calls on our innovative spirit to produce a new generation of airplanes that are cleaner, quieter, and ultimately more sustainable, both for our environment and our economy.

Thank you.

SUBMITTED RESOLUTIONS

SENATE RESOLUTION 417—COMMEMORATING THE 81ST ANNIVERSARY OF KRISTALLNACHT, OR THE NIGHT OF BROKEN GLASS

Mr. MURPHY submitted the following resolution; which was referred to the Committee on Foreign Relations:

S. RES. 417

Whereas November 9, 2019, through November 10, 2019, marks the 81st anniversary of Kristallnacht, or the Night of Broken Glass;

Whereas Kristallnacht began as a pogrom authorized by Nazi party officials and was carried out by members of the Sturmabteilungen (commonly known as the ''SA''), the Schutzstaffel (commonly known as the ''SS''), and the Hitler Youth;

Whereas Kristallnacht marked the first large-scale anti-Semitic operation of the Nazi Party and a crucial turning point in Nazi anti-Semitic policy;

Whereas, during Kristallnacht, synagogues, homes, and businesses in Jewish communities were attacked, resulting in murders and arrests of Jewish people in Germany and in Austrian and Czechoslovakian territories controlled by the Nazis;

Whereas the events of Kristallnacht resulted in the burning and destruction of 267 synagogues, the looting of thousands of businesses and homes, the desecration of Jewish cemeteries, the murder of 91 Jews, and the arrest and deportation of 30,000 Jewish men to concentration camps;

Whereas the shards of broken glass from the windows of synagogues, Jewish homes, and Jewish-owned businesses ransacked during the violence that littered the streets gave the pogrom the name of Kristallnacht, commonly translated as the ''Night of Broken Glass'';

Whereas Kristallnacht—

(1) proved to be a crucial turning point in the Holocaust, marking a shift from a policy of removing Jews from Germany and German-occupied lands to murdering millions of people; and

(2) was a tragic precursor to the Second World War;

Whereas, despite numerous global efforts to eradicate hate, manifestations of anti-Semitism and other forms of intolerance continue to harm societies on a global scale; and

Whereas, in 2018—

(1) anti-Semitic acts in France increased by more than 70 percent compared to the previous year, according to data from the Government of France; and

(2) anti-Semitic crimes in Germany, which include hate speech, increased by 20 percent, according to data from the Government of Germany;

Whereas, because hate crimes in the European Union are generally under reported, the real figures on anti-Semitism in France, Germany, and other states in the European Union are likely much higher;

Whereas, while the United States has made progress towards addressing anti-Semitism, recent events demonstrate that much work remains;

Whereas, in 2017, the Anti-Defamation League recorded 1,986 anti-Semitic incidents across the United States, including physical assaults, vandalism, and attacks on Jewish institutions, which represents a 57 percent increase compared to anti-Semitic incidents recorded in 2016;

Whereas recent anti-Semitic acts in the United States include—

(1) the shooting at the Tree of Life Synagogue in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania, in October, 2018; and

(2) the shooting at the Chabad of Poway Synagogue in Poway, California, in April, 2019;

Whereas, according to the Anti-Defamation League, since the Tree of Life Shooting occurred, at least 13 white supremacists have been arrested for their alleged roles in terrorist plots, attacks, or threats against the Jewish community in the United States; and

Whereas Kristallnacht teaches mankind how hate can proliferate and erode societies and serves as a reminder that the United States must advance global efforts to ensure that barbarism and mass murder never occur again: Now, therefore, be it

Resolved, That the Senate—

(1) recognizes the 81st anniversary of Kristallnacht;

(2) pays tribute to the more than 6,000,000 Jewish people killed during the Holocaust and the families affected by the tragedy;

(3) continues to support United States efforts to address the horrible legacy of the Holocaust and combat manifestations of anti-Semitism domestically and globally; and

(4) will continue to raise awareness and act to eradicate the continuing scourge of anti-Semitism at home and abroad, including through work with international partners, such as—

(A) the Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe (referred to in this resolving clause as the ''OSCE'');

(B) the Tolerance and Non-Discrimination Unit of the OSCE; and

(C) the Personal Representative on Combating Anti-Semitism of the OSCE.

SENATE RESOLUTION 418—EXPRESSING THE SENSE OF THE SENATE REGARDING THE GOVERNMENT OF TURKEY'S CRACKDOWN ON DISSENT RELATED TO ITS INCURSION INTO NORTHEAST SYRIA, AND BROADER HUMAN RIGHTS VIOLATIONS

Mrs. BLACKBURN (for herself, Mr. VAN HOLLEN, Mr. LEAHY, Mr. KAINE, Mr. WYDEN, Ms. DUCKWORTH, Mr. MARKEY, Mr. RUBIO, and Mr. BLUMENTHAL) submitted the following resolution; which was referred to the Committee on Foreign Relations:

S. RES. 418

Whereas Turkey is a constitutional, secular state with an ethnically, religiously, and culturally diverse population;

Whereas Turkey has been a modern democracy and a major North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) ally to the United States;

Whereas Turkey is a signatory to the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights and is therefore obligated to uphold the freedom of its people to peacefully express criticism of their government;

Whereas, immediately following the incursion by the Turkish Armed Forces into northeast Syria on October 9, 2019, the Government of Turkey began a coordinated crackdown on online dissent;

Whereas, on October 9, 2019, Turkey's National Security Directorate made a statement that criminal investigations had been initiated against 78 people for ''inciting enmity and hatred through black propaganda [smear campaign] against [Turkey] over Operation Peace Spring; sharing unsourced and false social media postings intended to destroy the reputation of [Turkey's] security forces and making propaganda for a terrorist organization'';

Whereas expression of opposition views through social media posts, social media reposts, and shared online articles has led to the investigation and detention of individuals in the region;

Whereas the shared content targeted by Turkish authorities was largely authored by Western and United States sources and outlets;

Whereas Turkey has over 120 journalists and media workers in jail, more than in any other country, with most of them detained under propaganda charges;

Whereas, on October 10, 2019, the digital services manager of the Birgun daily newspaper was detained in his home in Istanbul and questioned in relation to a news article and a tweet said to have incited enmity or hatred under the Article 216/1 of Turkish Penal Code;

Whereas, on October 11, 2019, Minister of the Interior Suleyman Soylu stated during a speech that 121 people had been detained for their social media posts ''insulting 'Operation Peace Spring', describing [our] country as an invader and insulating the unity of our nation'';

Whereas, on October 14, 2019, military police carried out a countrywide operation with the aim of ''preventing and deterring sympathizers of the terrorist organization from [engaging in provocations related to] Operation Peace Spring'' in which over 500,000 people were interrogated and 152 people were detained, according to Amnesty International;

Whereas, as of October 16, 2019, authorities have identified 839 social media accounts under investigation, and 186 individuals taken into police custody since October 9, 2019, related to ''shared criminal content'';

Whereas, on October 19, 2019, police raided several homes of human rights defenders and journalists on counts of ''inciting enmity or hatred'' through social media posts;

Whereas, on October 25, 2019, criminal complaints were made against the French weekly journal Le Point for its coverage of the military offensive;

Whereas the style and scale of the social media crackdown specific to Turkish operations in Syria has recent precedent in the aftermath of the Turkish Armed Forces' Operation Olive Branch in Afrin, in which—

(1) 1,719 social media accounts were investigated;

(2) 845 people were detained for social media posts; and

(3) 643 people were subject to judicial proceedings; including 11 physician members of the Turkish Medical Association's Central Council, who were sentenced to terms up to 3 years and three months for calling to an end to the Afrin military operation;

Whereas Turkish authorities have targeted more than a thousand criminal defense lawyers as part of the ongoing crackdown on dissent;

Whereas more than 265 academics have been prosecuted in Turkey for signing an appeal for peace between the Government of Turkey and Kurdish insurgents;

Whereas human rights violations have been a defining aspect of President Erdogan's authoritarian rule, including—

(1) the removal of at least 88 of the pro-Kurdish Peoples' Democratic Party (HDP) mayors from office in the last three years and their replacement with state-appointed trustees;

(2) the detention of HDP members of parliament; and

(3) the detention of Turkish employees of United States diplomatic facilities in Turkey;

Whereas blanket bans on peaceful protests of any form have been implemented by local governors across Turkey; and

Whereas these bans have resulted in the arrest and detention of many people and represent clear violations to the right to peaceful assembly as protected by international human rights conventions to which Turkey is a party and by the Constitution of Turkey: Now, therefore, be it

Resolved, That the Senate—

(1) reaffirms the position of the United States that peaceful dissent should be protected under the right of freedom of expression in Turkey;

(2) condemns policies and efforts by the Government of Turkey to suppress peaceful protesters, including those expressing dissent against military operations by the Turkish Armed Forces or policies instituted by the Government of Turkey;

(3) stands with the defenders of free speech and human rights in Turkey;

(4) encourages senior United States administration officials to raise the issue of suppression of free speech and media in Turkey at the highest levels, both bilaterally and multilaterally;

(5) encourages United States embassy and consular staff to attend politically motivated trials; and

(6) calls on the Government of Turkey to—

(A) immediately lift restrictions on freedom of expression, including expression online or in social media;

(B) ensure that criticism of the Turkish Armed Forces' military operations or calling for peace—through media, social media, peaceful assembly, or other peaceful means—is not criminalized;

(C) drop all charges and end prosecution of individuals or groups for peaceful expression of their opposition to Turkey's military operations in Syria;

(D) ensure that people can gather and protest peacefully, including by lifting blanket protest bans across the country;

(E) release all political prisoners, including journalists and Turkish employees of United States diplomatic missions; and

(F) respect the rights of Turkish citizens to elect their leaders through a democratic process.

SENATE RESOLUTION 419—PERMITTING THE COLLECTION OF CLOTHING, TOYS, FOOD, AND HOUSEWARES DURING THE HOLIDAY SEASON FOR CHARITABLE PURPOSES IN SENATE BUILDINGS

Mr. TESTER (for himself and Mr. ISAKSON) submitted the following resolution; which was considered and agreed to:

S. RES. 419

Resolved,

SECTION 1. COLLECTION OF CLOTHING, TOYS, FOOD, AND HOUSEWARES DURING THE HOLIDAY SEASON FOR CHARITABLE PURPOSES IN SENATE BUILDINGS.

(a) IN GENERAL.—Notwithstanding any other provision of the rules or regulations of the Senate—

(1) a Senator, officer of the Senate, or employee of the Senate may collect from another Senator, officer of the Senate, or employee of the Senate within a Senate building or other office secured for a Senator nonmonetary donations of clothing, toys, food, and housewares for charitable purposes related to serving persons in need or members of the Armed Forces and the families of those members during the holiday season, if the charitable purposes do not otherwise violate any rule or regulation of the Senate or Federal law; and

(2) a Senator, officer of the Senate, or employee of the Senate may work with a nonprofit organization with respect to the delivery of donations described under paragraph (1).

(b) EXPIRATION.—The authority provided by this resolution shall expire at the end of the first session of the 116th Congress.

AMENDMENTS SUBMITTED AND PROPOSED

SA 1244. Mr. INHOFE (for Mr. BLUNT) proposed an amendment to the bill H.R. 1865, to require the Secretary of the Treasury to mint a coin in commemoration of the opening of the National Law Enforcement Museum in the District of Columbia, and for other purposes.

TEXT OF AMENDMENTS

SA 1244. Mr. INHOFE (for Mr. BLUNT) proposed an amendment to the bill H.R. 1865, to require the Secretary of the Treasury to mint a coin in commemoration of the opening of the National Law Enforcement Museum in the District of Columbia, and for other purposes; as follows:

At the end, add the following:

SEC. 9. FINANCIAL ASSURANCES.

The Secretary shall take such actions as may be necessary to ensure that—

(1) minting and issuing coins under this Act will not result in any net cost to the United States Government; and

(2) no funds, including applicable surcharges, are disbursed to any recipient designated in section 7 until the total cost of

designing and issuing all of the coins authorized by this Act (including labor, materials, dies, use of machinery, overhead expenses, marketing, and shipping) is recovered by the United States Treasury, consistent with sections 5112(m) and 5134(f) of title 31, United States Code.

NATIONAL LAW ENFORCEMENT MUSEUM COMMEMORATIVE COIN ACT

Mr. INHOFE. Mr. President, I ask unanimous consent that the Senate proceed to the immediate consideration of H.R. 1865, which was received from the House.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The clerk will report the bill by title.

The senior assistant legislative clerk read as follows:

A bill (H.R. 1865) to require the Secretary of the Treasury to mint a coin in commemoration of the opening of the National Law Enforcement Museum in the District of Columbia, and for other purposes.

There being no objection, the Senate proceeded to consider the bill.

Mr. INHOFE. I ask unanimous consent that the Blunt amendment at the desk be considered and agreed to; that the bill, as amended be considered read a third time and passed; and that the motions to reconsider be considered made and laid upon the table.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Is there objection?

Without objection, it is so ordered.

The amendment (No. 1244) was agreed to, as follows:

(Purpose: To add a provision relating to financial assurances)

At the end, add the following:

SEC. 9. FINANCIAL ASSURANCES.

The Secretary shall take such actions as may be necessary to ensure that—

(1) minting and issuing coins under this Act will not result in any net cost to the United States Government; and

(2) no funds, including applicable surcharges, are disbursed to any recipient designated in section 7 until the total cost of designing and issuing all of the coins authorized by this Act (including labor, materials, dies, use of machinery, overhead expenses, marketing, and shipping) is recovered by the United States Treasury, consistent with sections 5112(m) and 5134(f) of title 31, United States Code.

The amendment was ordered to be engrossed and the bill to be read a third time.

The bill was read the third time.

The bill (H.R. 1865), as amended, was passed.

PERMITTING THE COLLECTION OF CLOTHING, TOYS, FOOD, AND HOUSEWARES DURING THE HOLIDAY SEASON FOR CHARITABLE PURPOSES IN SENATE BUILDINGS

Mr. INHOFE. Madam President, I ask unanimous consent that the Senate proceed to the immediate consideration of S. Res. 419, submitted earlier today.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The clerk will report the resolution by title.

The senior assistant legislative clerk read as follows:

A resolution (S. Res. 419) permitting the collection of clothing, toys, food, and housewares during the holiday season for charitable purposes in Senate buildings.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Is there objection to proceeding to the measure?

There being no objection, the Senate proceeded to consider the resolution.

Mr. INHOFE. I further ask unanimous consent that the resolution be agreed to, the preamble be agreed to, and the motions to reconsider be considered made and laid upon the table with no intervening action or debate.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Without objection, it is so ordered.

The resolution (S. Res. 419) was agreed to.

The preamble was agreed to.

(The resolution, with its preamble, is printed in today's RECORD under ''Submitted Resolutions.'')

UNANIMOUS CONSENT AGREEMENT—S. 2731

Mr. INHOFE. Madam President, I ask unanimous consent that the Senate's action placing S. 2731 on the Calendar be vitiated and the bill be considered introduced and held at the desk on October 29, 2019, and then indefinitely postponed today.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Without objection, it is so ordered.

MEASURE READ THE FIRST TIME—S. 2840

Mr. INHOFE. Madam President, I understand there is a bill at the desk, and I ask for its first reading.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. The clerk will read the title of the bill for the first time.

The senior assistant legislative clerk read as follows:

A bill (S. 2840) to authorize appropriations for fiscal year 2020 for military activities of the Department of Defense, for military construction, and for defense activities of the Department of Energy, and for other purposes.

Mr. INHOFE. I now ask for a second reading and in order to place the bill on the Calendar under the provisions of rule XIV, I object to my own request.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Objection having been heard, the bill will be read for the second time on the next legislative day.

ORDERS FOR WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 13, 2019

Mr. INHOFE. Madam President, I ask unanimous consent that when the Senate completes its business today, it adjourn until 10 a.m., Wednesday, November 13; further, that following the prayer and pledge, the morning hour be deemed expired, the Journal of proceedings be approved to date, the time for the two leaders be reserved for their use later in the day, morning business be closed, and the Senate proceed to executive session and resume consideration of the Wolf nomination, with the postcloture time expiring at 11 a.m.; further, that if confirmed, the motion to reconsider be considered made and laid upon the table and the President be immediately notified of the Senate's action; finally, that the Senate recess from 12:30 p.m. until 2 p.m. to allow for the conference meetings.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Without objection, it is so ordered.

ORDER FOR ADJOURNMENT

Mr. INHOFE. Madam President, if there is no further business to come before the Senate, I ask unanimous consent that it stand adjourned under the previous order, following the remarks of Senator MENENDEZ.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Without objection, it is so ordered.

The Senator from New Jersey.

Mr. MENENDEZ. Madam President, first, let me congratulate the Senator from Oklahoma on his upcoming 50th anniversary.

Mr. INHOFE. 60th.

Mr. MENENDEZ. That is the 60th anniversary. Oh, my God. That is a hallmark under any set of circumstances, and we wish him much health and happiness with his bride for a lot longer time as well. I say congratulations.

Mr. INHOFE. Thank you.

TURKEY AND SYRIA

Mr. MENENDEZ. Madam President, When President Trump welcomes Turkish President Erdogan to the White House this week, he will be welcoming a known authoritarian, human rights abuser, and friend to Putin, whose behavior increasingly runs counter to the interests of the United States and our allies. It is yet another strategic mistake and a terrible misuse of the power of the Presidency.

In recent years, the President of Turkey has made a series of decisions to part ways with NATO, with the United States, and with the basic principles of democracy. Make no mistake. Erdogan's actions are intentional. It is stunning to think that any American President would legitimize Erdogan's harmful policies by welcoming him to the Oval Office. This meeting is a mistake, plain and simple.

I can only hope that instead of yielding to Erdogan's policies that are so squarely at odds with U.S. interests, President Trump treats this misguided meeting as more than just a photo op with yet another dictator.

The President should instead use this visit to actually stand up for America, for our principles, and for our allies. He can do this by raising the many serious questions that Turkey has yet to address.

I would like to use this opportunity to outline 10 critical questions, each of which deserves real answers.

Question No. 1: Will Turkey reverse course from Erdogan's decision to buy

and receive the S–400 air defense system from Russia?

The President's National Security Advisor claims that the administration is very ''upset'' about Turkey's purchase of Russia's S–400 weapons system. Well, ''upset'' is not a policy, and it falls well short of the Trump administration's legal obligations.

Under the CAATSA sanctions law, Turkey's purchase of the S–400 is a significant and sanctionable transaction. These sanctions should have been imposed in July when Turkey first took delivery of the S–400s. Yet, by failing to implement the legal requirements of CAATSA, President Trump has done lasting damage to U.S. credibility, to the integrity of our sanctions, and to the rule of law.

Is it too much to ask the President of the United States to follow the law?

He can start by imposing CAATSA sanctions when Erdogan is in Washington.

Question Number 2: Will our President sanction the activities of Halkbank, a Turkish institution that facilitated the biggest evasion of Iran's sanctions in history? I repeat: It was the biggest evasion of Iran sanctions in history.

We know that the Justice Department has finally brought charges in the case, but if the administration had followed the law, they would have already imposed sanctions on Halkbank and sent a message to other actors who seek to evade Iran sanctions.

I understand that one of Erdogan's top priorities for his visit to the White House is to secure relief for Halkbank. That is the opposite of what the law requires, and I hope President Trump shows some backbone when Erdogan asks him for yet another favor.

Let's not forget that President Trump's personal attorney, Rudy Giuliani represented Reza Zarrab, one of the players in Halkbank's sanctions evasion.

It seems that the President likes to talk tough about his sanctions policy on Iran and yet all the tough talks suddenly stops when the interests of his authoritarian pals or his personal lawyer are on the line.

Question number 3: Will the President accept the commission of war crimes in Syria by Turkish-backed forces—the war crimes that he in effect invited Turkey to commit when he green-lighted its invasion of Syria?

The U.N. reports that more than 200,000 people have been internally displaced from the so-called safe zone controlled by the Turks. Some of those displaced have reported that Turkish-backed forces have beaten civilians and conducted kidnappings and summary executions.

With the pullout of American troops, Turkey was effectively given license to commit these abuses and unleash unspeakable crimes. That is ethnic cleansing.

So many in this Chamber have said never again to this kind of horror in the past. Can we depend on President Trump to do the same?

Last week, I introduced a binding resolution that would require the State Department to report on Turkish human rights abuses in Syria. State's findings could have a direct bearing on arms sales to Turkey. Meanwhile, we have additional legislation to hold Turkey accountable that has been waiting for a vote for weeks.

But where are we? Did we pass the Risch-Menendez bill on Turkey? No. Did we pass the House version of that legislation? No. Day after day, week after week, we sit on our hands, too timid to act on any legislation that might upset Erdogan while he is in town. Whatever happened to standing up for our American values?

This weekend, National Security Advisor Robert O'Brien declared that ''there's no place for ethnic cleansing, for war crimes in the 21st century.'' Will President Trump deliver that message to Erdogan on Wednesday? Will he seek to maintain any shred of dignity and U.S. credibility on human rights issues, or will he let Erdogan engage in these horrific human rights issues without consequence?

Question Number 4: Will our President stand up to Turkish aggression against its neighbors throughout the region? Turkish naval ships routinely violate the exclusive economic zones of Cyprus and may take measures in Famagusta that would set the peace process on the island back even further.

Turkey also routinely violates airspace that belongs to Greece, brazenly disregarding Greece's sovereignty and the safety of Greek pilots and those on the ground below.

Has President Trump uttered a word of support for our Greek friends and NATO ally? Will he affirm America's relationship with Greece during Erdogan's visit to the White House?

The EU has developed a sanctions framework that would address Turkey's actions in the Cypriot Exclusive Economic Zone. Will Donald Trump follow suit?

Question No. 5: Will our President condemn or accept Erdogan's warming relationship with the Russian Federation?

In addition to buying the S–400, Turkey is now in talks to purchase the Russian Sukhoi aircraft. Last week, Erdogan felt the need to coordinate with President Putin prior to coming to the United States. According to Reuters, he said he would hold a phone call with the Russian President over the weekend to ''form the basis'' of his talks with President Trump.

Imagine this, a NATO ally—NATO comprised primarily to defend against the Russian Federation—a NATO ally going to have conversations with Putin to form the basis of his conversation with President Trump. Aside from perhaps Hungary, I can't imagine any other leader in NATO coordinating with Putin before a conversation with an American President.

Some say we need to tread carefully with Turkey lest we push it into Russia's arms. Push? It seems to me that Erdogan has jumped into Putin's arms long ago with no provocation from us.

Question No. 6: Will President Trump call out Erdogan's assault on the democratic process in Turkey? Will he stick up for civil society groups, university professors, and others who have been unjustly detained? Will he stick up for journalists there, even as he demonizes the free press here at home? More journalists are imprisoned in Turkey than any other country in the world—in the world.

Under article 2 of the NATO charter, member countries commit to a certain set of democratic principles. This is the basis of the alliance. At its core, this is why we commit to the mutual defense of these allies. They share our values, our belief in human rights, in human freedom, in democracy, and in the rule of law. Yet all of Erdogan's actions over the past few years run afoul of the democratic principles that define the NATO alliance.

I know the President does not like to stand up for democracy at home or abroad, but I hope this meeting will be different in that he will finally come to understand what was clear to so many Presidents before him—Republican and Democratic alike—that how a leader treats his own people is indicative of how they will act on the world stage. An authoritarian at home is an authoritarian abroad, and both should matter to the United States.

Question No. 7: Will President Trump ignore the violent attacks by Erdogan's security detail in 2017 against peaceful protesters and DC police? The last time Erdogan visited in 2017, his goons did just that, resulting in criminal charges against more than half a dozen members of his security detail.

During his meeting, President Trump should insist that Erdogan hand over those guards implicated in the 2017 attacks. It is clear that Erdogan's visit will again attract demonstrators and rightfully so. While Erdogan may not believe in the right of peaceful protest in his home country, I hope Erdogan learned his lesson that here in the United States the right to peaceful assembly is enshrined in our Constitution and is core to our democracy. I hope President Trump clearly reminds him of this fact.

Question No. 8: Will President Trump accept efforts by Turkey to convert Hagia Sophia, which was the largest Greek Orthodox Church in the world for more than 1,000 years, into a mosque? Will he advocate for the religious freedom of the Ecumenical Patriarch Bartholomew, who continues to work and live under pressure from the Turkish Government? I hear a lot about religious freedom. Well, this is one glaring example where the administration has been silent.

Question No. 9: Will President Trump ignore Erdogan's violation of the U.N.'s

arms embargo on Libya? Now, to be fair, Turkey is not the only country funneling weapons to clients in Libya in clear violation of U.N. Security Council Resolution 1970, but the grinding, protracted conflict heightened by these weapons is destabilizing North Africa and allowing for the trafficking and exploitation of desperate migrants and refugees.

Will President Trump call on all outside powers, including Turkey, to engage in Libya with diplomacy rather than weapons transfers and to encourage the warring parties to find a political solution to the conflict?

Finally, Question No. 10: Will President Trump call out Turkey's relationship with Hamas, the Palestinian organization that continues to terrorize Israel on a daily basis? Will he stand by our ally Israel or will his personal interest and affinity for strong men win out once again?

The President says he wants to put America first. Yet on every one of these 10 issues, the President has cowered to the demands of Ankara and Moscow.

Look, President Trump can meet with Erdogan—that is his decision and his prerogative—but on these and so many other issues, President Trump's actions do not represent the values of the American people or their representatives in Congress. He does not represent those who support holding Russia accountable. He does not represent those who stand against war crimes in Syria. He does not represent those who want to see a democratic Turkey.

Despite our objections, President Trump will welcome Erdogan to the Oval Office. At the same time, it is worth pointing out that so many months into the controversy surrounding Ukraine, President Trump has yet to set a date for an Oval Office meeting with Ukraine's President Zelensky.

President Zelensky is a true friend to the United States on the frontlines of the struggle for democracy in his country. He is standing up to Russian aggression and corruption. He is respecting the free press. He is working to strengthen democratic institutions. President Zelensky is everything that President Erdogan of Turkey is not. Yet it is Turkey that President Trump continues to admire and Ukraine that he continues to demonize.

Something is wrong here. Something is wrong. We should not have to cross our fingers and hope that any American President stands up for our values, holds our adversaries accountable, and does the right thing when it matters most. It should not be a question. It should be a given. Yet all I can do at this time is hope that President Trump will reverse course and challenge the bad behavior of an authoritarian like Erdogan rather than celebrate it.

With that, I yield the floor.

ADJOURNMENT UNTIL 10 A.M. TOMORROW

The PRESIDING OFFICER. Under the previous order, the Senate stands adjourned until 10 a.m. tomorrow.

Thereupon, the Senate, at 7:01 p.m., adjourned until Wednesday, November 13, 2019, at 10 a.m.

NOMINATIONS

Executive nominations received by the Senate:

IN THE AIR FORCE

THE FOLLOWING NAMED AIR NATIONAL GUARD OF THE UNITED STATES OFFICERS FOR APPOINTMENT TO THE GRADE INDICATED IN THE RESERVE OF THE AIR FORCE UNDER TITLE 10, U.S.C., SECTIONS 12203 AND 12212:

To be colonel

THOMAS JASON ABELL
MAURICIA P. ALO
KEVIN D. ALONS
SOTERA L. ANDERSON
ROBERT P. ANDREWS
WILLIAM B. ANNIE
DAMON B. ARMITAGE
JENNIFER LEE ARMSTRONG
RYAN DOYLE AYERS
DOUGLAS H. BAILEY
CLAY M. BALDWIN
SEAN P. BARNETT
YAAKOV BRUHAEL BINDELL
JASSEN L. BLUTO
WILLIAM R. BOHNSTEDT
EDWARD F. BORNEO
ANTHONY STEPHEN BRADLEY
CLARK J. BRAMANTE
PATRICK LEE BROWN
BRIAN JAMES BUDDEN
FRANCIS X. BUSER
JESSE RYAN CARLSON
KYLE JOHN CERFOGLIO
DAVID ROY CHAUVIN
CHRISTOPHER JOHN CHERNEY
SHAWN M. CLINE
RALPH S. COLEMAN, JR.
MANUEL ANGEL COLON–DEJESUS
EDWARD WARREN COOK, JR.
LOUIS A. DAVENPORT
CHRISTOPHER R. DINOTE
TODD HENRY DOMACHOWSKI
ENRIQUE DOVALO, JR.
NATHAN O. DREWRY
ROBERT EDWARD DRISCOLL, JR.
CHRISTOPHER A. EASON
MANSOUR GEORGE ELHIHI
ERIC NILS ERICKSON, JR.
BRANDON WREGG ESKAM
AMANDA B. EVANS
CHARLES R. EWINGS III
KATHLEEN ANN FALLIS
CHRISTOPHER ALLEN FIELDS
DOUGLAS JAY FIKE
JEREMY RICHARD FORD
TERESA RENEE FRANK
MATTHEW WARD GALLEGOS
JUAN CARLOS GARCIA
SHELDON MCLANE GARDNER
JOSEPH PATRICK GEANEY
KRISTOPHER R. GEIS
GRACE ANN GIBBS
FRED GINSBURG
DANIEL W. GOWDER
NATHAN EDWARD GRABER
JULIE ANN GRATION
MARK C. HANSEN
RYAN NATHANIEL HARRIS
JASON LEE HAWK
TIMOTHY BLANE HAYNES
MICHAEL W. HOLDCROFT
CHAD ERIC HOLESKO
STEVEN J. HUNTER
NICOLE ANNE IVERS
EDWARD WORTH KELLER III
LISA KIRK
MICHAEL B. KOSDERKA
AMY P. KREMSER
JASON J. LABANT
JEREMY CHRISTOPHER LASITER
WILLIAM J. LAYTON
KRISTY JO LEASMAN
TODD A. LUCE
AARON J. MATHENA
GLENDA M. MATHURINLEE
BRIAN S. MCCULLOUGH
MATTHEW RICHARD MCDONOUGH
MATTHEW J. MCGARRY
MICHAEL PATRICK MCGINN
JENNIFER MAMULA MUMME
ROBERT JOSEPH NOVAK, JR.
JODY W. OGLE
BRIAN L. PARKER
ANTHONY JOHN PASQUALE
AERICK GOURLAY PAXTON
JONATHAN TODD PINKARD
ROBERT ALAN PLANTE
TROY DEAN POORMAN
KRISTIAN BRIAN POST
BRANDON J. POWELL
KEVIN S. RAY
CHRISTOPHER TERREN RAYMOND
JAMES TODD REEMAN
WILLIAM ROBERT ROCHE
MATTHEW PARRISH SANDS
MARC ANTHONY SCORSONE
KRISTOF K. SILLS
BEVERLEY ANN SIMPSON
JACOB P. SKUGRUD
STEVEN JON SMART
JONATHAN T. SMIES
JEFFREY W. SMITH II
SKY W. SMITH
EDWARD MICHAEL SOTO
DAVID J. SPISSO II
TIMOTHY PAUL STANLEY
GLENN HIGHTOWER STEPHENS
JESSICA Y. SULLIVAN
KELLY CALHOUN SULLIVAN
DARCY DELPHON TATE
JON M. TAYLOR
FREDRICK H. THOMAS II
BRET A. TRIPPEL
EDWIN EUGENE TUHY, JR.
ANDREW J. VANDERZIEL
RICHARD GRAHAM VOGT
JAMES BRIAN VOGUS
CHARLES B. WARREN
BART MAYNARD WILDER
JOE FORREST WILDMAN
WILLIAM JENNINGS WILKINSON
AARON THOMAS WILSON
KEITH CHARLES WILSON
DANIEL C. WRAZIEN
KERBY JOHN WRIGHT
BRYAN DOUGLAS YATES
LAWRENCE NAHNO YAZZIE

THE FOLLOWING NAMED OFFICER FOR APPOINTMENT TO THE GRADE INDICATED IN THE REGULAR AIR FORCE UNDER TITLE 10, U.S.C., SECTION 531:

To be major

JOSHUA B. STIERWALT

IN THE ARMY

THE FOLLOWING NAMED OFFICER FOR APPOINTMENT TO THE GRADE INDICATED IN THE RESERVE OF THE ARMY UNDER TITLE 10, U.S.C., SECTION 12203:

To be colonel

GERALD J. HALL

THE FOLLOWING NAMED OFFICER FOR APPOINTMENT TO THE GRADE INDICATED IN THE UNITED STATES ARMY UNDER TITLE 10, U.S.C., SECTION 624:

To be major

NICOLE L. KRUSE

IN THE NAVY

THE FOLLOWING NAMED OFFICER FOR APPOINTMENT TO THE GRADE INDICATED IN THE UNITED STATES NAVY RESERVE UNDER TITLE 10, U.S.C., SECTION 12203:

To be captain

THOMAS Q. GALLAGHER

IN THE MARINE CORPS

THE FOLLOWING NAMED OFFICER FOR APPOINTMENT IN THE GRADE INDICATED IN THE REGULAR MARINE CORPS UNDER TITLE 10, U.S.C., SECTIONS 531 AND 1211:

To be captain

EMMA R. SHINN

THE FOLLOWING NAMED OFFICER FOR TEMPORARY APPOINTMENT TO THE GRADE INDICATED IN THE UNITED STATES MARINE CORPS UNDER TITLE 10, U.S.C., SECTION 8287:

To be major

RYAN J. NOWLIN

EXTENSIONS OF REMARKS

LATE CONGRESSMAN JOHN H. ADLER

HON. DONALD NORCROSS

OF NEW JERSEY

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. NORCROSS. Madam Speaker, I rise today to honor and commend the late Cherry Hill, New Jersey resident, Congressman John H. Adler at the John H. Adler Memorial Park Dedication.

The late Congressman John Adler grew up in Haddonfield, New Jersey where his father owned a small dry-cleaning store, attended Haddonfield public schools and graduated from Haddonfield Memorial High School. He went on to attend Harvard University where he obtained his Bachelor of Arts degree in Government, and a Juris Doctor from Harvard Law School. John met his wife Shelley in law school and after they graduated, they returned to South Jersey and settled down in Cherry Hill.

In 1988 Adler began serving on the Cherry Hill Township Council where he passed the Township's ethics ordinance, was committed to strengthening Cherry Hill schools and improving health care. In 1991, Adler ran for a seat in the New Jersey Senate, representing New Jersey's Sixth Legislative District and won the election. He served as a New Jersey State Senator from 1992 to 2009. During his time in the New Jersey Senate, Adler served on the Judiciary Committee as Chair, the Environment Committee, and sponsored vital legislation designed to address key environmental and health related issues, including the Smoke-Free Air Act that banned smoking in most public places. He also championed major ethics reforms, support for children and adults with disabilities and laws that made our state and communities safer.

In 2008, Adler ran for the State of New Jersey's Third Congressional District seat and won the election. This was the first time a Democrat held that seat in over one hundred years. He was sworn into office in January 2009 and served on the Committee on Financial Services and the Committee on Veteran's Affairs. During his tenure he spearheaded legislation to support our veterans and seniors, protect women's healthcare, help working families, protect consumers, and end the Great Recession.

In 2011 Adler suddenly passed away. He is survived by his wife Shelley, and their four sons, Jeffrey, Alex, Andrew, and Oliver. In 2011, Shelley Adler started the John H. Adler Memorial Fund for Veterans' Affairs at Harvard University, which supports interdisciplinary research and programs intended to promote effective governmental policy as it relates to veterans.

On November 2, 2019 the Camden County Board of Freeholders will dedicate the John H. Adler Memorial Park at Challenge Grove to commemorate Adler's life and dedication to public service.

Madam Speaker, I ask you to join me in honoring the late Congressman John Adler, of Cherry Hill, New Jersey, a dedicated public servant who fought tirelessly for the people of New Jersey for more than two decades.

HONORING GLEN OAKS ELEMENTARY SCHOOL FOR BEING NAMED A NATIONAL BLUE RIBBON SCHOOL

HON. DANIEL LIPINSKI

OF ILLINOIS

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. LIPINSKI. Madam Speaker, I rise today to recognize Glen Oaks Elementary School in Hickory Hills, Illinois, for being honored with the prestigious 2019 U.S. Department of Education National Blue Ribbon School Award. The award was conferred under the Exemplary High Performing Schools category.

In 1982, the U.S. Department of Education established the National Blue Ribbon Schools Program to recognize public and private schools boasting high or significantly improved achievement. I am proud that Glen Oaks Elementary School of Hickory Hills, Illinois, has been honored as one of those exceptional schools.

This is not the first time Glen Oaks Elementary School has been honored for excellence in education. In 2012, Glen Oaks was designated for the first time as a National Blue Ribbon School. This year, Glen Oaks Elementary School has been recognized for performance in the top ten percent of all Illinois schools, and has also received a designation of exemplary from the Illinois State Board of Education.

Under the direction of District Superintendent Dr. Jeannie Stachowiak, School Principal Kristin Reingruber, and Assistant Principal Carla Braun, teachers implement a collaborative approach to classroom learning that facilitates individual growth. The teachers are committed to Glen Oak Elementary School's mission for every student to realize their full potential as a socially responsible lifelong learner. The Glen Oaks Positive Behavior Interventions and Supports (PBIS) program and the Academic Student Success Enrichment Teams (ASSETS) developed by teachers and administrators have also had a positive impact on student achievement.

Madam Speaker, I ask my colleagues to join me in congratulating Glen Oaks Elementary School for this remarkable achievement and recognizing the teachers, administrators, students, parents, and community for the hard work that they have put in to earn this award.

HONORING RIVER ROUGE POLICE LIEUTENANT RON GUFFEY

HON. RASHIDA TLAIB

OF MICHIGAN

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Ms. TLAIB. Madam Speaker, I rise today in tribute to Lieutenant Ron Guffey who served on the City of River Rouge's Police Department on the occasion of his retirement.

During his twenty-three years with the police force, Lieutenant Guffey has served with dedication and bravery. He first joined the City of River Rouge's Police Department as a patrol officer in 1996. Lieutenant Guffey served the force in several capacities and rose through the ranks, serving as Corporal, Detective, and Sergeant before ultimately retiring as Lieutenant. Lieutenant Guffey's presence will be missed and is a loss for the community and the City of River Rouge.

In short, Lieutenant Guffey has served bravely and nobly. Please join me in saluting him for his twenty-three years of public service as we wish him well on his retirement.

550TH BIRTHDAY OF SIKH GURU NANAK

HON. GREG PENCE

OF INDIANA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. PENCE. Madam Speaker, I rise today to recognize a very special day for the Hoosier Sikh Community: the 550th birthday of Guru Nanak, the founder of Sikhism. This occasion will be celebrated by more than 25,000,000 Sikhs worldwide on November 12, 2019.

Indiana is proud to be home to over 10,000 Sikhs that enrich our communities and embody the meaning of Hoosier values.

Hoosier Sikhs are one of the fastest growing business communities in Indiana, and their contributions to our economy and culture are valued.

On this day I am proud to stand with our friends in the Sikh community by offering legislation to celebrate this momentous occasion and honor their contributions to Indiana and to our great nation.

IN HONOR OF REVEREND ROOSEVELT CARTER, I

HON. SANFORD D. BISHOP, Jr.

OF GEORGIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. BISHOP of Georgia. Madam Speaker, I rise today to honor an outstanding Man of God, a devoted spiritual leader, and dear friend of longstanding, Reverend Roosevelt Carter, I, who retired from his role as Senior

Pastor of First Monumental Faith Ministries in Albany, Georgia after over three decades of selfless service and was honored on Saturday, November 9, 2019, at 5:00 pm.

In 1984, Reverend Carter answered the call to preach the word of God and founded First Monumental Faith Ministries alongside his wife, First Lady, and Co-Pastor, LaVerne Shinault Carter. For the past 35 years, Rev. Carter has been the shepherd at First Monumental where he has ministered to the needs of his flockchristening babies, baptizing believers, performing marriages, and consoling bereaved families while developing and honing his skills as a church administrator and inspiring spiritual leader. Under The Carters' dynamic and spirit-filled leadership, First Monumental Faith Ministries has experienced tremendous growth. But most importantly, under their leadership, First Monumental has been a beacon of hope and salvation for the congregation through its many ministries that share the good news of our Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ.

Outside of the church, Reverend Carter has also proved himself a true servant of the community in which he lives. His drive led him to organize First Monumental Community Outreach, Inc. (FMCO) to help provide services to those in need. By utilizing its access to government grants, FMCO opened ''Job's Place'', the first assistance program for persons diagnosed with HIV/AIDS in the Dougherty County area. Reverend Carter and FMCO also joined forces with the City of Albany & the Dougherty County Coalition to help end homelessness by leading the charge to acquire government funding from the Department of Housing & Urban Development (HUD) to support and transition over 15 families to self-sustainable living. Furthermore, Reverend Carter also extended the reach of First Monumental Faith Ministries through the Monumental Development Center and the Fluff-n-Fold Laundromat to aid in job creation for residents in the community.

Reverend Carter has achieved much in his life, but none of it would have been possible without the Grace of God and the love and the support of his loving wife, LaVerne, and his children, Roosevelt, Jr., Roderald, Lorenzo, and Renorta.

On a personal note, I have been blessed by Reverend Carter's sage counsel and enduring friendship over the time that I have known him. He has always encouraged and supported me during my career in Congress and, I am proud to call him my friend.

Madam Speaker, I ask my colleagues to join my wife, Vivian, and me, along with the 730,000 residents of Georgia's Second Congressional District, in extending our sincerest congratulations and best wishes to Reverend Roosevelt Carter, I on the occasion of his retirement and in congratulating him for 35 outstanding years of leadership at First Monumental Faith Ministries, and for a lifetime of selfless service to God, the church, and to humankind.

HONORING MARINE RETIRED CWO-3 WARRANT OFFICER DANIEL PAYNE

HON. JIM COSTA

OF CALIFORNIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. COSTA. Madam Speaker, I rise today to recognize my dear friend Mr. Daniel ''Dan'' Payne as he is honored as the 2019 Grand Marshal for the 100th Anniversary of the Central Valley Veterans Day Parade (CVVDP). Dan has dedicated his life to his country and the people of the Central Valley.

Dan was born in San Jose, California to Frank and Ubelia Payne on August 16, 1954. He attended local schools while working in the fields picking apricots and other fruits. He attended college but soon changed course. He enlisted into the Marine Corps in 1973, inspired by a television commercial about the branch. Dan told his then-girlfriend and now wife of 43 years Mary, that he was going to enlist the next day. He served as an enlisted member for 12 years, achieving the rank of Gunnery Sergeant. In 1986, he applied for Officers Candidates School and was accepted in February 1987. Despite severely injuring his knee, Dan continued his training to become an officer, graduating that same year.

Dan attended Electronics Radar Pulse Acquisitions Control HAWK Guided Missile, Command and Control Electronics Tech HAWK Guided Missile, HAWK Guided Missile Systems Tech, and Tactical Basics School TBS Quantico, Virginia. He has an associate degree in Law Enforcement, Missiles and Munitions, and an Electrical Engineering degree from Trinity University. A Decorated Desert Storm Veteran, Dan was the first Hispanic Chief Warrant Officer (CWO) in the HAWK Guided Missile field in the Marine Corps.

During his time in the Marines, Dan was a boxer and played multiple sports. He trained in Shotokan while he was in Japan and earned 4 black belts. He was named in Who's Who of Martial Arts and fought many different fighters, including Chuck Norris.

After being deployed and stationed around the world, Dan's last stop was in Fresno, California where he and his wife Mary, and two daughters Rebecca and Rachel, settled. In 1996, Dan retired as CWO–3 and began teaching at Fresno City College Training Institute. He was awarded the Center for Applied Competitive Technology (CACT) Teacher's Award in 1998. Dan was an ordained pastor while he was in the Marines and decided to continue this path after retirement.

Dan is also the founder and CEO of Cable Links Construction. The construction firm provides training for Lucent, Siecor, 3–M Amp, and other telecommunication companies. Their specialties are in fiber optics and high-speed copper cable. Over the years, Cable Links has also expanded into construction. Since its founding 20 years ago, Cable Links has grown into a successful small-business in the Central Valley. It has been featured in the Fresno Bee as one of the fastest-growing companies in the Central Valley, and twice was mentioned in Inc Magazine as one of the fastest-growing companies in the United States.

Following his retirement from the Marine Corps, Dan has served his community. Some of his many contributions include leading mission trips to Mexico for New Covenant Community Church for 15 years, and as music leader for Celebrate Recovery 12-Step Program. He was Co-Chair for Toys-for-Tots in 2011, Chairman of Central Valley Veterans K–9 fundraising for 11 years, Post Commander for American Legion Post 4, Executive Director of the California Veterans Action Alliance, Board Member of the Central Valley Veterans Retirement Home, and CEO since 2010 and announcer of the CVVDP since 2003.

Throughout his career Dan has received recognition, including as local television affiliate KSEE24's Hispanic Portrait of Success recipient in 1999; 2002 Business Man of the Year; honored with his 3 brothers and 2 sisters as the La Familia Silicon Valley Hispanic Veteran and Community Family of the Year in 2010; Guest of Honor for the Marine Corps Ball; the Gold Medal for volunteer work by President Bush in 2002; appointed to President George W. Bush's tax Sub-Committee.

Madam Speaker, it is with great respect that I ask my colleagues in the U.S. House of Representatives to congratulate CWO–3 Warrant Officer Dan Payne as he celebrates his last year as CEO of the Central Valley Veterans Day Parade and is honored as their Grand Marshal. I have had the honor to work with Dan for over 20 years and he is more than well-deserved of this recognition. I ask that you join me in wishing Dan and his family continued success, health and happiness.

RECOGNIZING JANE LOIS WELLER'S 100TH BIRTHDAY

HON. HARLEY ROUDA

OF CALIFORNIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. ROUDA. Madam Speaker, I rise today to recognize Jane Lois Weller of Huntington Beach for her service to our country during World War II and to honor her recent 100th birthday. Born in Chicago just after World War I and raised during the Great Depression, Ms. Weller bore witness to some of the most tumultuous times in our nation's history. By virtue of this upbringing, and because of what many would call an ambitious spirit, Ms. Weller went on to lead a life dedicated to service, both to her country and to her family.

Just one year after graduating from Nursing School at the Evangelical Hospital in Chicago, Ms. Weller enlisted in the United States Army Air Corps in December 1942. After completing flight school at Bowman Field in Kentucky, she was stationed at Hickam Field on Oahu, Hawaii.

From Hawaii to the Mariana Islands to the Solomon Islands to the Philippines, Ms. Weller bravely risked her life to tend to many soldiers wounded on the frontlines. For her valiant service in active combat zones throughout the Pacific Theater, Ms. Weller was awarded two Bronze Stars.

After the war. Ms. Weller graduated from the University of California, Berkeley, continued to serve as nurse in the public sector, and raised her three children. She has always kept an active mind, enjoying hobbies including astronomy, biblical and classical studies, knitting, jazz piano, singing, and more. I ask that all Members join me in recognizing the remarkable life and service of Jane Lois Weller on the occasion of her recent 100th birthday.

HONORING THE 100TH BIRTHDAY OF MR. GEORGE ARNOLD

HON. RASHIDA TLAIB

OF MICHIGAN

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Ms. TLAIB. Madam Speaker, I rise today to recognize my constituent, George Arnold's 100th birthday.

George Daniel Arnold was born in Reidsville, Georgia, to Joseph James and Susie Snell Arnold. The youngest of ten, he was affectionately nicked named GD by his older siblings. George graduated from Dorchester Academy where he received training as a plasterer. After graduation, George left home and traveled through the south, practicing his trade until 1943.

The lure of better opportunities convinced him to join his brothers in Detroit, Michigan. Once in Detroit, he quickly became part of the community by joining Aijlon Baptist Church. Today he is one of Aijlon's longest serving ushers, sitting on the usher board since 1946. In 1943 he also joined the King David Grand Lodge and is a dedicated member to this day. He has earned many titles of distinction such as, 33rd degree Mason, Past Grand Lecturer, Worshipful Master, Shriner, and Knight of the Temple. His past and current positions include Dean of the Most Worshipful Institute of Learning and Past Instructor of the Most Worshipful Institute of Learning, which in August of this year was renamed the George D. Arnold Institute of Learning in recognition for his devoted service to his Masonic Brothers. As part of his continual service, George also performs burial ceremonies in Detroit, Flint, Saginaw, and Grand Rapids.

In short, Mr. Arnold is a dedicated family man, business owner, and Michigander and we are excited to honor him on his 100th birthday.

HONORING THE 2019 WOMEN OF THE YEAR

HON. JOHN GARAMENDI

OF CALIFORNIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. GARAMENDI. Madam Speaker, I rise today to honor the 2019 Women of the Year. The honorees represent some of the most outstanding and dedicated women in the 3rd Congressional District. Nominated by their peers, these women and the leadership they have provided are being recognized for playing an integral and crucial role in improving the lives of everyone in their communities.

During the last 50 years women have made great strides in America. It used to be almost unheard of to see women as elected officials, CEOs, senior military officials, doctors or attorneys, but today many of our most successful leaders in the world are women. This progress has not come easy and many women before you have worked hard and strived to achieve the independence and rights you have today. I realize there is more work to be done to ensure that women have equal pay, flexible work schedules and affordable education. Each of the honorees will be a vital part of the future successes for women.

2019's Women of the Year are:

Kellie Geweke Sheeran is a Sutter County native who has worked continuously to give back to her community. A Yuba City High School graduate, Kellie graduated from Chico State with a degree in Organizational Communications before returning home in 2003 to join the family business at Geweke Ford Kia Collision. Over the years, Kellie has contributed tremendously through her family's non-profit organization, Geweke's Caring for Women Foundation, where she served as Director from 2008 to 2010. This organization financially assists local women facing cancer, having now provided over 10,000 women low-cost mammograms and women's health screenings. Under her leadership, the Geweke's Caring for Women Foundation has helped over 430 cancer survivors through numerous grants. Beyond her work with her family's foundation, she has been a steadfast advocate for breast cancer awareness, co-chairing the Pink October Race for Awareness for the last 12 years alongside her sister. Kellie is also an active member of Early Risers Kiwanis and has supported Beale Airforce Base as part of the Beale Military Liaison Council for 10 years, where she has been an honorary commander since 2011. Kellie's passion and dedication make her an invaluable member of the Yuba-Sutter community.

Joyce Hammond is a dedicated educator who has educated thousands of students on topics of health and nutrition. With 24 years of service to the Yuba City Unified School District, she has made a lasting impact on the community. Recently, Joyce has partnered with Sutter County Public Health and CalFresh to promote healthy and active lifestyles by teaching her students about good nutrition and how to make healthy choices through the CalFresh Healthy Living Program. Joyce's invaluable experience in education coupled with her expertise in nutrition has allowed her to seamlessly introduce this new program into her Childhood Development, Early Childhood Careers and Life Management, and Nutritional Science classes. Joyce also takes the time to serve as a co-advisor to the campus Family and Consumer Science Club where she encourages her students to participate in the healthy living program. Joyce's passion, commitment, and professionalism have been a source of inspiration to her colleagues who admire her determination to provide her students with the skills that will help them lead healthy lives for years to come. Joyce's tireless work to improve the quality of life for her students and their families will leave a lasting impact on her community.

Ms. Kathleen Heeren served her country in the United States Army and, following her honorable discharge, continued her life of service by devoting her time to advocating on behalf of her fellow veterans. She is a lifetime member of the American Legion, where she has volunteered for over 21 years. Over the years, Kathleen has served as Commander of the Vacaville American Legion Post 165, Commander of the American Legion 5th District, and the Women Veteran's Representative to the California American Legion. She now serves as the Women Veteran's Representative to the Vacaville Soroptimist International where she has been a member for over 10 years and given her time to a number of committees within the organization. Her generosity and volunteer work have extended to many youth programs in her community including the Vanden High School JROTC program, local Boy Scout troops, and the American Legion Boys and Girls State programs. Kathleen has truly lived a life of service, wearing the uniform for her country before going on to honor the men and women who served before, after, and alongside her through her work with veteran organizations. Kathleen is an integral part of the Vacaville veteran community and has touched the lives of many.

Kelly Heung has committed her life to helping children of all abilities and backgrounds thrive. Through her many professional and volunteer positions, Kelly has dedicated countless hours to supporting children in her community. Throughout her career she has devoted herself to understanding and meeting the needs of children and has lived that commitment in all her professional and personal actions. Having earned her PhD in Human Development, Kelly became an authority on autism and other neurodevelopmental disorders and now uses her expertise to mentor future leaders in the field. She has also become an active advocate for education in Yolo County, volunteering her time with the Superintendent Parent Advisory Committee, Davis Parent University Board, Davis Joint Unified School District Strategic Planning Committee, Davis Schools Foundation, Parent Teacher Association, and multiple School Site Councils. Kelly has used her positions within all of these organizations to champion the interests of underserved children and ensure equitable treatment for all students throughout her community. Kelly has inspired others with her compassion, conscientiousness, and commitment to being the voice for children who are unable to advocate for themselves. She is generous with her time, energy, and kindness, and is a devoted mother, wife, daughter, and friend.

Rosemary Hicks is a dedicated advocate for children and families in her community. For 42 years, Rosemary has been a devoted part of the Colusa Unified School District. As a former para-educator and current administrative assistant to the Principal of Burchfield Primary School, Rosemary has touched the lives of so many children, teachers, and families. She is known throughout her community as someone who will always find a way to help a family in need. Around the holidays Rosemary is a driving force behind countless community food, clothing, and shoe drives, as well as Toys for Tots programs. She has also served her community through leadership positions in organizations such as the Colusa Little League, IMPACT Thrift Store, the Catholic Ladies Auxiliary, the Lions Club, the Rotary Club, and many more. She is also an active member of the California School Employees Association where she has been a strong advocate for her colleagues. Through her tireless work and dedication to helping others, Rosemary has become a pillar of support for families and children in Colusa. She is known by everyone in Colusa as the heart and soul of the Colusa Unified School District and the community at large.

Jaye Hurt is dedicated to giving back to the men and women who serve our country and the families who support them. Through her work as the Team Lead at the Airman and Family Readiness Center, Jaye is highly respected and admired for her constant dedication to ensuring that our Airmen and their families get the services and support that they

need. As Team Lead, Jaye has provided oversight to key support programs that have helped over 73,000 military personnel. She coordinated the Monthly Hearts Apart Program, which provided activities for children and social emotional support for spouses of deployed troops. Jaye has focused many of her efforts on supporting troops and their families during deployment. She facilitated over 50 pre-deployment briefings and ensured that family members felt prepared and supported by the base community. She organized a Deployer Care project that sent more than 400 care packages to deployed troops. She has also worked with local community leaders to ensure viable employment opportunities for Military Spouses. Jaye was also the driving force behind the Annual Base Freedom Walk, where her coordination efforts resulted in the participation of more than 900 students. She also played a role in starting the Travis Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual and Transgender Alliance, is a founding member of the Special Needs Task Force for families with exceptional family members, is a Traumatic Stress Response Team member, and oversees many other support services encompassed by the Diversity Working Group. Through her commitment to excellence and continual support, Jaye has changed the lives of thousands of military personnel and their families.

Erica Hurtado has dedicated herself to improving the lives of children within her community. As a member of the Founding Families for the Dixon Montessori Charter School, Erica assisted in setting up classrooms, offices, and other sites around the campus in preparation for the first school year. For years, she donated her time and skill as a professional photographer to capture photos of students and staff. It was during this time that Erica joined the DMCS board of directors where she is still active today. Erica also helped form the first Dixon Little League Challengers Team, which gave children with cognitive and physical disabilities the opportunity to fulfill their dreams of participating in a team sport. After receiving immense support for the organization from the community, Erica was inspired to create T.E.A.M. Dixon with the emphasis that ''Together Everyone Always Matters.'' In founding this non-profit organization, Erica was instrumental in helping to break down barriers facing those with special needs while simultaneously helping to build their confidence and increase community awareness and understanding. T.E.A.M. Dixon's mission, with the help of Erica's vision and generosity, has spread to nearby towns where they wish to bring the same compassion and kindness to their community. Through her hard work and dedication, Erica has had a positive impact on the lives of countless children in her community.

Roberta James is an active member of her community who has devoted her time to promoting education, reading, and an appreciation for the arts and literature in Colusa. As an educator, she dedicated her career to keeping students engaged in their education, working with families, and mentoring new teachers. Ten years ago, Roberta founded the Virginia Yerxa Community Read and formed a committee of women who established the first one-book project in Colusa County, doing so in memory of another Colusa woman who was a tireless advocate for literacy. Every year, a new book selection is chosen to shine a light on different areas of the community. Several events are planned throughout the year that bring everyone together to share their interests and experiences through a shared appreciation of that year's book. Thanks to Roberta's commitment to the project, the Virginia Read has become part of the fabric of the Colusa community. Roberta still teaches part time while using the rest of her time to focus on art. She founded an Artist-in-Residence program which offers a space for artists to work on their craft in exchange for sharing their talents with the local community. Through this program and her support of the Colusa County Arts Council, Roberta works to promote her community as a destination for those interested in the arts. Roberta is an integral member of her community, consistently finding and addressing the needs of Colusa.

Mary Rose Kennedy has devoted her career and personal life to caring for and educating children. A mother of five, retired teacher, and current classroom volunteer, Mary Rose has touched the lives of countless children in her community. Having retired after more than 25 years of service to the Orland Unified School District, she now has the pleasure of seeing the impact she has made on her community when she is fondly greeted by her former students. Mary Rose was a strong and dedicated educator who was honored as a Glenn County Teacher of the Year, and later inducted into the Glenn County Educator's Hall of Fame. Though now retired, she continues to volunteer her time in classrooms helping children learn the joy of reading. Her volunteer work also extends beyond the classroom where she uses her grant writing skills to help secure funding for community organizations such as the Orland Arts Commission, the Orland Beautification Committee, and a local club providing scholarships to deserving high school students. Mary Rose is an integral member of the Orland community and has played a vital role in its improvement and growth.

Through her diligent dedication to her community, Juantia Menefee has become an unwavering pillar of support for those in her community with the greatest need. She has devoted her career to serving those in need of housing assistance and ensuring they receive the services they need. Through her work with Volunteers for America, Juantia became part of a national network of service organizations providing life altering support to 1.5 million people every year. She has also worked with the Department of Housing and Urban Development to help underprivileged individuals and families find affordable housing and employment. Juantia also volunteers with arts and reading programs at local schools, working to ensure that the students within her community are engaged and successful in their academic endeavors. Juantia's service to her community can be seen in everything she does, from her career path to her volunteer work, she devotes her time to serving others.

Glenda Nelson was born and raised on Enterprise Rancheria, instilled with the importance of honor and duty in serving her Native People. She surmounted many hardships before becoming one of the first Native American women to graduate college. Glenda then used her voice and her education to protect the Rancheria Lands and the sovereign rights of indigenous peoples, leading to her eventual election to the Tribal Council. Her desire to serve expanded to active involvement in political advocacy at the state and federal level, where she provided testimony on legislation and advocated for increased funding, protection of tribal sovereignty, and protection of the Indian Child Welfare Act. She has served as a delegate to the California Nations Indian Gaming Association and the National Congress of the American Indians. Glenda played an integral role in developing educational programs and participated in the founding of the Ipakanni Early College Charter School. Glenda has fought on behalf of her community on every issue, serving as a member of the Board of Directors for Feather River Tribal Health, a board member for the Enterprise Rancheria Indian Housing Authority, a delegate to the National American Indian Housing Council, and a delegate to the California Tribal Families Coalition. After years of hard work and leadership, together with the Tribal Council, Glenda is credited with creating hundreds of jobs in the region by making the vision of opening a casino in Yuba County a reality. Glenda's passionate and effective advocacy on behalf of her community will have a lasting impact for generations to come.

Pat Nicodemus has spent the last 35 years serving her community and working to improve the lives of some of the most disadvantaged populations. Early in her career, Pat helped found an emergency foster program where she helped recruit and prepare families to adopt drug exposed infants, ensuring a safe place for children facing unimaginable challenges. Later in her career she began to work on decreasing recidivism by helping incarcerated individuals access parenting classes, drug treatment programs, and other educational services essential for survival outside of the prison system. Pat co-founded the Women's ReEntry and Achievement Program, a program to guide incarcerated women to address their past trauma, deal with their addictions, and have the best possible chance to become productive members of their communities. Through this program, Pat has helped hundreds of women and their families lift themselves into prosperity. Her compassion, wisdom, patience, and devotion to serving women and families has transformed many lives and her positive impact on her community will span generations.

Vangie Porras has been an integral part of her community of Glenn County and has served in some form since 1989. As one of the first Latino students welcomed into the Orland School district, Vangie faced stark challenges to having her voice heard. But that didn't stop her from finding ways to become involved in her community. Vangie began her path of service at the Democratic Party booth at the Glenn County Fair in 1989. From there she eventually became treasurer of the Glenn County Democratic Party, holding the organization together with her many years of hard work and well-earned wisdom. Outside politics, Vangie Porras expanded her portfolio of service to the Orland Unified School Board and the Glenn County Fair Board. Her work ensured that current students never had to face the same challenges she faced in Glenn County and held together a tightly knit county fair community. Vangie Porras has become a permanent fixture of public service in Glenn County. On behalf of the people of Orland and the 3rd Congressional District, I offer Vangie Porras my congratulations and well wishes for her future endeavors.

Navneet Randhawa is a dedicated community servant who has routinely taken the time to reach out to people in need and bring communities together. In 2012 Navneet participated in the Sutter County Library's Citizenship Preparation class, where she learned of their Literacy Services Program. She was interested in the opportunity to give back to the library and volunteered a tutor for ESL students with the lowest reading levels. Colleagues and students alike attest to her friendly and welcoming manner as she provided critical assistance with the program. Navneet also worked tirelessly for Casa de Esperanza, a shelter, counseling, advocacy, and education facility for adult and child survivors of domestic violence, sexual violence, child abuse, elder abuse, and human trafficking. Through her work as a bi-lingual counselor advocate she was instrumental in bridging the gap between the organization and her Southeast Asian community, helping Casa de Esperanza reach more people in need of their services. She also worked to help her colleagues better understand her culture so they could better serve the community. Though Navneet now works as a nurse, she continues to volunteer her time with Casa where she continues to make a positive difference in people's lives. Navneet's unique skill and compassion in bringing together communities and treating everyone with compassion is a joy and inspiration to everyone around her.

Margaret Renn has dedicated her life to educating children throughout her community. Margaret taught in elementary school classrooms for 16 years at schools in San Jose, Vallejo, and Fairfield before going on to serve as an elementary school principal in the Fairfield-Suisun Unified School District for 16 more years. Now in retirement, Margaret continues her passion for education by volunteering with the Solano County Chapter of the California Retired Teachers Association. In addition to her many years of service as a public educator, Margaret now spends her free time serving special needs children and adults at the Horseplay Therapeutic Riding Center in Dixon, where she has been volunteering for five years, is one of two volunteer coordinators, and serves on their Board of Directors. Through her work at the Horseplay Therapeutic Center she has the privilege of getting to see special needs riders develop physical strength, social skills, and self confidence while expanding their horsemanship skills. Margaret has dedicated herself to the education and wellbeing of others and her service in the classroom and at the stables have had a lasting positive impact on her community.

Jenn Rexroad is a fierce advocate for children and families throughout our community. As the Founder and Executive Director of the California Alliance of Caregivers, Jenn consistently fights for the needs of at-risk foster care children. Jenn was instrumental in creating and implementing a policy agenda that advocated for the rights of foster children and played a vital role in establishing numerous projects important to children and families. Her work on the Resource Families' Policy Summit and the Mental Health Services Parent Stakeholder Engagement Project has furthered the goal of improving mental health services for all children and youth statewide. Her fervent advocacy has helped to create stronger protections and opportunities for those in need. Jenn is in position to continue her vital work by serving as a First5 Yolo Commissioner and volunteering as the Child Welfare Policy Director for the organization Children Now. Her unbridled energy and concern for those in need are instrumental in creating a more caring and compassionate community. Her work on behalf of children and families in our community will have a lasting impact on generations to come.

Jen Roberts is a passionate activist whose strong and energetic leadership has had a real impact on her community. As founder of Indivisible Colusa, a local volunteer organization focused on engaging in progressive political advocacy, Jen has been tireless in creating ways for local community members to develop their voice. In doing everything from organizing postcard campaigns to composing the Indivisible Colusa newsletter, Jen has been relentless in pursuing ways for community members to engage in the political process on the local, state, and federal levels. She has been known to regularly open her home for meetings and debate watch parties. Her courageous, thoughtful, and principled leadership has allowed Indivisible Colusa to rapidly transform from its humble beginnings in 2017 to the lively and visible presence it is in the community today. Jen is also a founding member of the Colusa County Democratic Central Committee, which held its first meeting in February 2018. Kickstarting this process, Jen was integral in establishing a Democratic party committee in one of the few California counties that didn't already have one. Jen is tireless in her efforts to engage others and ensures that those in her community have a place to develop and express their beliefs while delving into the democratic process.

I congratulate each of them and commend them for their work. I am inspired by them and firmly believe when women succeed, America succeeds.

TRIBUTE TO ANN AND VINCE BELLIS

HON. GREGORY F. MURPHY

OF NORTH CAROLINA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. MURPHY of North Carolina. Madam Speaker, I rise to pay tribute to Ann and Vince Bellis of Greenville, North Carolina.

In October of this year they were honored by the Friends of Greenville Greenways for their efforts to champion, create, and expand the family-friendly walking, running and biking space. They have given countless hours over several years to the fulfillment of this community-enhancing project.

This couple have been honored for a lifetime of civic engagement, their incredible technical knowledge of the environment including a plethora of horticultural expertise and for unselfishly sharing that knowledge with the community.

Many citizens of Greenville daily enjoy the Greenway and I applaud the work of the Bellis' in making what was once just an idea into a beautiful reality for the betterment of our city.

IN HONOR OF JULIO BALSERA

HON. DONNA E. SHALALA

OF FLORIDA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Ms. SHALALA. Madam Speaker, I rise in honor of Julio Balsera, the extraordinary Cuban activist. He passed away last month at the age of 80.

Born in Havana in 1939, Mr. Balsera spent his early years fighting the Castro regime. He fled Cuba by hiding inside the kitchen cabinets of a cargo ship bound for Caracas in 1960, and in 1963, he made his way to Miami.

Mr. Balsera continued his activism in South Florida. He founded the J. Balsera School Bus Service, which offered children rides to school. Through this business, Mr. Balsera became a key figure in the burgeoning Cuban-American community. He got to know the schoolchildren who rode his buses and their families, and he was always happy to provide vote recommendations. He also sent his buses to mobilize voters ahead of elections and to help Cubans arriving in Florida during the Mariel exodus.

Mr. Balsera sold his bus company after four decades of business, but he continued his activism, leading the charge to recall former Miami-Dade Mayor Carlos Alvarez in 2011. He was also a founding member of the Cuban American National Foundation.

Julio Balsera's influence can be seen at nearly every level of government in the greater Miami area, and his legacy of speaking truth to power will be felt for years to come. I'm proud to recognize his contributions to our South Florida community.

HONORING SAINTS CYRIL AND METHODIUS SCHOOL FOR BEING NAMED A NATIONAL BLUE RIBBON SCHOOL

HON. DANIEL LIPINSKI

OF ILLINOIS

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. LIPINSKI. Madam Speaker, I rise today to congratulate Saints Cyril and Methodius School in Lemont, Illinois, for receiving the prestigious 2019 U.S. Department of Education National Blue Ribbon School Award. The school was recognized under the Exemplary High Performing Schools category.

In 1982, the U.S. Department of Education established the National Blue Ribbon Schools Program to recognize public and private schools boasting high or significantly improved achievement. I am proud that Saints Cyril and Methodius School has been honored as one of those exceptional schools.

Saints Cyril and Methodius School has long been a fixture of the Village of Lemont having been founded at the same time as the parish in 1884. The mission of Saints Cyril and Methodius School is to provide an excellent Catholic education in a compassionate environment that strives to develop each student spiritually, academically, physically, and emotionally. The school offers an integrated set of courses to motivate students to understand the connection between the classroom and living one's faith. Students are challenged with a

rigorous and engaging curriculum which includes technology, art, Spanish, physical education, and music classes.

Madam Speaker, I ask my colleagues to join me in recognizing Saints Cyril and Methodius School for being honored with this National Blue Ribbon School Award. This impressive achievement is a well-deserved recognition of all the work done by Principal Shirley Tkachuk, Reverend Waldemar "Valdi" Stawiarski, teachers, school staff, students, parents, and parishioners.

HONORING THE LIFE OF EDWARD WALTER HOSTETLER

HON. JIM COSTA

OF CALIFORNIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. COSTA. Madam Speaker, I rise today to honor and pay tribute to the life of Edward Walter Hostetler, who passed away on October 22, 2019. Edward served our nation with honor and selflessness and will be missed by many in the community.

Edward Walter Hostetler was born on December 17, 1920 in Sugarcreek, Ohio. He attended Ohio State University on a 4-year academic scholarship and was a member of the ROTC program. In 1943, he graduated with an agriculture degree and joined the United States Army, serving during World War II. He served in Germany, Belgium, France, and Luxemburg. He was assigned to the Artillery, Tank Destroyer, Infantry and Calvary Branches as a Lieutenant. In 1945 Edward was assigned to the 7th Army War Crimes Court and was then transferred to a Constabulary Unit. Edward returned home in June of 1946 and was honorably discharged in September of 1946.

Upon his return to civilian life he began teaching in Orville, Ohio, before meeting the love of his life, Merry Belle Groff. The two married in Clearfield, Pennsylvania on December 10, 1947. After honeymooning in California, Edward and Merry made it their permanent home. Together they were the proud parents of Greg, Rory and Suzanne.

Edward and Merry initially lived in Los Angeles where Edward worked as a dairy inspector. Eventually they moved to California's Central Valley. Edward worked for the Chowchilla Water District and Cal Farm Insurance. The family moved to Dos Palos in Merced County in 1964 and eventually opened their own real estate brokerage, Hostetler Real Estate. Edward also supported his wife's entrepreneurship, as she was the proud owner of House of Hostetler Antiques.

Edward always enjoyed being surrounded by family and making new memories with his children and grandchildren. The family frequently vacationed together, creating lifelong memories. He was a man of strong faith and believed in helping others in need. Edward could always be found watching his Ohio State Buckeyes on Saturday afternoons.

Edward is preceded in death by his beloved wife of 70 years Merry Belle, his brother Richard Hostetler, and his daughter-in-law Cathie Hostetler.

He is survived by his sons Greg and Rory Hostetler of Los Banos, California, daughter Suzanna Hostetler Rider of Fresno, California, four grandchildren and four greatgrandchildren.

Madam Speaker, I ask my colleagues to join me in honoring the life of Edward Walter Hostetler. His presence in the community will be greatly missed. I join his family and friends in honoring his great life.

HONORING THE LIFE AND LEGACY OF W. GEORGE ALLEN

HON. ALCEE L. HASTINGS

OF FLORIDA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. HASTINGS. Madam Speaker, I rise today with a heavy heart to honor the life and legacy of my dear friend, W. George Allen, a selfless member of our community who spent his life serving others. I had the great privilege of working alongside George as his law partner for many years. Throughout his more than four-decade career practicing law, he established himself as one of our state's most influential civil rights advocates. I will never forget the years we spent working together to fight and end segregation in Broward County.

George was born in Sanford, Florida in 1936. He attended Florida A&M University and received his Bachelor of Science degree in Political Science with a minor in Economics, before continuing his education at the University of Florida Law School, where he became the first African American to receive a Juris Doctor degree.

Between 1958 and 1960, George served in the United States Army as a special agent in the Counter Intelligence Corps, before being honorably discharged at the rank of First Lieutenant. Following his military service, George was accepted into law school, where he became involved in social activism by organizing lunch counter sit-ins around Gainesville, Florida. After graduating and being admitted to the Florida Bar Association, he decided to open his own firm in Fort Lauderdale. Here he practiced for forty-two years, specializing in trial work, probate, personal injury, insurance defense and wrongful death.

Throughout his career, George was recognized time and again for his hard work and dedication to those around him. He was a member of the Urban League of Broward County, the NAACP, Alpha Phi Alpha Fraternity, Inc, the University of Florida Foundation, and the Florida Bar Association. He also served as the Broward County Bar Association's president. Additionally, he received numerous awards for his achievements, including the University of Florida Distinguished Alumnus Award in 2000, and the National Conference for Community and Justice Silver Medallion Award in 2001. In 2003, George was inducted into the National Bar Association's Hall of Fame, and in February of 2005, Governor Jeb Bush appointed him to the Florida A&M University's Board of Trustees.

Madam Speaker, W. George Allen was a champion for our community and positively impacted the lives of all those he met. He was a South Florida icon, whose life and legacy has left an indelible mark on our state and nation. I want to extend my deepest condolences to his children, Jonathan, Timothy, Frederick, and Amy Carole and the entire Allen family during this heartbreaking time. W. George Allen was a blessing to our community. I am so truly honored to have called him my friend. He will be dearly missed.

HONORING LINDY LEE GOLD ON THE CELEBRATION OF HER 75TH BIRTHDAY

HON. ROSA L. DeLAURO

OF CONNECTICUT

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Ms. DELAURO. Madam Speaker, it is my great privilege to rise today to join the family, friends and colleagues who have gathered in celebration of Lindy Lee Gold as she marks her 75th Birthday—a remarkable milestone for this very special member of the New Haven community.

As a Senior Specialist with the Connecticut State Department of Economic and Community Development, a position she had held since 1998, Lindy has dedicated her professional career to expanding opportunities for Connecticut's businesses and its workforce. However, there are few members of the New Haven community who have been more involved with the City's many facets than Lindy. She is perhaps most well known for her dedication and tireless advocacy efforts—from the arts to education, local government to community development, Lindy has played a critical role in New Haven's success.

Lindy's foray into public service began with her appointment to New Haven's Board of Education where she was vice chair of the Intergroup Relations Taskforce. She went on to win election for two terms on New Haven's Board of Alders representing the 26th Ward where she served as chair of the Legislation Committee and as a member of the Finance Committee.

Lindy currently serves as board chair of the Gateway Community College Foundation, a position she has held for the last decade, as a Fellow at Yale's Pierson College, and as a member of the Executive Board of the Shubert Performing Arts Center. She is also a board member of the United Way of Greater New Haven, the Community Action Agency, New Haven Arts Council, Jewish Federation of Greater New Haven, and the New Haven Manufacturers Association. She also was founder and the first female president of Fellowship Inc, and Cornerstone Inc., and is past president of the Jewish Community Center of Greater New Haven.

Lindy's civic contributions are hardly limited to New Haven. In addition to her many contributions to our fair City, she serves on a multitude of organizations across the state. Lindy is Vice-President of the Jewish Federation Association of Connecticut as well as a member of the state board of the Anti-Defamation League. She also holds board memberships with the Housatonic Community College Foundation, Southern Connecticut State University Foundation, JobLinks Fairfield County, Connecticut Technical High Schools, and the Women's Business Development Center.

Lindy's commitment is extraordinary and she has built a legacy of service which serves as an inspiration to many. Advocate, mentor, and friend, wherever Lindy goes she makes an impact. Her endless energy and dedication make all the difference. I, like so many others,

consider myself fortunate to call her my friend. I am thrilled to have the opportunity to rise today to extend my heartfelt congratulations to Lindy Lee Gold on the celebration of her 75th birthday. I wish her all the best for many more years of health and happiness. Happy Birthday.

TRIBUTE TO BRUCE AND ANNA BIGGS

HON. GREGORY F. MURPHY

OF NORTH CAROLINA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. MURPHY of North Carolina. Madam Speaker, I rise to pay tribute to Bruce and Anna Biggs of Elizabeth City, North Carolina who received the first ever Albemarle Area United Way Keel Club Philanthropy Award. For half a century the Biggs' have been giving back to the community with their time, talent and treasure by donating to numerous organizations and causes in the region as well as funding three scholarships.

Students at East Carolina University, the College of the Albemarle and MidAtlantic Christian University have all benefitted from the Biggs' generosity. Bruce Biggs had to borrow money to attend ECU for his bachelor's degree in business and being able to fund scholarships is especially meaningful to him.

Anna Biggs is a retired school teacher. Bruce and Anna have sought to give to others in a community that has been so good to them.

HONORING BOWLES FARMING COMPANY FOR 2019 AGRICULTURE BUSINESS OF THE YEAR IN THE CENTRAL VALLEY

HON. JIM COSTA

OF CALIFORNIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. COSTA. Madam Speaker, I rise today to honor Bowles Farming Company for the 2019 Agriculture Business Award in the Central Valley. Their contributions to the Central Valley extends to many families and to the community.

Bowles Farming Company originated in 1965 by George, Henry Bowles, and Amy Bowles Lawrence. The 3 siblings started the business and their families soon took over making it 6 generations between the Bowles and Lawrence family.

For over 150 years, the families have contributed growing food, creating jobs for many people, and having 14 different crops. They provide over a thousand jobs with over 50,000 days of farming. Their crops include cotton which is the world's only verified pima cotton, Pimacott, tomatoes that are both processed and fresh market, and almonds. Cotton like Pima or Extra Long Staple (ELS) is quality cotton, and Bowles Farming Company produces this quality crop.

Their farm is 11,000 acres and located in Los Banos, California. President and CEO, Cannon Michael is a passionate advocate for agriculture and on water. The importance of water and California's agriculture is a priority to the Bowles Farming Company.

Madam Speaker, I ask my colleagues to join me in celebrating Bowles Farming Company on their 2019 Agriculture Business of the year award. They are an influential company in the Central Valley.

HONORING THE 2019 WOMEN OF THE YEAR

HON. JOHN GARAMENDI

OF CALIFORNIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. GARAMENDI. Madam Speaker, I rise today to honor the 2019 Women of the Year. The honorees represent some of the most outstanding and dedicated women in the 3rd Congressional District. Nominated by their peers, these women and the leadership they have provided are being recognized for playing an integral and crucial role in improving the lives of everyone in their communities.

During the last 50 years women have made great strides in America. It used to be almost unheard of to see women as elected officials, CEOs, senior military officials, doctors or attorneys, but today many of our most successful leaders in the world are women. This progress has not come easy and many women before you have worked hard and strived to achieve the independence and rights you have today. I realize there is more work to be done to ensure that women have equal pay, flexible work schedules and affordable education. Each of the honorees will be a vital part of the future successes for women.

2019's Women of the Year are:

Lynn Rolston has used her creativity, determination, and skilled leadership to have a vast and visible impact on her community. She envisioned an economic rebirth for her rural community of Esparto, if only the right community stakeholders were gathered in the same space. Fueled by this vision for a brighter future, Lynn helped found the New Season Community Development Corporation to revitalize the core business community and to deliver a higher quality of life to her fellow residents of Esparto. Under Lynn's guidance, the New Season Community Development Corp. began rehabilitating unused properties and acquiring tenants for them. Lynn's eagerness to serve her community spread from community development to every facet of her life. Lynn revitalized the Esparto Regional Chamber of Commerce by injecting it with fresh new recruits from the newly strengthened Esparto business community. Furthermore, Lynn served on multiple Yolo County committees such as the Esparto Citizens Advisory Committee and the Recreation Task Force, where her efforts helped create the new Tuli Mem Park and Aquatic Center. Lynn Rolston is an example to us all on the positive effects one determined visionary can have on any community.

Beth Rowe is an active member of the Vacaville community who continues to show support and encouragement for women throughout Solano County. Beth has been an active member of the local Soroptimist International club for over four years. In her time with Soroptimist, she has mentored countless girls and actively participated in providing scholarships and grants to single mothers and young students. Beth gave an empowering speech representing the Soroptimist International of Vacaville regarding the detrimental impact of the rape kit backlog in Solano County on the ability to bring justice to victims of sexual assault. Thanks to her speech, Soroptimist received a $10,000 grant from 100 Women Who Care which they used to pay for the testing of old rape kits at risk of expiration. Beth has also been a fierce advocate for Assembly Bill 1496, which would mandate the testing of untested rape kits, and is determined to see this bill become law. She draws her strength and desire to help others from her upbringing which shaped her into the advocate she is today. Beth is also a member of Saving Gracie, Angel Fund for Pets, and her local VFW Auxiliary and is passionate about helping families and veterans in her community. Beth is a passionate advocate for those in her community who have the most trouble getting their voices heard.

Heather Sanderson is an active member of the Fairfield community who uses her time and talents to support and advocate for at-risk youth. She possesses the skills, commitment, and compassion to be an uplifting force for the entire Fairfield community. In her work as the Police Activities League Coordinator, she provides marginalized youths with after school programs, providing healthy food options, positive activities, and life changing opportunities. She has also introduced several programs to the community that focus on reducing violence and teaching younger generations how to navigate emotions such as fear, anger, and stress. She has developed valuable partnerships with community organizations to further the positive impact of the Police Activities League programs. Heather's generosity, kindness, and compassion make her an inspiration to all her peers. Her work has changed countless lives and left a lasting positive impact on her community.

Cherie Schroeder is an exceptional and selfless community servant whose work has had an incredible impact on Solano and Yolo Counties. As the Director of the Foster and Kinship Care Education Program at Woodland Community College, Cherie is a tireless advocate for foster youth and consistently provides support and guidance for the most vulnerable among us. For over 34 years, Cherie has put her heart and soul into this work. Her work-ethic, compassion, and intellect have made her a wonderful rolemodel for all those she interacts with. In addition to her work as Director of the Foster and Kinship Care Education program, she is a longtime member of the Soroptimist International of Dixon. When she served as President, Cherie oversaw the development of the Young Woman of the Month program which recognized local women for their outstanding achievements within their community. Through this program, she mentored countless young women and ran a generous scholarship initiative. Cherie serves her community with unparalleled kindness and compassion and has touched the lives of many.

Harmony Scopazzi is a vital and appreciated part of this community. She is dedicated to ensuring that every family in Yolo County is successful, happy, and healthy. For the past 13 years, Harmony has worked for Davis Community Meals and Housing as a Family Case Manager and Volunteer Coordinator. Harmony has selflessly devoted her time and energy to the mission of protecting

Yolo County families from food and housing insecurities and is a truly valued member of the agency. She is endlessly generous, caring, loving, and respectful and she will always go out of her way to help those around her. For the past five years, Harmony has served as a foster parent, opening her home to ensure that there is a safe and loving environment for any child in need. Her service as a foster parent is one of many ways in which she demonstrates her generosity, kindness, and drive to help others. Harmony has touched the lives of countless children throughout our community and her positive impact cannot be overstated.

Julie Shuffield is a renowned entrepreneur, dedicated community servant, and strong advocate on behalf of women. Julie long ago discovered her abiding passion for infrastructure development, operation, and strategic planning. Julie has long maintained this passion for infrastructure and appreciated its role as the backbone to safety, resilience, and a high standard of living for our local communities. Her decades of experience, first as manager of External Affairs for California Independent System Operation, then as Director of Regulatory and Government Affairs, and now as Senior Consultant for Advantage Consulting, have seen her exercise this passion to ensure the highest quality infrastructure standards are met for every project in which she is involved. Her ability to respond with foresight, flexibility, and ingenuity to any and all challenges that come her way have allowed her to make significant contributions across many fields. As owner of her own S-corporation and partner at her consulting firm, Julie knows what it takes to thrive as a female entrepreneur. She used this knowledge to assist in launching a United States branch of the Hawthorne club to promote female executives in energy to C-suite and board positions. In the community, Julie serves as Chairperson of Casa de Esperanza, a shelter for victims of domestic violence, child abuse, sexual assault, and human trafficking. Additionally, she has served as Co-Founder of Yuba-Sutter Back the Badge, a local law enforcement trauma and spousal support team, as well as being a Rotary Youth Leadership Awards counselor for over a decade. Through her career and volunteerism, Julie has made countless contributions to her local community.

Cathy Speck has led a life of activism and perseverance, demonstrating at every turn her indominable spirit. Cathy has faced a great deal of hardship in her life, living with two debilitating diseases and watching much of her family do the same. Despite these challenges and more, she has consistently spread joy in her community through her music, art, writing, and infectious spirit. Cathy has also fought for righteous causes, acting as a fierce advocate for marriage equality and ALS awareness. In 2009, Cathy was diagnosed with amyotrophic lateral sclerosis (ALS), a rare degenerative disease that has claimed four of her family members already. She takes part in many efforts to raise awareness about ALS, and as a columnist at the iPinion Syndicate, Cathy further raises awareness and support for those diagnosed with ALS, using compassion and humor to discuss a difficult topic. In addition to her work as an activist, Cathy is deeply invested in community building. For the past several years, she has organized a yearly Christmas caroling excursion to Courtyard Healthcare in Davis to foster friendships and bring smiles to long term patients. She is also a booster of the Dorothy Speck Memorial Basketball Tournament at Davis High School, the longest running girls' basketball tournament in the country. Cathy consistently demonstrates her unwavering commitment to use all that she can, from her activism to her artistic talents, to make her community a better place.

Dee Tokiwa has dedicated her life to helping others in her community. Dee works as a nurse in oncology and bone marrow transplants at Sutter General Hospital, but this demanding career never stopped her from volunteering her time in her community. For several years, she has volunteered at Alamo Elementary School in Vacaville, where she has overseen numerous activities and events. She has spent countless days with the children during their recesses where she created new games, encouraged participation, cultivated compassion, and fostered understanding amongst the students. As an advocate for education and literacy, Dee took the time to organize the district-wide Novel Knowledge program. This competition for students between fourth and sixth grades quickly became an avenue for children to improve their reading and critical thinking skills. She also served as the chairperson for the annual Scholastic Book Fairs and planned a book drive fundraiser which received enough books to fill the school library and classrooms. She contributes to her community in many ways, living up to the Mother Teresa quote by which she lives, ''Not all OF US can do great things, but we can do small things with great love.'' She is a loving mother and devoted member of the community who exudes kindness, humility, and generosity.

Tracy Tomasky is a fierce advocate for the rights of others who consistently works to build communities of respect and acceptance. Tracy serves as the co-chair of the Davis Phoenix Coalition, a nonprofit organization that works to build diverse and inclusive communities and advocate for the rights of the LGBTQ+ members of our community. Tracy is passionate about the work she does fighting for the rights of LGBTQ+ individuals, preventing of hate speech, and promoting immigrant rights. As the volunteer coordinator of the Davis Phoenix Coalition, she always comes prepared with a plan on how to best utilize the skills of the group and bring out the best of everyone's abilities to further the organization's mission. Tracy has a rare ability to bridge divides and bring communities together to deliver positive change through collaboration. Tracy's work on behalf of those who are underrepresented has made Davis into a safer and more inclusive community that is welcoming to all. Her tireless advocacy has had a widespread and lasting impact that cannot be overstated.

Kim Travis has dedicated her career to guiding young athletes to reach for and achieve their goals. As the girls' volleyball coach at Pierce High School in Arbuckle, Kim has served as a wonderful role model to each of her students. She is a proactive coach who has worked hard to build a successful high school and club volleyball team. Her coaching style exercises team building by developing their skills and confidence, teaching her players that success comes from failure. Her role in the community is felt by all. She started a youth camp program for children between first and eighth grade, and for the past ten years, has dedicated her time on the boards of Arbuckle and West Side Little League. She also volunteers for Pierce Pride Foundation and Dynamix Club Volleyball where she actively fundraises for sports equipment and programs. More recently, Kim organized a volleyball tournament between two alumni high school teams in Colusa to remember and honor fallen Davis Police Officer and Pierce High School alumni, Natalie Corona, bringing her community together in a difficult time. Many have come to know Kim as a leader, teacher, and friend and she has touched the lives of countless young athletes whom she has mentored.

Diane Vafis has lived for over 50 years in Colusa, where her love and kindness has touched the lives of countless people. Currently serving as the Co-Director of the afterschool program operated by St. Stephen's Episcopal Church in Colusa, she has worked to provide after-school tutoring to fourth graders for over 12 years. Diane takes extra care to create a healthy and nurturing environment for her students, personally picking up the children after school, providing craft sessions, and communicating closely with her students' teachers to maximize their success. Broadening the impact of her investments in local education, she became a vital member and treasurer of the Colusa County Alpha Kappa Chapter of Omega Nu, which provides academic scholarships to local high school graduates. In addition to cultivating after educational programs, Diane is the Civic Beautification Chair of the Garden Club of Colusa County, which is responsible for planting and maintaining gardens in public spaces such as libraries, post offices, and the courthouse. Diane demonstrates an unwavering dedication to serving her community and serves as a role model for everyone around her.

With a wealth of business knowledge and a heart of service, Sarah Villec has become a staple in the Dixon community since first moving to California as a military spouse. She began her career with the Dixon Tribune in 1988 working long and hard hours to ensure the paper published a fair and balanced interpretation of the local news. Recognizing her leadership and management skills, the owners asked her to manage operations for the Benicia Herald, The Martinez News Gazette, and the Rio Vista River News Herald. Despite her long hours involved in her newspaper career, Sarah managed to find time to dedicate Countless hours to the Dixon community. She is involved with the local Chamber of Commerce, the Downtown Dixon Business Association and is the President of Dixon Family Services, a non-profit which helps families and individuals who are experiencing difficult times. Sarah Villec is a champion of women in business with a heart for public service. Strong in her mind and body, she continues to be involved in the local community and is an inspiration to those around her. On behalf of the citizens of Dixon and the people of the 3rd Congressional District, I extend my sincere appreciation to Sarah for her enthusiasm and dedication to her community and love for her family.

Tina Viramontes' commitment and love for her community as a leader is reflected by her involvement in several campaigns and community events. She worked countless hours to help pass Measure V, a local measure which would improve the roads in the City of Clearlake. She's a staple in the local youth sports community where you will often find her volunteering her time by helping at events or

providing rides to the parents of athletes who have no way to get to the games. As a community leader, Tina organized the 1st Annual Soapbox Derby, a family friendly event that inspires children and adults to create the fastest gravity-powered, or most creative vehicles, they can and race in front of cheering fans. This was especially important to Lake County in that it was simply a joyous occasion for the entire community after four straight years of disastrous fires. Tina Viramontes is a Deputy City Clerk for the City of Clearlake who has a heart for public service and a strong desire to help people. She greets everyone with a smile, a cheerful attitude, and helps them navigate through the various departments with professionalism and integrity. On behalf of the Clearlake community and the people of the 3rd Congressional District, I offer Tina Viramontes congratulations and my well wishes in her future endeavors.

Dr. Vajra M. Watson has had immense influence the community during her career at UC Davis as the Director of Research and Policy for Equity. Her poise, work-ethic, and commitment to making the world a better place stands unmatched. Dr. Watson devotes her time to creating and expanding upon various academic and community-based programs. She digs in to solve problems on the ground, putting her renowned academic research to work. Just a few of the programs that she helped develop include Sacramento Area Youth Speaks (SAYS), the UC Davis Campuswide Equity task Force, and the UC Davis Outreach Center. Dr. Watson has been an invaluable figure for the African American Community, creating and fighting for these life-altering programs. Her work supports the education and elevation of marginalized youths from disenfranchised communities. Her SAYS program has been instrumental in helping teachers learn to incorporate authenticity in the classroom environment to engage and enrich their students. In addition to her hands-on work in the community, she has contributed to the education canon of academia with a multitude of books and peer reviewed studies. Her book Transformative Schooling addresses many of the central aspects of our time as she delves into the structure and nuances of America's education structure, as well as the necessary action that must be taken. On behalf of the 3rd Congressional District, I offer Vajra M. Watson my sincere best wishes and continued success.

Jeanine Werner has dedicated much of her life to improving the lives of children who are deaf and hard of hearing, or those that have physical and cognitive disabilities. Her empathy and drive started early in her life, leading her to begin working with these populations in high school. As she continued to develop her professional career, she never abandoned her original goal. After working with these populations as a classroom aid, she eventually took on the opportunity to work with adults and children known as ''Campers''. These ''Campers'', who are attendees of Lion Camps for people with disabilities, undoubtably benefited from her kindness and commitment to improving the lives of those around her. Upon returning to Yuba City, Jeanine involved herself with Casa de Esperanza, a shelter for those suffering from abuse and violence. Jeanine then began work as a Counselor Advocate for the First Responder program. Shortly after, she was promoted to be Project Director for the program because of her skill and passion. During her time at Casa de Esperanza, Jeanine transformed several programs and projects through expansive training, education, and outreach efforts. Her desire to improve the lives of those around her continues to benefit our community. On behalf of the people of Yuba City and the 3rd Congressional District, I am pleased to congratulate Jeanine Werner as a 2019 Woman of the Year for her dedication, passion, kindness, and intellect.

Kristina Wiley's dedication to helping others is unparalled. In her tireless work to improve her community, she has served as president of Soroptimist, a non-profit organization devoted to improving the lives of women and girls across the country. In addition, Kristina has raised money for charities and even traveled to Haiti to perform dental surgery for those in need. In her work in Dixon, Kristina has raised tens of thousands of dollars for breast cancer research, donated to the funeral funds of those in need and raised $47,000 for animal welfare. In addition to these great contributions, Kristina has devoted her time to mentoring children and even taken children in need under her wing while they get back on their feet. Kristina has also used her skills as a DDS in Haiti, traveling there 5 times in order to perform much-needed procedures on those who would otherwise not have access to dental care. Her involvement in the community has improved many lives and will continue to do so in the future.

I congratulate each of them and commend them for their work. I am inspired by them and firmly believe when women succeed, America succeeds.

IN SUPPORT OF THE SAFE RETURN OF AUSTIN BENNETT TICE

HON. HENRY CUELLAR

OF TEXAS

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. CUELLAR. Madam Speaker, I rise today to call attention to Austin Bennett Tice's prolonged captivity in Syria, where he has been held since August 14, 2012; over seven years.

Austin is an American journalist who headed to Syria to work as a free-lance reporter for the McClatchy News Service between his second and third years at Georgetown Law School. A native of Houston, Texas, and a Georgetown alumnus, Austin is an exceptional young man who demonstrated his determination and potential early in life as both an Eagle Scout and a National Merit Finalist.

After graduation from Georgetown University's School of Foreign Service, he was commissioned as an officer in the United States Marine Corps. As an infantryman, his service included tours of duty in Afghanistan and Iraq. At the time of his capture, Austin sought to ensure that the world understood the tragic situation in Syria. Because of his dedication to our country, we owe this young man every possible effort to affect his release.

Presidential Policy Directive 30, U.S. Nationals Taken Abroad and Personnel Recovery Efforts, clearly commits the Government to working in a coordinated manner and utilizing all instruments of national power to safely recover hostages. We appreciate that commitment and were grateful when the FBI announced last April a $1 million reward for Austin's safe return. We are aware that the Hostage Recovery Fusion Cell has been engaged with efforts to secure his release for several years.

Madam Speaker, it has now been over four years since that Presidential Policy Directive was finalized, and we strongly urge the President and State Department officials to personally ensure that the U.S. government galvanizes its efforts and employs all appropriate means to secure this young man's safe and expeditious return to the United States.

WAR EMERGENCY PIPELINE HISTORICAL MARKER

HON. JOHN SHIMKUS

OF ILLINOIS

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. SHIMKUS. Madam Speaker, I rise today to recognize the November 11, 2019, dedication of an Illinois State Historical Society Historical Marker for the Completion of the War Emergency Pipeline in 1943 from Longview, Texas, to Norris City, Illinois.

Before the bombing of Pearl Harbor on December 7, 1941, and entry of the United States into World War II, 95 percent of the crude oil delivered to east coast oil refineries was transported by tanker ships, with 90 percent of that from Texas oil fields. In 1942, oil tankers from the Gulf of Mexico were being sunk by German submarines at the rate of three per day. A committee appointed by President Franklin D. Roosevelt recommended an overland pipeline be built from Longview to Norris City.

Work began at Longview on August 3, 1942, and a dedication ceremony at Norris City was held upon completion, February 19, 1943. Newspapers and radio stations recorded the event; the newsreels were shown prior to movies in theaters all over America. The first day, 60,000 barrels of crude oil flowed into Norris City. The first trainload left Norris City the night of the dedication with 96 oil tankers.

Fifteen 80,000-barrel storage tanks and three loading racks had been built. 13,500 barrels of crude oil were received hourly on this pipeline between February 19 and September 1, 1943. The railroad hauled 124,193 tankers of oil out of Norris City. The War Emergency Pipeline put 3,500 people to work.

Madam Speaker, the pipeline's impact on the war effort was tremendous, enabling the safe and timely transport of oil vital to the allies during the height of wartime service. I want to extend a warm thank you to the Enbridge-Texas Eastern Company and The Illinois State Historical Society for collaborating to ensure an important piece of this nation's history is preserved for future generations.

HONORING MARK BORBA FOR 2019 AGRICULTURIST OF THE YEAR IN THE CENTRAL VALLEY

HON. JIM COSTA

OF CALIFORNIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. COSTA. Madam Speaker, I rise today to recognize Mr. Mark Borba on the occasion of

his award for the 2019 Agriculturist of the Year. It is transparent that Mark's 40 plus years of continuous passion for the agricultural community.

With only 40 cows and 120 acres of land, A.J. Borba started the line of farmers near Hardwick, California. He later moved to Riverdale, California in the 1900's and started a dairy farm. A.J. with his two sons, began a row crop operation. An immigrant from Azores, Portugal, he did not realize the impact his family would make for the Central Valley.

His two sons, Ross Sr. and Darril began what we know today, the Borba Brothers Farms in 1958. Ross Sr. and his wife Justina had two sons, Ross Jr., Mark, and a daughter, Dwayne. In 1976, the family passed the business down to Mark and Ross Jr.

The family has been through droughts, different crops, and their share of hardships. Yet, they have survived and have been able to be proudly called fourth-generation farmers. Their share of crops includes almonds, tomatoes, melons, lettuce, wheat, garlic, and cotton.

Mark believes in education and was recognized for it in 1996 for the U.C. Davis Award of Distinction for his contributions and accomplishments. He helped with the Ross Borba Sr. Scholarship Endowment for agricultural college students. Mark wants people to be educated on water and agricultural issues. He constantly talks to members of the community and to elected officials about water rights issues and practices in fanning. His passion to grow for farmers and for his family is clearly shown.

In various capacities, Mark has been involved in the community. He served as Chairman of the Board at Community Medical Centers in Fresno. He was also on the board for the Maddy Institute, and a Chairman for the California Cotton Growers Association.

Madam Speaker, it is with great respect that I ask my colleagues in the House of Representatives to congratulate Mr. Mark Borba on his recent award. His accomplishments to Fresno County made amazing impacts in the community. It is my honor to join his colleagues, family, and friends in honoring his award and achievements.

RECOGNIZING LYNNE AND MYRON MALNAA

HON. GREG GIANFORTE

OF MONTANA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. GIANFORTE. Madam Speaker, Lynne and Myron Malnaa of Glasgow, Montana are a shining example of dedication and compassion. For 18 years they have been active in the Montana foster care system, welcoming children into their home anywhere from overnight to 14 years. During this time, they have adopted two children and are the guardians to another.

Lynne ran a daycare from her home for 25 years before she devoted nearly 15 years to the State of Montana Office of Public Assistance. Myron served our state as a law enforcement officer for 25 years. Together, their experiences helped them provide a safe haven, day or night, for more than 150 frightened and neglected children in need of care and love, which they have given so freely and unconditionally.

We can all learn from Lynne and Myron's decades of kindness and generosity. I am pleased to recognize Lynne and Myron Malnaa as 2019 Angels in Adoption Honorees.

HONORING THE MEMORY OF FREDDIE B. YELDER

HON. RASHIDA TLAIB

OF MICHIGAN

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Ms. TLAIB. Madam Speaker, I rise today in honor of the memory of Freddie B. Yelder, a beloved Detroit community member.

Born July 15, 1934, Ms. Yelder spent her early years in Mosses, Alabama before moving with her husband and family to Detroit, Michigan. She quickly became a respected leader in her family, community, and church. Ms. Yelder was especially known for her kindness and generosity to others. The matriarch of the Yelder/Bain/Patton family, she cared for her large extended family, but especially her disabled brother, and as sole caregiver to her husband after he became disabled. As the owner of a party store, she never failed to donate goods and services to those in need. She never shied away from opening up her own home to others when someone needed shelter.

Ms. Yelder's openheartedness and charitable spirit were an asset in the leadership role she assumed in her forty-three years as a member and former Board of Trustees President of Sharon Missionary Baptist Church. She initiated the organizing of the church mission, which two years later lead to the mission deciding to purchase the permanent structure called Sharon Missionary Baptist Church. One of her proudest accomplishments was when she successfully negotiated in the church's favor the initial selling conditions and reducing the church's costs by several thousand dollars. In addition to her work on behalf of the missionary program, Ms. Yelder supervised the "Meet Up, Eat Up" program, which fed countless children in the surrounding community, as well as the church soup kitchen, which was funded solely through her own fundraising efforts.

In short, Ms. Freddie B. Yelder's life was distinguished by her generosity, kindness, and leadership. We give honor to her memory and tireless efforts in dedication to her surviving family.

CELEBRATING THE 75TH ANNIVERSARY OF FRESNO PACIFIC UNIVERSITY

HON. JIM COSTA

OF CALIFORNIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. COSTA. Madam Speaker, I rise today to commemorate Fresno Pacific University in Fresno, California on the occasion of its 75th anniversary. The university is a valuable part of the community and plays an important role in educating students in the Central Valley.

Fresno Pacific University was established in 1944 as the Pacific Bible Institute in a two-story home near downtown Fresno. The school had 5 faculty members and a student body of 28. The college's leadership took it upon themselves to expand its campus and curriculum. In 1958 land was purchased to build a larger campus, a biblical seminary and a Mennonite Brethren Church. Beginning in 1961, the biblical college expanded to a two-year institution, Pacific College, and eventually a four-year program in 1964. In 1997, Pacific College would henceforth be known as Fresno Pacific University, with satellite locations throughout the Central Valley.

The university has integrated five schools, including: School of Business, Natural Sciences, Education, a Fresno Pacific Biblical Seminary, and Humanities, Religion, and Social Sciences. They have over 30-degree options, 40 programs, and more than 100 areas of study. Throughout its history Fresno Pacific has experienced tremendous growth that continues to this day.

Past presidents that have helped the campus and the university's mission to grow have also left their unique mark. Samuel W. Goosen was named the first president in 1944. George W. Peters started in 1947 and introduced the importance of church missions. Reuben M. Baerg began as president in 1953 and was once an instructor in Greek and the Bible's New Testament. Bernhard J. Braun was named president in 1955 and was instrumental in developing the junior college curriculum for the university. Arthur J. Wiebe became president in 1960 and facilitated the transition to a four-year campus and increased the enrollment of students. Edmund Janzen began his tenure in 1975 and helped to expand the mission program. In 1985, Richard A. Kriegbaum was named president and under his guidance, the undergraduate program became nationally ranked. Allen Carden's leadership started in 1997, followed by Harold H. Haak in 2000. In 2002, D. Merrill Ewert became the 10th President. Pete Menjares started in 2012 and was followed by Richard Kriegbaum as he returned in 2014 to help serve one more time. Dr. Joseph Jones now serves as president for the university and continues to work to advance the university's growth and student success.

With strong leadership, the last 75 years have been tremendously transformative for Fresno Pacific University. As they continue to grow and prosper, their values of faith, spirit, and innovation has allowed them to continuously evolve.

Madam Speaker, I ask my colleagues to join me in honoring Fresno Pacific University as it celebrates its 75th anniversary. I commend Fresno Pacific for its 75 years of commitment to education and I wish the faculty, staff, students and alumni continued success.

TRIBUTE TO COLONEL RAYMOND CELESTE, USMC (RET.)

HON. GREGORY F. MURPHY

OF NORTH CAROLINA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. MURPHY of North Carolina. Madam Speaker, I rise to pay tribute to Colonel Raymond Celeste, USMC (Ret.) who has completed twenty-nine Marine Corps Marathons here in Washington, D.C. and was recently inducted into the Marine Corps Marathon Hall of Fame.

In addition to his 26 years of dedicated service to our country as a Marine, Ray has diligently served members of the military and veterans across the Third District of North Carolina since 2011, originally under Congressman Walter B. Jones, Jr. and continuing on my current staff.

Madam Speaker, please join me in thanking Ray for the work he has done and continues to do for the veterans in NC–03 as well as the service members stationed at Camp Lejeune, and Marine Corps Air Stations Cherry Point and New River.

Semper-Fi.

JONATHAN ZUMKEHR DEPARTS FCC VICTORVILLE

HON. PAUL COOK

OF CALIFORNIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. COOK. Madam Speaker, Jonathan Zumkehr has worked for the Federal Bureau of Prisons for over a decade. He began his work at Metropolitan Detention Center Los Angeles in May 2007, where he guarded inmates standing trial in federal court. After two years at MDC Los Angeles, he transferred to FCC Victorville in March 2009.

While at FCC Victorville, he became involved in improving the lives of his community and his fellow correctional officers. He worked with Be The Match to help raise awareness for finding bone marrow matches for those with blood cancers, and he supported Mothers Against Drunk Drivers in their campaign to fight intoxicated driving. Jonathan's passion for improving his community also led him to improve the lives and working conditions of his fellow correctional officers. He was successfully elected to serve as the Vice President for AFGE Local 3969, where he consistently advocated for better and safer working conditions. Among other important issues, Jonathan was instrumental in bringing to light the understaffing of FCC Victorville and highlighting the risky practice of augmentation.

Jonathan Zumkehr is an outstanding law enforcement professional whose dedication to those around him has improved lives and made our community a safer place. He will be sorely missed as he departs for AUSP Thomson, and I wish him continued success in his Bureau of Prisons Career.

IN REMEMBRANCE OF JOAN ALBERT LAWLER

HON. ROBERT J. WITTMAN

OF VIRGINIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. WITTMAN. Madam Speaker, I rise today to reflect on the life of Joan Albert Lawler, a respected businesswoman and passionate philanthropist, who touched countless lives by her life and work throughout Washington, D.C., Northern Virginia, and Westmoreland County, Virginia.

Born in Syracuse, New York, Joni, grew up in McLean, Virginia. After earning a bachelor's degree from the University of Vermont, she worked at the U.S. House of Representatives on the staff of Hon. Ron Marlenee and Hon. Albert Johnson, as well as the Clerk of the House and the Territorial Caucus. The positive feeling of helping others through legislation was a foundation for her good works that she continued throughout her life. It was here on Capitol Hill that she met her husband, John. They opened a watering hole for the young political community called ''The Third Party'' and were active members of the Congressional Flying Club. While raising her family, Joni earned a real estate license and co-founded a financial consulting firm, East West Financial Services.

In 2005, Joni moved with her family full-time to the Northern Neck of Virginia where she used her wide-ranging experience in business and philanthropy to become a pillar of the community, admired for her leadership, generosity, and grace. She served on the boards and committees of numerous organizations, creating many fundraising events that became beloved local traditions.

She always volunteered her time and leadership, establishing successful fundraising events that became longstanding traditions, with Our Lady of Victory Church and the elementary and high schools her three daughters attended including Our Lady of Victory School, Washington Waldorf School, and St. Margaret's School where she also served on the Board of Governors. Joni was guided by her deep faith, and spearheaded a successful capital campaign to support the construction of a new church rectory and office for St. Paul's Mission in Hague, VA. She truly was a doer of good works.

A pillar in the Commonwealth of Virginia, she was always striving to make a difference. I can assure you that our nation and Commonwealth is a greater, more successful place, due to her ever-present leadership and generosity. She is an example of community leaders that we all wish to emulate.

Madam Speaker, I ask you to join me in remembering the life of Joan Albert Lawler, a life lived serving her community. Words alone cannot express our gratitude. May God bless Joni and her family.

CELEBRATING THE 75TH ANNIVERSARY OF FRESNO PACIFIC UNIVERSITY

HON. JIM COSTA

OF CALIFORNIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. COSTA. Madam Speaker, I rise today to commemorate Fresno Pacific University in Fresno, California on the occasion of its 75th anniversary, The university is a valuable part of the community and plays an important role in educating students in the Central Valley.

Fresno Pacific University was established in 1944 as the Pacific Bible Institute in a two-story home near downtown Fresno. The school had 5 faculty members and a student body of 28. The college's leadership took it upon themselves to expand its campus and curriculum. In 1958 land was purchased to build a larger campus, a biblical seminary and a Mennonite Brethren Church. Beginning in 1961, the biblical college expanded to a two-year institution, Pacific College, and eventually a four-year program in 1964. In 1997, Pacific College would henceforth be known as Fresno Pacific University, with satellite locations throughout the Central Valley.

The university has integrated five schools, including: School of Business, Natural Sciences, Education, a Fresno Pacific Biblical Seminary, and Humanities, Religion, and Social Sciences. They have over 30-degree options, 40 programs, and more than 100 areas of study. Throughout its history Fresno Pacific has experienced tremendous growth that continues to this day.

Past presidents that have helped the campus and the university's mission to grow have also left their unique mark. Samuel W. Goosen was named the first president in 1944. George W. Peters started in 1947 and introduced the importance of church missions. Reuben M. Baerg began as president in 1953 and was once an instructor in Greek and the Bible's New Testament. Bernhard J. Braun was named president in 1955 and was instrumental in developing the junior college curriculum for the university. Arthur J. Wiebe became president in 1960 and facilitated the transition to a four-year campus and increased the enrollment of students. Edmund Janzen began his tenure in 1975 and helped to expand the mission program. In 1985, Richard A. Kriegbaum was named president and under his guidance, the undergraduate program became nationally ranked. Allen Carden's leadership started in 1997, followed by Harold H. Haak in 2000. In 2002, D. Merrill Ewert became the 10th President. Pete Menjares started in 2012 and was followed by Richard Kriegbaum as he returned in 2014 to help serve one more time. Dr. Joseph Jones now serves as president for the university and continues to work to advance the university's growth and student success.

With strong leadership, the last 75 years have been tremendously transformative for Fresno Pacific University. As they continue to grow and prosper, their values of faith, spirit, and innovation has allowed them to continuously evolve.

Madam Speaker, I ask my colleagues to join me in honoring Fresno Pacific University as it celebrates its 75th anniversary. I commend Fresno Pacific for its 75 years of commitment to education and I wish the faculty, staff, students and alumni continued success.

CONGRATULATING BOB LOZINAK

HON. JOHN JOYCE

OF PENNSYLVANIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. JOYCE of Pennsylvania. Madam Speaker, I rise today to congratulate Altoona Curve Owner, Bob Lozinak, on being named the 2019 King of Baseball by Minor League Baseball. Mr. Lozinak of Blair County, Pennsylvania, will receive this honor during the league's winter meetings in San Diego on December 8.

In 1999, Mr. Lozinak brought baseball to Altoona. Since then, he has grown the Curve's fanbase and garnered national recognition for his work not only with the Curve, but throughout his 40-year history in Minor League Baseball.

Mr. Lozinak's passion both for the sport of baseball and for our community is an immense asset to Pennsylvania's 13th Congressional District. This recognition is well-deserved, and I congratulate our ''King of Baseball'' on this outstanding accomplishment.

HONORING THE 2019 WOMEN OF THE YEAR

HON. JOHN GARAMENDI

OF CALIFORNIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. GARAMENDI. Madam Speaker, I rise today to honor the 2019 Women of the Year. The honorees represent some of the most outstanding and dedicated women in the 3rd Congressional District. Nominated by their peers, these women and the leadership they have provided are being recognized for playing an integral and crucial role in improving the lives of everyone in their communities.

During the last 50 years women have made great strides in America. It used to be almost unheard of to see women as elected officials, CEOs, senior military officials, doctors or attorneys, but today many of our most successful leaders in the world are women. This progress has not come easy and many women before you have worked hard and strived to achieve the independence and rights you have today. I realize there is more work to be done to ensure that women have equal pay, flexible work schedules and affordable education. Each of the honorees will be a vital part of the future successes for women.

2019's Women of the Year are:

Bobbi Abold is a dedicated, passionate, and invested advocate who brings over a decade of experience in education to her work on behalf of at-risk students. Bobbi currently serves as the Assistant Superintendent of Curriculum and Instruction for the Yuba County Office of Education. In this position as well as during her time as Principal at Durham Elementary School, Bobbi has leveraged her unique capacity for positive reinforcement and decision making to administer critical resources and engaging programs for all her students. As a true model and champion of the very best in leadership in alternative education, Bobbi has continuously gone out of her way to improve her skills by training in restorative practices and is always challenging others to become better educators. Her inclusivity allows her to foster a positive and constructive environment for students to learn and grow as individuals, and she lends a special focus to those facing the greatest challenges. Bobbi is a passionate public servant who consistently demonstrates her unparalleled dedication to securing bright futures for her students.

Rose Mary Avila is a dedicated advocate for members of the Yuba County community. She is a highly regarded volunteer, community servant, and business woman. Rose Mary works to help the Marysville business community thrive through her involvement with the Focus on Marysville business forum. Rose Mary has been an executive member at the Alliance for Hispanic Advancement in Yuba County for 15 years and contributes her time to many events and fundraisers. Through this organization she has worked to enrich the lives of people of Hispanic heritage in her community by awarding scholarships to Hispanic students, providing health resources and bilingual information for community members, and administering numerous other community programs. Rose Mary is also a member of the Marysville Kiwanis where she lends valuable assistance to their fundraising efforts. Rose Mary is also an active member of her church where she helps with annual fundraisers and volunteered as a catechism teacher. Rose Mary is a loving mother of two, grandmother of four, and a cherished friend to many. A lifelong resident of Yuba County, she has had a positive impact on countless members of her community.

Lisa Baker is a tireless advocate working at the forefront of some of the most pressing issues facing her community. Her activism encompasses issues such as housing, social equality, and climate change. Her efforts to provide affordable housing, connect residents with social services, improve social equity, and address issues related to climate change have had a profound and positive impact on our district. As CEO of the Yolo County Housing Authority, Lisa works tirelessly to realize the organization's mission of working to provide quality affordable housing and community development services for all. Her organization and its allies provide essential services that meet the needs of thousands of underprivileged households throughout Yolo and Solano counties. Under her leadership, the Yolo County Housing Authority works with community partners to combat homelessness and does innovative work on climate resiliency. Over the years, her organization has earned numerous national recognitions, and last year won the City of Davis Environmental Special Recognition award for ongoing work in sustainability and equity. Beyond her groundbreaking work in building climate resiliency and sustainability into affordable housing, Lisa lends her time and expertise to a variety of community organizations. She is Vice Chair of the Winters Planning Commission, serves on the Citizen Advisory Committee for the Yolo County Transportation District, is a member of the Cool Davis Council of Advisors, serves on the Prop 47 Steering Committee, and is a member of the Yolo Resilience Collaborative. She is also a member of a number of statewide and national organizations focused on advocating for affordable housing in underserved communities. Lisa's passion for public service and positive impact on her community cannot be overstated.

Navjot Bala-Singh has a unique and unparalleled ability as an educator. When Navjot came to the United States in 2002, it was her dream to become an educator and share the history of Indian women with her community. The challenges of adjusting to a new culture and learning to communicate effectively in a foreign language did not stop her from pursuing her goals. On the contrary, this experience endowed her with patience and a unique perspective she could share with others. In 2010 she became a U.S. Citizen, enrolled in college, and later completed her degree in early childhood education. She became a Mentor Teacher at Yuba Community College where she shared her skills as a pre-school teacher and her passion for cultivating young minds flourished. Throughout her educational career she has learned the value of sharing her Indian culture with students and her community. Navjot now plays a leadership role in the annual Indian Women's Teejan Meda, an event which shares the important contributions Indian women have made to national and local communities. She also plays a crucial role in putting on the annual Sikh Parade, Nagar Kirtan, which attracts over 100,000 visitors to Yuba City and provides a special opportunity to share Indian culture with the local community. Navjot and her husband lend the use of their local landmark restaurant, the Star of India, to make this event a resounding success year after year. Navjot plays an integral role in fostering cultural exchange and understanding that has helped to make Yuba City a vibrant and diverse community.

Dennise Burbank is a life-long resident of the Yuba-Sutter area with an extensive record of service to her community. Dennise is well known for her kind heart and unparalleled generosity. Fulfilling a lifelong dream to open her own business, Dennise founded Burbank Insurance in 2007. Outside of work, she spends her time doing a variety of volunteer work. Dennise and her son give their time training service dogs that are placed with children with autism all over the country. Dennise can also be found overseeing everything from the Olivehurst Christmas Parade to operating her non-profit organization SoYouCan. Under her leadership, this organization aids needy families across the county. For the last seven years, SoYouCan has partnered with the Yuba County Sherriff's Department, Olivehurst and Linda Fire Departments, and countless local schools and volunteers to put together Operation Turkey Swap. This annual event brings Christmas dinners and toys to over 250 families and 600 children, allowing those who might go without to participate in the Christmas spirit. Additionally, as President of the Marysville Kiwanis club, Dennise oversaw the BUGS program which focuses on incentivizing local middle school students to raise their grades with the promise of a new bicycle for the top-five most improved students, as well as an ice cream social for all who take the pledge to improve. In 2012, Dennise ran for Director of Public Utilities, going on to serve as President of the Board until 2015. With her vast array of accomplishments and caring spirit, Dennise serves as a shining example of philanthropic generosity and passionate service to everyone in her community.

Neelam Canto-Lugo is a community servant who has made contributions to the Yuba-Sutter area and beyond that cannot be overstated. As a retired adjunct professor of communications at Yuba College and a feminist ahead of her time, her main mission and purpose has always been to better the lives of students, children, and women in disadvantaged communities. In her two-plus decades at Yuba College, Neelam developed and coordinated the Crossing Borders—Building Bridges Events Series. Here she effectively promoted cultural, socio-political, and religious understanding through countless events and projects, including museum exhibits on the Japanese-American Internment experience, interfaith panel discussions promoting religious tolerance, as well as annual panels on women's health, domestic violence, human trafficking, and Women's History Month. Whether in the fight to reduce hate crimes in Yuba City or support women's entrepreneurship in Nepal and Bangladesh, Neelam's presence and service-oriented mindset are felt by all she meets. For her efforts, she has been recognized with numerous awards, including but

certainly not limited to, the United States President's Gold Volunteer Service Award for volunteer work in developing countries and the John W. Rice Equity and Diversity Award. Neelam's leadership has made a positive impact on women's issues locally and internationally, where her trailblazing approach to social justice, women's rights, and equity has broken many a glass ceiling.

Jill Cook has a heart of service that is clearly and consistently demonstrated in her commitment to serving those in need. In her work as the Yolo County Deputy Administrator she does just that, focusing on bringing health and wellness to the community. Jill passionately infuses her commitment to community health and wellness with her focused determination and natural ability to forge cooperation amongst partners. In doing so, Jill was at the forefront of the local Affordable Care Act implementation, secured over $6 million in new funding through an intergovernmental transfer with the Medi-Cal managed plan, and helped the County transition to a regional public health laboratory through a joint powers agreement with two adjacent counties. More recently, Jill oversaw the completion of the Tuli Mem Park and Aquatic Center spanning 8 acres of rural western Yolo County. Her steadfast belief that underserved communities throughout Yolo County deserve access to outdoor recreation for play and exercise, inspires her to find ways of galvanizing support. Jill uses her strong public health background to champion for her community and successfully secured funding from the California Department of Parks and Recreation for Knights Landing in order to provide new outdoor recreation space in her community. Jill continually seeks ways to help others and has implemented workgroups focused on improving the quality of life for residents of Yolo County. Her hard work and determination make her a strong advocate for the well-being of her community and her generosity and volunteerism are an example for future leaders.

Jenalee Dawson is a young professional who has accomplished more in her career than many do in a lifetime. She puts her unparalleled determination and focus to work as a fierce advocate for those at risk in her community, working to address issues of interpersonal violence, senior poverty and isolation, affordable housing, homelessness, mental health and substance abuse, and accessibility to services. While she is currently employed as the Resident Social Services Coordinator for the California Department of Human Development, Jenalee continuously finds additional opportunities to contribute to the well-being of those in her community. Whether it is in her role as Service Coordinator for Parkway Plaza Senior Apartments, serving as the Chair of the Solano Partnership Against Violence, or as co-organizer of the Family Justice Center, Jenalee's impactful presence is always felt. As a member of the Senior Coalition of Solano County, Jenalee was responsible for launching the Savvy Seniors Program, which seeks to avail seniors of resources and benefits for everything from budgeting to avoiding becoming the victim of fraud. Jenalee shows immeasurable strength and courage in compassionately using her own experience overcoming violence and adversity to serve as a role model for others looking to rise above difficult circumstances and build resiliency. Jenalee is a talented and selfless individual who has made countless contributions to the lives of others and I look forward to seeing what more she accomplishes in the years ahead.

Pat Dennis has had an immeasurable impact on the town of Vacaville, where she displays a commitment to sustaining and enriching fine arts in her community. Pat has always been eager to shoulder communal responsibility and began volunteering for the North Bay Opera Guild shortly after moving to Vacaville. Here she quickly rose to become President of the organization, leading it to its peak while fostering an inviting environment at its 354 seat Opera House facility. Pat has facilitated numerous school and community outreach programs, such as the annual Young Performers Concert, while also working with the Vacaville Museum Guild to support the preservation of Vacaville's local history. Pat has logged over 16,500 volunteer hours for the North Bay Volunteer Guild and has made significant contributions to the cause of Alzheimer's research. Pat has also become a crucial part of the Vacaville Arts Council, where she holds the position of Vice President. In this position she helped to advance the organization's impact, expanding events, adding membership, and acting as an integral piece of the ''Salute to the Stars'' event. Pat's work in the community is invaluable and she is pillar of the community, beloved by all who know her.

Ana Dineen has continuously sought out ways to support and engage the underrepresented in Solano County. During her decades-long career as a school nurse, Ana oversaw the Healthy Start Family Resource Center in Fairfield and Suisun City. Under her leadership, the Family Resource Center has grown into a model child abuse prevention program, providing families in crisis a place to receive basic necessities, crisis counseling, and parenting education. Ana has also served as President of the Solano Children's Alliance, providing crucial insight on child and family needs to the Solano Board of Supervisors. Under the steady hand of her leadership, these organizations have continued to expand the range and depth of available community resources. Now retired, Ana founded Voces Unidas (United Voices), a non-profit organization focused on availing the Latino community of resources, including know-your-rights workshops, information sessions on obtaining proper identification, and education on human trafficking. With her tireless dedication to aiding those in need, Ana is truly a treasure of Solano County whose impact will be felt for generations to come.

Deborah Dunham has led a life of service, dedicated to volunteer work and philanthropic efforts. Deborah served her country in the United States Marine Corps, where she was one of the first four female marines to be selected for IBM's Computer Programming School and received two Meritorious Promotions. This alone would make her worthy of recognition, but her service did not end there. Over the last 44 years, Deborah has served as a professional fundraising executive, volunteer, and generous supporter of numerous charitable organizations throughout her community. She has a passion for developing and improving nonprofit organizations and consistently makes invaluable contributions with unmatched selflessness and dedication. To many, she is known for her work with Gorilla Doctors, a joint program between the Mountain Gorilla Veterinary Project and the UC Davis One Health Institute of Veterinary Medicine which provides veterinary care to wild mountain and Grauer's gorillas throughout East Africa, playing an important role in saving the species from extinction. As chair of their Board of Directors, her leadership, purpose, and drive helped lead the organization to new heights. Through her efforts, she has brought international renown and accolades to our community and her work received recognition from the President of Rwanda. Deborah is an inspiration to many in our community, having effectively juggled the responsibilities of family, career, and community involvement and twice beating cancer while always maintaining her commitments to the many organizations she supports. Deborah is admired and revered by friends and colleagues locally, regionally, and around the world because when she sets her mind to it, she brings about indelible change.

Nancy Geweke Elrod has made vast and meaningful contributions to the Yuba-Sutter area over her lifetime. As a Yuba City High School graduate, Nancy went on to get her degree in Recreation Administration at Cal Poly San Luis Obispo. She subsequently served as sales manager for the Lodi Conference and Visitor's Bureau, before settling in as Recreation Coordinator for the City of Yuba City. During her time in this position she oversaw the budget and implemented festivities for Yuba City's Centennial Celebration while simultaneously supervising the city's youth programming and senior activities. When she decided to join the family business, Geweke Ford, in 2009, Nancy couldn't wait to continue getting involved in her community. She has contributed immensely to her family's non-profit organization, Geweke's Caring for Women Foundation, where she served as Director since 2011. This organization financially assists local women facing cancer and has now provided over 10,000 women with low-cost mammograms and women's health screenings. Under her leadership, the Geweke's Caring for Women Foundation has helped over 430 cancer survivors through numerous grants. Nancy has co-chaired the Pink October Race for Awareness for 14 years alongside her sister and under her leadership fundraising efforts have grown up to 35 percent, raising over $150,000 each year. Nancy has also been an active member of Early Risers Kiwanis, finds time to volunteer with the Beale Military Liaison Committee, and has proudly served on the Sutter Medical Foundation Philanthropy Committee since 2009. Through her effective leadership and enthusiastic approach, Nancy has touched the lives of many throughout the Yuba-Sutter community.

Catherine Farman is a dedicated advocate for the most vulnerable populations of her community. For years, Catherine has donated her time and expertise to the Empower Yolo Board of Directors, where she has been instrumental in furthering their mission to promote safe, healthy, and resilient communities. Empower Yolo is the county's leading resource for survivors of domestic violence, sexual assault, human trafficking, and child abuse. Catherine has served in numerous leadership roles at the organization, where she has helped to raise thousands of dollars, volunteered at countless events, and grown Empower Yolo's extensive network of support.

Additionally, she takes the time to inspire and mentor her colleagues, helping them to harness their own skills, knowledge, and passion to serve their community. Catherine is also the founder of the Davis Schools Foundation, which has helped every school in Davis and thousands of children over the years. She has also given her time and support to such organizations as 100 Women Who Care, the Yolo Crisis Nursery, and the Yolo County Food Bank. Catherine is a fierce advocate, caring friend, loving mother, and inspirational leader whose dedicated service to her community has changed countless lives in Yolo County.

Diana Fuentes-Michel is a dedicated advocate not only within the Yolo and Sacramento regions, but throughout the entire state of California. For years, Diana has applied her skills and expertise in higher education policy to ensure that migrant, low-income, and moderate-income students from the state of California can pursue a higher education. Diana has also been instrumental in ensuring that upwards of 50,000 undocumented students can attend college by ushering in California's Dream Act Application. Diana also contributed to the establishment of the bilingual career and college fair called Steps to College: Paseo de la Universidad, which was the first of its kind in Yolo and Sacramento counties. Diana's work as an establishing member and volunteer for the Chicano-Latino Youth Leadership Program has provided thousands of California's young Latinx with the opportunity to visit Sacramento, stay on college campuses, and participate in state government affairs. She has also volunteered her time with Cien Amigos where she helped to raise funds for the nonprofit that serves 300 students and helps administer the organization's yearly scholarship program. Diana is an inspirational leader whose dedicated service to her community has changed countless lives in our community and throughout the state of California.

I congratulate each of them and commend them for their work. I am inspired by them and firmly believe when women succeed, America succeeds.

CELEBRATING THE INSTALLATION OF DR. MATTHEW GIORDANO AS THE FOURTH PRESIDENT OF VILLA MARIA COLLEGE

HON. BRIAN HIGGINS

OF NEW YORK

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. HIGGINS of New York. Madam Speaker, today I rise to acknowledge the installation of Dr. Matthew Giordano as the Fourth President of Villa Maria College on Friday, November 15, 2019.

Villa Maria College is a private, co-educational, Catholic college providing the support and resources needed to give students the opportunity to learn and grow with a culturally diverse population that lives its ideals of truth, charity, and unity.

Dr. Matthew Giordano, the first male, layperson president in the college's history, assumed the role of interim president in July 2018 following the retirement of Sister Marcella Marie Garus, Villa's legendary forty-year leader. Since that time, the College launched three new academic programs including flexible business, game design and software development proactively responding to heightened employment opportunities in these growth industries. Scholarship eSports has also found a home at Villa Maria College.

This visionary leader is not only responding to the marketplace of today but ensuring the college's future growth as he and his team are creating a new strategic plan, introduced new models of governance and is developing strong connections between the Villa Maria family of students, faculty and staff.

Prior to his selection, Giordano served at vice president for academic affairs from 2012 to 2018. During that time, he played a pivotal role in planning and implementing the college's creative blueprint resulting in major enrollment growth and increased retention, launching new academic programs, including an honors program, and helping to secure grant funding in support of student success, including a $1.8 million Title III grant.

Dr. Giordano brought his passion for teaching English and gift for student engagement to Villa in 2005 and became chairperson of the liberal arts department in 2009.

It is especially noteworthy that while he is working within the beautiful, stately walls of the Villa Campus, Dr. Giordano understands that the college is strengthened when the surrounding neighborhoods are strengthened. An anchor institution and community asset linking the borders of the city of Buffalo and the town of Cheektowaga, Villa's new president is committed to open dialogue with local leaders and elected officials to develop partnerships and initiate collaborative relationships in support of its students and neighbors.

Dr. Giordano has a Bachelor of Arts degree in English and Philosophy from Binghamton University and both a Master of Arts and doctorate degree in American Literature from the Ohio State University. He successfully completed the Executive Leadership Academy of the Council of Independent Colleges and the Felician Leadership Institute this past year.

He follows in the footsteps of true Felician leaders as Villa Maria College was founded in 1960 by Mother Mary Annette Guzowski and the Felician Sisters of the Immaculate Heart of Mary Province. Through extensions of charters, National and State Accreditations and significant program expansions offering real world experiences, Villa Maria College at almost sixty years of service remains a vital center of educational energy as it embraces the academic, social and careers goals of its students.

Madam Speaker, I take this time to congratulate Dr. Matthew Giordano on his installation as President of Villa Maria College. This new era in the college's history will begin with a true celebration witnessed by his wife, Jennifer Desiderio, their three daughters and the extended Villa Maria Community. We extend our best wishes for continued success as he leads this unique institution of higher education into the future.

HONORING JAMES AND DELIA NETTO'S 60TH BIRTHDAYS AND 40TH WEDDING ANNIVERSARY

HON. JIM COSTA

OF CALIFORNIA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. COSTA. Madam Speaker, I rise today to celebrate Mr. and Mrs. James and Delia Netto on the special occasion of their 60th birthdays and 40th wedding anniversary. They are wonderful members of the community and have been an inspiration for all married couples.

James and Delia Netto were born in Hanford, California—he on May 17 and she on December 30—in 1959. They come from proud Portuguese families originating from the Azores Islands. James and Delia met in church and quickly realized they had found the loves of their life. They were married on September 1, 1979 at Shrine of Our Lady of Fatima Catholic Church in Laton, California. The Nettos are the proud parents of two daughters, Danae Koprivetz and Diandra Vantrease.

Together, James and Delia founded Double N Diary and Netto Trucking. James and his brother, Frank, then started Netto Agriculture, Inc., where Delia served as Chief Financial Officer. James now owns Penny Newman Grain Company, serving as Vice President of Sales and Production.

James and Delia are known for their service and generosity in the Central Valley of California. They were awarded the St. John Bosco Friends of the Youth Award in 2011 for their contributions to St. Rose-McCarthy Catholic School in Hanford, California. Additionally, James serves on the St. Vincent de Paul Center Board of Directors in Hanford and the couple support the Poverello House, Candle Light Guild, Saint Agnes Holy Cross Center, Make-A-Wish Foundation, among other organizations.

The Netto's favorite pastime is spending time with their family and friends, including their daughters, sons-in-law Jeff and Troy and beloved grandchildren Emma, James and Sloane. They also enjoy traveling.

Madam Speaker, I ask my colleagues in the U.S. House of Representatives to join me in celebrating my friends James and Delia Netto as they celebrate their 60th birthdays and 40th wedding anniversary. I join their family and friends in celebrating this milestone occasion.

TRIBUTE TO PARKER OVERTON

HON. GREGORY F. MURPHY

OF NORTH CAROLINA

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. MURPHY of North Carolina. Madam Speaker, I rise to pay tribute to Parker Overton of Grimesland, North Carolina. Mr. Overton was recently presented The Order of the Long Leaf Pine on October 22nd. The Order of the Long Leaf Pine is the highest award for state service granted by the Governor. It is presented to persons for exemplary service to the state of North Carolina and its communities that is above and beyond the call of duty and which has made a significant impact and strengthened North Carolina.

Mr. Overton, who grew up on Greenville, is the founder of Overton's, the world's largest

catalog of watersports and boating supplies from 1975 to 2003. He is chairman-elect of Greenville Utilities Corporation, chairman of the Board of Vidant Health Foundation, founding director and former board member of Metrics Pharmaceuticals, founding member of Select Bank and Trust Greenville and Select Bancorp, former president of the N.C. State Veterinary Foundation, member of the Advisory Board for the East Carolina University Chemistry Department and was instrumental in securing funding for the ECU School of Dental Medicine.

Madam Speaker, please join me today in honoring this great citizen of the state of North Carolina.

INTRODUCTION OF THE VETERANS AND CONSUMERS FAIR CREDIT ACT

HON. JESÚS G. "CHUY" GARCÍA

OF ILLINOIS

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mr. GARCÍA of Illinois. Madam Speaker, I am proud to introduce the Veterans and Consumers Fair Credit Act, which extends important protections to all consumers.

In 2006, Congress imposed an interest rate cap on many consumer loans, including payday products, for active-duty servicemembers and their dependents via a bipartisan amendment known as the Military Lending Act. This rate cap has proven successful in cracking down on usury and preventing predatory lending from trapping active-duty military families in a cycle of debt.

We know that the Military Lending Act has preserved access to credit while protecting consumers from predatory payday lenders. Some states have extended these proven protections to all their residents, but my constituents in Illinois remain vulnerable to payday loans, debt collection, vehicle repossessions, and more.

Veterans and consumers deserve the same protections from vicious debt traps that active-duty service members receive, and the Veterans and Consumers Fair Credit Act will do just that.

I encourage my colleagues to support this bill.

IN RECOGNITION OF RODNEY KROPF

HON. VICKY HARTZLER

OF MISSOURI

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Mrs. HARTZLER. Madam Speaker, I rise today to congratulate Ozark Organic Feeds and founder Rodney Kropf for the completion of their new $13 million expansion project. Rodney was able to use savings from the Tax Cuts and Jobs Act to expand his feed operation, investing an additional $10 million into the new project.

As a poultry farmer for over 36 years, Rodney knows a thing or two about hard work. Ozark Organic Feeds was incorporated in Dallas County a little more than a decade ago. Today the new 10,000 square foot facility includes four storage bins that hold over 700,000 bushels of grain.

Ozark Organic Feeds uses state-of-the-art technology to produce precision organic animal feed blends for 2.5 million hens throughout the United States. Output from their new plant operations is now yielding 2,400 tons of grain a week, enough to fill 100 to 110 semi-trucks.

Madam Speaker, I congratulate Rodney Kropf for his hard work and hope my colleagues will recognize that tax cuts lead to economic growth.

HONORING THE LIFE OF NAVAL VETERAN, LT. HENRY ROSS PEROT

HON. MARCY KAPTUR

OF OHIO

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Tuesday, November 12, 2019

Ms. KAPTUR. Madam Speaker, I rise today during this week commemorating veterans in memoriam of Lt. Henry "Ross" Perot, of Texarcana, Texas.

When I learned of Ross Perot's passing this summer, I was saddened by the loss of a passionate and determined American patriot.

Ross Perot was a one of a kind American. His swashbuckling, Texas vintage and 'can do' spirit was irrepressible. He lived the life he chose full steam ahead. His life of service was attributed to the love that he had for our great nation, and for that of his fellow service members who make the most honorable sacrifice to serve in our armed forces. He exhibited fierce loyalty to his family and friends, and his love of our nation was encapsulated in his famous catchphrase, "It's just that simple." On this Veteran's Day, let us remember and honor Ross' military career as a Naval Officer, and the thousands upon thousands of people and institutions he helped throughout his life—most often privately with no fanfare.

From a young age Ross strove for excellence. At twelve years old he joined the Boy Scouts of America, and within a year of joining he achieved the rank of Eagle Scout. This is the most prestigious title achieved by very few young men who participate in the program, which develops character and a strong foundation toward a life in public service.

A proud and grateful graduate of the U.S. Naval Academy at Annapolis, Class of 1949, Ross served as a Lieutenant (j.g.) in the Navy for four years. While at the Academy, Ross was elected Student Body President, and also aided in the development of its honor system. He was assigned to the destroyer USS *Sigourney* (DD–643), and was then later reassigned to the aircraft carrier USS *Leyte* (CVS–32).

Ross was also an agent of action and gave tremendous support to veteran's organizations such as the Vietnam Prisoners of War, and the Son Tay Raiders. He most notably advocated for the hundreds of former war prisoners left behind at the end of the Vietnam war. Exhibiting the mantra of "no man left behind," Ross fought to alleviate the afflictions of his brothers and strove to provide them with better nourishment and medical treatment. He was truly a beacon of light at a time of utter darkness for so many in the military.

A man of fierce determination, Ross lived every day to its fullest. His candidacy in 1992 and 1996 for the presidency of the United States created a thunderbolt in American politics. His founding of the Reform Party brought new issues forward to the public—fair trade was among them with his firm prediction that NAFTA would create a great sucking sound of U.S. jobs outsourced to penny wage nations. That proved correct. Trade deficits with U.S. trade partners have not been balanced since and, on balance, have been increasingly larger every year. He predicted the political thunderbolt this would spawn.

Though many pundits put forth highly critical and piercing commentary regarding this businessman turned presidential candidate, Ross Perot's persistence drew attention to America's diminishing industrial base and the risks posed to the nation's innate strength as to growing U.S. government debt. By the year 2000, his drive had helped move the nation to balance the annual budget and begin paying down its long-term debt. That is, until 9/11. In response to his critics who charged him with being crazy, Ross' answer was to jubilantly dance across the stage with his wife Margot to the great Patsy Cline's love anthem "Crazy," to the sheer delight and spontaneous applause of his audiences.

One cannot reflect on Ross' life without mentioning his astounding business prowess. He established many business ventures and cutting-edge firms such as founding the Electronic Data Systems (EDS), which became a leader in record processing. He also invested in Apple founder Steve Jobs' NeXT computer and software company, which helped shape our current technological age. One of Ross' most impressive ventures was his namesake, Perot Systems. Perot Systems helped streamline record keeping for government, manufacturing, banking, insurance, and most notably health records by digitization and automation. Before being purchased by Dell, Perot grew his business to be a Fortune 1000 company with offices in over 25 countries, with more than 23,000 employees, and annual revenue of $2.8 billion.

His business successes gave way to his unwavering support of private gifts of health and medical support to veterans and civilians, many of whom were strangers. One such instance was the National Medal of Honor Museum, a museum which he donated in an effort to highlight the sacrifice and bravery of American Medal of Honor recipients. His contributions to the University of Texas Southwestern Medical Center surpassed $100 million. Perot wanted this funding to be used for the indigent and uninsured, or ill veterans and armed services members. He also donated $2.5 million in seed money to fund research for returned veterans after the Gulf War suffering from neurological symptoms.

As we remember the life of Ross Perot during this Veteran's Day week, we remember his infectious laugh and how he was no one's fool. He will be deeply missed by his friends and family. My thoughts and prayers are with both the Perot and Birmingham families, his wife Margot, their five children Ross Jr., Nancy, Suzanne, Carolyn, Katherine, and their nineteen grandchildren. May his legacy of patriotism and service live on. And may he be granted eternal peace, though I suspect he is already rearranging heaven's accoutrements.

Daily Digest

HIGHLIGHTS

See Résumé of Congressional Activity.

Senate

Chamber Action

Routine Proceedings, pages S6489–S6514

Measures Introduced: Eleven bills and three resolutions were introduced, as follows: S. 2830–2840, and S. Res. 417–419. **Page S6507**

Measures Reported:

S. 1877, to establish procedures and consequences in the event of a failure to complete regular appropriations, with an amendment in the nature of a substitute. (S. Rept. No. 116–158) **Page S6507**

Measures Passed:

National Law Enforcement Museum Commemorative Coin Act: Senate passed H.R. 1865, to require the Secretary of the Treasury to mint a coin in commemoration of the opening of the National Law Enforcement Museum in the District of Columbia, after agreeing to the following amendment proposed thereto: **Page S6512**

Inhofe (for Blunt) Amendment No. 1244, to add a provision relating to financial assurances. **Page S6512**

Senate buildings charitable collection: Senate agreed to S. Res. 419, permitting the collection of clothing, toys, food, and housewares during the holiday season for charitable purposes in Senate buildings. **Page S6512**

ESSENTIAL NATIONAL SECURITY AUTHORITIES ACT INDEFINITELY POSTPONED—AGREEMENT: A unanimous-consent agreement was reached providing that the Senate's action placing S. 2731, to authorize appropriations for fiscal year 2020 for military activities of the Department of Defense, for military construction, and for defense activities of the Department of Energy, on the calendar be vitiated and the bill be considered introduced and held at the desk, on October 29, 2019, and then indefinitely postponed. **Page S6512**

Messages from the President: Senate received the following messages from the President of the United States:

Transmitting, pursuant to law, a report relative to the continuation of the national emergency that was originally declared in Executive Order 12938 of November 14, 1994, with respect to the proliferation of weapons of mass destruction; which was referred to the Committee on Banking, Housing, and Urban Affairs. (PM–36) **Page S6506**

Transmitting, pursuant to law, a report relative to the continuation of the national emergency that was originally declared in Executive Order 12170 of November 14, 1979, with respect to Iran; which was referred to the Committee on Banking, Housing, and Urban Affairs. (PM–37) **Page S6507**

WOLF NOMINATION—AGREEMENT: Senate resumed consideration of the nomination of Chad F. Wolf, of Virginia, to be Under Secretary for Strategy, Policy, and Plans, Department of Homeland Security. **Pages S6491–S6500**

During consideration of this nomination today, Senate also took the following action:

By 54 yeas to 40 nays (Vote No. EX. 353), Senate agreed to the motion to close further debate on the nomination. **Page S6500**

A unanimous-consent agreement was reached providing for further consideration of the nomination, post-cloture, at approximately 10 a.m., on Wednesday, November 13, 2019, with the post-cloture time expiring at 11 a.m. **Page S6512**

Nominations Received: Senate received the following nominations: Routine lists in the Air Force, Army, Marine Corps, and Navy. **Page S6514**

Measures Read the First Time: **Pages S6507, S6512**

Additional Cosponsors: **Pages S6507–09**

Statements on Introduced Bills/Resolutions: **Pages S6509–10**

Additional Statements: **Pages S6505–06**

Amendments Submitted: Pages S6511–12

Record Votes: One record vote was taken today. (Total—353) Page S6500

Adjournment: Senate convened at 3 p.m. and adjourned at 7:01 p.m., until 10 a.m. on Wednesday, November 13, 2019. (For Senate's program, see the remarks of the Acting Majority Leader in today's Record on page S6512.)

Committee Meetings

(Committees not listed did not meet)

No committee meetings were held.

House of Representatives

Chamber Action

Public Bills and Resolutions Introduced: 26 public bills, H.R. 5032–5057; 1 private bill, H.R. 5058; and 5 resolutions, H. Res. 688–692 were introduced. Pages H8782–84

Additional Cosponsors: Pages H8785–86

Reports Filed: Reports were filed today as follows:

H.R. 3699, to codify the Transportation Security Administration's responsibility relating to securing pipelines against cybersecurity threats, acts of terrorism, and other nefarious acts that jeopardize the physical security or cybersecurity of pipelines, and for other purposes (H. Rept. 116–279);

H.R. 1615, to transfer the responsibility of verifying small business concerns owned and controlled by veterans or service-disabled veterans to the Small Business Administration, and for other purposes, with an amendment (H. Rept. 116–280, Part 1);

H.R. 3224, to amend title 38, United States Code, to provide for increased access to Department of Veterans Affairs medical care for women veterans, with an amendment (H. Rept. 116–281); and

H.R. 3141, to limit the collection of annual premiums under the FHA program for mortgage insurance for single family housing, and for other purposes, with an amendment (H. Rept. 116–282). Page H8782

Speaker: Read a letter from the Speaker wherein she appointed Representative Butterfield to act as Speaker pro tempore for today. Page H8745

Journal: The House agreed to the Speaker's approval of the Journal by voice vote. Pages H8745, H8775

Recess: The House recessed at 2:05 p.m. and reconvened at 4:05 p.m. Pages H8745–46

Suspensions: The House agreed to suspend the rules and pass the following measures:

Protect the GI Bill Act: H.R. 4625, amended, to amend title 38, United States Code, to require that educational institutions abide by certain principles as a condition of approval for purposes of the educational assistance programs of the Department of Veterans Affairs; Pages H8746–51

Reducing High Risk to Veterans and Veterans Services Act: H.R. 4477, amended, to direct the Secretary of Veterans Affairs to submit to Congress a plan to address certain high risk areas identified by the Comptroller General of the United States regarding the Department of Veterans Affairs in the 2019 High-Risk List of the Government Accountability Office; Pages H8751–53

VA Tele-Hearing Modernization Act: H.R. 4771, amended, to amend title 38, United States Code, to permit appellants to appear in disability compensation cases before the Board of Veterans' Appeals by picture and voice transmission from locations other than facilities of the Department of Veterans Affairs; Pages H8753–55

Agreed to amend the title so as to read: ''To amend title 38, United States Code, to permit appellants to appear in cases before the Board of Veterans' Appeals by picture and voice transmission from locations other than facilities of the Department of Veterans Affairs, and for other purposes.''; Page H8755

VA Overpayment Accountability Act: H.R. 4360, to amend title 38, United States Code, to improve the due process accorded veterans with respect to recovery of overpayments made by the Department and other amounts owed by veterans to the United States, to improve the processing of veterans benefits by the Department of Veterans Affairs; Pages H8755–57

Protecting Families of Fallen Servicemembers Act: H.R. 4356, amended, to amend the

Servicemembers Civil Relief Act to allow certain individuals to terminate contracts for telephone, multichannel video programming, or internet access service; **Pages H8757–58**

GI Bill Planning Act of 2019: H.R. 4162, amended, to amend title 38, United States Code, to extend the period under which an election must be made for entitlement to educational assistance under the All-Volunteer Educational Assistance Program of Department of Veterans Affairs, to phase out the use of such program, by a ⅔ yea-and-nay vote of 408 yeas with none voting "nay", Roll No. 610; **Pages H8758–60, H8774**

VA Design-Build Construction Enhancement Act of 2019: H.R. 3996, to amend title 38, United States Code, to provide for certain requirements relating to the use of the design-build construction method for Department of Veterans Affairs construction projects; **Pages H8760–61**

Fallen Warrior Battlefield Cross Memorial Act: H.R. 1424, to amend title 38, United States Code, to ensure the Secretary of Veterans Affairs permits the display of Fallen Soldier Displays in national cemeteries; and **Pages H8761–63**

Amending title 38, United States Code, to provide for increased access to Department of Veterans Affairs medical care for women veterans: H.R. 3224, amended, to amend title 38, United States Code, to provide for increased access to Department of Veterans Affairs medical care for women veterans, by a ⅔ yea-and-nay vote of 399 yeas to 11 nays, Roll No. 611. **Pages H8763–73, H8774–75**

Presidential Messages: Read a message from the President wherein he notified Congress that the national emergency with respect to Iran that was declared in Executive Order 12170 of November 14, 1979 is to continue in effect beyond November 14, 2019—referred to the Committee on Foreign Affairs and ordered to be printed (H. Doc. 116–79). **Pages H8773–74**

Read a message from the President wherein he notified Congress that the national emergency with respect to the proliferation of weapons of mass destruction that was declared in Executive Order 12938 of November 14, 1994 is to continue in effect beyond November 14, 2019—referred to the Committee on Foreign Affairs and ordered to be printed (H. Doc. 116–80). **Page H8774**

Quorum Calls—Votes: Two yea-and-nay votes developed during the proceedings of today and appear on pages H8774 and H8774–75. There were no quorum calls.

Adjournment: The House met at 2 p.m. and adjourned at 8:07 p.m.

Committee Meetings

MISCELLANEOUS MEASURE

Committee on House Administration: Full Committee held a markup on H.R. 1980, a bill to establish in the Smithsonian Institution a comprehensive women's history museum, and for other purposes. H.R. 1980 was ordered reported, as amended.

UNITED STATES EXPORT FINANCE AGENCY ACT OF 2019

Committee on Rules: Full Committee began a hearing on H.R. 4863, the "United States Export Finance Agency Act of 2019". Testimony was heard from Chairman Waters, and Representatives Stivers and Lucas.

Joint Meetings

No joint committee meetings were held.

NEW PUBLIC LAWS

(For last listing of Public Laws, see DAILY DIGEST, *p. D1206)*

S. 693, to amend title 36, United States Code, to require that the POW/MIA flag be displayed on all days that the flag of the United States is displayed on certain Federal property. Signed on November 7, 2019. (Public Law 116–67)

H.R. 1396, to award Congressional Gold Medals to Katherine Johnson and Dr. Christine Darden, to posthumously award Congressional Gold Medals to Dorothy Vaughan and Mary Jackson, and to award a Congressional Gold Medal to honor all of the women who contributed to the success of the National Aeronautics and Space Administration during the Space Race. Signed on November 8, 2019. (Public Law 116–68)

COMMITTEE MEETINGS FOR WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 13, 2019

(Committee meetings are open unless otherwise indicated)

Senate

Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation: business meeting to consider S. 10, to require the Inter-Agency Task Force on Harmful Algal Blooms and Hypoxia to develop a plan for reducing, mitigating, and controlling harmful algal blooms and hypoxia in South Florida, S. 481, to encourage States to require the installation of residential carbon monoxide detectors in homes, S. 999, to provide for Federal coordination of activities supporting sustainable chemistry, S. 1069, to require the Secretary of

Commerce, acting through the Administrator of the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, to establish a constituent-driven program to provide a digital information platform capable of efficiently integrating coastal data with decision-support tools, training, and best practices and to support collection of priority coastal geospatial data to inform and improve local, State, regional, and Federal capacities to manage the coastal region, S. 1640, to require compliant flame mitigation devices to be used on portable fuel containers for flammable liquid fuels, S. 1982, to improve efforts to combat marine debris, S. 2330, to amend the Ted Stevens Olympic and Amateur Sports Act to provide for congressional oversight of the board of directors of the United States Olympic and Paralympic Committee and to protect amateur athletes from emotional, physical, and sexual abuse, S. 2346, to improve the Fishery Resource Disaster Relief program of the National Marine Fisheries Service, S. 2429, to reauthorize the Coral Reef Conservation Act of 2000 and to establish the United States Coral Reef Task Force, S. 2453, to assist in the conservation of the North Atlantic right whale by supporting and providing financial resources for North Atlantic right whale conservation programs and projects of persons with expertise required for the conservation of North Atlantic right whales, S. 2472, to redesignate the NASA John H. Glenn Research Center at Plum Brook Station, Ohio, as the NASA John H. Glenn Research Center at the Neil A. Armstrong Test Facility, S. 2525, to require the Director of the National Institute of Standards and Technology to conduct a study of personal protective equipment worn by firefighters to determine the prevalence and concentration of per- and polyfluoroalkyl substances, S. 2535, to require the Secretary of Commerce to conduct an assessment and analysis relating to the decline in the business formation rate in the United States, S. 2597, to require the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration to make certain operational models available to the public, S. 2693, to improve oversight by the Federal Communications Commission of the wireless and broadcast emergency alert systems, S. 2775, to improve the cyber workforce of the United States, S. 2782, to improve provisions of law relating to sexual harassment and assault prevention at the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, S. 2789, to amend the Communications Act of 1934 and title 17, United States Code, to extend expiring provisions relating to the retransmission of signals of television broadcast stations, S. 2800, to authorize programs of the National Aeronautics and Space Administration, S. 2802, to amend the Marine Mammal Protection Act of 1972 to reauthorize and modify the John H. Prescott Marine Mammal Rescue and Response Grant Program, S. 2805, to improve transit-oriented development financing, H.R. 3153, to direct the Director of the National Science Foundation to support research on opioid addiction, an original bill entitled, ''Marine Mammal Research and Response Act of 2019'', the nominations of Ian Paul Steff, of Indiana, to be Assistant Secretary of Commerce and Director General of the United States and Foreign Commercial Service, Michael Graham, of Kansas, to be a Member of the National Transportation Safety Board for a term expiring December 31, 2020, and to be a Member of the National Transportation Safety Board for a term expiring December 31, 2025, Carl Whitney Bentzel, of Maryland, to be a Federal Maritime Commissioner, Theodore Rokita, of Indiana, to be a Director of the Amtrak Board of Directors, and routine lists in the Coast Guard, 10 a.m., SD–G50.

Committee on Environment and Public Works: to hold hearings to examine preserving and expanding clean, reliable nuclear power, focusing on United States commercial nuclear reactor performance trends and safety initiatives, 10 a.m., SD–406.

Committee on Health, Education, Labor, and Pensions: to hold hearings to examine the response to lung illnesses and rising youth electronic cigarette use, 10 a.m., SD–430.

Committee on Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs: to hold hearings to examine unprecedented migration at the United States southern border, focusing on the year in review, 9:30 a.m., SD–342.

Committee on the Judiciary: to hold hearings to examine the nominations of Stanley Blumenfeld, and Mark C. Scarsi, both to be a United States District Judge for the Central District of California, Grace Karaffa Obermann, of Virginia, to be a Judge of the United States Court of Federal Claims for a term of fifteen years, and Stephen A. Vaden, of Tennessee, to be a Judge of the United States Court of International Trade, 10 a.m., SD–226.

House

Committee on Armed Services, Subcommittee on Readiness; and Subcommittee on Tactical Air and Land Forces, joint hearing entitled ''F–35 Program Update: Sustainment, Production, and Affordability Challenges'', 10 a.m., 2118 Rayburn.

Committee on Energy and Commerce, Subcommittee on Health, markup on H.R. 2339, the ''Reversing the Youth Tobacco Epidemic Act of 2019''; H.R. 4995, the ''Maternal Health Quality Improvement Act of 2019''; H.R. 4996, the ''Helping Medicaid Offer Maternity Services Act of 2019''; and H.R. 2387, the ''STOP GAMES Act of 2019'', 10 a.m., 2123 Rayburn.

Committee on Financial Services, Subcommittee on National Security, International Development, and Monetary Policy, hearing entitled ''How America Leads Abroad: An Examination of Multilateral Development Institutions'', 10 a.m., 2128 Rayburn.

November 13, Full Committee, markup on H.R. 2445, the ''Self-Employed Mortgage Act''; H.R. 3490, the ''Small Business Lending Fairness Act''; H.R. 3948, the ''Debt Collection Practices Harmonization Act''; H.R. 4403, the ''Stop Debt Collection Abuse Act''; H.R. 5021, the ''Ending Debt Collection Harassment Act of 2019''; H.R. 2398, to amend the United States Housing Act of 1937 and title 38, United States Code, to expand eligibility for the HUD–VASH program, to direct the Secretary of Veterans Affairs to submit annual reports to the Committees on Veterans' Affairs of the Senate and House of Representatives regarding homeless veterans, and for other purposes; H.R. 5003, the ''Fair Debt Collection Practices for Servicemembers Act''; H.R. 5001, the ''Non-

Judicial Foreclosure Debt Collection Clarification Act''; and H.R. 5013, the ''Small Business Fair Debt Collection Protection Act'', 2 p.m., 2128 Rayburn.

Committee on Foreign Affairs, Subcommittee on Europe, Eurasia, Energy, and the Environment, hearing entitled ''Democracy and the NATO Alliance: Upholding our Shared Democratic Values'', 2 p.m., 2172 Rayburn.

Committee on the Judiciary, Full Committee, markup on H.J. Res. 79, removing the deadline for the ratification of the equal rights amendment, 10 a.m., 2141 Rayburn.

Subcommittee on Antitrust, Commercial, and Administrative Law, hearing entitled ''Online Platforms and Market Power, Part 4: Perspectives of the Antitrust Agencies'', 2 p.m., 2141 Rayburn.

Committee on Natural Resources, Subcommittee for Indigenous Peoples of the United States, hearing on H.R. 4957, the ''Native American Child Protection Act'', 10 a.m., 1324 Longworth.

Subcommittee on National Parks, Forests, and Public Lands, hearing entitled ''Roads to Ruin: Examining the Impacts of Removing National Forest Roadless Protections'', 2 p.m., 1324 Longworth.

Committee on Rules, Full Committee, continue hearing on H.R. 4863, the ''United States Export Finance Agency Act of 2019'', 3 p.m., H–313 Capitol.

Committee on Science, Space, and Technology, Full Committee, hearing entitled ''Strengthening Transparency or Silencing Science? The Future of Science in EPA Rulemaking'', 10 a.m., 2318 Rayburn.

Subcommittee on Space and Aeronautics, hearing entitled ''Keeping Our Sights on Mars Part 2: Structuring a Moon-Mars Program for Success'', 2 p.m., 2318 Rayburn.

Committee on Small Business, Full Committee, hearing entitled ''Upskilling the Medical Workforce: Opportunities in Health Innovation'', 11:30 a.m., 2360 Rayburn.

Committee on Transportation and Infrastructure, Subcommittee on Railroads, Pipelines, and Hazardous Materials, hearing entitled ''Amtrak Now and Into the Future'', 10 a.m., 2167 Rayburn.

Subcommittee on Economic Development, Public Buildings, and Emergency Management, hearing entitled ''Review of Smithsonian Institution Current Facilities and Future Space Needs'', 2 p.m., 2167 Rayburn.

Committee on Veterans' Affairs, Full Committee, hearing entitled ''Hijacking our Heroes: Exploiting Veterans through Disinformation on Social Media'', 2 p.m., HVC–210.

Permanent Select Committee on Intelligence, Full Committee, hearing entitled ''Impeachment Inquiry: Ambassador William B. Taylor and Mr. George Kent'', 10 a.m., 1100 Longworth.

Joint Meetings

Joint Economic Committee: to hold hearings to examine the economic outlook, 11 a.m., SH–216.

CONGRESSIONAL PROGRAM AHEAD

Week of November 13 through November 15, 2019

Senate Chamber

On *Wednesday*, Senate will continue consideration of the nomination of Chad F. Wolf, of Virginia, to be Under Secretary for Strategy, Policy, and Plans, Department of Homeland Security, post-cloture, and vote on confirmation of the nomination at 11 a.m.

Following disposition of the nomination of Chad F. Wolf, Senate will vote on the motion to invoke cloture on the nomination of Steven J. Menashi, of New York, to be United States Circuit Judge for the Second Circuit.

During the balance of the week, Senate may consider any cleared legislative and executive business.

Senate Committees

(Committee meetings are open unless otherwise indicated)

Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation: November 13, business meeting to consider S. 10, to require the Inter-Agency Task Force on Harmful Algal Blooms and Hypoxia to develop a plan for reducing, mitigating, and controlling harmful algal blooms and hypoxia in South Florida, S. 481, to encourage States to require the installation of residential carbon monoxide detectors in homes, S. 999, to provide for Federal coordination of activities supporting sustainable chemistry, S. 1069, to require the Secretary of Commerce, acting through the Administrator of the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, to establish a constituent-driven program to provide a digital information platform capable of efficiently integrating coastal data with decision-support tools, training, and best practices and to support collection of priority coastal geospatial data to inform and improve local, State, regional, and Federal capacities to manage the coastal region, S. 1640, to require compliant flame mitigation devices to be used on portable fuel containers for flammable liquid fuels, S. 1982, to improve efforts to combat marine debris, S. 2330, to amend the Ted Stevens Olympic and Amateur Sports Act to provide for congressional oversight of the board of directors of the United States Olympic and Paralympic Committee and to protect amateur athletes from emotional, physical, and sexual abuse, S. 2346, to improve the Fishery Resource Disaster Relief program of the National Marine Fisheries Service, S. 2429, to reauthorize the Coral Reef Conservation Act of 2000 and to establish the United States Coral Reef Task Force, S. 2453, to assist in the conservation of the North Atlantic right whale by supporting and providing financial resources for North Atlantic right whale conservation programs and projects of persons with expertise required for the conservation of North Atlantic right whales, S. 2472, to redesignate the NASA John H. Glenn Research Center at Plum Brook Station, Ohio, as the NASA John H. Glenn Research Center at the Neil A. Armstrong Test Facility, S. 2525, to require the Director of the National Institute of Standards and Technology to

conduct a study of personal protective equipment worn by firefighters to determine the prevalence and concentration of per-and polyfluoroalkyl substances, S. 2535, to require the Secretary of Commerce to conduct an assessment and analysis relating to the decline in the business formation rate in the United States, S. 2597, to require the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration to make certain operational models available to the public, S. 2693, to improve oversight by the Federal Communications Commission of the wireless and broadcast emergency alert systems, S. 2775, to improve the cyber workforce of the United States, S. 2782, to improve provisions of law relating to sexual harassment and assault prevention at the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, S. 2789, to amend the Communications Act of 1934 and title 17, United States Code, to extend expiring provisions relating to the retransmission of signals of television broadcast stations, S. 2800, to authorize programs of the National Aeronautics and Space Administration, S. 2802, to amend the Marine Mammal Protection Act of 1972 to reauthorize and modify the John H. Prescott Marine Mammal Rescue and Response Grant Program, S. 2805, to improve transit-oriented development financing, H.R. 3153, to direct the Director of the National Science Foundation to support research on opioid addiction, an original bill entitled, ''Marine Mammal Research and Response Act of 2019'', the nominations of Ian Paul Steff, of Indiana, to be Assistant Secretary of Commerce and Director General of the United States and Foreign Commercial Service, Michael Graham, of Kansas, to be a Member of the National Transportation Safety Board for a term expiring December 31, 2020, and to be a Member of the National Transportation Safety Board for a term expiring December 31, 2025, Carl Whitney Bentzel, of Maryland, to be a Federal Maritime Commissioner, Theodore Rokita, of Indiana, to be a Director of the Amtrak Board of Directors, and routine lists in the Coast Guard, 10 a.m., SD–G50.

Committee on Energy and Natural Resources: November 14, to hold hearings to examine the nomination of Dan R. Brouillette, of Texas, to be Secretary of Energy, 10:30 a.m., SD–366.

Committee on Environment and Public Works: November 13, to hold hearings to examine preserving and expanding clean, reliable nuclear power, focusing on United States commercial nuclear reactor performance trends and safety initiatives, 10 a.m., SD–406.

Committee on Health, Education, Labor, and Pensions: November 13, to hold hearings to examine the response to lung illnesses and rising youth electronic cigarette use, 10 a.m., SD–430.

Committee on Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs: November 13, to hold hearings to examine unprecedented migration at the United States southern border, focusing on the year in review, 9:30 a.m., SD–342.

November 14, Full Committee, to hold hearings to examine the nomination of Peter Gaynor, of Rhode Island, to be Administrator of the Federal Emergency Management Agency, Department of Homeland Security, 9:30 a.m., SD–342.

Committee on the Judiciary: November 13, to hold hearings to examine the nominations of Stanley Blumenfeld, and Mark C. Scarsi, both to be a United States District Judge for the Central District of California, Grace Karaffa Obermann, of Virginia, to be a Judge of the United States Court of Federal Claims for a term of fifteen years, and Stephen A. Vaden, of Tennessee, to be a Judge of the United States Court of International Trade, 10 a.m., SD–226.

November 14, Full Committee, business meeting to consider the nominations of Patrick J. Bumatay, of California, to be United States Circuit Judge for the Ninth Circuit, Lawrence VanDyke, of Nevada, to be United States Circuit Judge for the Ninth Circuit, Philip M. Halpern, to be United States District Judge for the Southern District of New York, Bernard Maurice Jones II, to be United States District Judge for the Western District of Oklahoma, and Barbara Bailey Jongbloed, to be United States District Judge for the District of Connecticut, 10 a.m., SD–226.

Committee on Rules and Administration: November 14, to hold an oversight hearing to examine the Smithsonian Institution; to be immediately followed by a hearing to examine the nomination of Hugh Nathanial Halpern, of Virginia, to be Director of the Government Publishing Office, 10 a.m., SR–301.

Committee on Small Business and Entrepreneurship: November 14, to hold hearings to examine noncompete agreements and American workers, 10 a.m., SR–428A.

Select Committee on Intelligence: November 14, to received a closed briefing on certain intelligence matters, 2 p.m., SH–219.

House Committees

Committee on Agriculture, November 14, Full Committee, hearing entitled ''Safeguarding American Agriculture from Wild, Invasive, and Non-Native Species'', 10 a.m., 1300 Longworth.

Committee on Appropriations, November 14, Subcommittee on Military Construction, Veterans Affairs, and Related Agencies, hearing entitled ''Office of Accountability and Whistleblower Protection's Failures at VA'', 10 a.m., 2362–A Rayburn.

Committee on the Budget, November 14, Full Committee, hearing entitled ''The Economic Outlook: The View from the Federal Reserve'', 10 a.m., 210 Cannon.

Committee on Energy and Commerce, November 14, Subcommittee on Consumer Protection and Commerce, markup on H.R. 3851, the ''Travel Promotion, Enhancement, and Modernization Act of 2019''; and H.R. 4779, to extend the Undertaking Spam, Spyware, And Fraud Enforcement With Enforcers beyond Borders Act of 2006, and for other purposes, 9:30 a.m., 2123 Rayburn.

Committee on Foreign Affairs, November 14, Subcommittee on Africa, Global Health, Global Human Rights, and International Organizations, hearing entitled ''The U.S. Policy in the Sahel Region'', 2 p.m., 2172 Rayburn.

Committee on the Judiciary, November 14, Subcommittee on Crime, Terrorism, and Homeland Security, hearing entitled ''The Administration of Bail by State and Federal Courts: A Call for Reform'', 10 a.m., 2141 Rayburn.

November 14, Subcommittee on Courts, Intellectual Property, and the Internet, hearing entitled ''Examining the Use of ''Snap'' Removals to Circumvent the Forum Defendant Rule'', 2 p.m., 2141 Rayburn.

Committee on Natural Resources, November 14, Subcommittee on Energy and Mineral Resources, hearing on H.R. 4248, the ''Surface Mining Control and Reclamation Act Amendments of 2019'', 10 a.m., 1324 Longworth.

November 14, Subcommittee on Water, Oceans, and Wildlife, hearing entitled ''Oversight of NOAA's Report on Illegal, Unreported, and Unregulated Fishing'', 2 p.m., 1324 Longworth.

Committee on Oversight and Reform, November 14, Full Committee, hearing entitled ''Examining State Efforts to Undermine Access to Reproductive Health Care'', 2 p.m., 2154 Rayburn.

Committee on Science, Space, and Technology, November 14, Full Committee, markup on H.R. 4979, the ''Rural STEM Education Act''; H.R. 4704, the ''Advancing Research to Prevent Suicide Act''; and H.R. 4990, the ''Election Technology Research Act'', 10 a.m., 2318 Rayburn.

November 14, Subcommittee on Energy, hearing entitled ''Water and Geothermal Power: Unearthing the Next Wave of Energy Innovation'', 2 p.m., 2318 Rayburn.

Committee on Small Business, November 14, Subcommittee on Rural Development, Agriculture, Trade, and Entrepreneurship, hearing entitled ''Assessing the Government's Role in Serving Rural American Small Businesses (Part One)'', 10 a.m., 2360 Rayburn.

November 14, Full Committee, hearing entitled ''A Fair Playing Field? Investigating Big Tech's Impact on Small Business'', 1 p.m., 2360 Rayburn.

Committee on Transportation and Infrastructure, November 14, Subcommittee on Coast Guard and Maritime Transportation, hearing entitled ''Commercial and Passenger Vessel Safety: Challenges and Opportunities'', 2 p.m., 2167 Rayburn.

Committee on Veterans' Affairs, November 14, Subcommittee on Technology Modernization, hearing entitled ''Cybersecurity Challenges and Cyber Risk Management at the Department of Veterans Affairs'', 10 a.m., HVC–210.

Committee on Ways and Means, November 14, Full Committee, hearing entitled ''Caring for Aging Americans'', 10 a.m., 1100 Longworth.

Permanent Select Committee on Intelligence, November 15, Full Committee, hearing entitled ''Impeachment Inquiry: Ambassador Marie ''Masha'' Yovanovitch'', 9 a.m., 1100 Longworth.

Select Committee on the Climate Crisis, November 14, Full Committee, hearing entitled ''Member Day'', 1:30 p.m., 1300 Longworth.

Select Committee on the Modernization of Congress, November 15, Full Committee, hearing entitled ''Administrative Efficiencies: Exploring Options to Streamline Operations in the U.S. House of Representatives'', 9:30 a.m., 210 Cannon.

Joint Meetings

Joint Economic Committee: November 13, to hold hearings to examine the economic outlook, 11 a.m., SH–216.

Résumé of Congressional Activity

FIRST SESSION OF THE ONE HUNDRED SIXTEENTH CONGRESS

The first table gives a comprehensive résumé of all legislative business transacted by the Senate and House. The second table accounts for all nominations submitted to the Senate by the President for Senate confirmation.

DATA ON LEGISLATIVE ACTIVITY

January 3 through October 31, 2019

	Senate	*House*	*Total*
Days in session	155	159	..
Time in session	799 hrs., 39′	655 hrs, 18′	..
Congressional Record:			
Pages of proceedings	6,362	8,721	..
Extensions of Remarks	..	1,390	..
Public bills enacted into law	20	46	66
Private bills enacted into law	..	..	..
Bills in conference	1	1	..
Measures passed, total	403	522	925
Senate bills	76	22	..
House bills	49	350	..
Senate joint resolutions	24	5	..
House joint resolutions	4	8	..
Senate concurrent resolutions	12	5	..
House concurrent resolutions	8	11	..
Simple resolutions	230	121	..
Measures reported, total	*230	258	488
Senate bills	169	..	..
House bills	19	208	..
Senate joint resolutions	..	..	..
House joint resolutions	..	1	..
Senate concurrent resolutions	3	..	..
House concurrent resolutions	..	2	..
Simple resolutions	39	47	..
Special reports	20	8	..
Conference reports	1	1	..
Measures pending on calendar	196	69	..
Measures introduced, total	3,261	5,785	9,046
Bills	2,769	4,961	..
Joint resolutions	59	78	..
Concurrent resolutions	28	71	..
Simple resolutions	405	675	..
Quorum calls	2	1	..
Yea-and-nay votes	342	271	..
Recorded votes	..	337	..
Bills vetoed	5	1	..
Vetoes overridden	..	..	..

*These figures include all measures reported, even if there was no accompanying report. A total of 156 written reports have been filed in the Senate, 267 reports have been filed in the House.

DISPOSITION OF EXECUTIVE NOMINATIONS

January 3 through October 31, 2019

Civilian nominees, totaling 508, disposed of as follows:

Confirmed	274
Unconfirmed	215
Withdrawn	19

Other Civilian nominees, totaling 1,258, disposed of as follows:

Confirmed	987
Unconfirmed	270
Withdrawn	1

Air Force nominees, totaling 5,851, disposed of as follows:

Confirmed	5,684
Unconfirmed	167

Army nominees, totaling 6,560, disposed of as follows:

Confirmed	6,536
Unconfirmed	24

Navy nominees, totaling 4,615, disposed of as follows:

Confirmed	4,609
Unconfirmed	6

Marine Corps nominees, totaling 1,430, disposed of as follows:

Confirmed	1,427
Unconfirmed	3

Summary

Total nominees carried over from the First Session	0
Total nominees received this Session	20,222
Total confirmed	19,517
Total unconfirmed	685
Total withdrawn	20
Total returned to the White House	0

Next Meeting of the **SENATE**

10 a.m., Wednesday, November 13

Senate Chamber

Program for Wednesday: Senate will continue consideration of the nomination of Chad F. Wolf, of Virginia, to be Under Secretary for Strategy, Policy, and Plans, Department of Homeland Security, post-cloture, and vote on confirmation of the nomination at 11 a.m.

Following disposition of the nomination of Chad F. Wolf, Senate will vote on the motion to invoke cloture on the nomination of Steven J. Menashi, of New York, to be United States Circuit Judge for the Second Circuit.

(Senate will recess from 12:30 p.m. until 2 p.m. for their respective party conferences.)

Next Meeting of the **HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES**

10 a.m., Wednesday, November 13

House Chamber

Program for Wednesday: Consideration of measures under suspension of the Rules.

Extensions of Remarks, as inserted in this issue

HOUSE

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Cuellar, Henry, Tex., E1423
DeLauro, Rosa L., Conn., E1420
Garamendi, John, Calif., E1417, E1421, E1426
García, Jesús G. ''Chuy'', Ill., E1429
Gianforte, Greg, Mont., E1424
Hartzler, Vicky, Mo., E1429
Hastings, Alcee L., Fla., E1420
Higgins, Brian, N.Y., E1428
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Wittman, Robert J., Va., E1425

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